Favour

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/70969251.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warnings:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Lonnie (She-ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Slow Burn, Sexual Tension, Enemies to Lovers, Enemies to Friends to Lovers, Political Alliances, Uneasy Allies, Hurt/Comfort, Angst, Eventual Smut, Angst and Fluff and Smut, Past Rape/Non-con, Past Character Death, Past Sexual Abuse, Past Violence, Accidental Voyeurism, Bi Adora, Nice Parent Shadow Weaver, Unreliable Narrator, Plot Twists, Characters shaped by the AU, Not Always Canon, Not Canon Compliant, Master/Slave, Power Imbalance, Oral Sex, Fingerfucking, Strap-Ons, Scissoring, Possessive Sex, Gentle Sex, Suicide, Character Death, Decapitation, Grief/Mourning, Break Up, Self-Doubt, negative self-talk, Ambiguous/Open Ending

Language:
English

Series:
Part 2 of Disposition, Favour, Devotion

Stats:
Published: 2025-09-17 Completed: 2025-11-04 Words: 120,371 Chapters: 26/26

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by cjowofics

Summary

Etheria teeters on the edge of war, and Catra knows Prime is pulling the strings. He's plotting her downfall even as he parades her as his heir. To survive, she forges a fragile alliance with Adora, the enemy she should hate most.

Notes

If you've read the last one you should know this is based on Captive Prince (Prince's Gambit)

Chapter 1

"I dare you to make a run for it," Lonnie muttered, not quite under her breath.

Catra caught the words only distantly, as if they floated up through water. She had been turned so far inward that she barely registered the journey until the light shifted. When she surfaced from her thoughts, the day was nearly gone, the sky stained with bruised purple and rose. Ahead, Dryl's jagged towers rose against the horizon, stark and alien after so long away.

Adora didn't answer Lonnie's jab, and she didn't try to run. Catra noted that much with a detached kind of relief. Her so-called pet had managed to endure the entire trip without breaking a neck or starting a fight—an achievement she might have counted as impressive, if it hadn't also been true of the lead Horde clone. One quiet day did not a miracle make.

Catra lengthened her stride and took her place at the head of the company.

The courtyard was already prepared. Servants lined the path in neat rows, as picture-perfect as a parade: uniforms crisp, hair lacquered into place, eyes fixed forward. The Horde always liked its masks immaculate—Horde Prime most of all. There was nothing in their posture to betray how he dealt with his people in private.

Not for the first time, Catra found herself wondering how far back it went—how many worlds, how many courts had been dressed up this way, all while Prime hollowed them out from the inside.

If this was meant to impress her, it didn't.

She glanced over the ranks and felt the imbalance immediately. No sign of the soldiers Prime had promised to supply. A deliberate insult, too petty to mention aloud. Her small detachment looked

laughably fragile against the cavernous sweep of the courtyard. And what then, when they were at the border? What dent could this token force possibly make, assuming this venture was real at all and not some elaborate snare?

She didn’t bother giving the thought oxygen.

Her mind ticked over the revisions she had made during the journey. Crude still, but workable. The head clone was supposed to see the men, horses, and equipment settled; in practice, Lonnie would keep everything moving. Rogelio had orders to keep "Mara" under control. That bought her time—a sliver of space to work without eyes on her. Without distractions.

Catra already knew what she would find when she finally turned her attention back to the troops: barracks left in chaos, supplies uncounted, weapons unsorted. Prime’s Etheria based clones seemingly had no concept of preparation, and certainly no interest in discipline.

She would give herself an hour first. An hour to scratch her letters into order, to set down the bones of her plan. After that, she would pick up the mess.

✧

“Use Mara,” Catra told Lonnie later, once her messengers were dispatched and she had a rare moment to breathe. Her voice was casual, but her ears were angled, sharp for any resistance.

Lonnie arched a brow. “Those muscles can’t just be decoration, I suppose.”

“Have her check the inventory,” Catra went on. “I don’t feel like it.”

Lonnie blinked at her, half a laugh tugging at her mouth. “You think she can even read?”

Catra cut her a long, flat look. Lonnie's smirk evaporated, and she bobbed her head. "Right. Your Highness."

"Bet you ten coins she can," Catra drawled, just to twist the knife.

Hands lifted, palms out, Lonnie surrendered. "You know her better than I do."

Catra could see the question blazing behind her lieutenant's eyes, unspoken but practically written across her forehead: Why in the name of all the Ancients did you drag your pet here? Prime had seeded the story himself, peddling the image of her as some green fool, half-dazed by her first taste of a bedslave's charms. It was exactly the kind of rumor soldiers chewed on when they had nothing better to do, and Catra knew full well how her last-minute insistence on bringing Adora along looked. It wasn't the sort of decision that would burnish her reputation.

But reputation was already ash.

"She can lend your soldiers a hand when she's done with the inventory," Catra said, dismissive. "Anything else you need covered, especially the tasks no one wants. If it's unpleasant, put her on it."

Her tone carried the faintest edge of amusement, but her eyes stayed hard. Adora might have forced her way into this campaign, but Catra would make certain she earned her place. Even if not in the way the barracks liked to whisper about.

✧

"I always knew you wanted me, princess. Didn't have to send your bedslave as an appetizer. My cock's still hard, too. She didn't let me finish."

The Head Clone was loud, obnoxious, making sure everyone could hear. He palmed himself as he swaggered into the barracks, dragging his hand slow across his crotch. The dark wet stain blooming at the tip of his pants left nothing to imagination. He

squeezed and circled with thumb and finger, just to make the dampness spread, as if daring anyone not to look.

Catra's ears flicked, but she stayed perfectly still. There weren't enough witnesses here yet to make it worth teaching him manners, and besides—it was the first day back on Etheria. No point burning the game too soon.

She could almost hear Prime's smug voice dripping in her ear: Catra, the clones talk rough. Don't play the maiden. He'd allowed worse to be said to her—about her—smiling all the while at his "little sister's" humiliation.

So Catra didn't blush. She tilted her head, let her smirk curl lazy and sharp.

"Wow," she drawled, ears twitching back. "So you actually got my pet to spread her legs? Big day for you."

Her gaze flicked down, then back up with a deliberate once-over. She knew Adora hadn't actually fucked this clone, but she had definitely pissed him off. "Though, let's be real—she'll get on her knees for anyone. Doesn't exactly make you special."

The clone's grin faltered, jaw ticking.

Catra leaned in, soft and vicious all at once. "Still—congrats on finally finding your dick. Must've been a real challenge."

And then she clapped. Slow. Deliberate. Each sharp smack echoing off stone.

The Head Clone's face flushed dark, his swagger cracking. Around them, the handful of soldiers tasked with preparing the barracks froze in place, drawn like moths to the tension sparking between Princess and Captain. A few even edged closer, eager to see where it went.

The responses were mixed—some amused, some wary. Many had seen the Head Clone mouth off to Catra before, but never like

this.

Wouldn't it be funny, Catra thought, if he ruined everything on day one? If he blew the whole plan wide open with one temper tantrum? She toyed with pushing him further, bait dangling on her tongue.

And then, against all odds, he pulled back.

"What do you want?" he snapped. And for him—for him—to say that to her? That was practically polite.

✧

"I saved you for last," Catra said, voice low, teasing, as she stepped into the room. Adora had risen when she entered, which was… almost civil. Almost. She supposed Adora would put on her best behaviour until the moment she decided to strangle her in her sleep and make a run for the border. Catra had grown used to confronting who Adora really was—but she still hadn't grown used to the fact that she had agreed to bring her along.

The Princess's chambers at Dryl hadn't changed much since Catra's last visit. She wasn't sure if she would have preferred it if they had. She dismissed Lonnie earlier, and there was something uncomfortably intimate about standing here, alone with Adora.

You saved my life, Catra thought, with a flicker of irritation. And I hate you for it. No. I resent you. You took Shadow Weaver away. You've caused every nightmare since.

"You owe the armourer ten coins," Adora said, bluntly.

Catra raised an eyebrow, suppressing a smirk. That explained why the Head Clone had bbeenso much more manageable than usual. "The armourer," she said slowly, "should learn to demand payment before she bends over."

Stepping further into the room was almost painful in its slowness. Catra forced herself to cross the carpet Prime had made her kneel

upon, to stride deliberately, as though staking her presence. She went to the sideboard and poured herself a drink, placing herself deliberately near Adora—but she barely noticed her. Adora wasn't the concern.

Catra's gaze flicked toward the table. The servants had cleared Adora's dinner but left a knife behind. Carelessness? Laziness? Or Prime already stretching his long, quiet influence? Catra felt certain Adora had noticed—but had left it. A small, silent test, or just indifference? She shrugged. Her mind darted ahead, desperate for anything to think about besides the trap she was walking into here.

Adora's eyes widened slightly at the glass in Catra's hand, like Catra was holding a serpent.

"Relax," Catra said, wry. "It's just water. Probably." She took a careful sip, not as deep as she intended—some caution never hurt, not when she'd learned how quickly decisions could turn on discomfort.

Her gaze wandered over the setup the servants had prepared: chairs, maps, every piece of furniture in its place. Nothing new, and that, strangely, delighted her.

Catra offered a chair to Adora, voice casual but sharp. "Sit. Make yourself comfortable."

Catra could barely contain the strange, surreal amusement that hit her, standing in the bedchamber of one of Horde Prime's abducted Princesses with her enemy—her ally, her thorn—Adora of Etheria. They were sharing a room that Prime had filled with his presence, where he'd branded Catra a pet and declared her his new heir.

"You're staying the night," Catra said, a sharp edge of humour in her tone.

"No chains? No cuffs?" she asked.

Catra's amusement ebbed as her mind, given a single unguarded moment, leapt into dark corners she didn't want to explore—corners where Adora, and restraints, and the lingering memory of intimacy collided.

"You don't think I'll bolt?" Adora pressed. "Maybe slit your throat on the way out?"

"Not until we're closer to the border," Catra said evenly.

The answer was blunt. Honest. Necessary. Adora blinked at her, expecting a punchline, some hint that this was a game. When Catra offered none, she shook her head.

"You're unbelievable. Do you even feel anything?" she muttered, tone tight with disgust.

Catra set down her cup with deliberate calm. Then she picked up the knife.

Everything Catra said, everything she did, was usually measured—cold, precise, premeditated. But her temper was quick, a spark that could ignite into recklessness. And in that moment, a spark had. The knife was in her hand, and she stepped into Adora's space—too close. Intimately close. Closer than ever before, even the last time a knife had come between them in her rooms. Back then, before the blade was discarded, closeness had been… electric. Mara—Adora—had made her feel alive, made her feel something—

Could she have done that if Adora truly hated her?

She had saved her life. She had bent to her knees. She had left Catra gasping and undone—and now they were here again, tangled in indifference. Indifference, the cold gift Catra could give when all she wanted was to strangle her.

The knife would have gone in—so clean, so satisfying. Unlike the night the assassins came, Adora wasn't ready; she would have been caught off-guard.

But instead, Catra pressed the hilt into Adora's palm, curling her fingers over it. She held it there, pulling the arm until the tip nudged against the fabric of Catra's tunic. Just a breath could let it find skin.

"You heard me dismiss Lonnie." Catra said, voice low. The warmth of Adora's hand was electric under her own. They shared the same small space, the same stolen breath. Their eyes met, sharp and calculating. A kiss could have happened, had they chosen it. The knife remained between them, a shared pulse, an intimate edge.

"No threats. No posturing." Catra added. Adora's gaze darkened, hunger and fury warring there. "If you're going to do it—do it."

Heartbeats thundered, fast and uneven. The heat under her fingers thrilled Catra—the challenge, the gamble, the reckless surrender of plans and prudence. Adora wanted it; Catra could see it in her eyes, feel it in the tension of her body. And yes, a part of her wanted it too. A part of her always did.

"I'm sure servants are still awake," Adora murmured, "How do I know you won't scream?"

Catra didn't even laugh. "Do I seem like the type to scream?" Her words were bait, almost daring, almost inviting. She watched the flicker of conflict in Adora's dark eyes and felt a spark of satisfaction. Cut me down. Make it quick, like you did my mother.

Adora inhaled deeply, steadying herself.

"I'm not going to use the knife—but if you put it in my hand, you underestimate how much I want to," she said.

Catra's lips twitched, a faint smile. She tightened her grip on Adora's hand, tilting her head slightly, thinking. "No, Mara." she said softly. The tip of her index traced Adora's knuckle. "I know exactly what it is… to want to kill someone, and to wait."

Adora stepped back. Catra let go. She kept the knife clutched, as if weighing it, as if the threat was still very real.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

CW: past abuse, sa, grief and trauma

This fic is not going to shy away from the dark parts of Catra's past in this au.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The truce they'd hammered out was fragile, but Catra was confident enough it would last—for now. Adora was too straight-edged, too stubbornly earnest to break it. Treachery just wasn't in her nature. What she was was useful: disciplined, tireless, quick to win the trust of Catra's soldiers, and crammed full of knowledge Catra needed. That was the part that stung the most. Needing her. Depending on her. Every time the thought crossed Catra's mind, it left a sour taste.

Adora had agreed to obey, at least in public. Catra knew her well enough to expect complaints later, behind closed doors. That was fine. Let her vent in private. It wouldn't change anything. At the border, everything between them would come to a head. That was the promise they'd made to each other.

"On that day," Catra had told her, "we'll see who wins."

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The night wore on, and neither of them seemed willing to call it quits. The heater's low hum filled the silence as Adora bent over the maps, her fingers tracing roads and mountain passes like she was retracing half-forgotten scars. She remembered more than Catra expected, and she didn't like offering it up, that much was obvious. But she did. Honest, plain, straightforward.

It wasn't really a conversation. It wasn't personal. There was nothing easy about it. Sitting here with Adora was already bizarre

enough, but doing it in this room was almost laughable in its wrongness. Catra sat across from her mother's killer, gathering up Etherian military intelligence in the same space where Prime had broken her down again and again. It should've been unbearable. And yet it was happening, as ordinary as breathing.

Catra asked the questions. Adora gave the answers. And to Catra's own disgust, she believed most of them.

Catra had always had a mind that gnawed at things. She liked learning, liked hoarding information the way other kids had hoarded toys. And she'd dreaded this night more than she cared to admit: the thought of being shut up with Adora, of staring across the table at the same golden-haired nuisance who had ruined everything. She'd been prepared for games, for lies, for a fight that would drain her dry. She hadn't expected Adora to simply… give her the truth.

Once they sat down, the fight between them fizzled out. Just steady questions and blunt answers, traded like coins until the dark outside softened into pale morning.

For once, Catra managed not to let the room win. The bed loomed in the corner like a gaping mouth, waiting to devour her if she let her guard slip. But she didn't let it. She kept her focus on Adora, on the maps, on the sound of her own breathing, until the ghosts faded to the edges of her vision. The screams in her head stayed quiet. For a little while, at least.

Adora was useful. She was infuriating, exhausting, but useful. Catra hated her for it. And hated herself more for noticing how her shoulders loosened when Adora was around, how the world felt a fraction less impossible when Adora was the one tracing the roads.

Safe.

When Catra finally left—an hour before dawn—she glanced back once. Adora looked wrung out but still steady. Catra was sure

she'd take the chance to sleep. She wondered if she'd actually lie down on the miserable pallet laid out for her like some obedient little pet… or if she'd be bold enough to claim the bed. The thought of Adora snoring there, spread across the same mattress Prime used for his filth—Catra almost laughed out loud.

She hoped Adora took the bed. She hoped she stripped down and sprawled across it, shameless.

And knowing Adora, she probably slept like a baby.

Catra didn't even pretend she was going to sleep in Dryl. The walls pressed in too tightly, the air felt wrong, and no matter how she shifted, the ghosts here refused to give her peace. Even food turned her stomach. Horde Prime had missed a golden opportunity if he hadn't seeded the place with some kind of trap. Catra almost wanted to wait around and see what he'd pull, but patience had never been her strength. Instead, she had the soldiers out of their blankets before dawn, her voice cutting through the courtyard until they scrambled into something that almost resembled order.

By the time Adora finally showed up—hours later, of course, bright-eyed in a way that made Catra's temples throb—Catra already had the troops lined, drilled, and restless. They marched out of Dryl without incident, but Catra kept looking over her shoulder anyway. She didn't trust the silence.

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Their numbers swelled from just above fifty to two hundred once Prime's clones joined them. The first day with the full company, Catra did little besides watch. She needed to see how her own people would mix with Prime's blank-faced soldiers, needed to measure who she could rely on and who would snap the second things got difficult.

Shadow Weaver—her late mother, if Catra let herself use the word—would have had the whole army eating out of her hand before

noon. Weaver had been infuriating, manipulative, and impossible, but people had loved her for it. They would have followed her into fire. Even Hordak. She had remembered names, families, favorite foods. When she smiled, people believed it.

Catra wasn't Shadow Weaver.

She stayed at the head of the line where rank put her, but she didn't drift back to talk or cajole. She didn't have her mother's warmth to weaponize. What she had was her eyes and her mind—sharpened by years of surviving in Prime's shadow. She couldn't charm loyalty out of anyone. She'd have to win it with action, with results. Nothing else was going to cut it, not when Prime had already sunk his claws into the clones.

Hordak, for his part, was exactly what she expected and somehow less. His commands were slow, clumsy, arriving hours after they were useful. He barked at soldiers for mistakes born of his own bad orders, then strutted back looking smug, like the chewing-out made him important. By the time they stopped for lunch, he'd slunk off toward the servants' wagons.

Catra rubbed at her temple, head pounding, and muttered to Lonnie, "If he tries to force himself on anyone, I'm cutting it off."

Lonnie blinked at her. "Your Highness—do you… want me to tell him that?"

Catra's mouth curled into a tired, vicious grin. "Tell Hordak if he can't find anyone willing, he should invest in a goat."

Lonnie's lips twitched like she wanted to laugh but thought better of it. She saluted instead, brisk and sharp, and went to deliver the message.

✧

Catra used her time where she could. Her rank, her face, the damned ears—none of it lent itself to blending in. Not with a force

this small. Everyone knew where she was at all times. But she could still hang back, keep her distance, and watch.

She hadn't led a campaign before, not really. She'd read plenty about them, though. In the long weeks before departure, she'd spent more nights with heavy manuals than with her bed. Tents should be pitched at this distance apart, latrine ditches dug this many feet deep, food supplies calculated by this formula—she'd memorized it all. Shadow Weaver hadn't once told her to shut up, not even when Catra had trailed her around like some wide-eyed little shadow, quoting passages from war tomes like scripture. In hindsight, it was pathetic. She'd wanted to be useful. Wanted to be seen.

Hordak, clearly, had never opened a book in his life.

The clones weren't much better—they relied on a hive mind instead. She kept her eye sharp, noting who was dead weight and who quietly picked up the slack. A few stood out—two in particular. No surprise there. One of them wasn't surprising. The other? Extremely irritating.

Once Catra's own tent was standing, the complaints started. Apparently a princess was less a leader and more a convenient complaints department. She didn't look like she wanted to listen, but that didn't stop anyone.

First came a washman, furious that Hordak had stiffed him half the coin for a suck. Then a mechanic with the same story—and a black eye for his trouble. A nervous clone crept in just to admit he was homesick already and terrified of bears. Then a cook marched in to demand clarification on salt rations, sneering, "What does a princess know about seasoning, anyway?"

"Plenty," Catra shot back, bored.

By the time Hordak himself barged in, she almost welcomed the distraction.

His face was blotchy with anger, his voice already rising. Clearly Lonnie had relayed her goat suggestion.

Catra, lounging on her cot, inspected her claws. "With that attitude, I'm definitely not helping you haggle." She let him sputter before cutting in. "This does remind me, though. If I have to keep paying off your whores, this campaign's broke before we reach the border. Did you think my rules were negotiable? Or just that they didn't apply to you?"

"Prime—" Hordak started.

"Yeah, yeah. Prime loves you. Couldn't tell you why." She flicked an ear. "So. Pay your whores, respect your princess, and if your purse is light, cry to Prime about it. Want me to put you through to him? I'm sure he'll be thrilled to know what you get up to when out of his thrall." She tilted her head, smirking. "Also, feedback's been… let's say unflattering. Try a vegetable sometime, they grow on world. Or at least try soap. Or both. Real adventure for you."

Hordak's jaw worked furiously. "I'll fuck you—"

"Wow, tempting," Catra cut in, her voice turning flat and dangerous. "Here's the deal: if we can't figure out how to play nice, I'll make sure the rest of this trip is a hell you will not enjoy. You've had your warning. Get out."

He left bristling, but he left.

And then came more. There hadn't been time in Dryl, but two days marching was long enough for concerns to pile up. A few didn't even have real issues—they just wanted a glimpse of her. Wanted to know if the rumors were true. Is she that beautiful? That much of a bitch?

Catra forced herself to be professional, at least on the surface. Shadow Weaver would've smiled, asked names, charmed them. Catra did not. She kept her tone clipped, her face unreadable. At least this way, when they killed her and replaced her, she could

know at the end that at least she had been useful. She could die with pride.

Eventually, the stream of petitioners slowed. She was down to the last one, head pounding from lack of food and less sleep, when Adora ducked through the flap of her tent.

Catra wasn't all that surprised to see her show up early. That was classic Adora—on time to a fault, ready before she was called, like hard work alone could make up for everything else. Catra hadn't even had the chance to wonder if she'd ditched camp or decided this whole mess wasn't worth it. No, Adora was too stubborn for that.

She wasn't fumbling like she had back on the flagship, either. That pathetic show of bows and fake deference had just been Adora making fun of the whole setup, surely. But here? She looked like she actually belonged in the camp. She hauled gear, carried water, patched tents, sharpened blades—and she didn't hesitate once. She worked harder than most of the clones, and Catra noticed some of them speeding up, like they couldn't stand the thought of being shown up by the princess's sex-pet.

By the time Catra was finally free of petitioners for the night, Adora was waiting. Not barging in, not hovering—just standing outside the tent, quiet and patient, until Catra let her in.

This wasn't play-acting anymore. It wasn't that awkward performance she'd put on when she wanted Catra's help freeing Perfuma and the others. This felt different.

Catra studied her across the tent, arms folded, tail flicking. Adora kept her gaze steady, though Catra caught the flicker of her eyes toward the bedrolls. She couldn't quite read what Adora was thinking, and that unsettled her more than she liked to admit. Still, for the first time in a long while, Catra was certain she wasn't going to wake up with her throat slit. A strange kind of relief—and an even stranger kind of trust.

“Well?” Catra said at last. “Don’t just stand there. Attend me.”

Adora frowned, repeating the words like she was trying them out. “Attend?”

“Yeah.” Catra tilted her head, watching her closely. “What, you forget already?”

Adora’s mouth tightened. “Last time I tried to attend you, it didn’t end well.”

Her voice was quiet, steady, but Catra heard the weight behind it. The memory hung heavy between them: steam curling through the baths, her claws tearing into skin.

Catra’s claws flexed. Her chest felt tight, but her voice came out sharp and cool. “Then maybe don’t poke around this time.”

She turned away, tail lashing behind her, making it clear the conversation was over. Or at least, that’s what she wanted Adora to believe.

It was supposed to be easy. That was the joke of it—Catra had thought this would be the simplest thing in the world. Adora hadn’t killed her when she had the chance. She’d stood there, knife ready—and nothing. Catra strung out and barely holding onto reality, and Adora hadn’t taken advantage. Instead, she’d saved her. Three men had come with the intent to break and end her, and Adora had chosen—infuriatingly—to stand between Catra and death.

Catra hadn’t let herself think about what that meant until too late. Not until after she’d already carved her mark into Adora, already dragged her claws down skin and left scars she hadn’t earned the right to give. And even then, Adora hadn’t obeyed like a servant would. She hadn’t snapped to attention, hadn’t rushed to the order the way she was supposed to. She’d hesitated. She’d waited. And that left Catra far too much time to think.

Waiting was the worst part. Not the touch itself—no, Catra could survive the pain, the closeness, the indignity. It was the waiting. The anticipation, knowing someone was right behind her, that something was coming and she couldn't see it. That was worse. One heartbeat. Then another. Then a third, and suddenly Catra was back where she didn't want to be—Prime's hand fisted in her hair, jerking her head back until her neck screamed, forcing her mouth against his, her own tears bitter on his tongue. The table edge digging into her hips. His voice in her ear. Her legs kicked apart.

She couldn't breathe.

Adora exhaled behind her, and Catra clenched her jaw, forcing down the shake threatening to rise in her limbs. One memory pushed aside only to drag another up in its place, bloated and rotten.

And then another step. Adora was closer.

But it was different. Catra could feel her—her shape, her presence, like heat against her skin—and somehow it didn't set her off. It didn't feel like Prime.

The tight coil in Catra's chest loosened, just slightly. She kept her eyes shut, braced for the touch that didn't come, and in that strange in-between space she realized something absurd: she was safe. Not forever, not really. But right now, in this fragile, temporary truce—she was safe with Adora.

Her hair had to be moved aside to get at the ties and clasps. Normally, Catra would have snarled at anyone who dared to touch her there. She hated it—hated the feeling of hands in her hair, hated how vulnerable it made her feel. But Adora's fingers weren't rough. They were careful. Gentle. The same hands that had ended Shadow Weaver were now easing a few stubborn laces free, brushing skin by accident, warm breath stirring against her neck.

She didn’t talk, didn’t fill the silence the way a servant might. And strangely, that silence wasn’t unbearable. It was almost… tolerable. Almost something Catra wanted to last.

But it couldn’t.

Catra knew herself too well. It was too much—too dangerous—to let herself lean into it. To let the ghost of comfort settle in her bones, even for a second. She hadn’t felt that since Shadow Weaver had been alive. Since that last morning, when her mother had hugged her tight before leaving, whispering that she would end the war, that she’d give Catra a future worth living in. She’d held her so close, so fiercely, as if she could promise safety with her arms alone.

That had been the last time Catra had been held. The last time she had felt like someone cared enough to keep her safe. And now, against all logic, the touch of her enemy’s hands was stirring up the memory of it.

It was unacceptable.

And yet, part of her couldn’t let it go.

Shadow Weaver had lied. She always lied. Catra thought didn’t need anyone, that wanting to be held was weakness, indulgence, a failing. But Catra did want it. She ached for it. And now, absurdly, her mother’s murderer was sliding her jacket down off her shoulders, careful and slow, and Catra wanted—just for a breath, just for a heartbeat—for those hands to stay on her.

The thought made her tense. Made her furious.

She stepped out of Adora’s reach. Cold air rushed in where warmth had almost lingered.

“That’s enough,” Catra snapped. She tossed the jacket aside, as if she could throw the feeling with it. Better to be cold. Cold was safe. Cold didn’t leave you craving something you couldn’t have. “Sit. At the table.”

She already had the map spread, the night's work decided. The topic would keep her mind occupied and her hands busy. She couldn't let this turn into another sleepless stretch, not again—not when she was already half-chewed from exhaustion. Sleep would come eventually, with Adora under the same roof. Their truce would hold. It had to.

Still, her stomach turned at the sight of food. She snatched up one of the oranges weighing the map flat, just to peel, to do something. The sharp citrus bite clung to her claws.

"When the Fright Zone fought Bright Moon at Sandstorm," she said, her tone flat, businesslike, "there was a maneuver that cracked our eastern flank. Tell me why it worked."

✧

Catra heard Rogelio jeer: "What's the matter? Afraid to spar with me?"

Adora's reply was quick, steady. "No."

"Then what?" Rogelio pressed. "Can't fight? You're only here to fuck the princess? Is that all you're good for."

Catra's ears flicked. She looked up just in time to catch the moment Adora moved. A clean, vicious swing—only with a practice blade, but packed with enough force to make the onlookers step back.

She had come out expecting laziness. The soldiers ran their drills with varying degrees of effort; Catra had wanted to see which clones would actually show up, which ones might be worth a damn. She hadn't expected Adora to be the one to catch her attention.

Sleep had come for Catra, eventually—deep, dreamless, dragged over her like a heavy blanket. She hadn't even remembered falling under, only waking to the clatter of servants setting out breakfast.

Adora was already up, crouched at the fire, tending it like she belonged there.

The realization had cut sharp: Catra had been defenseless, unconscious, while Adora—Adora, who had cut through Shadow Weaver's neck without flinching—had been awake. Long enough to wash, to change, to move about freely. And yet… nothing. No knife at her throat. No smug words. Adora didn't even comment on her bedhead when she came to lace her into her clothes.

The silence was almost worse in the morning.

When Catra finally stepped out into the courtyard, the smell of coffee still clung to her hands. Extra had been laid out. Had the servants guessed, or had Adora thought of it herself? She shoved the thought away.

Now Rogelio's words rang out, crass and careless, the way soldiers always were. Catra had grown up surrounded by it—the endless muttered jokes, the constant speculation about her body, her appetites, her supposed desperation. Prime had engineered that filth, encouraged it, until no one batted an eye at calling their princess a whore. By now, even her allies slipped into it without realizing.

Most of the talk barely registered anymore. Cheap, repetitive, predictable. Nothing they could say compared to the things Prime had done. It bored her.

But watching Adora swing—watching her body move with coiled strength, watching the shock ripple through the soldiers who'd underestimated her—there was nothing boring about that.

What was unusual wasn't the insult itself—Catra had been called worse, had endured filthier whispers behind her back and to her face. What was unusual was that anyone cared enough to take offense on her behalf. Especially when the implication dragged their own name into whatever rutting fantasy she was supposedly engaged in. Most would brag about it, puff up their chests at the

thought of others believing they'd had her. Why wouldn't they? A crown and a scandal—what better prize?

But Adora didn't play along.

Catra knew that look when it overtook her. The sudden blaze in her face, the coiled violence thrumming through her body. She'd seen it when Adora wrestled the beast in the arena—though it had been aimed at her for putting Adora in that situation—then assassins had come for her in the night. But this time was different. This time, that fury had a blade in its hand.

And Catra hadn't seen that before.

She hadn't seen the weapon that cut down Shadow Weaver brought to bear.

Rogelio wasn't some soft recruit—he was one of Catra's most reliable soldiers, someone she trusted to hold a line. And Adora had been locked up for weeks, half-drugged, imprisoned, starved of her strength. She should have been stiff, clumsy, weak. Instead, it was obvious from the first clash that she outstripped him—and not just him. Any soldier on the field. Lonnie. Even Catra, if she were honest.

She couldn't even summon the anger that admission should've provoked. Not when watching her move was like watching something dangerous and dazzling in equal measure. Catra thought of the duel with Shadow Weaver and how much she had missed, how she had only seen the ruin it left behind. If she'd seen the whole thing, it would have been unforgettable—two predators testing each other, steel and fury and craft.

There was an artistry to Adora's violence. Her body carried strength like a birthright, and she wielded it without hesitation. Not clean, not ceremonial—no polished spectacle for the court. This was raw, ugly, alive. Fast and merciless. Catra felt herself leaning forward, pulled by it, heart beating faster. She wasn't thinking of Shadow Weaver's body cooling on the ground. She

wasn’t thinking of Prime, or the war, or anything that mattered. She was only imagining how it would feel to stand against that kind of power herself. To answer it. To find where she would break.

“Your Highness?” Lonnie’s voice startled her. She turned her head, muttered something dismissive, some excuse she didn’t even hear herself say. Her eyes never left the yard. She couldn’t look away, not from Adora’s grin as she matched Rogelio’s fury, not from the sharp satisfaction radiating off her.

“Are you going to fight me properly, or not?” Rogelio barked, sweat slicking his scales.

Adora only smiled wider. “I thought that’s what we were doing, have you been holding out on me?”

That was when everything tipped. Rogelio threw his practice sword aside, the wooden clatter sharp in the morning air, and tore a real blade from a soldier’s belt. No warning, no call for honor. He swung, steel hissing for Adora’s throat.

Catra’s heart lurched—she was too far, too slow in her grogginess —

Adora wasn’t.

She crashed into him, body meeting body with bone-jarring force. Rogelio went sprawling, dust clouding around him, but Adora stayed standing, steady as a fortress. She pressed her practice sword hard against his throat, eyes cold and alive all at once.

The yard stilled. No one breathed.

Catra’s lungs burned; her breath came jagged and uneven. She closed her eyes for the space of a heartbeat, dizzy, then opened them to see Rogelio hauled upright, Lonnie stepping in with a soldier’s hand to calm the fire down. Adora let it happen without a word, letting the weight of her presence speak for her.

Catra could only watch, her body thrumming, her mind racing.

Then Adora looked at her.

There was no explanation for the heat that rose in Catra's chest as she watched her walk closer, no rational reason for the rush in her stomach or the faint buzz at the back of her skull. It wasn't fear. Not exactly. Not desire, at least not the way she would have labeled it before. It was something strange and clumsy, like the shyness of a child reciting facts from a book to adults who were far too impressed, too patient, too attentive. She hadn't felt it since she was small and awkward and always trying to measure up.

"Were you looking for me?" Adora asked. Her voice was calm, controlled, and even a little cautious, as if she were checking for traps. Catra couldn't form an answer. The words tangled in her throat.

"What?" the Etherian pressed, concern threading through the question. Catra could feel the intensity of her gaze, and it made her cheeks warm. She had no excuse, no clever deflection, no proud quip to cover the truth. All she could say was the one thing that had lodged itself in her chest.

"You're just… better than I am."

Mara's grin was slow and teasing. It stretched, soft and confident, as if she knew exactly what that admission would do to her. Catra could feel the implied promise in the look: the slide of oil on sweat-slicked skin, the way she could overwhelm her in two steps, the helpless surrender that would follow if she let her. She could. Catra knew it. Every iron-bound rule, every wall of self-control she had erected, melted against that awareness.

Adora's grin widened. "Why?" she asked, deliberately taunting, testing the edges of her restraint. "Do you want to spar with me and find out, Catra?"

By spar, she didn't mean fight. Catra knew that.

And then there was the way Adora had said her name.

“No.”

The word came out too fast, too sharp, all panic and instinct. Adora tilted her head, a flicker of amusement crossing her face as if she could read the panic in every line of Catra’s posture. Catra saw the proof in how the mage-slayer held herself: the confidence, the lethal grace, the awareness that no one—not Rogelio, not any soldier, not even Catra—could have matched her without consequence. And yet, all she wanted was for Mara—Adora—to come closer.

Her body froze. Every instinct screamed stay still, don’t move, or you’ll ruin whatever fragile control you still had.

Lonnie’s voice cut through the haze.

“Your Highness,” she said, careful, observant, and Catra flinched—just a little. She hoped no one else noticed. “Apologies, if you need more time with—”

“No,” Catra said too quickly again, chasing the lie from her lips. “I’ll speak with you instead. Follow me back to the main camp.”

Lonnie didn’t comment, didn’t press. She had been with Catra long enough to know when to step back, when to step in, and more importantly, how to let her Princess maintain her sharp edge. She had been there when Catra first chose her for the Princess’s Guard, when she had demanded the best and refused mediocrity, still smarting from Prime’s endless barbs. Lonnie understood her place and held it, quietly, loyally, without need for recognition.

Catra followed, keeping her gaze fixed on Adora. There had been no smile, no overt acknowledgment of what just passed between them. But the fire in Adora’s eyes lingered, dangerous and alive, and Catra felt it in the hollow spaces inside her chest where she thought she’d buried all weakness.

The thought prickled at her—how furious, how impossibly quick Adora's reaction had been to Rogelio's insult. She had no obligation to defend Catra. She had no reason, no loyalty, no love—at least none that should have mattered. And yet, she had moved with a speed and precision that left no doubt: she did care. She did, in some twisted, indirect way that neither of them would ever admit.

Catra swallowed hard. She had watched Adora, studied her, tracked her, learned her habits. She knew how the mage-slayer's body reacted to want, to challenge, to command. The heat in her gaze, the slow, lingering sweep of her attention, the subtle tilt of her posture—all of it betrayed a hunger that was precise and controlled. She wanted. She wanted Catra. But she wouldn't touch without reason, without justification, without purpose. That part of her honor—whatever that meant—remained intact.

And yet.

Catra felt the weight of that desire pressing against her own defenses, and she knew she would never be able to fully ignore it.

Adora had no reason—none whatsoever—to throw herself at Rogelio. She had nothing to defend, not herself, not Catra. And yet she had. Catra had watched, frozen, a strange pull in her chest she didn't want to acknowledge.

"Your highness?" Lonnie's voice was careful, hesitant, testing the waters. Catra had been silent long enough.

"I want you to make sure the soldiers are tending to their feet."

"Their… feet?"

Catra tilted her head. "Hordak is not the type to care for the little things. Daily upkeep, the small details—do you disagree?"

"No, I—"

"I want no one marching with wet socks, blisters, or sores."

“We’re driving, your highness,” Lonnie reminded her.

“And I want the tires checked. Pressure, alignment, every bolt. The clones aren’t going to do it unless someone insists.”

“Yes, of course…”

Catra stopped pacing, and Lonnie fell silent as well. Her frown deepened. Her cheeks still burned faintly from earlier. “Prime has probably whispered into someone’s ear already,” she said. “He knows we expect threats from Etheria. What he doesn’t want is a clean fight. He’d rather seed discord inside our own lines first, let tension fester while we worry about outside attacks.”

Lonnie rubbed the bridge of her nose. “Your… your Etherian asked me to talk Rogelio down. She thought—well, she thought it would be better to avoid unnecessary conflict with the clones.”

Catra’s expression hardened. The warmth she had felt toward Lonnie earlier flickered like a candle in a draft.

“And… did you?”

“Your highness…” Lonnie hesitated, then continued, her voice tight. “The… the clones… there’s been some speculation… inappropriate speculation about… you.”

Catra’s lips twitched. “You talk about me too,” she said flatly. “All of you. Individually. Collectively. Did you really think I was oblivious? We’re all experts in hypocrisy here, apparently. But you—do I sense discomfort at being caught?”

Lonnie’s face reddened. “It’s different when your soldiers do it,” she murmured.

“Oh, I’m certain you mean it with the utmost respect when you debate whether get on my knees and swallow. I do, if that settles the discussion. Do you want me to demonstrate? Perhaps locate an appropriate vegetable as a visual aid?” Catra’s tone was cutting, mocking, but under it was steel. “Do you know why

Rogelio nearly murdered my Etherian this morning? I suggest clarity, Lonnie, before my temper gets the better of me."

Lonnie's flush deepened, but her eyes were steady. She had seen Catra at her worst, and still, she didn't falter. Not fully. "I understand," she said, voice tight. "I told Rogelio about Mara's concerns—but she thought I went behind his back. That's why he reacted. Infighting starts before the week has even ended."

"Fascinating how loyalty twists itself into a knife," Catra said dryly, eyes narrowing.

"I'll fix it," Lonnie said firmly.

"Oh? And how do you plan to do that?" Catra's tone was sharp, amused, dangerous.

"By… by making sure everyone understands the truth," Lonnie stammered.

"Then your real concern," Catra said, voice softening only slightly, "is who's offended. The Etherian may think you set her up. Rogelio doesn't handle embarrassment well. Keep that in mind."

"I… I'll fix it," Lonnie repeated, tighter this time, more certain.

Catra studied her for a long moment, then finally nodded. "Dismissed," she said. "Have the soldiers prepare for departure. Perhaps the day's drive will cool tempers… and remind everyone who is in charge."

https://open.spotify.com/playlist/3mRrf9vcf2NkzUQ80tX5a1?si=IoezCXQXRHGxn-Xa6GhkXA&pi=-r5Lv9ZcTy-XY

Chapter End Notes

> The link: These are the songs I listen to to get into the right headspace for this story. The art is mine. A concept I had before I started writing this.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

CW: past sa, abuse, mention of continuing abuse, and trauma

Please enjoy 😊

Catra was small enough that her legs didn't quite reach the end of the cot, and her blanket had slipped halfway to the floor again. She kicked it back up, grumbling softly, then froze when the room filled with a wash of golden light.

Shadow Weaver sat beside her bed, fingers raised, the faint shimmer of magic spilling from her hands. It bent and curled into shapes Catra had never seen before, bright threads of color weaving together into tiny, glowing figures.

"There is a realm far away, called Eternia," Shadow Weaver murmured, her voice low and even, the way she only ever spoke to Catra. "And in that realm lives a hero. His name… is He-Man."

The glowing figure swelled larger, a broad-shouldered warrior with a shining sword raised high. Catra's ears perked, her wide eyes drinking it all in. He-Man's sword caught the light and split it into dozens of sparkling stars that drifted through the tent. Catra reached up to paw at one, giggling when it burst into sparks against her fingertips.

“He protects Eternia, with the help of his friends,” Shadow Weaver continued. A new figure appeared beside him: a man in armor, with strange, clever eyes; then a massive green-striped cat, its mouth opening in a silent roar; and finally, a woman draped in white feathers, wings spread wide. The Sorceress.

Catra curled against Shadow Weaver’s side, small claws clutching at the edge of her sleeve. She wanted the story to go slowly, so she could see every detail.

“And who do they fight?” she asked in a gleeful whisper.

Shadow Weaver’s magic darkened, twisting into a jagged figure with a skull for a face, cloak billowing like smoke. “The one they call Skeletor,” she said, her voice deepening for effect. The villain’s staff crackled with purple light, clashing against He-Man’s sword in a burst of sparks that made Catra squeak in delight.

The battle raged in the air above them, fierce and dazzling. He-Man and Skeletor clashed again and again, the light flashing so bright Catra had to squint, but she refused to look away. Her heart thumped, her little fists tight around Shadow Weaver’s sleeve.

And then, at the last moment, He-Man’s blade struck true. Skeletor’s magic shattered apart in a crackle of sparks, fading into smoke. He-Man stood tall, victorious.

Catra’s body relaxed, the tension ebbing away. She nestled closer into Shadow Weaver’s robes, the warmth of her magic and the steady rise and fall of her breathing lulling Catra toward sleep.

Catra spoke up one last time:

"Does Skeletor stay gone for good? Are we safe?"

"Catra," Shadow Weaver murmured softly, "it's just a story my dear."

The last thing she saw was He-Man raising his sword in triumph, the glow fading to nothing as her eyelids drooped. The last thing she felt was Shadow Weaver’s arms gathering her up, holding her safe and close.

Catra dreamed with a smile on her face, while He-Man defeated Skeletor again and again.

✧

The Keep looked even worse than it had a decade ago, the stone walls sagging like they were tired of holding themselves upright. They hadn’t stayed in the buildings then either, too far gone to be safe. The tents felt steadier somehow, their canvas pulled tight

against the wind. Catra's was the same one that had once belonged to her mother.

She lay back on the cot, staring at the patterned ceiling cloth, letting herself get pulled under by the memory. Shadow Weaver's hand brushing through her hair as light from her magic flickered across the room. That tired, put-upon sigh whenever Catra crawled into her bed, telling her she was too old for silly nightmares—and then the way she always went quiet, never pushing her away. Catra felt the tug of it like two worlds pulling at her ribs: the girl she had been, and the woman she was now. Neither of them felt real.

The flap to her tent jerked open without warning.

"Seriously?" Catra muttered, not even lifting her head.

Lonnie stormed in like she owned the place. No announcement, no hesitation, just the thump of her boots on the rug.

"You need to turn off Clone Twenty-Eight," she snapped.

Catra didn't answer right away. She stayed flat on her back, hands folded over her stomach, pretending her body wasn't aching from three days of travel and half-sleepless nights.

“Turn off one of the only soldiers outside my unit who actually works without complaining?” Catra asked. She finally rolled to sit up, smooth as she could manage, hiding the stiffness in her shoulders. “You’ll have to remind me which one that is. I don’t keep them straight. Clone Twenty-Eight, you said?”

Lonnie crossed her arms. “He doesn’t shut up. Always running his mouth. Rogelio’s gonna snap if it keeps up, and when he does, Hordak’ll string him up instead. That’s how it goes.” Her voice cracked sharp, like she’d been sitting on this too long. “You expect the people who love you to just sit there and take it—for you?”

The word—*love*—it almost made Catra laugh, except she couldn’t bring herself to waste the effort.

Instead she looked Lonnie straight on and said flatly, “I expect them to have self-control, like the adults they supposedly are.”

That should’ve ended it. Should’ve sent Lonnie slinking back out. But she just stood there, jaw tight, glaring like Catra had betrayed her personally. Then she spun on her heel and shoved the flap aside, storming out without so much as a bow or a salute.

Catra sat for a long moment in the silence she left behind. Her most reliable officer, breaking chain of command, yelling at her like she was anyone else. Prime didn’t need to swing a sword—he only had to nudge, and even the steady ones cracked. Catra stretched, biting back a wince as her uniform cut into her shoulders. The pop in her spine barely helped.

The flap moved again. This time it was Adora.

"You think I should send off Clone Twenty-Eight," Catra said immediately, not giving her the satisfaction of a warm welcome. "Lonnie's already lectured me about it." She slid into the chair at her desk, pulling the stack of supply reports toward her.

Adora blinked at her, caught off guard, then crossed her arms. "Clone Twenty-Eight's fine. He works hard. Fights hard. Better than most of them." A pause. A faint frown tugged at her mouth. "If you wanna send someone off, send off Entrapta."

Catra's head jerked up, her pen freezing mid-scratch. "…What?"

Adora leaned on the desk, close enough to make it feel like a challenge. "She's too scatterbrained. She doesn't take things seriously. She stirs things up without even noticing." She ticked the points off on her fingers, never looking away. "She's not why I came here, but since you asked—she's trouble. And one of these days she's gonna stop mooning over her machines and actually do something with the clones. And when that happens, things are gonna get a lot worse."

Catra leaned back in her chair, tail twitching lazily behind her. She had thought about Entrapta—mostly about how much of a headache she could become. The girl drew attention like a beacon, chattering about wires and schematics as if no one would notice how badly she wanted Prime's eye on her. Catra hadn't

sought her out. Wouldn't risk it. But Entrapta had still found her, slipping in through Lonnie when Catra herself had been too busy preparing to be bothered. Lonnie vouched for her, and that had been enough—for the moment.

"I can't turn her off," Catra said finally, her tone flat, like the whole conversation bored her. "She's not just another soldier. Her benefactor's Double Trouble."

Catra saw the shift in Adora's face, the way her shoulders stiffened slightly. Sometimes Catra swore she could see the way Adora thought—the pieces moving, connections slotting together, like a puzzle snapping into place. Honor had made her predictable once. But now? Catra wasn't sure anymore.

"And which border post does Double Trouble control?" Adora asked.

"Talon Mountain."

Adora's eyes narrowed. "So you're ususing the girl to get close to Double Trouble."

Wrong conclusion. Disappointing, really.

"Entrapta isn't some kid who wandered in after a shiny toy," Catra shot back. "She's technically Etherian royalty. She chose to side

with the Horde, Mara. She knows that this puts her benefactor in a bind. And she's fine with it." She flicked her pen back to the stack of reports, deliberately dismissive, like Adora's disapproval wasn't worth her time. "Half the reason she's here is because she wants someone—anyone—to pay attention to her."

Silence stretched out. One beat. Two. Catra was good at silence—good at making people sit with it.

By the third, she looked up with a frown, playing irritation. "Still here? If you're not here to whine about Entrapta, what is it?"

Adora rolled her shoulders, her stance tightening like she was bracing for a fight. "You told me if I had objections, you'd hear them in private. So here I am. I want to talk about Hordak."

Catra sat back in her chair, eyes narrowing.

That was the problem, wasn't it? She'd told herself Adora was just a tool—a weapon dressed up in silks when Prime needed the show. But even with paint scrubbed off her skin and sheer silks traded for armor, Adora never forgot she was Catra's equal. And Catra couldn't forget it either.

She'd wanted Adora close enough to keep from undermining her in front of Prime's clones. She needed Adora's eyes on maps, her instincts in the field. That part was undeniable. But she couldn't have it both ways—treat Adora like a mouthy slave one moment,

then a commander the next. Catra might not know what she was doing half the time. But Adora? Adora did.

Adora had brought down the Fright Zone. She'd struck down Shadow Weaver. She'd survived on the Flagship despite Catra's best efforts. If anyone had earned the right to be heard, maybe it was her.

Catra hated that truth. Hated that letting Adora speak meant admitting, even silently, that she wasn't enough on her own. That the butcher who had taken away her mother could bring something to the table Catra herself lacked. It wasn't strength to keep Adora gagged and kneeling. Not now. Not when Catra needed her.

She forced herself to nod once. Slow. Controlled.

If Adora was surprised, she didn't show it. She just stood there, thoughtful, weighing her words like she actually wanted them to land right. Like she thought they mattered.

Maybe Catra was wrong. Maybe Adora actually believed in their deal—that she could argue her case in private, like an equal. Maybe she had no idea what it cost Catra, every time, to let her stand there and talk to her. To admit, even by silence, that she needed her.

Adora was used to being heard. Catra wasn't.

When Adora finally spoke, it wasn’t the voice of a soldier begging forgiveness, or a slave testing her chain. It was steady. It was equal. “I know—for whatever reason—you’re giving Hordak way too much freedom.”

Catra’s ears flicked back, but she didn’t interrupt.

“Maybe you’re waiting for him to trip himself up, or maybe you think the worse he looks, the easier he’ll be to cut loose later,” Adora went on, patient in that way that made Catra want to claw her face. “But that’s not what’s happening. The soldiers don’t see it that way. Right now, they hate *him*. By tomorrow, they’ll hate *you* for letting him run unchecked. You need to bring him under control. Fast.”

Catra kept her face blank.

Adora took a step closer, stubborn eyes locked on hers. “I know you can rein him in without making it look like you’re defying Prime. You’re not afraid of Hordak. You're just being reckless for some reason.”

That jab landed too close. Catra’s claws flexed against the wood of her desk. “That’s enough,” she snapped.

Adora halted, but Catra knew that look—the one where Adora dug her heels in.

"The longer you let this slide," Adora pressed, "the harder it's going to be to get respect back from the clones. They already talk about you like—"

"I said that's enough!" Catra's voice cracked. She was on her feet without realizing it, tail lashing, every muscle tight with the effort of holding herself together.

Adora bit back whatever she was going to say. For once, she actually obeyed. They stared at each other across the desk. Catra's hands itched to shake, but she locked them down at her sides.

And then—damn it—her mouth betrayed her. "Why do you give me good advice?"

It sounded wrong in the air. Too raw. Too small. Like a kid lost in the dark. Catra wanted to swallow it back down, claw it into silence. But it was there now, hanging between them.

Adora's fists clenched at her sides. She looked frustrated, angry—but the way she spoke was careful, almost soft. "Why don't you ever take it?"

Catra’s breath caught. She wanted to claw the words out of Adora’s throat. She wanted to scream until the walls shook. Because Adora’s eyes were saying everything Catra refused to believe—that she wasn’t here to sabotage her, wasn’t maneuvering, wasn’t playing some deeper game. That she was here to help. That she could be trusted.

That she was the only person Catra really had.

And that was unbearable.

✧

Catra left Adora in the tent and stalked the length of the camp, restless.

She didn’t waste time twisting Adora’s words in her head, trying to catch some hidden edge. Adora had been right, and Catra knew it. Hordak wasn’t a wild card anymore; he was dead weight dragging her down, and Prime was the one who benefitted from her pretending otherwise. Waiting for him to fail was just waiting for Prime’s leash to tighten.

She was still playing Prime’s game. Still chasing some phantom win condition he’d written into the rules. Three days into this campaign and already her soldiers were bickering, Lonnie had raised her voice to her in her own tent, and Shadow Weaver’s murderer—Adora, the so-called Mage-Slayer—was in her head

every third thought, as if her voice had worked its way into Catra's bones.

Had Prime seen that coming? Was this his idea of a joke—send Adora, let her become the distraction Catra couldn't shake? If so, he was probably laughing himself sick. Within a fortnight, the whole damn army would be convinced Catra was on her knees for the Etherian Queen as well.

She clenched her claws into her palms, fighting the laugh bubbling in her throat. On the flagship she'd imagined her own corpse a hundred ways—flies in her eye sockets, jaw slack and rotting, her carefully brushed hair gone limp and grey. She'd told herself that was all she had to look forward to: an ugly, pointless end. But now, the board was spread out again in her head, the game alive and glittering with moves to make—Adora a carved piece she couldn't stop staring at.

Why was she still playing? Did she think Prime would clap her on the shoulder if she managed to outthink him, like some proud father? Did some pathetic corner of her still believe beating him meant winning him back? It was childish, humiliating. She should have flipped the table long ago, refused to take part in his farce.

She imagined the words: You were right. I was never strong enough to leave you. Take my body, my will, my DNA. Just let this one body stay free, let me rot in it. No army. No legacy. Just me. Let me stay me.

Wouldn’t that be simpler? Wouldn’t it spare everyone—the soldiers, the people who didn’t even know her name—from being collateral because she couldn’t resist proving she wasn’t afraid?

But if she surrendered, how many more would Prime grind down? A planet every few years, maybe more. That was the trade. And it wasn’t the Horde’s subjects she cared about—she knew that. She wasn’t lying to herself. Only part of her fight was for them. The rest… the rest was pride. Stubbornness. Spite.

She paced through rows of crooked tents, her ears twitching. Prime’s clones kept themselves apart from her own troops, but after only three days, their rot was spreading. The camp was thick with noise: laughter, drunken brawls, moans and grunts that cut through the night air.

And at too many fires, she heard her name mixed in with the rest.

“Think the Etherian stuffs something in her mouth when they’re at it? No way she shuts up otherwise.”

“As long as she’s on her back, she can run her mouth all she wants. I wouldn’t complain.”

“Please. You’d shrivel the second she looked at you.”

“Not if you shoved your balls in her mouth first.”

The laughter was rough, rolling, full of men who thought themselves clever. A soldier's humor, sure, but Prime's poison had sharpened the edges. Her own troops joined in, their voices taking on that same proud, possessive sneer, like they thought it was a badge of loyalty to claim her like that.

Catra didn't stop walking. She didn't look. But her claws cut deeper into her palms.

Catra had grown up in a world where soldiers kept their voices in check around royalty. Even their crude jokes came wrapped in a layer of restraint, coded in respect—at least when she was in earshot. You did not freely, loudly, and carelessly disrespect your Princesses.

On her fifteenth birthday, Catra had worn an austere black tunic with a collar pulled high, high enough to conceal the dark, fingerprint-shaped bruises along her throat. Horde Prime had pressed them there earlier that day. When the summons came that evening, she braced herself for more of the same, a continuation of the ritual horrors that had been threaded through her adolescence.

Instead, she found coldness. Ceremony. Horde Prime stood in his chamber like a judge behind a bench, not a lover. His face was carved into disdain. He told her flatly that he had "*indulged her twisted sickness*" long enough, that whatever had passed between them was at an end.

"*A being such as myself has needs*," he had said, "*But I should never have given in to your sick perversions, Little Sister*."

He had said more. Too much. Enough to leave her shaking when she staggered back to her rooms.

By morning, the rumors were already everywhere. Whispered across court banquets and in corners of the training grounds. Shadow Weaver, brave and tragic, a martyr to Catra's supposed appetites. Shadow Weaver, corrupted and preyed upon by her ward. Shadow Weaver, the victim. Catra, the predator. Catra was just a sick and perverted creature that seduced anyone with more power than her.

It was Prime's narrative, and his allies picked it up with sick eagerness. Believing it marked you, made your loyalties clear. To disbelieve was to risk being outed as disloyal.

The effect was slow but steady: it made her fair game. Every year after, the gossip grew a little louder, a little bolder. It became acceptable—even fashionable—for others to speculate on her tastes, her body, her "experience." She had tried once, briefly, to court someone, to prove she could be normal. That had only made the whispers worse. When she insisted on her celibacy, the sneers didn't stop. They just changed shape. Respect never returned.

Catra learned to swallow it. To save her claws for other fights. But she carried it, always: the knowledge that every laugh behind her

back, every crude joke, was another victory for Prime. Another reminder that he had already poisoned her name.

She wanted to ruin him for it. She wanted to make him watch as she gutted his empire, brick by brick, and proved that the "*vile, reckless, disgusting creature*" he named her could bring the Horde to heel. She wanted to do it for herself, for the memory of Shadow Weaver's old promises, for Kyle and every other forgotten child in the Horde who deserved better.

So when Adora offered advice, Catra listened. She hated that she listened, hated how much sense it made, but she did. She turned her focus to Hordak.

What would it take to get him off the board? To break him without breaking her fragile détente with Prime?

Once she started thinking in those terms, the ideas came quick. Setting the trap had its own sharp thrill: the clarity of the game board laid out in her mind, the neat satisfaction of seeing where every piece would fall.

The real question was how. She knew Hordak's weakness well enough—hadn't she heard it herself, years ago, when the soldiers thought she wasn't listening? On the march to Horror Hall, she had caught fragments of their chatter before it had been hushed: whispers about Sixth Base, about laundry girls who offered more than clean shirts, about men who wanted "special" company. The kind you winked and nudged about. The kind you whispered in

low voices, eyebrow raised. The kind Hordak was said to prefer. Women.

The memory was a decade old. For all she knew, it had been nothing but empty bragging. But it was something, and a gamble was better than nothing.

So she went herself.

The cottage was small, tucked at the edge of the Keep, but the lanterns glowed steady, and the shutters were well-kept. She circled once, sharp-eyed, before spotting it: the sign, subtle but unmistakable, a crimson thumbprint smeared on the leftmost pane of glass.

Inside, the place was cleaner than she expected, the air thick with incense and perfume instead of sweat. Women lounged about, not so many that they felt trapped, but enough that she knew Hordak wouldn't be left wanting. She let out a breath she hadn't realized she was holding.

And strangely, none of them seemed to recognize her. Not as their Princess, not as anything more than a customer. Their greetings were polite, practiced, careful. They didn't fawn, and they didn't flinch.

Catra wasn't sure if that was better or worse.

Because really—what else could they do, if they had recognized her? Who would ever expect to see the crown Princess out at midnight, shopping for illicit whores for her captain?

Her lack of laundry gave her away immediately. No bundle of shirts, no bag of linens—just Catra slipping in through the crooked door of the cottage. The women inside didn't hesitate. They pulled her into the warmth of the fire and the sweet-spiced smell of tea like she belonged there.

One of them caught her in a quick hug, pressing Catra's head into the softness of her chest. "Well, aren't you a cute little thing," she teased, fingers brushing Catra's hair back. "Like my first girlfriend. You've never been here before, huh? I can always tell."

Catra bared her teeth in something that could have been a smile. "Yeah, thanks, I'm just *radiating* innocence tonight."

Another woman, older, sat at the kitchen table with a mess of fabric in her lap and a cluster of lenses strapped over her eyes. She didn't look up from her stitching as she said, "Bit young to come sniffing around on your own. Married, are you? That's usually when the soldiers sneak out, once the ring starts pinching. Or else you'd be here with your squadmates daring you on."

For half a second, Catra thought of Shadow Weaver—her sighs over the court ladies, her clear, steady preference for women. Further feeding the rumor-mill.

She smirked, let her ears tilt back just enough to look bashful without meaning it. “Sorry to disappoint. I’ve got…other plans tonight.”

In truth, she wondered what Adora would make of her if she walked back into their tent with one—or two—of these women in tow. Probably nothing. The stupid girl would probably enjoy it. Reports suggested most of her flings in Etheria had been men, though. Wouldn’t it be something to see her reaction if Catra handed her a man as a *treat*, like a bone tossed to a hound? Maybe one day. If she decided Adora deserved it.

“But,” Catra went on smoothly, “I was hoping I could arrange a little surprise for my captain. Tomorrow morning. He’s…let’s just say he’s been in a mood, and we’ve got a long march ahead. I’d rather he start the day on something other than a tantrum.”

“Oh, I see how it is,” the mender said, snipping her thread. She gave Catra a look over her lenses. “Travelling hard these days, huh? Must be murder on that pretty backside of yours.”

Before Catra could snarl, a hand smacked her ass. She yelped, twisted away, and the whole room of women dissolved into cackling laughter. Catra rubbed at her hip and scowled. The novelty was definitely wearing off on this little adventure.

She pulled the pouch of coin from her belt and set it on the table with a firm clink. “Look. He’s…difficult. The experience might not

be all roses and kisses. You should know that going in.”

It was more than generous, a heavy pouch that hurt to part with. Catra wasn’t exactly drowning in funds, but if she was going to shove some poor woman into Hordak’s claws, she couldn’t stomach doing it cheap.

The women exchanged glances, quick and sharp. One slid the bag open, counted with her fingers, raised her brows. They all shared another look.

Then, with a grin, she tucked the pouch down into her blouse, safe between a pair of full breasts. “Honey,” she said, “you just let us worry about him.”

✧

Catra had wanted to play the long game. To sit back, let Hordak unravel at his own pace, and wait for the crack that would show her what bound him so tightly to Prime beyond the obvious—beyond that cursed chip. With half the Horde marching at his side, this was as close to “safe” as she was ever going to get for poking at his secrets.

But committing to this plan meant giving up other chances. Other angles. It meant setting aside the quiet sabotage she’d been running for weeks, abandoning the possibility that Hordak might slip up on his own. It meant risking the exposure of her own

hand, piece by piece, until she had no cards left to play but the dangerous ones.

And if she pushed further—if she kept walking this path—there would be no turning back. She would be choosing one future over another, cutting herself off from options she wasn't ready to lose. It set her nerves on edge. But if she didn't start laying the groundwork now, there might not be a future left to choose at all.

It was reckless. Not the sort of move Catra made, and certainly not the sort of move Prime expected from her. Everything in her training screamed at her to stay in line. She knew what happened when you stopped following the script. She'd paid that price before.

And yet, here she was, about to step off the board entirely. It would either destroy her—or it would change everything.

When she slipped back into her tent, Adora stirred. The pallet creaked as she sat up, pale eyes catching the faint lamplight, steady on Catra like she'd been waiting.

Catra stiffened. She had never gotten used to being watched for her return. Never had a servant she trusted enough to keep nearby, never kept a pet she wanted close, never let anyone past the walls of her solitude. It was intrusive, uncomfortable. Was Adora really waiting for her? Had Catra's entrance woken her? Would she ask questions—about where she'd been, what she'd been doing, why she reeked faintly of cheap perfume and soap from the washer women's den?

The truce between them was fragile at best. Could she risk sharing even a sliver of her plan, if Adora pressed?

She chose silence instead. Ignored the weight of Adora's gaze and sat at the table, dragging parchment toward her.

Her hand hovered with the quill, the letters forming in her mind long before they met the page. She hated how hesitant she felt. How raw. The silence pressed on her nerves until she almost wished Adora would break it—say something, anything, to stop her thoughts from circling tighter and tighter in her head.

But Adora stayed quiet, watching, and so Catra wrote.

The words were harder to commit to than she expected. Each line was a move, each seal a gamble. She played it out in her mind like the strategy games she'd once excelled at—if Prime countered here, she could strike there. If he forced her off one path, she might still carve out another.

Her palms pressed against her eyes until sparks bloomed behind them. She was afraid, she realized. Not of Prime—she'd been afraid of him for years. Afraid of herself. Of stepping too far outside the lines he'd drawn for her, of making a choice he couldn't predict or control. That had always ended badly before. Why would it be any different now?

Prime liked his pets with bite. He enjoyed grinding that spark into the dirt, proving himself stronger. But only on his terms. He never allowed a move he couldn't turn around, never tolerated resistance beyond the lines he'd already drawn. Every time Catra had slipped outside those lines, his punishments had been swift and vicious.

Adora's maiming had been one of those moments. Pushing Scorpia to bargain for the Etherian slaves had been another. Both had cost Catra dearly. A body lost, presumably—another its place. And then he tried to swipe her off the board entirely.

But what she was setting in motion tonight—the things sealed in these letters—went far beyond those.

She melted wax, pressed her seal into it, and set the letters aside.

✧

Catra woke with a sour twist in her stomach. Nerves. Useless, human little remnants she'd tried—Prime had tried—to carve out of her years ago. Feelings only ever made things harder, messier. If she could cut them out completely, she would have.

From the other pallet, she heard Adora stirring. Of course she woke early too. *Typical*. Another thing they had in common that Catra had never wanted to notice. Sharing the same room, waking

to the same soft shuffle of sheets and half-muffled yawns—it carried a kind of intimacy Catra hadn't counted on when she set this arrangement in motion.

She hadn't even shared a bed with Prime. When he was done with her, she was expected to clean herself up and vanish from his sight. No warmth, no lingering. Just silence, bruises, and the long walk out. That was how it worked.

It had stunned her to learn that Kyle—*Kyle*, of all people—had managed to worm his way into Prime's quarters often enough to actually sleep there. As if that was some kind of reward. Catra hadn't shared space with anyone like this since Scorpion Hill, when she was just a kid curled up beside Shadow Weaver in this very tent. Back then, she'd had her own bed, technically, but more often than not she'd ended up cuddling her mother, tucked under a quilt after a nightmare. Shadow Weaver would pretend to scold her—*this is the last time, Catra*—but she always let her stay. Always wrapped the blanket tighter.

Until Adora killed her. And the last time was really the last.

Now, Catra found herself remembering the tiny, private sounds that came with waking. The shift of fabric, the little groans, the soft drag of someone stretching. Yesterday, she'd caught herself staring before she'd even realized it—at the strip of skin revealed where Adora's nightshirt had ridden up, the stretch of muscle shifting with her yawn. Adora hadn't noticed her lingering eyes. Of course she hadn't. Catra had. And she hated herself for it.

This morning, she stayed still, feigning sleep. She didn't need *that* kind of distraction—not today. Not when she had a role to play.

She listened to Adora rise, wash at the basin, refresh the water for her. Heard the quiet murmur of her voice at the tent's entrance as she ordered their breakfast. Only then did Catra "wake," slowly.

"I'll need coffee," Catra said coolly, splashing water on her face as though Adora were nothing more than another servant. She was determined to get used to this intrusion, even if she hated it.

"I already ordered it," Adora answered.

Catra paused, just for a heartbeat, before resuming her routine. She told herself she was imagining the weight of Adora's stare on her back. That was why she kept her shirt on—why she was careful. Even so, when she bent to wash the back of her neck, she felt the trickle of water slide beneath her collar, down her spine.

Adora's voice cut into the silence. "Why don't you keep mirrors in here?"

Catra's claws tightened around the edge of the basin. "None of your business."

"I wasn't trying to pry, I just—"

“Do I sound like someone who enjoys small talk? Because if I did, it sure as hell wouldn’t be with you, *Mara*.”

A heavy pause. For a second, Catra thought maybe that would shut her up.

It didn’t.

“You don’t want to pick up where we left off last night then, huh?” Adora asked at last.

Catra drew in a slow breath. She tugged off her nightshirt and reached for a clean undershirt instead, making a point of not rushing, even with Adora’s eyes boring into her. “Look at that,” she drawled. “The slave gets it right.”

Another pause, this one sharper. When Adora finally spoke, Catra could hear the irritation in her voice.

“Do you need help with anything else, your highness?”

Catra slid her arms into her jacket and thrust it toward her. “The front. Then you can get lost. Go play soldier with the rest of them.”

✧

Catra had rehearsed this kind of thing a hundred times in her head. The trick was to start small—offhand, almost lazy. Let the words fall like bait in a crowded pond and see which idiot fish swam toward the hook. She liked it that way: calm, casual, like she hadn't even bothered to care until the moment demanded it.

The first sign was always that she spoke in public. When Catra turned her head and made her first remark, Clone 28 stiffened immediately, suspicion flashing across his face. Entrapta, meanwhile, looked like she couldn't decide if she should beam at being addressed directly, or crawl under the nearest table.

"I think my slave still has a few silks lying around," Catra said, her voice pitched loud enough to carry. Her claws flexed lazily against her arms as she folded them. "If the two of you were that desperate to entertain the rest of the camp, you should've just asked to borrow them. At least then your little scuffle would've looked intentional. As it is? Pretty pathetic."

That earned her a ripple of amusement through the soldiers nearby. Catra tilted her head, eyes sharp. "So what was it? A spat over who gets on top? Or were you trying to show off for each other? I've heard whispers about the kinds of *things* Entrapta's hair can do. Don't tell me my soldiers are really wasting my time fighting over that."

Entrapta's face went red so quickly it was almost comical. Her braids twitched and curled like agitated snakes. "Oh—um, no! No-no-no. Not like that! I, uh—your highness, I apologize. It was my fault. I won't do it again!"

Catra's grin widened, sharp and dangerous. She'd dangled the bait, and Entrapta had bitten right down on the hook. "You're sorry. *Cute*. What started it, then?"

For a second Entrapta looked like she'd been hit between the eyes. The blush drained from her cheeks, leaving her pale. Her braids twitched tighter, pulling close to her shoulders.

"It—it doesn't matter," she said too quickly. "Really. Just that I was wrong. Entirely wrong! Completely unnecessary conflict, statistically unproductive. That's the important part."

Catra's ears flicked, her smirk pulling higher. "Doesn't matter, huh?" She let the words roll off her tongue, then slowly, deliberately turned her gaze toward Clone 28. The clone managed to hold her eyes for half a breath before looking down at the dirt.

Ah. So it was that kind of comment. Catra didn't need the details to recognize poison when she saw it. Entrapta might've been the genius, but Catra had the instincts.

"Well," Catra said, stretching the word like taffy. "Guess it doesn't matter, then." Her voice was syrupy sweet now, her smile anything

but.

She glanced lazily toward the crowd. “Where’s the Captain?” she asked, as if she didn’t already know the answer. Several soldiers scrambled at once, eager to escape the crossfire. When they came back empty-handed, Catra waved a claw toward Rogelio. “You. Go find him.”

He gave her a look like he’d swallowed glass, but left without a word.

And then came the waiting.

It was always the same game. Hordak loved this part—making people wait, dragging it out, showing he could waste their time if he wanted to. Prime’s summons, Catra’s summons, it didn’t matter. He liked the power of arriving late.

Catra didn’t mind the power play. She minded the boredom.

Around her, the crowd grew. The longer the Captain delayed, the thicker the air got with amusement. Everyone could guess what Hordak was doing instead—tangled up with some unfortunate body he’d dragged into his quarters. It was almost too easy to imagine.

What wasn’t easy, at least for them, was imagining Catra had arranged the entire thing herself. No, that idea was laughable. No one could picture the crown princess scheming out something so messy, so indirect. Not even Adora, who usually leapt to the worst possible conclusion where Catra was concerned.

Catra’s gaze flicked to her across the crowd—golden-haired, jaw tight, more noticeable than anyone else. She didn’t miss the shift in Adora’s expression as the waiting stretched on. Pensive. Suspicious. Watching Catra like she couldn’t decide what she was seeing.

Good. Let her wonder.

The soldiers were restless now, murmuring, nudging each other, coin changing hands as bets were whispered on whether Hordak or Catra would come out ahead. Catra didn’t care about their wagers. She didn’t need luck—she made her own.

Whatever tremors of doubt had tickled her stomach that morning, whatever hesitation lingered from the night before, had been erased the moment Hordak appeared. The creature was fussing with his belt, adjusting himself as if to broadcast the evening’s indulgence. Catra noted it carefully: the way he wanted the world to know he’d made her wait, all while he got himself off. He had no clue that she’d orchestrated the entire tableau.

She kept her expression neutral. Calm. Controlled. No one could see the faint edge of amusement underneath.

“Am I interrupting something?” she asked, her voice low, a pinch of ice in it. She saw it immediately: the way Hordak’s sneer flared, how he reveled in the thought of some imaginary triumph over the crown Princess of The Horde with nothing but the power of his dick and his swagger.

“No,” he said, voice oily. “I’m done. What do you want?”

Catra’s jaw tightened. She wished she could remember Hordak from before Scorpion Hill, back when he might have been nothing more than a groveling, desperate little runt like the rest of the clones, bowing and trembling at the sight of someone with a speck of real authority. The look of petty desperation lingered beneath the surface even now, and Catra couldn’t help the smirk that tugged at her lips.

Hordak, of course, missed it.

She let the soldiers catch her first, letting Rogelio drag forward the boldest of the women from last night—the one who had slapped her backside with a grin that still lingered in Catra’s mind. The woman looked only slightly ruffled now, oblivious to the connection, and Catra made sure it stayed that way. Context, after all, was everything.

“You made me wait while you fucked one of the Keep women?” Catra asked, voice soft, almost conversational.

“Men need to fuck,” Hordak said, as though that explained all things—just as if she was also an object to be used and discarded.

“Men need to fuck,” Catra repeated, sharper now, letting the words sink. “But you’re not *really* a man, are you?”

Hordak’s grin was repulsive. It had that same oily, overconfident gleam that made Catra want to tear it from his face with her claws. The memory of Prime came unbidden—the same smugness, the same alien eyes that always reminded her what horrors could be cloaked behind a sneer.

“I fucked her mouth, not her cunt, no breeding to worry about.” Hordak said, as if that clarified everything. As if he had further schemes for her if the opportunity ever presented itself.

Catra’s teeth clenched. She saw it all: the posture, the tiny smirk, the certainty that he believed himself superior. She felt the memory of weight on her, the smell, the sounds, crawling up her spine—but she forced herself to hold it in check.

“Your problem,” Hordak continued, voice dragging toward a sneer, “is that the only body you’ve ever been hot for you own moth—”

“Draw,” Catra snapped.

The blade was already in her hand before her mind had caught up. She didn’t even remember reaching for it, didn’t care about timing or thought or logic. The rest didn’t matter. Hordak’s smug grin froze, just enough for the soldiers to catch a glimpse of what had been simmering under Catra’s cold, measured surface.

She was done waiting.

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra had known this would spiral out of control. She had counted on it.

It was never difficult to push Hordak. He was brittle pride wrapped in bad temper, easy to prod until he snapped. All she had needed was something—some undeniable excuse—to bring him down in front of the troops. She had expected to coax him into it, step by step, until he finally gave her grounds.

And then he had spoken of her mother.

The rest of her plans fell away in an instant.

For all her practiced calm, for all the mask of calculation she wore day to day, Catra was no stranger to losing herself. This was the same molten fury that had driven her claws through Adora's back—the same blind hunger to lash out, to tear flesh, to finally make someone else hurt, scream, bleed. To balance the scales of her own misery. To take something back.

Hordak had now become the outlet. Nothing else mattered. Not Prime. Not strategy. Not appearances. She wanted him broken.

From the corner of her vision, she caught a flicker of gold hair, Adora's worried stare, the hesitant shift of her weight as if she might step in. Catra shoved the sight aside. If Adora interfered now, she'd cut her down too. Rage wasn't something she could divide. It was all or nothing.

Hordak's mouth curled into a lecherous grin, slow and grotesque. He drew his blade with the air of a man exposing himself, savoring the display, eager to show everyone the filth in his head. For him, violence and sex were interchangeable currencies. Prime at least

had restraint, kept his tools intact until he tired of them. Hordak lacked even that.

He lunged first, swinging heavy, overconfident, certain she would choke now that the moment was real. Certain she would freeze and let him cut her open.

Her sword was already there, metal clashing sharp and hard. The shock rippled up her arms, satisfying and grounding. She twisted with the force, absorbed the weight difference, shoved him back.

The look on his face—genuine surprise—was almost delicious.

He struck again, then again, each attack clumsier than the last. Catra let him. She wanted to see him show his hand. What she found was almost insulting.

He was crude. Ungraceful. His blows were strong, yes, but wild—sledgehammer strikes that any half-trained soldier could read and avoid. He had power, but no discipline, no refinement. A brawler pretending at mastery. A thug who had once learned just enough to kill and had never bothered to improve.

She could have laughed if her blood wasn't still boiling.

He charged again, putting all his weight into it. The swing was stronger, fueled by frustration, but just as transparent. Catra's lip curled. This was swordplay for beginners.

She slipped aside, steel meeting steel, her blade taunting his with every deflection. Her movements were fluid, sharp, precise—more dance than duel. Shadow Weaver had wielded magic as if the world itself bent to her will. Catra didn't have that gift. What she had was grit, claws, and cunning.

So she fought dirty.

She baited him, circled him, let him waste himself with every arrogant slash. He broadcasted his every intention—his impatience, his need to be seen, his desperation to prove himself

invulnerable. Look at me, defying the princess. Look at me, untouchable. Look at me, the great Hordak.

Pathetic.

His swings carried weight, but they were slow, telegraphed, begging to be avoided. His ego screamed louder than his blade.

Catra cut through it with practiced cruelty. Her feet were sure, her sword quick, her tongue ready to slice deeper than steel. She wasn't fighting Hordak—she was dismantling him piece by piece.

And he was too dense to understand he was already losing.

Getting under Hordak's skin was easy. Too easy. Catra had a knack for it, like scratching open a scab just to watch it bleed.

"Pick it up," she told him the first time his blade went clattering to the floor. She leaned back on her heels, arms loose at her sides, every line of her body screaming confidence. She'd already decided—five times. Five humiliations before she let herself knock him sprawling with a kick. Five, and she'd make the whole thing into a joke, just for herself.

There had been a time she was kind. Soft, even. It felt like another life. Prime had scorched that version of her until nothing tender was left. Now anger fueled her, clean and merciless. Rage gave her claws. Rage made things simple. Someone hurt her? She hurt them back, worse.

And Hordak—oh, he deserved worse. She wanted him ruined. Not dead—that would've been too easy—but stripped of the little power he clung to. She wanted to make him small. She wanted to grind his pride into dust beneath her boot.

Especially after what he'd intended to say about Shadow Weaver.

So Catra smiled while Hordak sweated and gasped, his chest heaving as if the air itself fought him. She didn't so much as break

rhythm. She was calm. She was patient. And she was enjoying herself.

To be fair—if fairness counted for anything—he managed a better swing the next time. Sharper footwork. Less wasted movement. He wasn't treating her like a nuisance anymore.

Not that it would save him.

She'd already sliced open his arm in their first clash. A moment later, she carved a line down his leg, alien blood darkening the fabric. He stumbled, slower now, and she pressed the advantage.

When she batted his weapon from his hand again, this time with a bored flick, she didn't rush him. She let silence stretch, let every soldier watching feel the weight of it: their captain stripped bare by a girl who hadn't even broken stride.

"Go on," Catra said, tipping her chin toward the fallen blade. "Pick it up." Her voice was light, amused. She studied his expression like a collector admiring a prize—shame, fury, disbelief, all warring across his face. She made a mental note to tell Perfuma about it later, or maybe describe it in the next letter to Scorpia. Either way, it would make her smile again.

This was the real fight, after all—not steel, but humiliation. Catra weighed whether to let him chase her around for another few minutes, to make him sweat and stumble for the crowd, or to end it right now. Death wasn't on the table. Death was neat, final. Hordak didn't deserve neat. He deserved to be shown, piece by piece, for the blustering fraud he was.

So she stripped him again. A third time. The sword went flying.

That was when she saw it—something collapse behind his eyes. Quick, subtle. Too subtle for the onlookers, but not for her. His pride broke, and with it went the thin thread of confidence he'd been holding onto.

He lunged barehanded, snarling like some beast cornered and wild. No thought left, no strategy—just rage, teeth, and claws that weren't there.

For the first time, Catra understood why people hunted animals. Why they talked about the thrill of the kill. Watching Hordak reduced to nothing but instinct, stripped of reason and dignity—it was invigorating.

Catra hadn't loved fighting. It wasn't her passion. It was only studied under Shadow Weaver's tutelage first, Prime's later. She'd learned anyway, because she had to. Because she had been trained to. Because survival often looked like obedience. But left to her own devices? Catra would've put her effort elsewhere. Something that was hers, not theirs. Instead, all that untapped fire had been poured into combat, until the blade felt like a natural extension of her own body.

So when she squared off against Hordak, it wasn't about conscious thought. It wasn't calculation. It was instinct, smooth and precise, like she'd been born to it. Her sword came up without hesitation, and she let her body carry the motion through.

The steel punched through his shoulder before he realized what had happened. Catra didn't merely stab—she braced. She met his mass with her own, pressing the hilt back into her own collar, so that the harder Hordak charged, the deeper the weapon bit.

It was almost too easy.

She could've taunted him—could've asked if he'd driven the slaves half so deep, could've mocked the pathetic size of the weapon he was so proud of between his legs. She'd seen the reality of it. She knew the truth of his inadequacies. But there was no need to waste breath. The look on his face said everything for her.

The sound of him collapsing—his knees striking dirt, his breath coming in a harsh, wet gasp—was the extinguishing of her fury.

Like a flame smothered in ash. One instant she burned, the next she was hollow.

He was nothing now. Less than nothing.

She stood over him not as some desperate orphan, not as the frightened child Shadow Weaver had raised and protected until she was gone, but as a princess—a predator—armed with every advantage her situation had given her: endless lessons, practice in polished halls, steady meals, and time to hone herself.

And here was Hordak: diminished, disgraced, brought low in front of his peers. The same peers he had enjoyed lording over, humiliating.

Did she feel sorry for him? No. Did she regret it? Not for an instant. He'd earned worse than this, and if justice truly existed, worse was still waiting. Yet as she stood there, the taste of victory turned flat in her mouth. No sweetness. No satisfaction. Just emptiness.

Catra yanked the blade free. It came slick, with a tearing sound that made a few of the soldiers flinch. Hordak's gaze fixed on her, glassy and hateful. The rest of the crowd didn't breathe.

"Strip him," Catra said. "Take everything. His armor. His sword. Cast him out of the Keep. There's a village to the west—two miles, maybe less. If he wants to live, he can crawl there."

She hadn't spoken to the group at large, only to the nearest pair of soldiers—Prime's own clones, in fact—but they moved immediately, efficient as hounds on command. The rest stayed frozen, eyes fixed on her.

Catra was used to being watched. A princess. An orphan. The striking little beauty to whisper about. People always stared. But this—this was different. Their eyes were not curious, not indulgent. They were measuring. Weighing. They had seen her transform from a pampered, ornamental girl fit for nothing, into

something else entirely: someone who gave orders. Someone dangerous.

It left her unsettled, that realization.

And so she kept her gaze steady, careful not to flicker toward the one person in the crowd whose opinion she dreaded most. The Etherian. She couldn’t afford to know what she thought of her, not yet.

✧

“Did you seriously pay someone to sleep with Hordak?”

That was how Adora chose to greet her. No 'hey'. No 'Catra, are you okay?'. Just straight to it. Catra thought, not for the first time, that Adora’s timing could use some work.

“Hello to you too,” Catra muttered, tugging off one glove finger by finger. The deliberate slowness steadied her pulse. She wasn’t going to let Adora see how rattled she felt.

Adora waited, arms folded, all broad shoulders and disapproval.

“I paid her to approach him,” Catra said at last, tone flat. She had hoped—naively—that Adora wouldn’t piece it together, but of course she had. Adora had somehow been better at seeing through her than anyone else. It was infuriating. Worse, it was dangerous. “That’s it. I didn’t force his hand. Or anything else.” Her mouth curved in a cruel little smile. “He made his choices.”

Adora just shook her head. “No. You just made him think he had a choice.”

Catra snapped her gaze up. That tone—quiet, steady, and not exactly judgment, but not letting her off the hook either—it made her bristle. Was Adora actually defending Hordak now? That was rich. The sanctimonious Etherian championing the poor misunderstood tyrant.

“You’re not seriously taking his side,” Catra said. “What’s this? A moral lecture? Fine. You were right. It needed to happen sooner rather than later. I sped things along, that’s all.”

“Right?” Adora repeated, eyes wide, almost scandalized. “That’s not what I meant at all!” She bit the words off like she’d said too much, but the damage was done.

“Say it,” Catra pushed, teeth bared.

Adora didn’t back down. “You broke him, Catra. In front of everyone. You humiliated him. You brought a man to his knees for your own pride. Does that…doesn’t that matter to you at all?”

Catra laughed, harsh and empty. “Hordak barely counts as a man. And don’t act like you don’t know this is a game—we’re all pieces on Prime’s board.”

“Then congratulations,” Adora shot back, voice low but cutting, “you’re already acting just like him.”

The words landed like a blow to the gut. Catra staggered under them, though she refused to show it. Her breath stuck in her throat, hot and jagged.

Adora pressed on, relentless. “If you win their loyalty with tricks and lies, you’ll never really have it. You don’t need to manipulate them—they’d follow you because of who you are. You are someone they would admire. Why can’t you just let that happen?”

“There isn’t time.” The words came out cracked, raw, her voice breaking. Her chest felt like it was splitting open. That line—just like him—rattled around her skull, relentless, a curse she couldn’t shake. She pressed her hands into her stomach, as if she could hold herself together by force.

She couldn’t look at Adora. Couldn’t let her see the shame burning hot under her skin, the humiliation of being laid bare.

For once, Adora kept her mouth shut. It felt like a miracle—undeserved, but welcome. Catra dragged air into her lungs, slow and steady, until she was sure her stomach wasn't going to revolt. She refused to break down in front of Adora. She wasn't going to let her see tears. She wasn't going to give her the satisfaction.

"There isn't time," Catra said again. This time her voice was steadier, almost calm. She forced every crack, every tremor, down into the pit where all her worst feelings went to rot. "Two weeks. That's all I've got before we hit the border. Don't pretend I can charm Prime's little clones into loyalty in that time with—what? A smile and some pep talks?"

The words left her mouth sharp, but the heat still burned her throat. She hated how close Adora had gotten to the truth, how much it stung to hear her own darkest fears thrown back at her. Just like Prime. The thought made her sick.

You don't know what Prime is, she wanted to snarl. If you'd wanted to deal with someone worthwhile, you should've let Shadow Weaver live.

"I'm not the green fool Prime parades around," Catra said instead. She bit down on the lie and kept talking, fast enough to drown it. "I'm not here to make friends. I'm not here to lose people because they won't follow orders. I'm here to survive. To win. And I'll use whatever I have to."

Her hands dropped from her stomach and curled into fists at her sides. She tried to stand taller, like it might hold her together.

Adora's eyes softened. "You mean that."

It wasn't a question. It was… recognition. Like she could see how close Catra had come to giving up before. How close she'd been to fighting just to bleed out slower, so long as she took something of Prime with her.

"I mean to win," Catra said. Her voice was low, but firm. She bared her teeth in something like a smile. "Did you think I came

here to play martyr? To throw myself on the sword for fun?”

She expected pushback. Mockery. The usual. What she got instead was a long, thoughtful look. Adora weighing her words, seriously, carefully. Like she believed her. Like she respected her.

When Adora finally spoke, it wasn’t what Catra expected at all. “Two weeks won’t cut it. You’ll need at least a month to get them in shape. And even then, some of tthem still won’t be worth keeping.”

Something flickered in Catra’s chest.

“All right,” she said slowly, almost tasting the words. “Anything else, Mara?”

“Yeah,” Adora said, and for half a second her mouth twitched like she might laugh. But it passed, and when she went on, her voice was serious. “I’ll help. However I can. But it means no shortcuts. No games. You’ll have to do everything right.”

Catra bristled. Was that a jab? Or was it just Adora still carrying around the image of the spoiled little princess Prime had painted? Either way, it landed like a challenge thrown at her feet.

But there was something else underneath it, too. Catra turned the words over in her head—'you are someone they would admire'. She hadn’t really heard her before, not past the sting of being compared to Prime. But now, those words lodged there, gnawing, insistent. Not “could be.” Not “might be.”

Are.

Catra would have paid good money to know what was rattling around in Adora’s head. What made her push like this, keep pressing past boundaries that weren’t hers to cross. Fine—she wanted to stop a war. Noble. Heroic. But it didn’t explain why she had to come with her. Why she had to advise, argue, challenge. Like she knew better. Like she wasn’t fully aware of what Catra was capable of.

If their places were switched, Catra wouldn't have done the same. She wouldn't admit out loud that Adora had traits worth respecting. She wouldn't throw herself into saving Adora's life, not when it meant laying her own on the line.

Shadow Weaver might've. But Catra? Never.

So Adora wanted a fight? Fine.

Catra raised her chin.

"Watch me."

And damn her, Adora smiled. That grin—crooked, bright, too warm—should've belonged to someone else, anyone else. Catra's chest itched with the urge to smile back, but she shoved it down. It was too close, too dangerous. The same grin she'd worn after Shadow Weaver fell, and Catra couldn't forgive that. Wouldn't. Not now. Not when she needed her alive.

Adora tilted her head, playfully. "So? Should we take our seats, your highness?"

Their roles blurred, the lines cracked, and Catra hated how easy Adora made it seem. How natural.

Catra didn't hesitate. She swept into her chair like a queen claiming her throne, shoulders squared, tail flicking. She sat tall. Untouchable.

Adora didn't mimic her attitude. She didn't have to. She only looked at Catra, long and steady, as if weighing something unspoken. Then she sat down, simply, but with that unmistakable air of command. She didn't need to posture. Power clung to her like a second skin.

Adora. Mage-Slayer. Etheria's chosen.

Catra's rival. Catra's ally.

They were going to build an army together.

Chapter End Notes

I might get one more chapter posted before October, then I will focus on kinktober.

There will be about 2 Catradora one-shots for kinktober, too.

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

I said there would at least be one more, and I had a lot of free time today.

So maybe 2 more after this before I focus on Kinktober

**fixed the mistake where Catra calls her Adora and not Mara.

***hopefully everything is fixed this time with no accidentally cut sentences (don't know what happened there)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

By the time they called it a night, even Catra had to admit she was wrung out. Hours of drills in the dirt had left her ears ringing with shouted orders, her claws aching from clapping out the rhythm when the soldiers lagged, and her patience stretched thin. Still, there was a strange satisfaction to it. They'd hammered some order into that sorry mess of clones. Not much yet—but enough that Catra could almost picture what they might become with more time.

It was Adora's bright idea, of course, to bring Lonnie in. Catra hadn't been thrilled about that—dragging another set of eyes into what had always been her business alone. But she couldn't deny Lonnie's experience showed, and the soldier's blunt commentary had sharpened the drills more than Catra liked to admit.

Adora, naturally, had the most optimism of the three. She kept talking about "potential" like it was some hidden treasure buried in these soldiers. Push them hard enough, she said, and the rough edges would break away. Heat and pressure—that was her line—made diamonds. Catra had wanted to snap back that heat and pressure also made things explode, but she bit her tongue. Barely.

By the time the three of them were crowded in Catra's tent, sweat-stained and reeking of leather and iron, she was too tired to posture much. Still, she managed to sound sharp when she said,

"Let's get it over with. Your turn first, Mara. Don't sugar-coat it. I'm not in the mood to be handled gently—and if you try, I'll find the energy to get pissed off anyway."

Adora's grin was immediate, irritatingly bright in the lantern glow. Her blonde hair was plastered to her forehead, her armor straps still crooked from the drills. She looked exhausted but alive in a way Catra couldn't ignore—like this, here, was where she belonged.

"It's not bad," Adora said, leaning her elbows on the table, casual but steady. "Could be a lot worse. Tents are too slow to go up, you know that. But the drills worked. We're not ready to show off on a parade route anytime soon, but I think we can get them moving together, actually listening. That's the start we need." She tilted her head toward Lonnie, inviting her in.

Lonnie scratched the back of her neck and gave a short nod. "Right side still looked like a busted wave at the end. I want an extra hour with them tomorrow—ten, maybe five, pull the worst and see who's dragging the line. Just need to burn the mistakes out."

Catra flipped open her field journal, jotting names without comment. Lonnie watched her do it, then hesitated. Which was unusual. Lonnie didn't usually hesitate.

"If I can ask—" she started, then stopped, actually glancing at Adora like she was testing the air before continuing.

Adora didn't say a word.

Lonnie huffed and pushed through. "How locked in are we on the timeline? Two months would make a real difference. One's not enough to turn this lot into anything more than a patchwork line."

Catra snapped her journal shut with a little too much force. “We don’t get that luxury,” she said, flat and dry. “Prime wants us on the border. And as much as I’d love to take my sweet time, apparently we still have to show up eventually.”

Her tail lashed once against the floor in sharp punctuation.

Adora leaned back, arms crossed, but her expression stayed steady. “Then we make the time we have count,” she said. Simple. Certain. Infuriatingly optimistic.

Lonnie made a sharp, derisive sound through her nose—less amusement than contempt, the kind reserved solely for her attitude towards Horde Prime. Catra ignored her. She was bent over her journal, drawing firm, straight lines across the page to precise split columns. If everything else in the world was chaos, the page would obey her.

“Standouts among the clones,” she said. Her voice was brisk, clipped. “Who’s shaping up? Who’s dead weight? And I want names of anyone circling too close to bad influence.”

The three of them tossed out names, some overlap, some disagreements. Catra only marked down the ones Adora seconded. She tried not to make it obvious, but Lonnie’s eyes narrowed once, like she’d noticed. Let her. Catra could live with that.

Once, she’d thought Shadow Weaver’s trick of memorizing every soldier’s name, every servant’s child, was ridiculous. But Shadow Weaver had insisted it was duty. *How can I serve them if I don’t know them? I remember them because I love them, and I want them to love me, too.* Catra had stopped trying after her mother’s death. It had been easier to stay cold, to never give Prime more lives to hold hostage. But now—now, with Prime her enemy—it felt like the least she could do was write the names of those who might die for her.

“Entrapta kept up?” Catra asked without looking up.

Lonnie answered first, quick, defensive. “She pulled her weight. Had to do twice the work to keep pace, but she did it.”

Catra’s pen paused mid-scratch. She cut a glance at Adora, who just shrugged.

“She kept up,” Adora said. “She did good, actually. Maybe the trick is keeping her too busy to get… creative.”

Catra let out a dry hum. “I don’t think that will be difficult.” She gave the page another second to dry, then flipped to a fresh one. “All right. Drills. Changes for tomorrow.”

What followed wasn’t the usual grinding marathon of lonely calculation she’d grown used to. With Lonnie cutting in with blunt observations, and Adora’s maddeningly thorough breakdown of formations, Catra found the work—efficient. Almost bearable. The brazier threw out steady heat, loosening the ache in her shoulders, and when Adora finally said she needed to check the armor before sleep, Catra heard herself say:

“Bring it in here. I don’t care.”

It was insane, but she didn’t want her gone. Didn’t want to be alone with the silence that usually pressed down on her like a weight.

Catra let her head sink briefly into her hand, watching as Adora spread both sets of armor on the table. The way she moved—confident, focused, practiced—Catra could see it plain as day. Her hands knew each buckle, each strap, the weak spots where metal might bend or leather would fray. War was her element. Leadership was her air. She didn’t have to fake it.

Catra felt something coil tight in her chest. *This was why Shadow Weaver had lost*.

The thought jolted through her like a slap. She shoved it down, hard. Too dangerous, too wrong to hold onto. But it didn’t stop

her from staring across the table, watching Adora work, her pulse quickening despite herself.

For all her fury, for all her cold determination, Catra couldn't shake it: Adora belonged here in a way she never would.

Catra could admit it and still hate her.

Adora being useful didn't erase anything. It didn't mean Catra forgave her. It didn't mean she wanted her around. Not by a long shot.

Still, she found herself breaking the silence. "What do you make of Lonnie?" she asked, pretending it was idle curiosity when really, the quiet had grown too easy between them. Too comfortable. In another world, she knew, she'd be pacing the tent alone, wound tight and half-mad with worry. But here and now, she was going to sleep tonight—tired, maybe even hopeful—because Shadow Weaver's killer, that maddening, steady, frustratingly capable woman, was working for her.

"I like her," Adora said calmly, eyes on the armor in her lap. She spoke to Catra like they were equals, partners on a long march. "She's a good pick for captain. You should be proud."

That actually made Catra laugh. "No. *You* were."

Adora's hands froze, fumbling the straps. She looked up like Catra had confessed her undying love or something. "What? Catra, come on. No one here would ever take orders from me. I'm an Etherian. From Bright Moon of all places."

"I know that," Catra said, surprising herself with the patience in her voice. No sharp edges, no temper—not this time. "It's one of two reasons why I went with Lonnie. They'd fight you every step of the way. You'd win them over eventually, but we don't have the time for eventually. Not even with the extra fortnight. You're wasted in this role, and it pisses me off that I can't use you the way I should."

Adora blinked at her, genuinely thrown. “That is… not what I thought you were going to say.”

“Did you think I was too proud to see it?” Catra leaned back, watching her with something sharp and unblinking. “I promise you, Mara, my pride in beating Prime is bigger than any grudge I’m holding against Bright Moon.”

It was true, even if admitting it left a bitter taste. A week ago, she’d been prepared to die. She’d seen no other option, no other path—every move left to her led to the same inevitable end. But now? Now there were choices. Possibilities. She owed that to Adora, and she wasn’t about to throw it away. She’d use her for everything she was worth. She’d bleed the Mage-Slayer dry if that’s what it took.

And yet, some part of her knew Adora could never have gone to Prime’s side. Even with all the reasons in the world, even with every provocation Catra had hurled at her—Adora wasn’t built that way. Prime could never hold her leash.

Maybe Kyle had nudged her. Maybe not. Catra hoped it was Kyle. She liked the thought that Prime’s pretty little pet had cost him someone this valuable.

The ugly truth was hard to avoid: Adora of Etheria was a good woman. She’d chosen Catra, of all people, because it was the right thing to do.

“You just keep catching me off guard,” Adora muttered, finally breaking eye contact. She bent over the armor again like it could shield her from the conversation. “Half the time I think I’ve got you figured out, and then you say something like that, and I don’t know what to think anymore.”

Catra’s jaw clenched. She hated it. Hated her. There had to be some trick, some angle she was missing—but Adora wasn’t built for guile. She was strong, simple, straightforward.

A good woman. Shadow Weaver's murderer. A good, stubborn, infuriatingly decent woman.

"Believe me," Catra said, voice flat, "that feeling's mutual."

She wanted to feel relief, even gratitude, for what they'd pulled off today. She wanted to let herself soften. But watching Adora's bent head, her steady hands moving over every strap and buckle with sure precision, Catra clung to her anger like it was the only thing keeping her afloat.

"You said there were two reasons," Adora said carefully, fiddling with the buckle in her hands. "What's the other?"

Catra hadn't meant to say it. The words slipped out, quick and unfiltered. "Half the camp thinks you're fucking me in here."

Her face burned, but she forced her voice flat. Calm. Casual. Miraculous that Adora didn't immediately catch the crack in her mask—too busy fumbling the armor, nearly dropping it in her lap.

"It'd wreck my authority," Catra went on, because silence was unbearable and she always talked too much when she got nervous. "All that hard-earned fear and respect, gone. You look the part, sure—tall, broad, shining hero—but that's exactly the problem. Maybe if you were less… *you*."

Adora's head shot up, eyes wide. "Less… *me*?"

"Forget it." Catra dug her claws into her own thigh under the table to keep herself steady. She could *see it* if she let her mind wander too far—the ridiculousness of Adora actually doing it, those big hands shoving her down, ripping clothes instead of untying them. She bit her tongue until she tasted copper. Don't. Don't say it. Don't *ask* for it.

Adora cleared her throat, awkward as always. "For the record," she muttered, "I've never done anything to make them think that. I wouldn't—" She stumbled, tripping over the words. "Not with you."

Catra went cold. The heat that had been crawling up her neck evaporated in an instant.

"Not with me?" she repeated, too soft, too sharp all at once.

Adora looked like she wanted to crawl out of her own skin. "That's not—ugh." She rubbed at her face with both hands. "I mean, I haven't given anyone a reason to think that. I wouldn't encourage rumors. About us."

The last two words stuck in her throat like splinters.

Catra laughed, brittle and ugly. She couldn't stop herself. "Relax. If I thought you had, I'd have had you tied up and flogged already. Front would finally match the back." The words came out like ice, but she'd meant them as reassurance. Somehow. Her chest ached with the effort of holding it all in place.

Adora didn't laugh. Didn't even smile. She froze, shoulders tight, jaw clenched. The armor creaked in her grip.

Catra's stomach twisted. It hit her then, sharper than any blade: she'd been wrong. Adora wasn't thinking about her that way. Not at all. All those stolen glances she'd spun into something more, all that heat in her own veins—that moment in her quarters—it had been one-sided. Pathetic.

She swallowed hard, bile thick in her throat. She was used to being wanted for the wrong reasons. Used to disgust, too. But somehow, this felt worse.

"Forget it," she said again, pushing to her feet before she could fall apart. "Leave the armor. Just—attend me."

Adora rose reluctantly, moving behind her. She loomed taller than ever, broad and solid, her breath brushing the back of Catra's neck as she tugged her overshirt loose. Catra held herself rigid, refusing to notice the heat of her body, refusing to think about the hands at her buttons.

All she could feel was how much Adora didn’t want to be touching her.

By the time she stripped down to her undershirt, the earlier spark of strange, fragile connection had guttered out. She didn’t want Adora’s company anymore. Didn’t want to risk another word between them.

If Catra was ever going to let herself dwell on regrets, Adora of Etheria would be the last place she’d start.

✧

The drills were brutal. Day one had left the soldiers ragged. Day two? Worse. Catra was proud of that. She wanted them sore, raw, and half-broken. By day five, she half-hoped the weak ones would be dropping. Better they break here than in the field.

She hadn’t slept. Not a wink. Her body was begging for it, her brain chasing itself in circles. She’d wanted rest, or at least distraction. Neither came.

Adora, meanwhile, had passed out like it was nothing. Out cold the second her head hit the pillow.

Catra had thought about smothering her. Just a little pillow over the face. Quick. Easy. Gentle, if she was feeling charitable. If the blonde had snored any louder, Catra might’ve actually gone through with it.

But she didn’t. Somehow.

Instead, she dragged herself out of bed, lit a lamp—brighter than necessary. Maybe on purpose. Maybe she angled it toward Adora’s face because she was petty like that.

Adora only frowned, rolled over, and kept right on sleeping, hair a golden mess across the pillow, shirt twisted up her back, legs tangled in the blanket like some spoiled pet cat.

Catra stared at her. Thought, briefly, about spilling the lit oil. Pretending it was an accident. One slip and the problem solved. Adora would be dead or her beauty would be completely marred.

But she didn’t.

Instead, she sat at her desk and wrote. Updates for her contacts, neat reports that didn’t take nearly as long as she wanted them to. She couldn’t send anything out anyway, not yet—half her messengers hadn’t even returned. But the writing helped, for a minute. Helped her feel like she was still moving pieces on the board. She angled the lamp to throw more light across Adora’s face and kept going.

Then she started a letter to Kyle.

Her stack of unsent letters to him was getting ridiculous. Sometimes three in a day. She knew he’d never read them—hell, the kid might not even bother pretending he knew how. And if Prime ever saw them? That would be it. Kyle would have a target painted on his back, all because she’d dared to care.

So the letters stayed with her. Hidden. Quiet. Still, she wrote them. Maybe one day, when this was over, when Prime was gone, when Kyle wasn’t a pawn but just… a kid again—maybe then she could hand them over. Proof that she’d thought of him. Loved him. Fought for him, even here, even now.

Something like that would’ve saved her, once. Might’ve kept her human.

er pen paused over the page. She already had whole sections: the way she and Rogelio had made a fool out of Hordak in the barracks, the crawl of dread when she’d stepped into the King’s chambers, the way her pulse had soared when she forced Adora to press a knife to her stomach. Always honest about knowing it was Adora. Always honest about her “slave's" true identity.

Kyle, my brother, I know.

I’ve always known who she was.

She smirked to herself, then scribbled out the next line before it could stick: She’s never fucked me either. I wouldn’t touch my mother’s killer.

Her mind wandered. She wrote about the First Ones statue she’d always wanted to see—an owl goddess towering twenty feet, broken down now to rubble. Shadow Weaver had promised one day. One day had never come. Too much to do. Always too much.

She told him about watching Adora spar Rogelio, and the sharp realization that she’d never be able to kill her. Not properly. Not in a duel. Not in a way that would honor Shadow Weaver.

All those years with a sword, making a fool of myself. Maybe I should’ve been honing other skills. What do you think, Kyle? How do you kill a woman like She-Ra? I can’t exactly drop a building on her head.

She even wrote about Lonnie—Captain Lonnie, now. About how the girl’s eyes had gone wet when Catra named her. How proud she’d looked. Like serving Catra was some kind of honor. Ridiculous. Sweet. Sad. Lonnie had always been a little off.

She’d already written to Kyle about the new schedule. The extra fortnight. The drills designed to wring every drop of weakness out of the soldiers until they broke. At lunch, she’d hunched over her papers, scribbling like her life depended on it, proud and obsessive, determined to preserve every detail. A record. A monument to the impossible she was dragging into existence with her bare claws.

Now she supposed she could update him on how the day ended.

She doesn’t want me. That was the line that came out first. Stark. Blunt. No buildup. Just sitting there like an insult across the clean page. Of all the things to obsess over, Catra hated that this was the one she couldn’t shake. She read it back to herself, rolled her eyes, and barked out a laugh that sounded a little too sharp. She

didn’t cross it out. Instead, she scrawled underneath: *Everybody I know wants to fuck me. Except my enemy. Outrageous. Mortifying. Honestly—offensive.*

She stared at the words, lip curling. What the hell was wrong with her?

There had been… something. That humming tension whenever Adora came too close, when her hands brushed hers helping her with the armor straps, when they’d stood locked in place with a knife between them, and the air had gone hot and thin. Catra had leaned into it, prodding, needling, taking a twisted satisfaction in the idea that she might be driving Adora crazy, dangling temptation in front of her. But apparently, it had only ever been her own game. A one-sided joke where the punchline was Catra, the fool.

If their roles were reversed, she’d have sneered, turned her nose up, spat venom. She’d never—never—admit Adora had anything about her worth wanting. She’d rather choke. And yet—her body betrayed her. Even now, with rejection sitting on the page in black ink, there were thoughts. Stupid, involuntary, traitorous thoughts that crawled back into her brain every time she glanced at the girl sleeping in her bedroll. The way Adora’s mouth had felt on her… her tongue…

The lamplight spilled across Adora’s sprawled form, picking out all the ways she annoyed Catra just by existing. The broad shoulders, golden curls, her shirt riding up in a way that exposed more than it should, the arm slung over her face. Her mouth relaxed, parted. She held her pillow like it was someone worth holding. She looked —ugh—peaceful. Strong and vulnerable all at once. The kind of image that gnawed at Catra in places she didn’t like to acknowledge.

She tightened her grip on the pen, tore her eyes away. Adora, walking contradiction. Hero. Idiot. Nightmare.

Catra wrote until her fingers cramped and the words blurred. She hid the letters away, scrubbed her hands clean, and resisted—barely—the urge to shake Adora awake just so she wouldn't have to sit with herself anymore.

It wasn't loneliness. She didn't do lonely. She'd cut that out of herself a long time ago. She didn't care if Adora wanted her or not. She wasn't restless because of that. She just had too much work to do. That was all.

By dawn, she had the company out of their beds and lined up with weapons in hand. If she couldn't sleep, neither would they.

Exhaustion hit her like a wall about eleven minutes into the drills, but it was too late by then. She was already off, prowling down the line, tearing into them with the speech she'd been rehearsing in her head all night. Picking apart their stances, their sloppy timing, their weak shoulders. She didn't hold back—didn't know how to. She'd trained herself to bite harder when she was tired, and now the soldiers got the full brunt of it.

They'd never know she was going easy on them. That the cruelty she dished out wasn't even a fraction of the poison she turned on herself when she thought she'd failed. To them, she was merciless. To Catra, she was practically kind.

She didn't even mention how ugly most of them were. Or how many bastards she had counted among their ranks. Or the fact she had an entire column in her mental logbook dedicated to their abysmal bedroom reputations.

Those were gifts she was saving for another day.

Had she been Shadow Weaver, she'd have whipped the soldiers into a frenzy with some speech about glory, loyalty, sacrifice. Maybe even tossed in a line about destiny for good measure. *Yes, yes, you're all mighty warriors with enormous, gleaming swords! Let's wave them around and smite those filthy Etherians! Hurrah!*

Catra didn’t have the patience for that kind of crap. She wasn’t a cheerleader, she wasn’t a saint—she was a realist. And the truth mattered more than making anyone feel warm and fuzzy. If she thought they were pathetic, they deserved to hear it.

And as far as metaphors went? The only body in camp worth praising belonged to Adora, and Catra would rather slit her own throat than admit that.

“Oh, don’t look at me like that,” Catra said dryly, arms crossed as she surveyed the rows of exhausted soldiers. “Have I lied once? Honestly. Pick one thing I said that wasn’t true, and I’ll get down on my knees right here and apologize.” Her eyes slid to the newest recruits, and she smirked. “Clone Eighteen? Forty-One? Anyone?”

She was proud of herself for remembering their designations at all. Not that it mattered. No one spoke.

“Yeah. Thought so.” Catra gave a sharp nod. “Smarter than you look. That was a compliment, by the way.” She paced in front of them, tail twitching with satisfaction. “Here’s another one: you didn’t completely embarrass yourselves yesterday. Barely. But progress is progress. Let’s see if you can surprise me again today. Strike camp.”

✧

They were still close enough to the Outpost that Catra expected some kind of response to the message she’d sent about Hordak’s demise. At minimum, she’d braced herself for one of Prime’s pompous lectures, the kind that made her claws itch just thinking about them.

What came instead was… nothing.

A clipped acknowledgment. Two lines. No signature flourish, no smug posturing—just an official confirmation that change in

command had been received. For all Catra knew, some clone had dashed it off. Or Double Trouble, if Prime was feeling theatrical.

The envelope had held something else, though. A scrap of paper folded tight and shoved in with the rest.

Kyle's handwriting.

What the fuk are you even doing? Get back here and say sorry. I'm not joking—you have no idea what you've stirred up. And fuk you for making me put this in writing. I fukin hate you. —Kyle. P.S. Don't get yourself killed.

The paper was ripped from a poetry book. Not one of Catra's—thank the stars—or the entire company would've been marching on the Horde by nightfall. Even if it meant their certain deaths.

She held it for a long time, staring at the messy scrawl, the way the swear words were spelled wrong on purpose like Kyle couldn't quite admit to them.

Adora was in the tent when the note dropped into Catra's lap. She didn't say anything, but Catra could feel those eyes on her.

Catra shoved the scrap into the fire before she could think twice. Watched the edges curl black.

"The left flank's still sloppy," she said flatly, ignoring the flicker of curiosity on Adora's face.

✧

Two weeks in, the drills felt less like training and more like an extended beating. Which, Catra supposed, was the point.

Her own body was a patchwork of bruises, purple over green over fading yellow. Beneath her uniform her fur told the story of every fall, every strike. Prime used to comment on how easily she bruised—like it was some defect, another weakness to exploit.

But Catra didn’t limp. Didn’t wince. Didn’t let herself be seen shifting her weight when her back screamed or her arms trembled. She couldn’t afford it. Not here, not now. She’d been in fighting shape before they ever left, but even that hadn’t prepared her for the punishing gauntlet she and Adora had dreamed up. It wasn’t about endurance anymore—it was survival. And she’d be damned before she gave anyone the satisfaction of seeing her falter.

The soldiers were getting better. Reluctantly, stubbornly, but still—better. By the second week, they were holding lines instead of scattering like frightened children. Orders didn’t bounce off them anymore. They obeyed. Slowly, Catra began to see something like an army forming in front of her.

And Adora saw it too.

Catra hated how the girl’s face lit up at their progress. Hated how the excitement looked good on her. Sometimes, in the evenings, Adora’s energy filled the whole tent, her hands moving confidently as she talked, polishing blades or fixing straps. Catra would catch herself watching her too long, the warmth of the brazier in her bones, and for one dangerous second, she’d almost forget—

No. Not forget. Never forget. Just—stop thinking so hard.

A sound at the entrance broke her thoughts. Catra blinked, refocusing on the map spread before her. She leaned back in her chair with studied carelessness and flicked a hand toward the other side of the table.

“Don’t hover, Mara. Sit. You’re blocking the map.”

Catra told her to put together a list of soldiers and clones she wanted gone—clean cut, no dead weight.

Adora hesitated, like she always did when the order wasn’t simple. “Not more than ten,” she said finally. She looked nothing like the painted, silken doll she had paraded around on the flagship. That version of her had been unbearable to look at—mockery wrapped

in jewels. This one though—hair loose and wild, leather straps sticking to her skin from sweat, every line of her body honed again for battle—this one was dangerous in a way Catra didn't like to think too hard about.

"While we're talking about difficult people," Adora said, almost too casually. "I've been meaning to ask you something."

Catra leaned back, making a show of indifference even as her stomach tightened. "Yeah? Go for it."

"Why'd you let Hordak live?"

That threw her. Catra blinked. She'd expected some personal jab, maybe a question about her loyalties or her motives—not that.

"Why not?" she shot back.

Adora's eyes narrowed. "You know why not."

Catra said nothing. It wasn't worth smirking at, even though part of her wanted to. It was ridiculous, really, how her opinion of Adora kept inching higher—despite every reason not to—while Adora's opinion of her seemed nailed to the floor. If Catra admitted as much, it'd sound like weakness. Like regret. And regret wasn't an option. Not for her. Not anymore.

She poured herself a glass of water instead, letting the silence stretch until she found words that didn't cut too close to the bone. "Didn't feel like giving Prime an excuse to lash out at me for stepping out of line," she said at last. A half-truth, neat enough to slide across the table.

Adora frowned, like she was trying to see straight through her. "After he came at you, you had every right to finish him. Nobody would've questioned it."

"Sure," Catra muttered. What she wanted to ask was if killing had really become that easy for Adora—if it was just another reflex now. But she bit her tongue.

For once, she wasn't in the mood to pick a fight. Not with this. Not with Adora looking at her like that, blue eyes too sharp, too knowing. If she started that argument, she'd crack open a part of herself she wasn't ready to touch yet. Better to box it up, shove it to the back of her mind, and deal with it later.

"There's something else," she said, redirecting with the start of a grin.

Catra tilted her head, studying her, and then nodded. "Something else," she echoed.

That little grin—half amusement, half challenge—was somehow easier for Catra to stomach than the look of disgust she'd worn before. It reminded her less of blood and more of…

"It was a hell of a fight," Adora added, her tone lighter now.

"Obviously," Catra replied. And then she had to stop herself from smiling, because Adora's grin stretched wider.

Against her better judgment, Catra relaxed. These conversations weren't always terrible. Sometimes, they even felt like a win.

Adora leaned forward, elbows on her knees, eyes intent. "You must've trained for that. A lot."

Catra looked at her, and something in her chest shifted. She knew now she'd never take Adora in a fair fight. She wasn't meant to. Accepting that didn't feel like failure—it felt like breathing again after nearly drowning. Like letting go of a promise Shadow Weaver's death had wrapped around her throat.

See, Catra? she could almost hear her mother whisper. *See why I lost to her?*

It wasn't strategy, or calculation, or even malice that made Catra open her mouth. It was impulse. A reckless, unguarded impulse that had her speaking before she knew what she was doing.

“I wasn’t a fighter,” Catra started, her voice low. “That was Shadow Weaver’s role. But after her last battle, I—”

She caught it. The flicker. The way Adora’s shoulders tightened, the tiny flinch she tried to bury. She thought she was subtle. She wasn’t.

Catra had talked about her death before and Adora had sat there stone-faced, refusing to give anything away. But this time—

Catra told herself not to hope. Guilt wasn’t in Adora’s wheelhouse, not where the Fright Zone was concerned. To her, it was a nightmare factory, crawling with monsters. Catra among them. She had no idea what Shadow Weaver had been. What she had taken from them.

Catra forced herself to continue, deliberate now, steady, staring straight into Adora’s blue eyes.

“Adora of Etheria,” she said, drawing out the name like it was a sharpened blade. “Leading troops at thirteen. At fifteen, she cut through the Horde’s best like they were paper. And then she took my mother’s life.”

Her tone was flat. Controlled. She wouldn’t give Adora the satisfaction of seeing her bleed. It was fact. Nothing more. Still, the weight of it pressed between them like smoke.

The words she didn’t say hovered heavy, unspoken: *Do you really not see why I’ve treated you like this? Why I hated you? You did this to me first. You ruined my life first*.

She wanted to spit it out, wanted to force Adora to look at it—look at her. But she swallowed it down.

What she thought instead was worse. *Do you want to know how she looked when they laid her on the table? Do you want to know how she smelled, when I brought her home? Do you want to know what Prime did to me when there was no one left to shield me?*

Her voice, when it came again, was softer. A betrayal of her own restraint.

"They said she was the best warrior Etheria ever had. I thought if I was going to kill someone like that, I'd have to be the best too."

There it was. The ugly truth. She'd built herself in the shadow of her murderer. Adora's face flickered again, unreadable this time, but enough to twist Catra's gut.

She almost laughed. If she'd approached Adora on the flagship with honesty, without rage, without bitterness—played the damsel, told her the truth of what Prime had done—maybe things would have been different. Maybe it all could've gone neatly, tidily, with Adora slipping into the role Catra had needed her to play.

But Catra hadn't been capable of that. She'd made Adora into a monster in her head when she was thirteen because it was easier than admitting what she'd lost. Because hating her was simpler than hating Prime.

Now it was too late.

Adora leaned back, eyes breaking away first. Whatever ease had been in the air before, it was gone, scattered like ashes. And why wouldn't it be? Catra had just admitted she'd spent seven years sharpening herself like a blade against the hope of one day driving it into her.

Disgust was back on Adora's face. That stubborn, clean disgust that never seemed to fade completely. It should have stung less by now. It didn't.

Catra drained her glass, set it down with more finality than she intended.

"I'm too tired for maps tonight," she said briskly. "Attend me, then go. Do whatever you want. I don't care."

It was supposed to be an offering. A scrap of peace. But her voice came out cold.

Adora didn’t answer. She just nodded, jaw tight, and did her work quickly, efficiently, with the distance of someone tending a wild animal. Catra caught the way her hands lingered at her cloak ties, careful, cautious, like she expected vipers to spill out if she tugged too hard.

The moment her duties were finished, Adora stepped back and left.

The silence she left behind was deafening.

Chapter End Notes

Okay, one: I made the decision that Adora is two years older than Catra. She was almost even older.
Two: sorry, but don't expect Catra to admit what happened to her for a painfully long time.
Three: This fic has the warning "major character death". Neither character that dies in this fic will be Hordak or Horde Prime, unfortunately. They must live face another installment. There will be 2-3 major character deaths and you probably will not like any of them. 2-3 because I am struggling with killing off one of the characters. Maybe they will come really close to death.
And lastly, four: there is no ship tag for a pairing I may introduce.

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

CW: mention of past sa

Get ready for tense flirting and teasing. So excited to write the next chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Shadow Weaver lived in Catra's head like a ghost that refused to fade. Through the long, grinding days of drills and bruises, as their ragtag army stumbled into something resembling order, Catra felt her mother everywhere. How could she not? This—this mess of half-trained mercenaries, Etherian defectors, and camp-following trash slowly, painfully sharpening into something that looked almost like soldiers—this was the kind of transformation Shadow Weaver would have reveled in. She would have stood there, cloak flaring in the wind, purring with satisfaction to see Catra commanding, Catra shaping chaos into discipline.

If she ignored the context—that it was all in service of preparing to fight Horde Prime—Shadow Weaver would have been delighted. That part would have horrified her. But the rest? The pride would have burned her up from the inside.

And yet, every time Adora raised her sword, Catra's thoughts curved back to the same brutal memory: Shadow Weaver's body, split open. Adora's blade, dripping with her mother's blood. The grin she wore after the kill. Catra couldn't stop herself from measuring Adora's strikes against the wounds she'd seen. Was that swing the one? That angle? That cut?

Shadow Weaver would have adored Adora. Of course she would. That realization stung worse than anything else.

And she would have been proud—obnoxiously, blindingly proud—of Catra too.

The thought caught her off guard, enough that she half-waited for it to twist into something cruel. Normally, that was when Prime's voice slithered in, calling her a worthless, spoiled, disgusting little thing. But the voice stayed quiet, and for once, Catra was left with the surprising comfort of believing that if her mother could see her now, she might actually approve.

The drills were running smoother than Catra dared to hope. Below them, the crooked little town of Ghost's Ridge Stop nestled into the hills, peaceful and picturesque, a backdrop almost too gentle for the kind of training they were putting their soldiers through. She allowed herself, just for a breath, to feel as though Shadow Weaver's pride was a certainty—solid, factual, unshakable.

When she was young, she used to imagine Shadow Weaver's spirit creeping back to watch her on the flagship. At first she had wanted it. Later, she had dreaded it. What would her mother have thought if she saw Catra kneeling, obedient, pliant beneath Prime's hand? Bent and broken into positions she hadn't chosen? Prime had delighted in making her body betray her, insisting every shudder and every flush was proof she wanted it. Proof she was filthy, ruined, perverse. *You like it. Stop crying. Thank me properly or I'll teach you again.* What excuse could she have offered Shadow Weaver's ghost if she had appeared in that moment?

What if Prime had been right?

This—this was the first time Catra could remember thinking, *if she's watching, I don't need to be ashamed.*

"Left flank! Shields up, you useless sacks of worms! Did I say please? Do I look like I'm serving fucking tea?"

"Right flank, press forward!"

Lonnie's bark bit across the field. Adora's voice cut through from the other side. The soldiers strained under both, eager to impress either commander. And Catra—shockingly, absurdly—found they were willing to impress her too. Not love her. Never that. She

wasn’t Shadow Weaver, beloved mother to the Fright Zone. Catra could walk past any campfire and hear a dozen filthy jokes about how best to shut her up. Which way to fuck her into a better personality.

But sometimes—sometimes—she caught them looking at her like they might almost be proud to serve under her.

That was…something.

Adora’s gaze flicked over her shoulder, caught Catra watching, and lingered longer than necessary. Then she strode forward until they were side by side.

“Your highness,” Adora said, her tone light. She almost never used the title, and when she did it was usually barbed: half-joke, half-mockery, threaded with just enough warmth to confuse the hell out of Catra. Today it tilted toward teasing flirtation, casual in a way Catra couldn’t imagine getting away with.

Catra snorted under her breath. If she tried that kind of tone with her own soldiers, she’d probably end up bent over a weapons rack before she finished her sentence.

It made her wonder—why hadn’t Adora taken advantage of any of the soldiers who clearly would have welcomed it? She had the time. The freedom. Catra had never implied she cared one way or another. Lonnie was sleeping with Entrapta now, and far from damaging her authority, it had cemented her place in the ranks. Adora had no such excuse. Surely she wasn’t holding out from loyalty. She didn’t play politics. But maybe—just maybe—she was considerate enough to avoid rubbing salt into wounds Catra refused to admit she had.

Not that Catra cared who Adora fucked.

Still. The thought lodged there, prickling. Catra weighed whether she should bring it up. Whether Adora had earned something for her efforts. Whether Catra was willing to offer it.

“I like that look on your face,” Adora said, grinning in that way of hers.

Catra narrowed her eyes. “Bold of you to assume my face needs your commentary at all. What ‘look’ is it, exactly? I’d like to avoid ever giving you that kind of satisfaction again.”

Adora didn’t rise to the bait. Instead, she gave one of those earnest shrugs that made Catra want to claw the smug right off her. “It’s proud. You’re proud of them. You should be. You’ve earned this.”

Catra made a noise in her throat—half scoff, half growl—and turned her head away. She couldn’t decide if Adora was trying to provoke her or genuinely meant it. Either option was irritating. Adora had a knack for saying things that made Catra feel cornered, like there was no right answer that wouldn’t expose her.

“They’re… fine,” Catra muttered at last. “Good enough.”

“Catra—”

“Don’t.” She lifted a clawed hand, silencing Adora before she could get any more sentimental. Catra’s attention had already shifted, her ears twitching toward Lonnie as she passed nearby.

“Take the soldiers back,” Catra ordered, sharp and certain. “That’s it for today.”

Lonnie didn’t question her. No protest, no hesitation—just a nod and a barked order to the others. That was why Catra trusted her to begin with.

When she glanced back, though, Adora was still there, trailing behind like she belonged at Catra’s side instead of in her shadow. That was when Catra said, low and firm, “The pet stays with me.”

Adora didn’t flinch at the word. She only watched the troops march off, pride written plain across her face as if she had every right to claim it. She stood too close, too steady, as if they were

partners on patrol instead of commander and captive. And then Catra saw the way her body shifted—the tightening of her shoulders, the subtle readiness in her stance, her hand drifting toward her sword.

Adora had noticed the horse, too.

Nothing in the hills moved. No assassins sprung from the brush, no arrows whistled through the air. Still, Adora stayed taut as a bowstring, and Catra couldn't ignore it. If Adora hadn't found danger, maybe there wasn't any. Still, Catra gestured. "Stay close."

She approached the riderless gelding, and before she could draw her own conclusion, Adora said grimly, "They wanted you to see this. Your messenger never made it through."

Her tone was low, steady, far too serious for Catra's liking. Catra inhaled, forcing herself to meet it with control.

"Take the horse," she ordered. Her voice was clipped, full of command. It worked on everyone else. With Adora… not always. "Ride back to camp. Tell Lonnie I'll rejoin tomorrow."

Adora's face went hard instantly. Her jaw clenched, her eyes flared that electric blue, and suddenly she wasn't the obedient soldier trailing after orders. She stepped into Catra's path, broad shoulders and bristling energy.

"No," she said. Catra felt her hackles rise. Adora's stubborn streak was nothing new, but the weight behind that word—it was like she'd grown taller, brighter, impossible to ignore.

Adora's voice dropped into the kind of tone that made Catra want to snarl just so she wouldn't have to admit it rattled her. "Prime wants you isolated. You know that. Walking into town alone? That's suicide. We're going back. Now."

She was scolding her. Actually fucking scolding her.

Catra's tail lashed, and she bared her teeth. "You think you get to order me around?"

Adora didn't budge. Her eyes locked on Catra's, unwavering, steady as stone. "When it keeps you alive? Yeah. I do."

Catra wanted the anger to come. She wanted to dig it up like a buried weapon and swing it at Adora's face—spit fire, tell her she wasn't some wide-eyed princess, and Adora sure as hell wasn't Prime with another lecture. But nothing came. No heat, no rage. Just a hollow space where fury usually lived.

Which was exactly why she had kept Adora here with her. Not Lonnie. Not anyone else. Adora was the one she could count on to push back, to tell her when she was about to do something reckless and she was too stubborn to notice.

Lonnie would have said nothing. Lonnie would have obeyed, and Catra would already be halfway into the trap Prime had set for her. That wasn't loyalty—that was habit. Prime had trained them all in habits. Catra knew the script well enough: follow orders, don't question, keep the hierarchy intact. If Lonnie had stayed, Catra would be gone already.

Adora, though… Adora never let her get away with anything.

Even so, Catra wasn't about to just roll over because Adora looked at her with those big blue eyes and acted like she knew best. She forced herself to take stock of the ground, the hills, the way the shadows stretched. She wouldn't let herself be cowed by the soldier planted in front of her—whom she knew was more than capable of throwing her over one shoulder if she chose.

"It's the wrong terrain for an ambush," Catra said flatly. Her ears flicked, her tail twitching like punctuation.

Adora's brow furrowed. "The town isn't." Her voice sharpened with urgency, cracking into something that almost—almost—sounded like she cared too much. She took a step forward, and for one disorienting second Catra thought she was going to reach for her

hand. But Adora stopped short, fists clenching at her sides instead.

"Just… think, Catra," Adora said. Not begging. Not quite. "Isn't there someone else you can send?"

Catra's eyes lingered on her. "No." The word landed heavy, without explanation.

Adora exhaled through her nose, slow and steady, trying to keep her temper. "Fine. Then at least don't be stupid about it. Ride back with me. Wait until nightfall, then go. Take someone with you. A guard. You're not in this alone anymore. You can't keep acting like you are."

Catra almost spat the words before she stopped herself. *It's safer alone*. It always had been.

Instead, she swallowed it down and said: "Move."

Adora hesitated—but then, slowly, she stepped aside. She could follow orders, but only after letting Catra know exactly what she thought of them. That was the problem. That was the difference.

Catra stared at her, frowning, and Adora stared right back, stubborn as ever. Catra hated that it made her think.

The idea of dragging a guard with her made her skin crawl. She already felt caged sharing a tent with Lonnie and Adora. Some nights the three of them pressed in too close, their breathing loud, their presence unbearable, like insects crawling across her skin. Two was manageable—barely. Three made her twitchy. Four or more? Impossible. Entrusting something this delicate to anyone else, even Lonnie, even Rogelio or Entrapta—no. She wouldn't risk it.

She glanced at the riderless horse again, then up at the sun, calculating. Did she have time? Could she afford the risk of delay? If the contents of this message got out too soon, it would blow everything apart. Every soldier would call it betrayal, mutiny. She

didn’t have their trust yet. She didn’t have the groundwork in place.

Who could she possibly trust with this secret? Who wouldn’t turn against her if the truth came out?

Even Lonnie’s loyalty would fray under the weight of this.

Catra already knew the answer. She hated that she knew it. She hated how natural it felt, how quick she was to think of her, how much she’d started leaning on her without even realizing. Hated that whenever something hard, dangerous, or ugly needed doing, her first thought was always the same.

Adora.

And worst of all—she knew that if she handed this over to Adora, it would get done.

Catra hated how fast it had happened. A few weeks ago, the thought of letting Adora stand this close to her—let alone argue with her and *win*—would’ve been laughable. Now here she was, entertaining compromise like it wasn’t poison in her veins.

She forced herself to look straight at her. “Fine. You’ll come with me instead of a guard.” She thought she saw Adora’s shoulders drop in relief, which irritated her more. “But we leave at dusk,” Catra snapped, cutting off any chance of victory from lingering in the blonde’s smug little smile. “And that’s all I’m giving you. Don’t push it.”

Adora held her gaze. “All right.”

Catra blinked at her, caught like a rabbit in a snare. It took effort to break away, to scowl and fold her arms. “…All right,” she echoed, tone acid. But Adora still hadn’t moved. Catra tapped her foot. “Well?”

“Well what?”

“Is that it? You’re done? You’re really not going to argue with me for another hour?”

“I’m trying to figure out if you’re gonna bolt for town the second I turn my back.”

Catra’s grin was sharp, dangerous. “You could always tie me up. Toss me over the horse and drag me back to camp.”

Adora’s mouth quirked. And for one dizzying instant, there was something in her eyes that made Catra’s stomach twist. Heat, maybe. Or hunger. It vanished as quickly as it came. “I *could*,” Adora said, light and teasing, before pulling back like she’d stepped too close to fire.

Catra considered running anyway, just to spite her. She pictured it: Adora shouting, charging after her, tackling her into the brush. She imagined fists grabbing her by the uniform, by the hair—Adora’s weight knocking the breath out of her.

Then her brain betrayed her. The image shifted. Hands rough but warm, pinning her down. Breath against her neck. Fingers digging bruises into her skin.

Catra shoved it away. Her ears burned hot. She turned toward camp without a word.

Adora fell in step behind her. Too quiet. Too steady.

“You *could* just be obedient,” Catra said finally, unable to take the silence. “You could keep your head down and let me handle my own business.” She flicked her ear back. “Wasn’t that what you were fishing for? Suggestions?”

“I could be obedient,” Adora said, voice low, steady. “If you didn’t keep trying to get yourself killed.”

Catra barked a laugh. “Touching. Truly. I never dreamed you held me in such sweet regard. How humiliating.”

Adora frowned. “Did you really think I was lying when I said I’d see this through? That I’d stay with you? Has it been that long since you heard the truth out loud?”

“How arrogant my sweet little pet’s become.”

Adora crossed her arms. “Are you mad because I’m right?”

Catra tilted her head, eyes narrowing. “Do you *think* you’ve got the power to make me angry?”

“I don’t think,” Adora shot back. “I *know*.”

Catra bared her teeth in a grin that wasn’t quite friendly. “Then if I were you, I’d quit while you’re ahead.”

Adora’s jaw worked, but she let the silence fall. Which meant Catra had technically won. It didn’t feel like much of a victory.

By the time they returned, the camp was quieter—soldiers slipping off to their tents, grateful for a break from drills. Catra gestured for Adora to see to the horse and strode into her own tent without looking back.

She told herself she would rest, but her mind refused to stop chewing over the problem. She had pushed for an earlier departure. That meant no wasting time. Already she’d cleaned up, changed into plain but durable clothes, and laid out something for Adora as well.

When Adora came in, she stopped short. The bed was covered in fine, freshly tailored armor and clothing—commissioned at great cost in those frantic nights before leaving the flagship. She looked at it like it might hiss and bite.

Catra leaned back in her chair, cup of water in hand, enjoying the show.

“Change into those,” she drawled, ears flicking with amusement. She planned to watch every awkward, bashful movement, every

blush, every stumble.

It was no less than they both deserved.

✧

Catra lingered too long with the horses. Her fingers skimmed over the worn leather of the bridles, then pressed against the warm star-shaped patch of white on her mare's forehead. The horse leaned into her touch, trusting, patient, unbothered. It made something tight in her chest ache. She hated the thought of leaving them tied off the road like this—easy prey for anyone desperate enough to steal or foolish enough to try their luck against a tethered animal.

It was stupid, she told herself. Stupid to care about a pair of horses when she was neck-deep in politics, danger, and plots. And yet she couldn't stop the way her chest pulled at the siight of wide, liquid eyes that had never once judged her.

Normally, she would've hidden the softness. But there was only Adora here. No soldiers, no Horde officers, no one to see her falter. And Adora—of course—just waited, leaning on her heels, keeping an eye on the road. She didn't rush Catra. She didn't tease her. She simply… let her.

"Do you even know where we're headed?" Adora finally asked as they slipped back onto the road. Her tone wasn't sharp, but it wasn't casual either.

Catra flicked her ears back. She'd dressed Adora herself before they left camp, wrapping her in fine velvet, the kind of clothes that made her look more like a visiting noble than a soldier. A disguise, nothing more. And yet the sight of Adora done up like that—high collar hiding her slave's collar, sleeves covering the cuffs at her wrists—unnerved Catra. The armor had been easier. Armor belonged on Adora. Velvet did not.

She hated how her thoughts kept twisting—picturing Adora at her side in another life, in some impossible "what if." What if there had been no war? What if the Horde had come as allies instead of conquerors? What if she had been older, wiser, able to stand beside someone like Adora without fear, without rage?

Disgusting. She shut the thought down before it could bloom.

"I know enough," Catra muttered, voice clipped. "We passed through here often on the way to Shadow Weaver's old fort. I used to make her stop for pastries." Her mouth kept running despite her better judgment, words spilling quicker than she wanted. "We're not here for a tour. So no more chatter. We stay quiet, we stay unnoticed, and we walk away alive."

Adora gave her a sidelong glance, something between exasperation and amusement. "You've done most of the talking."

Catra bared her teeth in something not quite a grin. "And you've done most of the listening. Congratulations on knowing your place."

The town swallowed them as night deepened. Even after the sun slipped below the horizon, the streets weren't empty—farmhands trudging home, vendors packing up, guards swapping shifts. Catra had counted on the crowd to hide them, but the deeper they went, the fewer bodies there were to blend into. Empty side streets. Dark alleys. Too quiet.

Adora's voice broke the silence, low enough that only Catra could hear it, her breath brushing warm against Catra's ear. "We're being followed."

Catra didn't startle. If anything, she felt a rush of grim satisfaction. "Good. That means they don't actually know where we're going."

A fragile ember of hope flickered in her chest. Maybe her messenger hadn't been captured. Maybe they still had a chance.

She forced her focus to the map in her head—Ghost's Ridge Stop, its twisting lanes and crooked paths. She'd known these streets once, when she was small enough to trail alongside Shadow Weaver, before everything turned to ash. But the town had grown since then. Changed. She couldn't afford to lose her bearings now.

Left, right, another left. A moment of hesitation—was this the right corner? Then a glimpse of the old bookshop, shutters nailed shut for the night. That was it. Two more turns and they'd be clear.

But when she stole a glance behind her, the prickle at the back of her neck told her what her eyes confirmed.

They were still being followed.

Damn.

Catra froze mid-step. The narrow street curved into shadow here, quiet enough that the muffled noise of the town seemed far away. The building before her was nothing remarkable—stone walls, a plain wooden door. But the glass inset in the door had been smudged with a single red thumbprint, half-hidden in grime. Someone had pressed it there deliberately, a signal to those who knew how to read it.

Her ears twitched. Curtains had been drawn tight across every window, sealing in whatever was inside. To the unknowing eye it might have looked like a private home, just another darkened residence.

She frowned, tail flicking, weighing the thought that had just sparked in her mind. It wasn't a *good* plan—she could admit that much. But then, her best ideas had never exactly been good. And whether she liked it or not wasn't the point.

Behind her, Adora's voice cut through her thoughts, low and impatient. "Catra, this is ridiculous. Whoever's tailing us, we should deal with them. Not—" she gestured at the building, exasperated, "—whatever *this* is."

That tone was all the push Catra needed. If Adora hated it, then it was absolutely the right call. Catra's lips curved into something sly. She tilted her head, as if the decision had been difficult, though her pulse was already quickening with anticipation.

"I have an idea," she announced breezily. "You might even like it."

Adora's brows shot up. "*Might*?" Her suspicion was instant, written in every line of her body.

Catra didn't give her a chance to protest. She knocked, sharp and decisive, knuckles echoing against the wood.

The rush that followed hit her like lightning. The tangle of frustration and nerves that had dogged her since they entered town melted into something sharper, brighter. Excitement. The kind she hadn't tasted since she was a kid sneaking through Shadow Weaver's halls, heart racing at the promise of breaking rules and finding secrets.

This wasn't about what waited inside. It wasn't about bodies or beds or whatever sordid business kept this brothel afloat. It was about discovery—about stepping somewhere she shouldn't, about dragging Adora of all people with her. About watching that familiar scrunch of disapproval crease her face.

Annoying Adora was an art, and Catra had become its master.

She schooled her expression into wide-eyed innocence, tail swishing lazily, and turned to glance at her companion as if nothing at all were out of the ordinary. Her heart thundered recklessly in her chest, and for the first time in years, it felt like freedom.

✧

Catra's ears twitched first. The sounds leaking through the velvet-draped rooms were impossible to mistake—low moans, sharp gasps, the steady thud of flesh meeting flesh. A bedframe rattled against plaster. Somewhere, someone laughed breathlessly.

Even for Catra, who had heard plenty she wished she hadn't growing up in the Fright Zone or otherwise, it was… a lot.

The air was thick, cloying. Incense burned too heavily, cheap perfume saturating every breath until it stuck to the back of her throat. There was smoke too—something narcotic, not top-shelf but enough to leave edges blurred and heads light. Not the worst place she'd walked into, not the best. Passable. The silks on the walls were faded but intact, the carpets worn but not threadbare. A middle-of-the-road brothel, then. Reliable. Safe. A disappointment, really—Catra had been hoping for something grimier, something that smelled of danger. That was half the fun.

She slouched onto a couch with ease, tail flicking, claiming space without actually choosing a lap to fall into. When she glanced at Adora, she nearly snorted aloud. The idiot had perched herself on the very edge of the cushion, ramrod straight, like the couch might bite if she relaxed even a fraction. Her shoulders hunched, her gaze fixed awkwardly on the door like she was trying very hard not to look anywhere else.

Pathetic.

Kind of Adorable.

The men noticed them quickly—hungry eyes cutting across the haze, measuring, weighing. Catra met their stares with deliberate boredom, cataloguing the glass jewelry, the dated cuts of their tunics. Nothing here screamed wealth.

One of them—a brunette catfolk with a cocky tilt to his grin—caught her eye. She filed the expression away to mimic later, if she could stomach her own reflection long enough to practice. Catfolk were remarkably rare these days, especially in the Fright Zone.

"You're sitting way over there,"

Catra smirked. "Then get up."

She rose, and the brunette mirrored her movement. A sharp flick of her head redirected him toward Adora instead. Smooth as anything, he adjusted course, as though the tall blonde had been his target all along. Adora stiffened instantly, her eyes darting up, then down. Too slow to hide the way her gaze lingered—on the broad chest, the easy smile, the way his shirt hung loose and unlaced. Catra caught the quick flick of her tongue across her lips and felt a jolt of dark amusement.

Perfect.

When the brunette finally reached her, Adora blinked like she'd forgotten how to function. "Uh—" she started, but the man purred right over her.

"M'lady," he said, his grin sharpened now. "Anything I can do to help pass the time?"

Catra leaned back, stretching, enjoying the picture: Adora trying not to squirm, her hand twitching like she wanted to reach for a sword that wasn't there.

"Unlace her jacket," Catra ordered lazily.

That snapped both their heads toward her. The man blinked, surprised but game. Adora's blue eyes locked on Catra's with such force it nearly stole her breath. For a heartbeat, everything narrowed to that stare—the heat, the anger.

The man's fingers brushed Adora's collar before she snapped back to herself, grip iron-tight as she caught his wrist. "Don't."

The man hesitated, then let his hand fall. His eyes flicked to the iron band at her throat. "So—you're hers?"

Before Catra could bite out a reply, another voice joined in. Smooth. Older. From the shadows at the far wall, a man with sun-browned skin and red silks stepped forward, marked by the Scarlet Wastes.

“If you prefer privacy, I can clear the room,” he offered, polite but direct. “Give you space to enjoy yourselves.”

Catra tore her eyes away from Adora, unhurried, as though it were her choice. Her claws flexed against the couch, her pulse still too fast, too hot.

“You’re the Patron?” Her voice came out flat, steady, belying none of the mess inside her.

The man inclined his head. “I am. This house is under my care.”

Catra gave a short nod, tail lashing once. She was glad her tone had held. Glad no one else could see the sharp twist in her chest —the absurd, traitorous flicker of disappointment she’d never admit to.

Adora wasn’t going to play along. Of course she wasn’t. And Catra? Catra wasn’t going to want her to. Not here. Not now. Not ever.

That’s what she told herself, anyway.

Catra’s knees wobbled, but she forced them steady, refusing to let any of the room’s eyes catch the crack in her. She was furious with herself—too many jagged feelings cutting into one another. She bared her teeth in what passed for a grin.

“If I’m paying,” she said, “I call the shots.”

The Patron bowed, smooth and practiced. A little too practiced. It wasn’t the shallow bob of a thug trying to placate her—it was graceful, deliberate. The sort of bow meant for courtiers or princes, the kind that whispered *I see who you really are.*

Catra’s gut twisted.

“Whatever pleases you, Princess,” he said, barely stumbling on the word. The other bodies in the lounge caught it quick enough, collapsing into hurried bows of their own. He smiled with his lips

closed, the way merchants do when they've already calculated your price. "You have my word. Discretion. Silence."

Catra's claws dug into her palms. She'd gotten what she wanted, but somehow she still felt cornered.

"My *slave* and I want a room. Back of the house. Bed. Window. Lock on the door." Her tail lashed once. "And if you send anyone else in, I'll gut them before they can say hello."

The Patron inclined his head, unruffled. "As you command."

The room they were given wasn't much. Four walls, a bed draped in threadbare silk, and a window with ironwork curled across it like vines choking a tree.

Adora shut the door hard, throwing the latch. She didn't stop there—she shoved the low chest in front of it, bracing it with her hip until it scraped into place. Her movements were military, efficient. There was no trace of shyness, no flicker of anticipation. She didn't even glance at the bed.

Of course she didn't. Catra told herself it was a relief. It was better that way. Except it wasn't. Not with that bed sitting there like an open dare. Not with every look, every accidental brush of Adora's hand still burning in her skin.

The window ruined everything anyway. Catra crossed to it, tail flicking in disgust. The iron lattice was thick and ornamental, twisting together in obscene, suggestive shapes.

"This is useless," she muttered. "We'll never get through."

Adora came up beside her, frowning at the plaster. She rolled her shoulders once, like she was limbering up.

"Looks weak to me."

Before Catra could snap back, Adora gripped the bars with both hands. Her jacket stretched tight over her shoulders, seams

straining, muscles shifting under the fabric. She yanked once—plaster cracked. White dust rained down.

Adora adjusted her stance, jaw tightening, and pulled again. This time the entire grille tore free with a groan, crumbling chunks of wall tumbling at their feet.

She leaned the iron aside with a grunt and turned, that familiar half-grin flashing across her face. Infuriating.

"After you."

Catra opened her mouth, some sharp remark already waiting. But it caught. She was staring at the bed again. At Adora's arms, dusted with plaster. At the way her smile was so easy, like none of this touched her the way it touched Catra.

She snapped her jaw shut. Couldn't risk the words that might come out.

So she vaulted through the window instead, landing light as a cat in the alley below. The night air was cool on her face. She welcomed it.

✧

The rhythm of walking, the puzzle of where to step and when to duck into shadow, was just enough to keep Catra's mind from spiraling. Only once they were several blocks clear did it strike her how careless she'd been. She didn't want to be recognized again. Not tonight. Not here.

She pulled the coin purse from her belt and tossed it to Adora without ceremony. She didn't give herself the luxury of wondering *what if this is the moment?* What if Adora finally turned? Betrayal was an itch she'd trained herself to expect at any second. *Now? Now?*

But Adora hadn't betrayed her when she was half-conscious, drugged, and surrounded. Not with a blade between them,

pressed to Catra's stomach. Not even in the moments Catra had been foolish enough to sleep in her presence.

She wouldn't do it now—gold in hand.

Catra was certain. Absolutely certain.

Adora caught the purse, blinking down at it like Catra had just handed her a live scorpion.

"It's better if no one connects us to the Keep," Catra said, dry, almost bored. She flicked her eyes over Adora—the flash of silver at her neck—and her tail twitched. "And do up your collar before someone starts asking questions."

Adora's hand immediately went to the jacket, fumbling at the clasp. "I'm not the one who has to worry about being recognized. Everyone in this city knows the Horde soldiers are stationed at the Keep. You're not exactly… subtle, Catra. Brown hair, ears, tail—people notice."

Catra bit down on the retort that flared in her throat so hard her tongue stung. She *literally* tasted blood before she forced herself to say, evenly, "I brought a disguise."

Adora made a face. "A disguise," she repeated, heavy with disbelief. It was the exact tone she used whenever she thought Catra was being reckless—or arrogant—or both.

"This is the place," Catra muttered. They'd stopped outside a narrow-fronted inn, the lanterns over its doorway guttering in the wind.

Adora cast her gaze up and down the street, painfully obvious. "So what? You're just going to change right here in the open?"

Catra shot her a flat, unimpressed look, and tugged a small object from her pocket. A flash of purple caught the lantern-light—Kyle's gaudy gem earring.

Her fingers hesitated, but only briefly. Jewelry was complicated for her. She'd sold most of hers off years ago. What she'd had had been—gifts. Tokens. Collars disguised as trinkets. Prime's way of reminding her she belonged to him. Wearing anything, even something innocent, still scraped against that shame.

But this piece was different. She'd won it from Kyle on purpose, knowing exactly the degrading hoops he would have jumped through to earn it in the first place. She'd sworn she'd wear it while doing something to spit in Prime's eye. Tonight would do.

She slid the earring into place.

Adora gawked. Actually gawked—eyes wide, lips parted, shoulders locked stiff like someone had just smacked her upside the head.

Catra's smirk spread slow and smug. Oh, this was rich. She pushed through the inn door with more force than necessary, letting it creak and bang.

The innkeeper barely glanced at her. His gaze went straight past, landing deferentially on Adora instead.

The satisfaction that purred in Catra's chest was almost indecent.

Watch me, she thought, eyes narrowing. *I'll play the perfect Pet, better than you ever managed to be*.

She bet herself ten gold she could make Adora *want* her before dawn. Acting wasn't the hard part. Not for her.

Adora was the one who couldn't fake a thing to save her life.

"I want your best room," Catra said, cutting in before Adora could open her mouth. Her voice was sharp, just shy of a purr, pitched to carry across the common room. "Big bed. Private bath. And if anyone tries to come knocking—maid or otherwise—they'll regret it. I want her all to myself."

Adora winced like she'd just swallowed vinegar. She flashed the innkeeper a weak, apologetic smile. "She's… uh… high-maintenance," she said, and then—out of nowhere—perked up with this blinding grin that was so bright it was suspicious. "Why don't you go grab us a table, *Pet*?"

Catra narrowed her eyes. Adora's delivery was so clumsy it was almost insulting. Not even a token attempt to make it sting, no subtle shove, no handsy flourish. Just earnest cheer. Catra stalked off anyway, because if Adora thought she was going to win points for enthusiasm, she was dead wrong.

She picked her target—a table half-occupied by men nursing their drinks. She already had a speech brewing, a whole routine, complete with the infuriating little head toss she used to send Prime into conniptions. She got two steps from the table, narrowed her eyes, and—just like that—the men scrambled. Not a word exchanged. Gone in a flurry of boots and muttered appologies.

It was so effortless Catra laughed under her breath, her good mood flickering back. The night was dangerous, the stakes high, every step one misstep from disaster—yet she couldn't help herself. It felt good to play again. To poke, to prod, to make the world move for her.

She sat, her tail flicking lazily, soaking up the envious looks from nearby tables. They weren't worth noticing—she didn't care about their attention. But she hoped Adora noticed. Hoped the golden girl saw that other people *looked* at Catra. Wanted Catra. That she wasn't just some discard.

Adora finally returned, dropping into the chair across from her. Of course across. Always the wrong choice.

"What now?" Adora asked, lowering her voice, glancing around. She didn't look like a conspirator or a partner. She looked like a babysitter trying not to lose her temper.

Catra tilted her head, studying her. Maybe Adora just couldn't act. Or maybe she couldn't stomach it. Couldn't bring herself to sit close, to pretend even for a second that Catra could be anything but poison.

You killed my mother, but I'm the monster? Catra thought, the words pulsing bitter in her chest. If that was how Adora saw her, then fine. Say it. Spit it out. She wanted to hear it. Needed to.

Catra stood abruptly.

"Now we wait," she said, circling the table. Adora tracked her warily, posture stiffening as Catra slid in beside her, close enough to feel the heat of her body.

"What are you doing?" Adora hissed. Her eyes went wide, panicked, like Catra had just crawled into her lap.

Catra leaned closer, deliberately brushing shoulder against muscle, thigh against thigh. She smirked. "Relax, I'm committing to the bit. You want a disguise? This is how you sell it."

Adora's breath hitched, and for a second Catra felt that old, familiar thrill—danger mixed with curiosity, the sting of a dare. But now that she was pressed close, the execution felt more complicated. She could make Adora uncomfortable, sure. She could let herself ache for the rejection, bleed out that old wound again. But Prime hadn't broken her enough to grope her way through the joke. She wasn't going to force it.

So she sat there, close enough to rattle Adora, close enough to feel her heartbeat quicken, and whispered, smug:

"Don't tell me you're getting shy in front of a crowd."

For a moment the thought of her own hands taking liberties with Adora's body flitted into her mind, right here in the crowded inn. Cupping her breasts over the jacket, straddling her lap—

The image flashed through Catra's mind unbidden, and she felt her palms slick with sweat.

"I'm glad I brought you," she blurted before she could stop herself. Her voice sounded almost normal, steady on the surface, though her heart threatened to betray her with its erratic thump. She eased back slightly, just enough to keep Adora from sensing how fast it was racing. "I didn't expect to be tearing things out of walls tonight. You… do you visit places like that often?"

"No."

Catra's sharp laugh was almost a bark. "Not brothels, really?" In Etheria, such establishments were hardly necessary, after all. Adora's clipped answer offered nothing to prod at. Too disgusted even to speak to her? Catra's smug little plan risked collapsing under its own arrogance.

You tore the skin off my back. You are the last person in the universe I would ever trust.

The memory hit her with ice, and the thrill she'd felt seconds before curdled into a bitter twinge. Just moments ago, she'd wanted the rush of Adora's judgment, the sharp edge of disdain. Now, it cut like a knife pressed under her collar. Exhilaration shrivelled to something darker: regret, self-loathing, an urgent wish that neither of them existed as they were, or as they had been.

"Camp followers?" she offered, voice cooler now, teasing but calculated, trying to navigate the chaos of her own making. Lowering it, she added, "Pleasure slaves."

Adora didn't answer, of course. She never did when Catra was fishing for a reaction. Catra let herself watch the subtle shift in her profile—the jaw tightening, a slight flare of the nostrils. "Bright Moon," she continued, a thin smirk playing across her lips. "A realm of delights. You enjoy the chains on others. Just not on yourself."

Adora pivoted, forcing them face to face. Her height loomed, her presence pressing down with the kind of weight Catra could feel in her chest. The soap on her skin smelled clean, sharp, alien—different from her own scent, yet almost intoxicating. Catra's pulse betrayed her despite the hardened mask she tried to maintain.

"Don't strain yourself," she spat, bitterness coating the words.

Adora's lips twitched. "You seem to talk more when you're feeling uncomfortable."

Catra's ears burned. Her attempt to hide her reaction had failed, and she knew it. Every twitch, every micro-expression gave her away. Yet she couldn't help but hold Adora's gaze, despite the ache of her own emotions, despite the risk of being undone by a simple look.

Chapter End Notes

I had to stop there.... I feel like I want to do the next chapter in Adora's pov...

** I made a plan of the next 19 chapters. I swear this fic will be roughly 130000 words when I'm done. (I'm most excited for chapter 20)

~~Catra's breath hitched, uneven. She clenched her fists in the sheets, eyes darting anywhere but Adora's face.~~

~~"You can't—" her voice cracked, sharper than she meant. "You can't say things like that to me. Not when I can't keep you."~~

Also I gave myself a migraine from writing so much today. 🙃

Chapter 7: Adora

Chapter Notes

> Please keep in mind when reading this chapter that Adora has NO IDEA why she was betrayed, she is guessing at best. The characters are also different to the show where I need them to be. (Suspend your disbelief a little bit, all will be revealed in time okay. TRUST ME.)
>
> Enjoy one of the chapters that I have been looking forward to writing since I started writing Disposition. 🥰🥰

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“My lady,” the innkeeper said with a little bow. Adora stiffened, but Catra didn’t so much as flick an ear.

“Your room will be ready shortly. Third door at the top of the stairs. Honey will bring wine and food while you wait.”

Adora gave a polite nod, but Catra was already scanning the room.

“We’ll keep busy,” Catra said smoothly, then jerked her chin toward the corner. “What about him?”

The man she indicated had hair like moldy straw sticking out from under a greasy wool cap. He was hunched over a battered deck of cards, shuffling them with exaggerated care, as though they were fine treasures instead of bent scraps.

“That’s Rummy,” the innkeeper said. “Don’t play him. He’s a hopeless drunk, that one. He’ll swindle you out of your purse and your boots before the night’s over.”

With that warning, the innkeeper retreated.

Catra's eyes hadn't left Rummy. He was trying—and failing—to charm a tired serving girl, showing her a pitiful sleight-of-hand trick with a spoon that disappeared only because he'd dropped it in his lap. The girl rolled her eyes and left him to his "magic."

"Perfect," Catra said, pushing away from the table. "Give me some coins. I want to play him."

Adora's hand hovered over the purse, then hesitated. Her brows knit. "What have you done to earn them?"

Catra leaned in, her smirk sharp as she purred. "You want me to *earn* it? Say what you want, Mara. I'll deliver."

Adora flushed scarlet, muttered something under her, and tossed Catra the purse before she had to hear more. Catra caught it one-handed, helped herself to a handful of coins, and lobbed the purse back. Then she strolled across the inn, sliding into the chair across from Rummy.

They played. Catra bet silver. Rummy bet his foul old hat.

Adora tried to focus on the room instead of the sound of Catra's laugh. She found a man in a fur-lined cloak watching with merchant's curiosity and invited him over. He introduced himself as Sea Hawk, a trader with family ties in the region. His manners were polished, but his questions were sharp. Adora fed him a name and pedigree she'd borrowed from Scorpion Hill.

"Scorpion Hill!" Sea Hawk exclaimed. "Of course—you've got the accent."

They spoke of trade, alliances, and rumors of Bright Moon. Sea Hawk didn't support the rebellion outright, but he trusted the new Etherian queen less than he trusted Princess Catra. He mentioned the princess at Ghost's Ridge, preparing to face Bright Moon's envoys. Adora had to work not to glance at Catra, recklessly gambling, when he spoke of responsibility and leadership.

Food arrived: fresh bread, platters heavy with meat. The innkeeper, clearly favoring her "lady," had sent Adora the best cuts

By the time Sea Hawk excused himself to the stairs, the card game was finished. Catra had lost all her coins but won Rummy's reeking cap. Rummy bellowed laughter, slapped her on the back hard enough to rock her forward, then bought her a drink—with Catra's own money.

She carried the drink back to Adora's table, set it down untouched in front of her.

"Souvenirs of someone else's victory."

Adora eyed the greasy cap hanging from Catra's claw. "If you wanted a drink and a hat that badly, you could've just bought them. Would've been faster. And cheaper."

"It's not about the prize," Catra said, flicking a coin out of Adora's purse with light fingers. She palmed it, then held up her hand, empty. "See? I've been learning tricks." She tilted her wrist, and the coin fell out of her sleeve, clinking to the floor.

Her ears flattened. "…Still working on it."

Adora sighed, but her mouth twitched toward a smile. "If the trick is making coins disappear, I think you've mastered it."

Catra narrowed her eyes, but she couldn't quite hide the tiny purr that slipped into her chest. She leaned forward, elbows on the table. "So. What's the food like?"

Adora tore off a hunk of bread, holding it out like an offering to a stubborn stray.

"Try it and see."

Catra eyed the bread, then the men by the fire, then Adora—slow, deliberate, her gaze cool. Adora had seen that look before, had endured it enough times that she didn't flinch.

“All right,” Catra said at last.

The words sank in just as Catra slid closer, straddling the bench so she faced her. Adora’s back went rigid. Catra was really doing this.

On the flagship, pets seemed make a show of it—sly touches, giggles, feeding games meant to entertain their master. Catra did none of that. She stayed sharp-edged, precise, like she was dissecting a role she refused to fully step into. When Adora offered the bread, Catra leaned forward and bit cleanly, nothing playful about it. The only thing Adora felt was the faint brush of her breath across her fingers.

Playing the part, Adora told herself. That was all this was. But her eyes dropped to Catra’s mouth before she could stop them, then to the glint of Kyle’s earring at her ear. The violet stone looked almost elegant on her, reframing her face in ways Adora didn’t want to admit she noticed. It was dangerous—like everything Catra carried from Prime’s shadow.

Another piece of bread. Another careful bite. This time, Catra’s lips grazed her fingertips, feather-light, the way the start of a kiss might. Adora’s breath caught. She forced herself to think of claws raking across her back, not of steam-filled baths and wet skin, not of how perfect Catra’s body had looked.

Catra finished chewing, then dropped a hand to Adora’s thigh. Slowly, she dragged her claws upward, not breaking skin but reminding Adora of how easily she could.

“Control yourself,” Catra murmured.

Adora nearly laughed at the audacity. But Catra shifted in until they were almost chest to chest, her hair brushing Adora’s cheek, her breath warm against her ear.

“You notice?” Catra whispered. “We’re almost the last ones here.”

Adora forced herself to answer evenly. “So?”

The next words slid into her skin like a secret: “So take me upstairs.”

Adora’s pulse hammered, but it was Catra who stood first, Catra who trailed up the stairs. Adora followed, every step heavy with conflicted anticipation.

The third door at the top of the stairs opened into warmth: a wide bed with carved headboard, fire in the hearth, walls thick enough to swallow secrets.

But someone was already there.

A dark-bearded man, early thirties, and six extra eyes like a spider might have, sat on the bed. He rose quickly to his knees when Catra entered.

Adora stopped dead, then sank into the chair by the door, arms crossed tight over her chest.

“Your Highness,” the man said.

“Get up,” Catra told him, cool and commanding. “I didn’t expect you’d still be here.”

“I came every night,” he said as he rose. “After you camped at Ghost’s Ridge, I thought—maybe—your messenger would arrive.”

“He was detained. We were followed out of the keep. The roads are watched.”

“I know another way,” the man said. He pulled a sealed parchment from his coat and offered it with both hands. As Catra tried to take it, the paper stuck to the mans fingers but didn't seem to stick to Catra’s at all.

Catra broke the seal, scanning the ciphered lines carefully, lips pressed into a flat line. When she finished, she tossed the parchment into the fire. It curled, blackened, vanished. Then she removed her signet ring and pressed it into the man’s palm.

“Give her this,” she said. “Tell her I’ll be waiting at Talon Mountain.”

The man bowed low, then slipped out quietly into the night.

For a long moment, the room was silent but for the fire.

Adora stood. She studied Catra’s face like she was trying to read what was left behind. “You look… pleased.”

Catra leaned back, stretching out, the firelight catching on the curve of her earring. “You know me,” she said, her tone laced with mock satisfaction. “I live for the small wins. Makes the big ones worth chasing.”

Mara arched an eyebrow. “You weren’t even sure he’d be here.”

“I wasn’t,” Catra admitted, unclasping the earring with a careless flick of her fingers. “Two weeks is forever in this mess. I didn’t expect him to wait around.” She set the jewelry on the nightstand, voice dipping into something more serious. “But we’ll be fine on the road tomorrow. Whoever’s sniffing at our trail—” her mouth curled into a wry grin, “they want him more than me. Otherwise, they’d have made a move tonight.” She was already halfway to the door when she tossed over her shoulder, “That door goes to the bath, right?” A beat, then a flash of teeth. “Don’t get your hopes up. I don’t need your help.”

The latch clicked shut behind her.

Adora stared at the empty doorway, then let out a breath and gathered an armful of bedding. She dumped it by the hearth with a muffled thump and sank down cross-legged on the floor. There was nothing else to do.

Downstairs, the inn had mostly emptied. Only Rummy lingered, hunched over his drink, and the inn maid, her dark hair mussed and falling into her face. Neither paid her the slightest attention. The quiet was strange.

Outside, the night air wrapped cool and steady around her, calming the tangle in her chest. The street was deserted. The messenger was long gone. For a moment, it was easy to imagine peace. But she couldn't stay out there forever.

On her way back up, she detoured through the kitchens, snagging a plate of bread and meats. Catra had eaten barely anything.

When she opened the door, Catra was back from the bath, half dressed, hair damp and falling around her face as she sat by the fire. She'd claimed nearly all the space on Adora's pile of blankets.

Adora crossed the room, holding out the plate. "Here."

Catra blinked at it, then at her. For a second, her sharp mask slipped. "Thanks." She set the food on her lap. After a beat, she added, softer, "The bath's free. If you want it."

The water was still hot when Adora slid into it. Catra had even replaced it with clean water. The towels hanging over the rim were warm and soft. She dried off quickly and tugged her pants back on instead of wrapping herself in a towel. Just like a campaign night, she told herself. Nothing different.

When she came back, Catra had eaten carefully—half of everything, and no more. She'd set the rest on the chest within Adora's reach. Adora ignored it, lowering herself onto the blankets beside her, shoulder brushing Catra's knee.

"I thought Rummy was your contact," Adora said.

Catra smirked. "Nah. Just wanted to play."

The fire painted everything in warm gold, flickering across bare skin and damp hair. Adora sat close enough to feel it, close enough to feel the heat of Catra herself.

Catra tilted her head, watching the flames. "I don't think I'd have made it here without you. Not without leaving an easy trail." Her voice softened, almost reluctant. "I mean it. You were right. I'm

not used to—" She broke off, shaking her head like the words tasted strange.

Adora studied her. With her hair pushed back, Catra's face looked almost… vulnerable, the sharp edges smoothed by firelight.

"You're in a weird mood," Adora said.

Catra grinned. "Weird? I'd say good. Better than usual."

"A good mood," Adora repeated, skeptical.

"Not as good as Rummy," Catra shot back, lips quirking. "But hey—the food's edible, the fire's warm, and no one's tried to stab me in the last three hours. I'll take it."

Adora shook her head, half smiling. "I thought you were harder to please than that."

"Did you?" Catra's eyes glinted.

"I've seen your court," Adora said quietly. If the flagship counted as a court.

Catra's smile vanished. "You've seen ***his*** court. Not mine."

The silence that followed was heavy. Adora didn't ask the question that burned in her chest: *Would yours be any different?*

The fire popped, breaking the quiet. Catra leaned back on her hands, drying her hair in lazy motions that only half-hid the tension beneath her words.

Then, suddenly: "Tell me something."

Adora glanced over.

"What really made Glimmer send you to the Horde?" Catra asked. Her voice was low, but the edge was there. "Don't tell me it was some lover's spat. I know better."

The warmth of the fire turned cold. Adora's throat tightened. She couldn't answer. It was too dangerous to answer. Too much would give her away.

Still, the past pressed close, closer than she could bear. She swallowed hard. *I don't know. I don't know why. I don't know what I did to make her hate me this much. Why we couldn't mourn—*

—our mother—

"You aren't wrong," Adora heard herself say, the words coming out as if from somewhere far away. "There was someone. I… cared about him."

Catra's ear twitched. "Let me guess—Bow." Her grin was crooked, almost mocking.

Adora's throat tightened. She didn't answer.

"Oh, come on," Catra pressed, her voice lilting. "Don't tell me you fell for Glimmer's boy toy."

"He wasn't that," Adora said quickly, the ache in her chest flaring. "Not then. Glimmer wasn't Queen. And he—he wasn't hers. Or if he was, no one knew it." The words spilled too fast now, like she couldn't stop them. "He was brilliant. Brave. Kind. Everything I thought I wanted. But he wanted power, too. And he must have realized his best chance was with her."

Catra gave a low, amused laugh. "Figures. My noble Mara—reaching for the one who'll stab her in the back."

"That's not—" Adora shook her head, frustrated.

"What? Not your type?" Catra tilted her head, feigning innocence. "Pretty face, clever brain, cold ambition? Sounds exactly like your type."

“No,” Adora said, sharper this time. “I didn’t know. I didn’t *see* what he was.”

“Didn’t you?” Catra’s voice softened.

Adora faltered. “Maybe I knew he cared more about his skill than his heart. That he was ambitious. I found it… attractive. But I never thought he’d betray me. Not like that. Not for Glimmer.”

Catra’s smile thinned. “Shadow Weaver used to be like you. Blind. She had to learn to see the knife in people’s hands before it cut her throat.”

Adora drew a shaky breath. “And you?”

“I don’t miss knives,” Catra said. Her tail flicked lazily, but her eyes were sharp. "It's easier if you always assume they're coming."

“That’s not what I meant.”

“Yeah, it is.”

Adora tried to turn the question back on her, desperate to push the spotlight away. Catra only lounged closer to the fire, all sharp grace and unreadable calm. The light made her lips look softer than they had any right to be. She met Adora’s gaze easily, without even blinking.

“You’re shy,” Adora said, trying to bait her.

Catra smirked. “Ask the question, dummy.”

“Half your soldiers think you’ve never—” Adora hesitated, then forced it out. “That you’re a virgin.”

“Is *that* your question?” Catra teased.

“Yes.”

“I’ve had people trying to get in my bed since I was *twelve*,” Catra said flatly. “I’m not a virgin.”

Adora swallowed, uneasy at the age Catra mentioned. "I wondered if you only wanted… men."

Catra blinked at her, genuinely startled. Then she caught herself, turning her head with a muttered curse. When she looked back, her smile was wry, her eyes too steady. "No."

"Did I… offend you?" Adora asked.

"No." Catra leaned back on her hands, lazy. "It's just so you. Come up with the most boring explanation possible."

"I just thought—" Adora frowned. "You picked someone safe. Someone you would't really care about when you chose me to be your slave. That you wanted men instead."

Catra cut her off, purring, "Want to know why Bow picked Glimmer?"

Adora stared at the fire. A log cracked, embers breaking apart.

"She was a princess," Adora whispered. Her shoulders were tight, her voice tighter. "And I was… just me."

Catra's tone sharpened. "Wrong. He would've chosen her even if you were royalty. You don't understand how people like him think. I do." She leaned in, eyes gleaming. "If I were him, I'd have chosen Glimmer too."

Adora's fists clenched. "And why's that?" The bitterness scratched her throat.

"Because someone like that always picks the weaker one," Catra said simply. "Easier to control."

Adora's head snapped toward her. She expected spite. She expected mockery. Instead, Catra was just watching her, steady and unreadable.

It hit differently. The words sank into her, shifting something she thought was immovable.

"You don't know Glimmer," Adora whispered. "What makes you think she's weaker?"

Catra's gaze didn't waver. "Because I'm starting to know ***you***."

✧

Adora sat propped against the wall, blanket wrapped around her shoulders, staring at the dim glow of the embers. The fire had nearly given out; the only sound left was the faint crack of cooling wood. The room was quiet, warm, heavy with the kind of stillness that kept sleep at bay.

She was wide awake. Catra, of course, was not.

Even in the dark, Adora could make out the familiar shape of her—the spill of messy brown hair across the pillow, one arm sprawled like she owned the bed. She slept like Adora wasn't even there. Like Adora wasn't a threat, wasn't a soldier sworn to a cause opposite hers.

It wasn't trust. Catra didn't *do* trust. It was calculation: the same quiet certainty that had let her hand Adora a blade, or strip down in a room full of steam without hesitation. Catra always bet on the odds, and she'd decided Adora had more reasons to keep her alive than not. For now.

Adora didn't understand her. She didn't understand the things Catra said, the way they lingered in her chest like wounds she couldn't stitch up. And with nothing left to distract her but the crackle of dying coals, the past pressed down heavy.

Her thoughts snagged on Glimmer—her sister, her rival, the girl who'd once been everything she admired. Mermista's warnings, Scorpia's quiet words, her mother's deathbed. Adora still couldn't reconcile the pieces. She didn't want to.

The image splintered as a pounding echoed from below, muffled by walls but unmistakable.

Adora was on her feet in an instant, tugging on her shirt and jacket. She crossed to the bed and laid a hand on Catra's shoulder.

"Wake up," she whispered.

Catra stirred instantly, no panic, no surprise. Just those sharp eyes snapping open.

"What now?" she muttered, voice husky with sleep.

"Trouble," Adora said. "We need to move."

"Figures," Catra sighed, already sliding out of bed. "This is getting old." She yanked on her jacket without bothering with the laces. "You really know how to show a girl a good time."

Adora ignored the jab, already throwing open the balcony shutters. Cool night air rushed in. The drop below was steep, too steep. The plaster walls were smooth. No handholds.

But there—a strip of broken plaster and stone near the next balcony, just far enough away to be terrifying.

Catra caught her look and smirked faintly. "Think you can make it, Mara?"

Adora squared her shoulders. "Probably."

"Comforting," Catra deadpanned. She swung over the railing in one fluid motion, light and sure. She leapt, caught the next balcony clean, hauled herself up without a sound. For a second, she just crouched there, listening. Whoever was inside hadn't heard. Then she glanced back at Adora, tail flicking in the moonlight.

Adora climbed over, heart pounding. The distance seemed longer now. Her stomach dropped. “Probably” didn’t feel very convincing anymore.

She jumped.

Her hands hit the railing, but her grip slipped. Her stomach lurched—until Catra’s claws caught her wrist. The impact slammed the breath out of her, but Catra’s strength held.

Adora clung to her without protest, letting herself be pulled over the railing and onto the balcony. For a moment, she didn’t move. Her hands were still on Catra’s waist. Their faces were too close. Her heart hammered like it was trying to break free.

They froze there, tangled together in the shadows—too late to pretend it hadn’t happened.

The sounds inside the room cut off abruptly.

“I swear I heard something,” the inn maid’s voice came, sharp, suspicious. “On the balcony.”

“It’s just the wind,” Rummy replied, half a laugh in his voice. “C’mon, I’ll keep you warm.”

“No, it wasn’t the wind,” she insisted. “Go check—”

The bed creaked as Rummy shifted, but before the shutters could open, Adora moved fast. She shoved Catra hard, pinning her to the wall beside the window. Catra’s back hit the plaster with a muted thud, a shocked hiss escaping her lips—followed by an even sharper jolt of surprise when Adora pressed full against her, holding them flush together in the narrow space.

A breath later, the shutters swung wide, trapping them in the thin wedge of shadow between the wall and the wooden panel. They were hidden by sheer luck and proximity, bodies pressed together too tightly to risk even a flinch.

Adora froze. If she leaned back even an inch, she'd rattle the shutter. The only way to avoid it was to stay pressed against Catra—closer than she'd ever intended to be. She could feel the warmth radiating through Catra's shirt, the brush of her chest against hers, the curve of her hip slotted against her thigh. Catra's hair tickled her cheek, a teasing brush she couldn't shake off without betraying them.

Inside, Rummy grumbled. "See? Nobody here."

"I *know* I heard something," the maid muttered.

Adora forced her breath shallow, silent. Her heart was pounding so loud she was sure they'd hear it.

"Maybe it was just a cat," Rummy said, amusement creeping back into his tone. "Now… come back to bed. I'll make it worth your while."

There was a pause. Then the maid gave in with a reluctant, "Fine. But shut the shutters."

Adora tensed—only to feel the bottom drop out of her stomach when Rummy *didn't*. He turned back to the bed, leaving the window yawning open and the two of them stranded there, plastered together like guilty lovers.

Catra shifted slightly, her ear brushing Adora's jaw as she craned to glance past her at the open shutters. The movement was small—but to Adora, it felt unbearable. "Stop moving," she whispered, almost inaudible, her voice rough with restraint.

Catra tilted her head back enough that her mouth nearly brushed Adora's neck. Her voice was low, amused despite the danger: "This is… not ideal."

"That's an understatement," Adora muttered back, eyes flicking upward toward the eaves. "If we climb, we can get out before—"

Catra interrupted, her words a soft purr just under Adora's ear. "Or… we wait until they're too busy fucking to notice."

The word landed under Adora's skin, heat blooming across her face just as the maid moaned loudly from the bed, "There, yes—right there—"

Adora's throat worked. "We don't have time—"

And then the door to Rummy's room burst open.

"They're in here!" an unfamiliar man's voice barked.

Chaos followed—the maid yelping, Rummy's furious shout of, "Hey, hands off!" The scuffle made no sense until the intruder declared, with grim satisfaction: "We've got her. Horde princess, just like they said."

"What?" Rummy sputtered. "I only paid three coppers for her!"

"Then you've been overcharged," the man snapped. "Stand back." Then, awkwardly, to Catra: "Your Highness."

"What?" the maid shrieked.

Pinned tight against the wall, Catra's shoulders began to shake. Adora realized with horror that she was *laughing*.

More boots pounded into the room. "Here she is," another man crowed. "Caught her in bed with this pathetic drunk, pretending to be a tavern girl."

"This *is* the tavern girl, you moron," someone else snapped. "The Horde's princess doesn't waste time on sex. I doubt she even touches herself once a decade. Plus—she's a damn feline!"

Adora's nails bit into her palms. Catra was trembling harder now, silent laughter spilling through her chest, pressed so close that Adora could feel every suppressed shake.

“Anyway, we’re looking for two women,” the soldier continued. “One’s tall, blonde, soldier type. The other’s a brunette catfolk. Attractive. Not this mess.”

“Blonde lady’s pet was downstairs,” Rummy offered helpfully. “Brain like a pea. Can’t imagine she was royalty.”

The maid sniffed, sulking. “I wouldn’t call her pretty.”

At that, Catra muffled a snort against Adora’s shoulder, and Adora wanted to scream.

The shaking only got worse. Catra’s shoulders trembled against Adora’s chest, the little jolts betraying how hard she was trying not to laugh.

“Stop enjoying yourself,” Adora whispered, jaw tight. “We’re about to be killed.”

Catra tilted her head up just enough that her breath skimmed Adora’s throat. “Relax, it’s finally getting interesting.”

“Catra—”

“Shh.”

Inside the room, a man’s voice cut through: “Check the other lodgings. They’re close.” The footsteps retreated.

Catra’s smirk was audible in her whisper: “Boost me. We’re not hanging around.”

Adora braced her palms, crouched, and Catra stepped into her grip. She was up the wall in a heartbeat, claws finding holds the stone had long since forgotten. Adora followed, slower in the cramped space, her boots scraping mortar. By the time she hauled herself onto the roof, Catra was already sprawled flat, grinning like she’d won a prize.

The rooftops stretched out under a thinning night sky, Ghost's Ridge Stop scattered in crooked lines of tile and chimney. Adora caught her breath, a laugh slipping unbidden, and saw Catra wearing the same reckless exhilaration.

Catra's mismatched eyes glittered with mischief.

"I think we're clear," Adora said, low and cautious. "No one saw."

"Told you," Catra shot back. Then, with deliberate malice, she nudged a loose tile with her boot until it tumbled and shattered in the street below. "I wanted to play."

Shouts erupted instantly: "On the roof!"

Adora groaned. "Seriously?"

Catra's grin widened. "Now it's fun."

And then it was a chase.

They bolted across the uneven skyline—tiles clattering underfoot, alleys yawning open beneath them. Adora leapt chimney to chimney, muscle memory carrying her forward with soldier's precision. Catra kept pace effortlessly, light and sharp, darting ahead to scout the next landing. Below, their pursuers sprinted through clear streets, angling to cut them off.

Catra ripped free another tile and flung it with deadly aim—an alarmed cry rose from below. Adora, spotting an opening, tipped a flowerpot off a balcony; beside her, Catra yanked down a line of drying laundry, sending white sheets spiraling into a knot of men, who stumbled, swearing, like ghosts had grabbed them.

The rooftops became a gauntlet—slopes to scramble, slick tiles to skid down, alleyways to vault. The sky was paling, the town waking beneath their racket. Every leap carried risk; every heartbeat said **too close, too loud, too slow.*

Finally, ahead by a slim margin, they dropped to a drainpipe and slid down into a side street. Cobblestones greeted their boots. Empty. For the moment.

“This way,” Catra said between breaths, tugging them into a narrow archway that funneled into a busier thoroughfare. Dawn-lit vendors were already carting out wares. Adora pressed flat against the wall, lungs burning, eyes scanning.

Catra leaned beside her, flushed and bright-eyed, still drunk on the thrill. Adora’s hand shot out, catching her arm before she stepped into the light.

“Wait. Too open. Your ears are basically a dead give away now.”

Catra snorted. Then, with a magician’s flourish, she pulled Rummy’s wool cap from her belt and tugged it down over her head, the ears squashed flat out of sight.

Adora’s chest squeezed, sudden and disorienting. Catra—mocking, reckless—looked impossibly young in that stolen cap. She was having fun. And Adora felt herself teetering at the edge of something just as dangerous as the men chasing them.

“We can’t,” Adora said quickly. “Didn’t you hear? They’ve split up.”

Catra frowned. “Meaning?”

“Meaning we’re not pulling them off the trail. Some went after your messenger. Some are still on us.”

Catra studied her. “You’ve got good ears, Mara. Even if they’re so small.”

Adora’s throat tightened. “Then listen to me. Go. I can handle this.”

“No,” Catra said.

Adora’s jaw worked. “If I wanted to run, I could’ve tonight. While you were in the bath. While you slept.”

“I know,” Catra said.

Adora pressed. “You can’t be in two places at once. Splitting up is the only way.”

Catra shook her head. “It’s too important.”

“Trust me,” Adora urged.

Catra’s eyes held hers, sharp and searching, then softened—just barely.

Finally, she said, “Fine. One day. We’ll wait at the Fort. After that, you catch up.”

Her tone carried no room for doubt, but her gaze lingered.

Adora had watched Catra until the crowd swallowed her up, wool cap tugged low, jacket laces still dragging like an extra tail.

She turned and slipped back toward the inn, keeping to shadows the way Catra would have teased her for. The street was noisy, but the air outside the inn was tense. That’s when she saw a familiar figure pacing near the stable.

“Sea Hawk?” Adora blinked.

“My *lady Veska!*” He flourished, startling the stable boy with his cape. “I was just about to find you! There were men here—ruffians—searching high and low!”

"It's *Mara*, actually." Adora’s stomach dropped as his words sank in. “Are they still here?”

“They stormed off, then two of them slunk back, whispering questions, spreading tales.” He leaned in, lowering his voice as if he were delivering the most scandalous of gossip. “Word is…the

woman with you was none other than—brace yourself—the Horde's *princess*, disguised as…" His voice dropped to a dramatic whisper, "…a *lady of the night!"*

Adora pinched the bridge of her nose. "Sea Hawk."

"Yes?"

"What happened to them?"

"They rode off. Southwest. Only just—fifteen minutes, perhaps." His hand pressed to his chest as he struck a heroic pose. "Say the word, my princess, and I will deliver you a horse! No quest too daring, no ride too long for Sea Hawk!"

Adora's chest tightened. Southwest meant the mountain pass. Meant the messenger. Meant danger. "I'll take that horse," she said quickly.

Sea Hawk grinned so wide she thought his face might split. "Then ride! Into destiny!"

✧

Sea Hawk's horse was, annoyingly, excellent. Strong, steady, faster than she looked—Adora could feel it in the mare's stride. If the men ahead of them pushed their mounts too hard, they wouldn't last long.

The landscape rose up around her, jagged granite cutting into the sky, the path narrowing as they pushed into the hills. When she finally caught sight of the riders, their horses were already flagging, sweat darkening their flanks. Adora leaned forward, urging the bay faster.

Luck was with her: no bows, no strategy, just thugs with swords. When they wheeled to fight, she met them head-on, knocking one from the saddle. He hit the dirt hard and didn't get up. The other dropped his weapon but clung to his horse—until she crowded

him, forcing his mount into chaos. He tumbled off, scrambling on foot into the rocks.

Adora swung down from the saddle, heart pounding. This wasn't over.

Whoever was paying this guy clearly wasn't paying him enough. The second the fight tipped out of his favor, he bolted. Not brave, not disciplined—just another hired sword hoping his payday came easier than this.

Adora could've ended it there. All she had to do was spook the horses and let them scatter—by the time this man or his buddy caught them, the messenger would be long gone. Safe. Done. But she'd been at this too long not to feel the hook. Someone had sent these men. Someone had planned this. And she couldn't walk away without knowing who.

She slid off Sea Hawk's horse and followed on foot, boots crunching across the rocky ground. The man ran awkwardly, throwing panicked glances over his shoulder, until his luck ran out—his ankle twisted on loose stone and he went down hard beneath a crooked tree. He tried to throw a rock at her like a desperate child, but Adora batted it aside.

"Enough," she muttered, yanking him up by the collar. "Who sent you?"

The man's lips clamped shut. His skin was gray with fear, his eyes darting everywhere but her face.

Adora's jaw set. She hated this part—always had—but the messenger didn't have time for her to play nice. She hit him once, sharp across the face. He crumpled against the tree, blood spilling from his mouth.

"Who sent you?" She asked again.

The man coughed, then hissed, "Let me go. If you care about her at all, you'll let me go now. Maybe you'll still have time to save

your princess.”

Adora’s chest tightened, but her grip didn’t falter. “Catra doesn’t need saving. Not from the likes of you.”

That earned her a thin, unsettling smile. His posture shifted—too calm, too knowing. And then his eyes rolled white, his voice bending into something far too familiar. Horde Prime’s words spilled out of him, smooth and venomous:

“How much do you *trust* the soldiers you’ve been training, Mara?”

Her stomach dropped. For a moment she just stared, horrified, as if Prime himself had reached through the man’s body to sneer at her. The emptiness of the land pressed in—the jagged rocks, the thin trees, the hot suns overhead. Ghost’s Ridge was still half a day’s ride away. She didn’t have the time. She didn’t even have a fresh horse anymore.

And all she could hear was Catra’s voice in her head: *One day. We’ll wait at the Fort*.

Adora closed her eyes, swallowing down the dread. She was already going to be late.

✧

Adora left the broken mercenary behind, slumping against the jagged granite. She swung back onto her horse and spurred it forward, hooves thundering across the rough hillside. Her pulse hammered in time with the clattering hooves. She had to get to the Fort. She had to—because right now, it wasn’t just Catra’s life on the line.

The man she’d left had been part of a carefully orchestrated trap. Ghost’s Ridge wasn’t just a town; it was a staging ground. First, the ambush on Catra in the streets. Next, a calculated upheaval within the Princess’s troop. And if she and the troop survived that… the hills were littered with mercenaries lying in wait.

Adora's mind refused to dwell on the full scale of the plan. She could barely manage one thread at a time—Catra. Catra. Catra. The thought consumed her, gnawed at her. Every turn in the path, every lurch of the horse, brought the image of Catra sprawling across rooftops, eluding every hand, every attack aimed at her. Alive.

The sun had already begun its descent, sending long shadows across the jagged, granite-studded hills. Each rock and gnarled tree seemed designed to trip her horse or force it off its feet. Adora kept the reins tight, but gave the mount room to navigate the pitted earth, trusting instinct and muscle over speed alone. The slightest misstep here could send her flying.

Her mind raced faster than her horse. Catra—impossible, infuriating, brilliant Catra—had deliberately left herself exposed, maybe. Or maybe she'd anticipated this all along, as she always seemed to. And yet… Adora couldn't stop thinking about last night. The firelight dancing off Catra's hair, the rush as they jumped between rooftops, the reckless thrill of their escape. Every thought sharpened the ache in her chest.

The landscape flattened briefly, and Adora pressed her heels into the horse's flanks. The animal responded, straining every muscle, hooves pounding the dirt, dust rising in clouds. Smoke curled in the distance—thick, black, acrid—and her stomach knotted. The camp.

The Fort came into view. Tents that had once stood in precise rows now sagged at odd angles, poles snapped, canvas scorched and fluttering in the wind. Smoke spiraled from burned-out pyres. Soldiers moved among the ruins, grimy, bloody, exhausted. Entrapta caught her eye immediately: pale, her shoulder bandaged and dark with dried blood, but alive.

Adora swung off the horse, landing lightly but with the force of her worry driving her forward. The animal stood, flanks heaving, nostrils flaring, a sheen of sweat glistening over taut muscles.

Her gaze scanned the ruined camp. Every shadow, every tent flap… searching.

No cat-eared princess. Her chest tightened. Fear coiled in her stomach, sharp and unrelenting. She forced herself to run, to push through the debris, to keep searching.

And then—

Movement. A shadow gliding from a partially intact tent. Ears flicking. Eyes wide.

Catra.

Adora froze.

And then she saw it: the pause, the sudden stop in Catra's stride. The tilt of her head. Her mismatched eyes locked onto Adora, wide, impossibly bright, the same mix of shock, relief, and disbelief mirrored in Adora's own chest.

Chapter End Notes

Maybe one more chapter tomorrow ~~if you behave~~

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

CW: Mention of Prime being gross. Major character death. Sexually transmitted diseases.

Should I add the warning tag for "Non-con/rape"? I'm on the fence about it. But Catra is going to have some pretty rough flashbacks before things start to get better.

[Art is mine]

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra wasn't going to fall apart. Not now. Fear was useless, wallowing was pathetic, and if she'd ever been the type to give in to either, she wouldn't have made it this far.

Adora was going to be fine. She'd get herself back to camp. And if she didn't—if she got delayed, if she had to take the long way—she'd still catch up eventually. Because that's what Adora did.

Catra trusted her.

She hated that she did, but she did.

Which meant if Adora didn't come back… if she didn't make it out… Catra knew what that meant. She didn't even want to finish the thought. But the picture forced itself into her mind anyway: Adora caught, dragged down, killed.

And if Adora was killed—then Catra wasn't sure she could win. She could be clever, she could be ruthless, she could wriggle out of just about anything—but against Prime, without Adora? The thought twisted her stomach. Adora had experience, instincts, and—annoyingly—a way of keeping her alive when Catra's own recklessness should have gotten her killed a dozen times over. Without her, Catra wasn't enough.

Prime would take her back. He'd lock her up. He'd make an example of her. She knew exactly what he'd do—how he'd drag her apart piece by piece until there was nothing left but something broken and screaming.

She didn't want to die screaming. Maybe one day Adora could offer her a quick death if no other option was left.

She didn't want to let go of this life. Not after last night. Running rooftops. Knocking laundry into the streets. Laughing with Adora like it wasn't all life and death for once. That heartbeat, that heat—she wanted to hang onto it.

She wasn't ready to let go. Not yet.

So she shoved the spiral down. Forced the panic into a corner and slammed the door on it. Control. She knew how to do that—tie it down, lash it tight, turn herself cold enough to survive. She straightened her shoulders, tied the last of her jacket laces with sharp, efficient tugs, and wrapped herself in the mask she knew best: unbothered, arrogant, untouchable.

By the time she reached the gates, the façade was almost solid.

But the sight of two Horde grunts posted there—watching every traveler, dragging people out of carts—made her stomach sink. She stopped, turned casually on her heel, and wandered toward the nearest stall like she had nowhere important to be.

She kept one eye on the guards while pretending to study a pile of sad-looking bread. Maybe, with the cap hiding her ears, she could tack herself onto some farmer's wagon and slip through. Maybe. But Adora? Adora was about as subtle as a thunderstorm. If she came through those gates, she'd light up every red flag in the Horde handbook.

Catra hesitated, her claws flexing against her palms. Then, slowly, she pulled off her cap. The morning air hit her ears, and for the first time since last night, she didn't bother hiding who she was.

The baker barely glanced at her at first—another scruffy traveler with dirt under her nails. Catra slapped a silver coin onto the stall.

"I'll take two loaves," she said, voice lazy. Then she tilted her head, a sharp little smile curling at her mouth. "Not the burned ones, thanks."

The coin caught the merchant's eye. The face caught the rest. He straightened immediately, scrambling to box up the best bread he had, all smiles now where there had been indifference before.

Catra stood perfectly still, radiating arrogance, letting him work for it. No fidgeting. No impatience. Just the cool, imperious look of someone who expected to be noticed. And she was noticed. She could feel it—the shift in the air as people turned their heads, whispers starting to ripple down the street.

Good.

Let them look. Let them talk. Let the Horde see her here.

If Adora came this way, Catra would already have drawn all the eyes.

Catra didn't rush the exchange. She watched every little motion—the stall keeper's hands picking out the loaves, the delicate wrapping in brown paper—as if she might leap across the counter if he tried to cheat her. When the bundle was finally offered, she lingered over it like she expected to find some flaw. Suspicious. Demanding. Drawing it out because the longer she stood there, the more people noticed.

Only when she was satisfied she'd wasted enough of everyone's time did she flip a coin onto the stall and stroll off, casually.

She forced herself to walk with that same careless arrogance. Not hunted, not wary. Just Catra, the spoiled little traitor-princess who thought rules didn't apply to her. The one too sharp for her own good, too defiant to be useful. *Yeah, that's me. Come on then. Keep up*.

She didn’t cut alleys. She didn’t skulk. She kept to the broad roads in the full light of day, knowing exactly how tempting the trail looked to anyone tailing her. After last night’s fiasco, the grunts would be desperate for a win. Two of them against one of her? They wouldn’t dare split up.

Good.

When she reached the place, she stopped. Made a little show of it—glancing around like she’d only just realized she could possibly be watched. She never once looked behind her. She hesitated, hammed it up like she was stuck on some grand decision. It felt clumsy. Overacted. Too obvious. It felt like something *Adora* would do.

But subtlety didn’t reel in idiots. Big, clear bait did.

She jammed Rummy’s cap back on her head with a flourish and ducked down a side alley slick with last night’s rain. Sure enough, one of the grunts sloshed straight through a puddle after her. Catra didn’t let herself smirk. She kept her face blank, feigning oblivious, and rapped on the back door of the brothel.

The woman who answered nearly spilled out of her corset. Catra held up the parcel like she was delivering jewels instead of bread.

“Got something for the Patron,” she said. When the woman only frowned, Catra tipped her head toward the bundle. “Said he wanted it personally.”

Her expression stayed flat, skeptical. Catra leaned into the light, letting her face do the work her words couldn’t. Sharp cheekbones, steady stare, the kind of pretty that got doors opened even when it shouldn’t.

“Well?” Catra said, all lazy bite. “You want to explain to him why you turned me away?”

The back entrance opened into a kitchen—hot stew bubbling, a pot of underthings boiling in some caustic mess. At the table, a

woman had her skirts bunched up, thighs bare, a foul green paste slathered between them. She didn't even blink at Catra, just muttered something about itching and went back to the book of complicated diagrams in front of her. She scribbled notes one-handed, flipping the page with a pencil plucked from her hair.

The Patron arrived a moment later. Whatever slick charm he'd worn the night before was gone. The only thing left was fury.

"You run out on your bill. You drag soldiers into my house. You barricade my best room until they smash down the door. You have your twit of a pet tear through my wall like an animal—"

"Windows were barred," Catra cut in smoothly. "Could've mentioned that."

The words knocked the wind out of his rant. He glared at her, chest heaving. Across the table, the poulticed-woman looked up with a raised brow, interest flickering now. She had no intention of leaving, Catra could tell. Besides, the girl had bigger issues considered the clear rash on her nethers.

Catra didn't flinch under the Patron's stare. She'd measured men like him before. Kings of tiny kingdoms, convinced their word was law. It worked for them because they made it work, because everyone around them played along. He expected the same here. Expected her to bend.

She didn't.

The Patron, when he first welcomed "Mara" and her shadow into his hall, hadn't seen a trap waiting to spring. Why would he? As far as he knew, the princess camped outside his walls was here for drills, nothing more. Border patrol. Routine. And a bored, highborn girl sneaking into a brothel for anonymity? That wasn't a crisis, that was Tuesday.

Even when he offered his "assistance," he'd probably thought the worst he'd face was a drunken noblewoman trashing a room. Nothing that couldn't be cleaned up. Certainly not *Prime's men*

—not even the usual clones—showing up to drag the crown princess away in chains. Or that her dumb blonde companion would rip the guts out of his building with her bare hands.

So when his temper flared now, Catra had to admit, he had a point.

She just didn't let him keep it.

"I'm sure," Catra said smoothly, catching the exact second his eyes dipped, "you don't need me to promise that the Horde compensates its debts."

His mouth tightened. He wasn't from the Fright Zone; he hadn't been suckled on Horde loyalty the way their soldiers were. There was no patriotism here. His pride was his currency, and Catra tread lightly—just not too light. He had to feel like she was a problem worth the risk, not an anchor around his neck. Otherwise, why not sell her straight back to Prime?

She let the silence work for her. Calm. Relaxed. To Adora, it would look like arrogance. To anyone else, it was control.

The Patron's jaw shifted. Finally, he said, "How can I be of assistance, your highness?"

Catra smiled, small and sharp. "Do you have a girl about my size? Close enough coloring. Pretty."

He snorted. "Please. I don't deal in ugly whores."

✧

Hemlock sulked like it was her job. And maybe it was. She pouted through every part of the arrangement—through Catra pressing coin into her master's hand as insurance, through the demand that she muss her hair up into fake ears. She'd even looked insulted when Catra told her point-blank that *no,* the princess wasn't here to fuck her.

Not that they were ever going to be friends anyway.

The resemblance was… fine. Not good. Passable. Hemlock's skin was a touch paler, dusted with freckles; her hair was too bright with auburn. But under the cap and with Catra's cut, it blurred enough. Their mouths were the sticking point—Hemlock's always pinched, like she'd just eaten something sour. Catra's scowl, she explained, was an art form: lofty, untouchable, the dissatisfaction of someone *above* it all. Hemlock didn't get it. At least she coincidentally had Catra's same heterochromia.

At least the girl could walk the walk. Literally. Within minutes she copied Catra's stance, her prowl, even the whip of her tail—well, the ghost of one. The used a filled stocking and a string tied to Hemlock's wrist to give the illusion of a tail if you didn't look too close. Catra found herself wishing Adora were here to see it. *See? Acting's easy. Whores do it between tricks. Even you can manage it, I'm sure.*

The thought twisted, sickly. She shoved it away. Catra had been so good at acting exactly as Prime wanted her to.

By the time Hemlock was shoved into Catra's uniform, the Patron's eye gleamed with approval. He turned to Catra for the final word.

"You really know your stock," Catra drawled, giving him a deliberate once-over. "When I'm Queen, maybe I'll drag you onto the Flagship. I won't need a brothel, of course. Or maybe I will. Could be fun to scandalize everyone."

He studied her a moment longer, weighing if she was serious. Catra smirked, offering nothing.

Hemlock ruined it by whining.

"I want the earring."

Catra braced herself before turning to the mirror. Kyle's purple gems gleamed against the borrowed green dress, dangling elegantly. The gown wasn't hers—it might not survive the night to

be returned—but it shaped itself well enough to her flat chest and sharp shoulders, curving where there was nothing to curve. Illusion stacked on illusion.

Paint was offered, insisted upon. Catra refused, baring her face without it. She hated the feel of it.

And she caught it, just for a second, in the mirror's angle: the Patron's eyes narrowing at Hemlock, a silent warning.

Catra didn't look away. She let him see her watching.

"I'm too gorgeous for tacky junk like that," Catra had scoffed, lounging with her usual mix of arrogance and irritation. That left the Patron scrambling—whether to flatter her or push back. Prime, of course, had liked dressing her up in gaudy paint. Prime had liked ruining it even more. Smudged lipstick, streaked rouge, tears dragging dark rivers down her cheeks. His hand in her hair, yanking her head up so she had no choice but to stare in the mirror while he commanded her—watch yourself, Catra, watch how pathetic you look. She hated that mirror almost more than him.

She waved it away now, sharp and final. She couldn't stand another second of her own reflection. The air against her bare shoulders felt wrong—too vulnerable. She craved the solid weight of her uniform. She even missed the constant shadow of her Etherian.

Out in the brothel's common room, she drew attention the moment she stepped in.

"I'm so sorry, my lady—our Colette is still in training." They said it over and over, different voices, same empty politeness. None of it stopped the hungry stares. The workers intrigued her, but their clients? Pathetic. Panting mutts chasing a bitch in heat.

"I'm shy," she purred, brushing off a hand with a flick of her claws, eyes narrowing.

Prime's men were here too, wasting time with cheap distractions while pretending to keep watch. Professionals, huh? Pathetic. She almost laughed thinking about writing Kyle one of her sarcastic letters. Maybe she'd send a version to Prime too: *Turns out your thugs are just as gross as you. Guess their paychecks come with a blowjob quota, huh? Shame I forgot to ask Hordak before he limped off.*

None of them noticed the *real* Catra. Not really. Just another body to leer at—until one idiot actually made her an offer. She laughed, before the Patron could intervene.

"Look at me," Catra said, "You really think you can buy me with that pocket change? My virginity's worth more than your entire purse." Never mind that she'd lost it years ago, for nothing more than a promise Prime had broken the moment it suited him. She named her price anyway—more than twice what Scorpia had once joked she'd pay for Adora, stacked on top of what Etherian slaves went for. A number so high it was obscene.

The man slunk off, humiliated.

"If you were mine to employ," the Patron murmured, "I could never pay rent."

"One sale and you'd own a palace," Catra shot back, baring her fangs in a grin.

"I should throw you over my knee. Terrible little beast."

She leaned into the couch cushions, utterly at ease, almost purring. "You could triple your prices and they'd still line up drooling to pay. You're welcome."

"For what?"

She tilted her chin toward a customer fumbling for his purse. "That one. He already paid once, and he's about to pay again. Bet you a silver he doesn't last the night."

The Patron's expression shifted—measuring her now, not dismissing her. On the next couch, her double was busy kissing three girls in rotation like it was a contest. Perfect. Another stain on Catra's reputation.

Unbothered, Catra slid her skirt just enough to flash a little more thigh, then leaned close, voice dropping into something intimate.

"I've got a pen pal in the Crimson Wastes," she said lightly. "Spent hours digging up maps, rumors. But you? You'd know better. Tell me about the clan leaders near Weave's Slope."

The Patron laughed, surprised and charmed, her coin already tucked away. "You ask for the world, my lady." His hand brushed her knee like they were conspirators.

Catra only smiled.

And she listened. Very, very carefully.

✧

By the time the fake-Catra—Hemlock in a stolen look—finally stood up, she was draped in whores like some victorious conqueror. Prime's men had also finished their business, wiping their mouths and buckling their belts with the gross satisfaction of men who thought themselves above notice. Free now, they trailed after her, mutts chasing their false mistress down the brothel halls.

Which meant none of them saw when the Patron quietly ordered his house muscle to escort *Colette* out. Cloak on, basket in hand, Catra walked right through the front door. The bouncer strutted beside her, brazenly escorting her down Ghost's Ridge Stop's main road. They parted cleanly at the gates—no questions, no trouble.

The horse was still tied where she'd left it. Catra smirked to herself. Too easy.



✧

Riding back into camp, Catra fought the urge to look smug. Her skirts were bunched high enough for the saddle. Soldiers glanced up as she passed—some confused, some openly gawking, some pretending they hadn't noticed at all. Their Crown Princess, foul-mouthed, cold-blooded Catra, gone overnight and returning at dawn in a dress with no slave in sight. She could practically *hear* the rumors starting.

Lonnie came out first, shirtless, her sword dangling in her hand like she'd only just picked it up. Her face was hard as iron, but her stance—wide, wary—said she'd expected trouble. Entrapta

scrambled out behind her, wearing less, holding a shirt she'd been trying to force on Lonnie, wild hair frizzing in the morning wind. The moment Entrapta saw Catra, she yelped, cheeks going pink, and ducked half-behind Lonnie as if she'd been caught out in her underwear. Because she had.

"Y-your highness," Entrapta stammered, voice muffled from her position half-hidden.

"She escaped?" Lonnie asked flatly.

Catra stiffened. The accusation hit raw. After everything, Lonnie thought she'd *let* Adora get away?

"Prepare the camp to move within the day," Catra ordered coolly, ignoring the bite of it. "Run drills until then. Real drills. Not—" her eyes flicked to Entrapta, "—eachother.' Do I need to slow that down for you?"

Entrapta made a small noise of protest. "We weren't—"

"The Etherian—" Lonnie started.

Catra cut her off, her tone sharp. "Where my slave is, what she's doing—that's my business, not yours." And then, more softly, like she could make it true if she just said it: "She'll catch up."

Lonnie's jaw tightened, but she didn't argue. Discipline kept her silent. Her face, though, betrayed her—doubt and disapproval plain as day. Entrapta peeked from behind her, eyes darting between the two of them, looking like she wanted to disappear.

Catra ignored them both, riding past without a second glance.

✧

Her tent was dark, empty, and far too quiet. Without Adora's constant, infuriating competence—without the girl striding ahead to bark orders and have everything arranged—Catra had to face the silence. She hadn't even brought a proper staff, just barely

enough attendants to make Adora's presence plausible. At the time it had amused her, imagining the "Mighty She-Ra" scrubbing her chamber pot. She'd even toyed with the idea of making herself suffer through bad meals to make that task even worse. But she'd dismissed it, knowing such childish behaviour would weaken her own position.

Now she mildly regretted it. At least then she'd have *something* to laugh at.

The three boys scrambling to serve her were hopeless. Too nervous, too clumsy, too *loud*. They bowed too much, hovered too long. One stared at her like she was a wild animal, another wouldn't shut up with his attempts at friendliness, the third tripped over his own boots. When they finally brought her coffee —after two wrong attempts—it was watery swill.

Catra seriously considered executing them, if only to get some peace.

✧

She woke to the smell of smoke.

Not the sudden snap-to-alertness she'd felt in Ghost's Ridge Stop, when she'd trusted Adora to wake her only for something urgent. This time her body was heavy, dragging her back toward sleep even as the scent of burning canvas stung her nose. Horses screamed. Soldiers shouted.

Her first thought was almost laughable: *Adora will wake me if it matters*.

She almost slipped under again when Rogelio crashed into her tent, scales glinting in the firelight.

This time, she bolted upright.

Bleary-eyed, heart hammering, Catra didn't know where she was. For a heartbeat she wasn't in her tent at all—she was thirteen

again, trapped in on the Flagship, Prime looming over her. Furious, cruel. She flinched before she even registered Rogelio's bulk in the firelight, his sword dripping blood onto her rug, his stride heavy and purposeful.

"No—" The sound came out small, raw. A whimper, not a command. "Prime, don't. Please."

Rogelio's face was carved in fury, but there was something else under it—concern, fleeting, gone almost before she could notice. Then something struck his back hard. He snarled, whipping around, and flung a smaller body to the floor.

"Your highness," he rasped, advancing again, eyes locked on her. "I have to—"

He was too close. The tent blurred. Prime's shadow was overlaid on Rogelio's, the stench of alien wine muddling with the sharp reek of burning canvas. Panic clawed its way up her throat.

"Please—!" Catra didn't even know what she was begging for. A breath? Mercy? Anything to stop this moment from breaking her in half.

And then Rogelio froze.

He hadn't seen Entrapta get back up. She slammed into him with all her wiry strength, and his sword came up too late. Her knife was already buried in his throat. His eyes went wide. He staggered, choking, and then he was down—scales, steel, blood—thudding to the rug.

Rogelio's blood spread black across her floor, mingling with Entrapta's smaller drips.

Rogelio. One of her best. One of the few she had trusted.

It wasn't the first time trust had ended with a blade pointed at her chest. And, thanks to Entrapta, it wouldn't be the last. There was no way to question Rogelio now.

Catra pieced herself back together slowly, her gaze tracking the blood down Entrapta's shaking hands, the way she swayed where she stood. She was pale, breathing fast. The knife clattered from her fingers, thrown as though it scalded her.

Catra finally remembered that her Etherian wasn't here.

"First time?" Her voice was even, steady. She swung her legs over the edge of the bed and crossed them, a picture of calm. Entrapta jumped at the sound, still trembling.

Catra gestured lazily toward a chair. "Sit, before you fall."

Entrapta nodded jerkily, then folded down—onto the floor, beside Rogelio's corpse. Not the choice Catra would have made.

"I'm sorry!" Entrapta burst out, bloodied hands hovering helplessly before her face. She froze when she realized what stained them. "I didn't—I didn't mean—!"

The tent flap opened. For a second, the smoky world outside bled in, red-orange with fire. Then Lonnie stepped through, blade already drawn.

Catra's chest clenched. Another betrayal? Another friend turned enemy? She thought she'd hardened herself, but the old hurt still flared hot.

This was her fault. Her arrogance. Everyone had a price. Everyone but one person—and Catra had let that person walk away.

Her eyes flicked to her sword. She measured the distance. She could make it—if she used Entrapta as cover. Entrapta, who had just saved her. Entrapta, still shivering in a puddle of blood. Catra was willing to do that. That was who she was.

Yes. She could win.

She waited. Calm, collected, ready.

Lonnie's eyes scanned the scene—the corpse, the knife on the rug, Entrapta's pale face, Catra perched on the edge of the bed.

"Want to tell me," Lonnie said flatly, "why the hell Rogelio's bleeding out in your tent?"

Catra's lips curved. Sharp. Defensive. "Maybe because he tried to kill me?"

Lonnie's eyes narrowed. "He—"

Catra prepared herself to leap for her sword.

But –

Lonnie didn't attack. She didn't come charging in like another knife aimed at Catra's back. She froze instead, boots half-sinking into the ruined rug, her eyes darting over the blood, the body, Entrapta's pale form on the ground. She took a half-step toward Entrapta before her gaze locked on Catra.

"Princess," Lonnie said, voice low but steady. "You hurt?"

Catra arched a brow. "Is that what we're calling it now? 'Hurt'? You walk in on Rogelio bleeding all over my floor and you want to check if I scraped my knee?" Her tone was light, but her claws dug into her palms, hidden by the way she folded her arms.

Lonnie shifted, jaw tight. "Are you okay?"

"Do we have an uprising?" Catra countered, coolly, like she hadn't just been startled out of sleep by betrayal.

"Yes, Your Highness." Lonnie's eyes flicked back to Rogelio, then Entrapta, then Catra. Her shoulders eased a fraction. So she wasn't here to slit Catra's throat. Not tonight.

"Well," Catra said, a smile curling, razor-edged, "I seem to have napped through the fun part. Very unprofessional of me." She tilted her head, ears twitching. "But given you're standing here

giving me a status report, I take it you've already dragged the situation back under control?"

"Yes," Lonnie said again, though her voice faltered. "Are you sure you—"

"Don't finish that sentence," Catra snapped. She straightened, finally letting the claws show in her voice. "Rogelio tried to kill me. Entrapta killed him instead. That's the report. Now tell me you didn't let the coffee supplies go up in flames."

"I—" Lonnie's gaze flickered again to Entrapta, who was pale and swaying where she sat in the bloodstained rug.

Catra sighed, long and theatrical. "She's bleeding, not dead. Drag her to a medic before she collapses on something expensive. Unless the medic's a traitor, too. Hard to keep track these days." She flicked her fingers in dismissal, a little wave like shooing away a cat that wasn't her. "And have someone deal with this mess. The body, the rug. And coffee. Real coffee, not the piss that got served last night. If the idiot who makes it can't tell the difference, I'll just assume he's plotting treason, too."

✧

Lonnie had claimed it was under control, but the camp didn't look anything close to steady until well after the sun had clawed its way up, burned overhead, and begun to slip again.

The real threat hadn't been the traitors—they were few, pathetic even, and most of the clones hadn't followed them. That was something Catra would almost be proud of later, when she had the space to let herself think it through. It meant the work mattered. It meant she, Adora, Lonnie—they had built something that held.

But the fires. The fires were the problem.

Adora had been the one to think ahead, of course. Fire drills, bucket chains, all the boring shit that Catra had mocked at the

time. Now, the soldiers moved like clockwork, passing water in steady rhythm. The water was far from the blaze, naturally. Nothing could be simple. And there weren't enough hands.

Catra didn't bark about it. She didn't waste time. She grabbed a bucket, joined the line.

When the smoke cleared and the camp steadied, Catra turned to what mattered most.

"Round up the survivors," she ordered. She scratched a line in the soot with the toe of her boot. "Here. Kneeling."

By the time they were dragged in front of her, the sun was high and brutal, and sweat plastered her coat to her back. Her hair clung to her neck, heavy with ash.

One of the rebels lifted his head and spat at her boots.

"You'd know about kneeling, wouldn't you, you filthy little—"

Lonnie's fist cracked across his jaw before he could finish. The soldier hit the ground, teeth red in the dirt.

Catra's lips quirked, sharp and satisfied. She gave Lonnie the smallest nod. Then, without looking back, she turned toward her tent. "I'll be back when I'm clean. Try not to let anyone else stab me before then."

Catra scrubbed her hands, then her face, then the back of her neck. Over and over. The water ran pink, then red, then clear again. She didn't think. She pulled on a clean jacket, fastened it with quick, sharp motions. She didn't think. She brushed out her hair with rough strokes that made her ears flick back. She didn't think.

When it came time to deal with the traitors, she didn't delegate. Catra did it herself—efficient, clean as possible. She didn't flinch, even when the first one was a servant she'd seen just the night before, pouring her wine instead of cofee. She kept her eyes low,

fixed on the blade, not their faces. Looking into their eyes—that was the mistake she'd made before.

The sword was heavier than she wanted to admit. The bodies were harder to sever than she expected. But her swings were quick and final. She didn't gag. She didn't stop.

"Two pyres," she said when it was done, her voice clipped, like none of it mattered. "Ours separate from theirs. I want names written down for every soldier we lost today. Families notified."

Logistics. Numbers. Boxes to check. Something to hold onto.

The soldiers scattered to obey. Catra went to the wounded. She didn't ask how they were feeling—didn't care for pain levels or fears. She wanted facts. Were they stable? Were they fit to march tomorrow? Could they fight? She was satisfied: one would need watching overnight, maybe a stretcher in the morning, the rest would live. Clone 12 muttered about keeping them longer, but Catra barely listened.

Entrapta wouldn't meet her eyes.

When the pyres were ready, Catra lit them herself. Flames roared to life, greedy and hot, the air thick with the stench of burning bodies. She told herself it was just smoke. Just another fire. Nothing more. But when she saw Rogelio among the traitors, her stomach clenched. His scales cracked and curled as the heat swallowed him.

She stood long after the others drifted away, staring into the blaze. She kept her jaw tight, her arms folded. She didn't let herself think of how many nights Rogelio had stood guard outside her door. Of how many times he had shielded her from Prime's wrath before it went too far. Of how often she'd screamed herself awake and no one had ever breathed a word, because Rogelio had made sure of it.

When did you turn on me? What did they offer you? Why does everyone have a price? Were you merely chipped or did you truly

hate me all this time?

The sky was bruising into night when Catra finally moved. That was when she heard hoofbeats thunder in the distance.

Not a surprise. A relief.

Adora was back.

Catra didn’t hesitate. She shoved through camp, ignoring the carts, the wreckage, the weary soldiers still putting things in order. Her pace quickened with every step until she was practically running. She didn’t want to stop, didn’t want to give herself the chance to think better of it. She cut straight through the husk of a burned-out tent, shouldering the charred flap aside—

And froze.

Adora was there. Alive. Staring right at her.

For once in her life, Catra had no words.

Chapter End Notes

> I honestly don't think I'll get another chapter done by tomorrow but it's only 5pm and I'm not cooking dinner, so anything could happen.
>
> Thank you for behaving 😘
>
> Otherwise there will be Catradora one-shots for day 10 and 29 of Kinktober. In my head, they're the same Catra and Adora from this au, but obviously not canon for this story. But I'll probably add them to the series so they're easy to find.

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

> I spoil you, here's a slightly shorter chapter because I stopped to draw Catra again.

“Ad—” Catra started, the word breaking from her before she could stop it. Her chest clenched at the slip, at how easy it still was to almost say her name like that. She was grateful when Adora cut her off. Now it sounded like nothing more than a mumble, barely spoken.

“You’re not dead,” Adora said.

She looked at Catra like she couldn’t believe it, like the sight of her was a miracle pulled out of smoke and fire. She sounded relieved. ***Relieved***.

Catra’s mouth went dry.


I'm
not dead

“I’m not dead,” she echoed, because her brain had short-circuited. Because she couldn’t stop staring. Adora looked wrecked—like she’d gone a few rounds with someone bigger than her and then rode hard through the night without stopping. Dirty, tired, bruised. But her eyes…

Her eyes were fixed on Catra like it *mattered* that she was standing here.

“I didn’t think you'd make it back,” Catra admitted, the words slipping out before she could lock them down. Too soft. Too open.

“And yet I made it back,” Adora said. Quiet. Simple. But the way she said it—

“You missed the fun,” Lonnie cut in, her voice flat.

Catra caught it—the way Adora’s expression shifted, like Lonnie’s presence had shattered something fragile that hung between them. Adora’s lips had parted, like she’d been about to say more, something that belonged only to the two of them.

Catra forced her ears down, tried to slow the pounding in her chest. She tried to look like she hadn’t been about to lean forward, like she hadn’t wanted—

Lonnie added. “It’s over. But you can help clean up.”

Adora’s head snapped toward her. “It’s not over, actually. There's another ambush.”

And so Adora shared what she knew.

Catra’s pulse steadied for a different reason now. Prime’s game. Always Prime’s game. Rogelio’s betrayal. The soldiers splintering. The pass ahead. She’d stepped off the board, traded strategy for freedom, and now she couldn’t see the whole pattern. She hated it. She hated not knowing where the knife was coming from next.

Lonnie tried again. “We don’t have to take the pass. We can reroute, circle south. These mercs—they won’t chase us into home territory. They’d be idiots to try.”

She was earnest, almost desperate. Catra nearly sneered. Lonnie wasn’t seeing the game; she didn’t want to. But Catra could. Prime’s hand was all over this.

Her gaze slid back to Adora, who was bent over the maps, shoulders slumped, elbows braced on her knees like they were the only things holding her up.

“No,” Adora said. Her voice was low, but firm. “We should face them tonight.”

Catra leaned back in her chair, arms folding loosely, trying to look unaffected even as her eyes lingered—on Adora’s lips, on the smudge of dirt across her cheek, on the steadiness in her even now. Exhausted, filthy, stubborn as ever.

And still wanting to fight.

Catra let the silence stretch before she spoke. “Normally, I’d say smashing straight through an ambush is idiotic. Not really my style.” She let herself smirk. “But that’s why I think we should do it. It’s the last thing anyone would expect from me.”

Adora’s eyes lifted. Met hers. And for once, Adora didn’t argue—she just nodded.

A yawn cracked her jaw a second later, and she pushed to her feet, steady but bone-tired. Catra stayed seated, watching her, watching the soldier who’d come back when Catra hadn’t believed she would.

Catra didn’t *have* to justify herself. Not to Adora. Not to Lonnie. Not to anyone. Still—she did. Not out of obligation, but because she chose to.

“Your highness—” Lonnie started.

“No,” Catra snapped, “I’ve decided.”

Lonnie shut her mouth, stiff-backed but obedient. Catra knew if she were a better leader, she’d temper her edge. Remember Lonnie had been through hell today. Rogelio gone. Entrapta rattled. Everyone running on fumes. Shadow Weaver would’ve played it smoother—cold comfort, but true. Catra would…try harder. Tomorrow.

“Bring in Clone Twenty-Eight,” Catra ordered. The number tasted strange, mechanical, but she forced herself to use it. Rogelio was dead and a traitor both, but somehow Twenty-Eight had survived, and was starting to prove he wasn’t completely useless. “And Sixteen.” Her tail flicked once, restless. “We’ll need to plan the fight.”

Lonnie saluted, crisp, and left without a word.

Silence settled. Catra looked up. Adora was staring at her again.

“I didn’t think you’d go for it,” Adora said. Her voice was rough from travel, but steady.

“I’ve learned,” Catra said, leaning back in her chair, “that sometimes the fastest way out is just punching a hole straight through the wall.”

That crooked little smile—gods, Catra hated how it undid her. Relief bled across Adora’s face like sunlight breaking through stormclouds. Catra felt something loosen inside her chest, something she didn’t want loosened.

“Your hands,” Catra said, noticing the raw skin across Adora’s knuckles.

Adora blinked down at them, like she’d forgotten. “Oh. Yeah. One of Prime’s mercenaries and I…talked.”

Catra’s lips curled into a dangerous grin. “Please tell me you left him wishing for soup.”

“Catra…” Adora sighed, soft, almost pleading.

Whatever she meant to say, there wasn’t time. Catra stood, brushing it away. “You won’t get to rest. Sorry.” She pushed past the ache in her throat and signaled for coffee.

Clone Twenty-Eight strode in before it arrived, smirking. “Yikes, you look like roadkill. And here I thought the princess only liked putting you to use in her bed.”

Adora’s response was firm. “It’s not like that between us.”

Something flickered in Catra’s chest. She ignored it.

By the time Sixteen and Lonnie returned, the tent hummed with strategy. Maps unrolled, markers scattered, voices rising and cutting. When the servant finally arrived with the tray, his hands shook, spilling drops across the cups.

There were four mugs. One of them set at Adora’s side.

✧

They were splitting up again. Smart plan. The right plan. Catra had even argued *for* it. She wasn’t a child, and Adora wasn’t…a comfort blanket.

Didn’t matter. She still hated it.

Her soldiers were learning fast—reading her moods, tensing when her ears twitched, waiting for claws. A rebellion was reason enough for sharp tempers. Much easier to blame that than admit the real reason her tail lashed was because Adora wasn’t in reach.

She couldn’t remember half her speech before the march. Something about crushing raiders, about hitting them so hard they’d choke on it. She might’ve told the troops to whip out their junk and beat the enemy with it. Honestly, she hoped she hadn’t. Some of the dumber ones might actually try it. The usual liquids on the battlefeild were gross enough.

The convoy rattled on in silence, trucks grinding through rough passes. Even with headlights, the path was brutal. The fighting would be worse. Catra welcomed it. Something to burn herself against. Something to stop her from thinking about the soldiers she'd executed, the ones she'd lost. Later. She'd bleed over it later.

Ahead, Adora rode half out of her truck's cab, barking orders, profile carved in starlight. Catra hated it. Too exposed, too easy a shot. Not because she was soft—because she wasn't. Adora was valuable. Useful. A captain like Lonnie couldn't bait an ambush the way Adora could. And Adora was good. Catra had given her soldiers orders to foller her without question, slave or not.

It was fine. It had to be fine.

A clatter. Hair like living ropes curled over the side of Catra's truck, and Entrapta's wide eyes appeared upside-down in the window.

"Hi! Can I ride with you?" she chirped, cheerfully oblivious to the tension hanging heavy in the cab.

Catra's tongue felt coated with something bitter and rancid, like she'd swallowed ash and grease. Dislike. Irritation. It clung. She told herself it was just the insurrection, the waiting ambush, the memory of Rogelio's betrayal. It was sending Adora ahead as bait when every instinct in her body wanted the Etherian close, where Catra could keep her under watch. It felt too much like Prime was still here, standing just behind her—his shadowy breath on her neck, fingers in her fur.

"This is a *war*, not a picnic," Catra snapped, eyes narrowing. "Get back in your truck."

"But—" Entrapta clung to the side of the vehicle with her hair, her wide eyes catching the faint light of the moons. "We're not even the target here. If the bait doesn't draw their attention, then it's not really bait, is it? And if Mara can't keep them busy enough, then she's obviously worth some more scarr—"

Her mouth snapped shut under Catra's glare.

"If you're about to suggest I need advice on how to discipline my slave," Catra said, "you'd better think twice."

Entrapta flushed crimson, but her jaw set stubbornly. "Maybe not advice. But. I *did* save your life back there, remember? Doesn't that count for something?"

Catra's lips pulled thin, her stare like sharpened ice. Entrapta's face went pale under it, but she didn't look away.

"I'm not your enemy," Entrapta said softly. "I'd like to be…your friend."

"I don't do friends," Catra bit out, sharper than she meant.

"You could," Entrapta pressed, her voice quickening with strange, earnest energy. "If you wanted. You've seen you can trust me—I'm not lying. I have a title, a rank, I've stood beside you—" Her hair shifted as she leaned forward, almost reaching for Catra's arm.

Catra slid back an inch, just out of reach.

Entrapta froze, hand half-outstretched, face flushing even further with something Catra couldn't pin down. It wasn't humiliation, not exactly. Something more complicated. Something Catra didn't have time to figure out right now.

Because the ground shook. The thunder of hooves tore through the night. Black shapes—mercenaries spilling from the treeline like a flood.

Lonnie's shout cut through the air, barking the alarm.

Catra's claws itched for her sword. Entrapta's fingertips brushed her sleeve in the scramble, but then fell away as Catra drew steel.

The mercenaries hit, slamming into exhausted foot soldiers, into broken lines. This wasn't where the ambush was supposed to happen—it wasn't—

But before panic could take root, headlights seared through the dark. Trucks came roaring back down the ridge. Catra heard her voice before she saw her—Adora, yelling commands with impossible clarity over the engine roar, rallying soldiers, shifting formations.

The mercenaries broke. Undisciplined, sloppy. They couldn't stand against soldiers fighting in clean, trained lines—against the pressure from both sides.

Catra jumped from the truck, cutting through the chaos. She struck down a mercenary raising his axe toward Adora, fur bristling, breath ragged, and didn't feel the usual hesitation twist in her gut.

She stepped into Adora's orbit, blade dripping. "Weren't you bait?" Catra hissed.

"Change of plan!" Adora shouted back.

She was grinning, Catra knew it without needing to see her face in the dark. She could *hear* it in her voice. And for a single, dangerous heartbeat, Catra's chest clenched with relief so sharp it hurt.

✧

When the dust settled, there was still work to do. But even with the wounded to tend and the dead to burn, the camp hummed with restless joy. A night that should have broken them had ended with an impossible victory.

The mercenaries were scattered, the trap overturned. Only two more soldiers lost. And every hour, some clone or soldier made their way to Catra—saluting, reporting, sometimes awkwardly stammering—to tell her how her "slave" had saved them, saved

the fight, saved *her*. How proud they were to serve under a woman like that.

It gnawed at Catra, though she kept her back straight, her replies clipped.

The tents rose again. Bonfires flared. Someone opened a barrel of wine, and laughter carried across the dark. Catra pulled Lonnie aside, kept her pinned with orders until the woman's shoulders drooped, until the excuse of "duty" wore thin. Then Catra got to the real point.

"Entrapta's mouth is going to get her killed," Catra said flatly. "She doesn't get to talk to me like that just because she got lucky once."

"Your highness, she didn't mean—"

"Oh, I'm sure everything in that cluttered brain is sunshine and innocence." Catra's eyes narrowed. "That doesn't mean I'll tolerate it. You talk to her, Lonnie. Because if I have to, she won't like it. Neither will you."

Lonnie stiffened, jaw tight, but she nodded. She understood.

Catra waved her off soon after and leaned back against a tree on the camp's edge. Her limbs felt heavy, her chest hollow. She *shouldn't* feel that way. Not with the camp alive with laughter and firelight, not with another of Prime's little plays unraveled.

Lonnie deserved to laugh tonight. They all did. And Catra—Catra deserved…what? She couldn't even remember the last time she'd told Lonnie she'd done well. Probably never. She thought of Shadow Weaver, of the way she had always found a way to inspire her, and hated herself for knowing she wasn't like her.

"Not going celebrate?"

The voice startled her. Or rather, the *effect* of it did—how much the sound jolted through her. Adora leaned against the same tree

without waiting for permission, too close, smelling like sweat and iron and smoke. Catra should have shoved her off. Instead she found herself wanting her closer.

Infuriating.

"I'm not used to Prime screwing up," Catra said, because that was safer than admitting anything real.

Adora huffed a breath, half a laugh. "That's because he's working blindly from a distance." Her voice was rough, exhausted, but there was warmth in it. Fondness, maybe. Or maybe Catra was too tired, hearing things that weren't there.

"It's because of you," Catra said before she could stop herself.

She felt, rather than saw, Adora's head turn—her confusion, her surprise. Catra kept her gaze locked on the firelit camp, refusing to look back.

"What do you mean?"

Catra's claws dug faint crescents into her palms. Don't say it. Don't make it real. But the words spilled anyway. "He doesn't know what to do with you. After everything I—after what I did to you." Her throat closed for a beat. She forced it open again. "He expected another Hordak. Another thug. Another mercenary who'd turn the second things got hard. That's what was supposed to happen tonight. That's the trap he set."

The silence stretched long. Broken only by the crackle of fire and the echo of laughter across camp.

Finally, Catra made herself look.

There she was—*Adora of Bright Moon*. Hair plastered to her forehead, streaked with dirt and someone else's blood. Eyes red-rimmed with exhaustion, but still that impossible blue. Shoulders that shouldered everything—burdens, battles, a world—without complaint.

Catra hated her. She wanted her. She didn't want her dead anymore. She didn't want to imagine the world without her.

And for one fleeting, treacherous heartbeat, Catra allowed herself the thought: *I'm so glad you came back to me.*

She looked at her hands. The hands that had pulled iron grates from walls, that had ripped through enemy lines like paper, that had driven a sword straight through Shadow Weaver's chest. Those hands had ended her life—*ended* her, in all her power and mystery and care. Reduced her to nothing but meat that would fester and rot in the dirt.

Those same hands had left Catra defenseless, had cleared the way for Prime to come knocking on her door more times than she could count.

Catra forced herself not to flinch. She made herself look. She made herself keep speaking.

"Instead," she said, "you've saved my life. More than once. You've taken the disaster of a unit I was given and turned them into real soldiers. Fighters. You…" She had to breathe. It burned. "Tonight you handed me my first victory. Prime never imagined you'd be useful to me like this."

Her throat ached with everything unsaid. *You're the best person I've ever known. And you killed the only one who came close. Why did it have to be you? Why could Angella or Glimmer have done it? Not you.*

"If he'd known what you could do," Catra forced herself to finish, "he'd never have let you off the flagship with me."

She wanted to bite down on the rest. On the truth. *I wanted to leave you there. I tried. If I had, I'd be dead by now, a dozen times over. Why are you still here? Why are you still saving me?*

"I should help with repairs," Adora said, pushing away from the tree. Her voice was low. For one instant, her face flickered with

something Catra recognized—so sorrowful. Regret.

She was leaving. Taking the conversation, the almost-confession, away with her.

Catra's hand shot out before she thought. She caught Adora's arm, her claws pressing through fabric. The move startled them both.

But she couldn't ask her to stay.

"Leave them," she said instead, voice sharp. "Sleep."

Adora shook her head immediately. "I'm fine, really Catra."

Catra's grip tightened. "That's an order, Mara."

Adora looked at her then, and smiled—a weary, crooked thing that had no fight in it. She gave a little huff, almost a laugh, almost a sigh, and went.

✧

When Catra came back to the tent less than an hour later, Adora was already out cold. She'd collapsed across her pallet like a toppled statue, twisted halfway into the sheets, still half-armored.

Catra stood in the doorway, lamp in hand, and stared. The sight of her—solid, snoring, undeniably alive—filled the space with something steady, something strangely comforting.

"She's supposed to keep herself in order," Catra muttered as she fumbled with her own buttons. "Supposed to check every strap before bed."

But Adora hadn't. Her chestplate still clung awkwardly to her. The rest of her armor lay in a heap, crusted with dirt and blood. She hadn't even washed.

“You’re disgusting,” Catra hissed, glaring as she stripped down to her nightshirt. “You’re supposed to *attend* me, not—fall asleep like a rock.”

She tried again, louder. “Adora.” The name slipped out. It gave Catra a shock to hear it aloud. But Adora didn’t twitch.

“If you’re dead,” Catra muttered, “I swear I’ll kill you.”

She crouched beside her, claws teasing at the buckles. Nothing. No stir, no protest.

“And if you wake up,” she added, sharper, “I’ll kill you twice.”

Adora gave a mighty snore, deep and unbothered.

Catra rolled her eyes, but she kept working—sliding straps free, tugging buckles hard, stripping the armor off piece by piece. Adora didn’t even seem to notice.

“Such a shame, Adora,” Catra drawled, crouched over her as she tugged the sheets out from under the heavy bulk of her. “If you were conscious—and didn’t reek like battlefield sweat—I’d make you fuck me into the mattress right now. I'm sure *someone* knows where I could find a strap at this hour.”

She gave a grunt as she yanked the linens free, glaring at the dead weight sprawled on them. “Is that—ugh—drool? Clearly I have no choice but to claim you immediately.”

Adora didn’t so much as stir—except to let out a thick snore and twitch against the pillow. She’d managed to keep on one boot, a bracer, *and* both shin guards, on top of the chestpiece. Catra stripped each off, muttering curses under her breath as she worked.

The only response she got for her trouble was the brush of Adora’s fingertips across her cheek—completely unintentional—and a garbled string of words that sounded suspiciously like “Horses can't talk.” Followed by an amused snort.

Catra froze, stared at her, then rolled her eyes. “Unbelievable.”

There was even one half-hearted attempt at snuggling that she dodged neatly, leaving Adora to clutch at a pillow instead. The Etherian rumbled contentedly around the poor thing, mumbling incomprehensibly as if it were a living creature.

When Catra finally finished, she yanked the half-filthy, half-freed sheets back over her pet and dumped the armor outside the tent for servants to deal with. Adora could double-check the fittings later.

✧

By the time morning came, Catra was already up, washed, dressed, and on her second cup of bitter camp coffee. She’d even finished drafting a terse note to Kyle that she would put in with the rest of the unsent letters to him.

Adora, by contrast, woke like a creature dropped into the wrong dimension. She bolted upright in her pallet, still cocooned head-to-toe in blankets, golden curls sticking every which way like she’d fought a windstorm in her sleep. One cheek was creased with deep pillow-lines.

She blinked blearily at the tent like she’d never seen fabric before.

Catra actually laughed. She couldn’t stop herself.

“Good morning,” she offered lightly, arching her brows. “And no, before you ask—I don’t need anything.”

Adora just blinked at her. Blinked. Stared.

“Clean, dress and report to Lonnie,” Catra instructed, setting her cup down. “We move when the repairs are finished.”

“Goose…mornin,” Adora mumbled finally, rubbing her face with one hand. It was probably meant to be “good morning.” She still hadn’t stopped staring.

Catra bit the inside of her cheek to keep from smiling. The ridiculous lump of her looked so wrong, so out of place here.

She leaned back in her chair, feigning concern. “What’s the matter? Still tired? Should I carry you, maybe? It’s, oh, at least five whole paces to the tent flap.”

That got through—barely. Adora’s hand shot out, fumbling for a pillow, which she hurled with all the force of a dying kitten.

Catra caught it easily, smirked, and tossed it back onto her lap.

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

You'll either hate this or love this... or both?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Before they set out the next morning, Catra dispatched a rider. The horse Sea Hawk had loaned out was to be returned—with a generous payment and a smug note of thanks. The cloth merchant's dress Catra had borrowed was bundled up as well, sent back to the brothel with extra coin and a neatly phrased message for the Patron about his people. Catra's small gestures of diplomacy had smoothed things so far, but Crimson Wastes trading routes were trickier, and she knew well enough that charm had limits.

A single rider could outrun an army. By dawn, an answer was back in Catra's hands.

"You can open it," Catra told Adora after the brief exchange was done and the Patron's messenger had left. She'd spoken in cool tones throughout, letting the words of victory sit comfortably in her chest. This had been hers alone—her maneuvering, her win. And watching Adora's face go blank with confusion at the negotiation had been satisfying. The look she gave her now, though—when she lifted the wrapping and found the green dress folded inside—well. That was something else.

"You wore—?" Adora started, fingers brushing the fabric.

Catra caught the flicker in her eyes, the imagining. Could see it as if the picture itself hung between them. *Would you like me better in that? Would you see me as yours?*

Catra's mouth twitched. She couldn't decide what answer she'd give if she said the words aloud. It didn't matter. There were

harder roads ahead, and distractions were luxuries she couldn't afford.

✧

Weave's Slope rolled out before them, a landscape Catra knew in her bones. The air itself tasted like home—sun-warmed stone, faint salt from the southern winds. Weave's Slope was hers, the one patch of the world untouched by Prime's suffocating reach. Not her body, not her mind—those had all been claimed, used, turned against her. But this place, this stretch of land, remained hers alone.

Even so, Catra's nerves clawed at her that night when she sought Adora out. She waited until Adora was bent over the gear, hands busy with straps and checks—so normal, so stupidly diligent—and then Catra slipped into words she'd practiced in the dark, words that still felt like pebbles grinding against her teeth.

"As we draw closer to the border," she began, careful, in halting First Ones' speech, "I think it would be safer—more private—if our talks were in your tongue, not mine."

Adora's head snapped up. The look she gave her was sharp. Catra's pulse doubled.

"What is it?" Catra asked.

"...Nice accent," Adora said, trying and failing to keep a straight face. Her mouth twitched. Her shoulders trembled. She was absolutely about to laugh.

Catra's ears flattened. Her tail lashed behind her. She *knew* her pronunciation wasn't perfect, hated every uneven syllable. She'd studied the old language alone, clawing her way through it word by miserable word, hating the sound, hating the taste, but hating failure more. And now here was Adora, biting her lip to keep from cracking up.

She glared. Adora didn’t stop grinning. In fact, she leaned closer, as if listening more intently was some kind of gift.

“You mean,” Adora said slowly, “in case people are listening in.”

“Yes,” Catra said flatly. *And so you can’t lie to me in First One any better than you lie to me in Etherian*.

Adora’s smile softened, then. “Last night we were talking about the Siege, weren’t we? You… wanna keep going from there?”

✧

“If you don’t stop laughing at me,” Catra snapped later, switching back to Etherian, “I’ll have you whipped.”

“I’m not laughing at you!” Adora protested—while very obviously laughing at her.

Catra hissed, but the sound came out weak. Infectious, that was the problem. Adora’s grin carried a heat that seeped under Catra’s skin, made her chest feel unsteady. It wasn’t just the words—it was the fact that Adora was *happy*. Happy hearing her speak this cursed tongue. Happy that Catra was trying.

She leaned forward, elbows on her knees, eyes shining, and murmured in a voice that sent a flush prickling along Catra’s ears, “Say artillery again.”

Catra’s ears pinned flat. She repeated the word anyway.

Adora collapsed into laughter, full-bodied, head thrown back, curls shaking.

Catra crossed her arms, scowling hard enough to set the tent smoldering. Her lips betrayed her anyway, tugging at the corner.

Catra scowled. “What exactly is so terrible about the way I’m saying it?”

Adora didn’t even try to answer—she just doubled over laughing, shoulders shaking, cheeks pink with the effort of holding it in.

Catra’s ears twitched. “You’re impossible.”

Adora wheezed, “No—no, it’s good, it’s—really good!” Then she lost control again, laughter spilling out.

Catra sighed, but the corner of her mouth wanted to twitch upward too. She stretched long and lazy, tail flicking, and stood. The night had gone softer than she’d meant it to, and that was dangerous. “Alright,” she said, deciding it was time to cut things off before they drifted anywhere she didn’t want to follow.

She gave her back to Adora without hesitation. “Come here. Help me out of this.” Her tone was casual, but she said it in First One, watching carefully out of the corner of her eye.

She heard Adora rise, felt her presence draw close, felt warm hands brush the fabric between her shoulder blades—then stop.

Catra frowned. “Well? Don’t just stand there.”

Silence. Then Adora’s voice, quieter than before. “I don’t think we need a secret language for this.”

Something in her tone made Catra’s stomach clench. She turned her head slightly, trying to catch Adora’s expression. The teasing warmth from moments ago was gone.

“You don’t like it?” Catra asked, sharper than she meant. The good mood drained out of her as fast as it had come. For a second she felt as if she’d been careless—like she’d let herself laugh and relax with *Adora*, the woman she could almost imagine as a friend, instead of *Adora*, of Etheria, weapon forged by her enemies.

Adora’s hands didn’t move. Catra forced herself to keep her tone even, to keep speaking First One. “Maybe I just need to be more accurate,” she murmured. Her voice had an edge now. “How does

someone in Eternia order around a slave? Should I sound more like that?”

She felt Adora’s fingers clench against her fastenings. When Adora spoke, her voice was low, cold. “You want me to teach you how to command a bed slave?”

Catra smiled without any humor. “Why not?”

The silence stretched. Catra could hear her own pulse thudding in her ears. She felt her jacket give way as Adora tugged at the fastenings, a little too hard, before finally answering.

“If you owned a slave,” Adora said carefully, “you could order her however you wanted.”

“Funny,” Catra replied, bitter-sweet. “Doesn’t always feel that way.”

Another pause. She could feel Adora leaning closer, her breath stirring the hair near Catra’s ear.

“I’d rather you just… talked to me,” Adora said finally, still in First Ones, but softer, truer. “As a woman.”

The words hit harder than Catra expected. All the sharp edges inside her seemed to scatter. She turned to face her, pulse quick.

Adora was closer than she usually allowed herself to be. Her eyes were steady, intense—not disgusted, not mocking. Just *there*. It made Catra’s throat tighten.

Catra tipped her head back a fraction, surrender and defiance tangled in the gesture. Adora’s presence was overwhelming, but she didn’t pull away.

“Unbutton the front,” Catra said at last, still clinging to command even as her pulse jumped.

Adora's hands slipped from her waist to her collar. She didn't look down as she worked, didn't break eye contact. The jacket opened slowly, button by button, until her hands slid inside—broad palms against Catra's shirt, her sides, her back. Catra's arms felt pinned.

Adora leaned in closer, breath hot at her ear. "Unless you want me to…" Her fingers brushed just under the line of Catra's belt, lingering there, a question in the touch.

"Move away," Catra said abruptly.

Adora obeyed instantly, retreating a pace.

They stared at each other in the heavy silence that followed, the air between them charged, unfinished.

Catra's reply had come out in her own tongue, not First One. That alone was proof of how badly she'd slipped. Her voice was too raw, too unguarded. She hated how much she could feel it shaking. She probably looked like some cornered animal, ears flat, eyes wide.

And Adora—Adora was still looking at her. Not like she pitied her. Not like she was disgusted. She looked at her like she *wanted* her.

And Catra—stars help her—wanted that too. She wanted it so badly she could choke on it. And maybe that was why she panicked, because the want felt like claws around her throat, the kind she'd never escape. Prime's claws.

She watched Adora's expression soften, then sharpen again, the heat in her eyes cooling into caution.

Adora cleared her throat. "Unless you… need something else, I should grab some fuel for the heater."

"Go," Catra snapped. The word was too quick. She wanted to claw it back the moment it left her mouth.

Her chest hurt. She wanted to cry.

✧

By the time Catra changed, she didn't even try to sit at her desk, head high, like she usually would. That mask felt too heavy. She crawled into bed instead, curling under blankets as if hiding there could smother the ache inside her.

She wanted Adora so much her whole body hummed with it—and she hated herself for trembling at the same time. Fear and desire wrapped around each other like vines strangling the same tree.

When Adora came back with the fuel, she didn't linger.

Catra kept her back turned the whole time, pressed tight to the blankets. She wouldn't risk Adora seeing her like this, wouldn't risk her seeing the fear knotted up with her want.

But when the tent was quiet again, the shadows heavy around her, Catra could still *feel* him—Prime. His hand in her hair, his voice curling through the dark.

Even here, even now, he'd found a way to ruin her. He had broken her so thoroughly that the first person she could ever want again was the one person it would kill her to touch.

And oh, he would laugh. He would *love* to know she ached for Adora and couldn't take her. That his shadow still sat at her side. That she was still his prisoner, even free of him.

Catra pressed her eyes shut. Adora had given her hope, reminded her she was more than Prime's toy. Adora had made her *remember*.

But in this? Here? Catra was ruined. Horde Prime had won.

✧

"Welcome to my—" Catra waved a hand at the jagged outcropping and the wards that shimmered faintly along its walls, "—ancestral home."

Her tone was dry, mocking, but something in her chest was tight. The wards still held, Shadow Weaver's last gift to her. Weave's Slope was the only place she had left untouched by Prime's reach. Her only claim to home.

And now she was bringing Adora here.

It made her feel… strange. Shy, even. As if this were some family estate, as if she were about to introduce Adora to kin waiting inside. Ridiculous. But she couldn't shake it.

Adora, of course, was being Adora—eyes sharp, taking in everything. Catra knew she was cataloguing supplies, defenses, weak points. Always on duty. Always the soldier.

Catra stuffed down the little flutter in her chest and reminded herself not to flirt. Not anymore.

"The warden," Adora said finally, gaze flicking toward the crooked old caretaker who had opened the gates, "doesn't look thrilled about letting me through."

The woman had glared daggers at Adora but bowed her head to Catra.

"She doesn't have to like it," Catra replied coolly. "She just has to obey."

But then she ruined it—because she always ruined it—by blurting before she'd planned it out: "We're not staying here. Not tonight. Meet me at the stables after dark. When you're finished with your duties. Covertly."

She'd rushed it out in First One.

Adora blinked at her, then tilted her head, eyes dancing. "Oh. Are we running away together?" she asked in the same language.

Catra glared. "Do you think you're funny?"

“Sometimes? Yeah.” Adora’s grin widened.

“Stables,” Catra said, low and sharp. “After dark.”

Adora leaned closer, voice a little too smooth. “Say covertly again.”

“Covertly.”

“Co-vert-ly.”

“That’s exactly what I said!”

Adora tilted her head like she wasn’t convinced. “No, no, it’s fine. Very cute.”

Catra’s tail lashed. “*Cute*?” She switched back to her own tongue, narrowing her eyes. “I really hope I’m misunderstanding that word.”

Adora only smirked, saluted half-heartedly, and turned away. “I’ve got work. Covertly.”

Catra hissed under her breath, but her cheeks were warm.

✧

Adora paused just inside the stables, letting her eyes adjust to the dim. Catra didn’t need to look to know what she’d see—rows of horses settled for the night, quiet except for the occasional snort or shuffle. She’d already dismissed the grooms. No one here but them.

“There’s nothing wrong with the way I talk,” Catra said sharply, before Adora could open her mouth. She made the First One words sound deliberate, crisp—too careful, like she was daring Adora to laugh. Her restless hands found something to do in tugging her horse from the stall. Both mounts were already saddled and waiting. She wasn’t about to risk Adora getting annoyed over chores.

Sometimes, Catra actually did know where to stop.

“You packed,” Adora noted instead of biting. Her tone was light, but she didn’t miss much. “Guess you hated riding around without extra clothes. You’re kind of high-maintenance, you know that?”

Arrogant in her own tongue, sure of herself. Catra rolled her eyes, but she didn’t hate hearing it.

“Are we going to stand here all night?” Catra asked, shoving the reins at her. “Get on.”

Adora obeyed with a grin instead of a fight, swinging easily into the saddle. “Since you brought it up,” she said, settling in, “I’ve got a list of words I’d love to hear you say. Think you can keep up?”

“Careful,” Catra shot back. “You’re picking interesting last words.”

They rode east.

The third moon hung low, shedding pale light until the slope fell away and left them in near-dark. Catra didn’t need the glow. She knew the road. The air was warm, thick with the hum of night insects. For her, it stirred something old—the same restless tug she’d felt back at Ghost’s Ridge. Freedom, danger, possibility.

Her mother had once camped beneath this same sky. The thought pressed on her chest.

She pushed it down.

By the time she slowed within the ruins, her throat was tight. She masked it with sarcasm. “Worse than Weave’s Slope. Didn’t think that was possible.”

The collapsed palace loomed in the dark, hollowed out and broken. The first time she’d seen it as a kid, she’d almost cried. Shadow Weaver had wanted to poke through the wreckage for

scraps or bones. Catra had been too scared. She wasn't afraid of much anymore.

That didn't mean this place didn't claw at her.

The riders came for them soon after. Adora's jaw went tight when they stripped her of her weapon, but she didn't resist. Catra knew it burned her—having no control, no say. Still, her temper held. That was something.

"They don't let outsiders see the approach," Catra explained, keeping her voice level as the blindfolds came out. She might have been trying to reassure herself as much as Adora. "We'll be taken in blindfolded."

The last thing she saw was Adora scowling before the cloth cut off her view.

✧

The walk dragged—half an hour of muffled footsteps and men's voices, the scrape of boots on stone. Catra should have been counting turns, memorizing the path. Instead she strained for every trace of Adora—the rhythm of her breathing, the shift of her stride, the familiar scent of her close by.

When the blindfold came off, relief hit sharper than she wanted to admit. Adora was there. Exactly where she'd pictured her.

Her eyes were already scanning the camp. Tents, fires, drummers—Adora was soaking in every detail, breaking it down for strategy. Always. Catra should have been doing the same, but instead she caught herself staring.

"This is it?" Adora finally asked, glancing at her. "Where we're staying?"

She sounded unimpressed. Annoyed, even. She didn't see it—the ground Catra had fought for, the chance that had almost never been.

“It’s a sign of trust,” Catra murmured, leaning a little closer to Adora as the woman’s tense posture radiated discomfort. “Do you know their customs?” She explained the hierarchy, the etiquette, as she had painstakingly pieced together from the old files and scattered accounts—what gestures were proper, what words might impress or offend. She pointed subtly to Siah, Adora’s watchful handler, and to Huntara, the clan’s sharp-eyed chief.

Adora’s jaw tightened, her hands fidgeting against her thighs. Catra could almost feel the pulse of her tension, the rigid coil of energy that said she would rather flee than submit to formality. Catra half-expected Adora to launch herself at Siah the moment she was left to climb the dais.

“Your woman is bitter,” Huntara greeted without ceremony. Her tone was informal, sharp, and direct—far more relaxed than Catra had anticipated. But she noted Adora’s stiff posture, the subtle narrowing of her eyes, and couldn’t help but smirk inwardly. Even among the Etherians, Adora’s presence was remarkable.

“No one warned me Etherian slaves were so high maintenance,” Catra drawled, dropping easily onto the furs at her feet, spreading herself with a casual, feline ease. “She’s… pleasant enough to look at,” she added, a faint edge to her voice, “but some days I wonder if she’s worth the trouble. I hope her ghastly expression hasn’t caused offense.”

The guards hesitated briefly, but eventually Adora was forced to her knees. Huntara’s critical gaze lingered longer than polite, examining her posture, her stance, her restraint.

“My man in Ghost’s Ridge tells me she is strong,” Huntara said, eyes sharp on Catra. “How does she perform?”

Catra allowed herself a quick glance at Adora, noting the tightness in her shoulders and the restrained energy, the way her hands curled at her sides. She knew that look—adrenaline and controlled frustration—but she didn’t let her gaze linger.

“Adequately,” she said, voice flat, masking the heat that rose in her chest.

Huntara laughed, rich and sudden, slapping the arm of her chair until it creaked. “I hear you’re a lovesick cat!”

“I’m ever sorry to disappoint,” Catra answered, tilting her head, the hint of a smirk curling her lips. “I’ve come on business. One queen to another.”

“You think highly of yourself. Catfolk often do,” Huntara remarked, her sharp eyes scanning Catra like a blade testing its edge.

“I have my strengths,” Catra replied, deliberately measured.

The moment stretched, silent but heavy, a battle of wills played out in the subtlest gestures. A servant knelt, offering a cup of milk-colored drink, and Catra waved it off without hesitation. Huntara’s eyes flicked briefly to her, calculating, before the next movement of the negotiation unfolded.

“All right, little cat,” Huntara said at last. “I am convinced. I will deal with you.” She signaled, and the rhythmic beat of drums shifted below. Men moved forward for a demonstration of wrestling technique. Plates of food were offered: Adora was given the milky drink, the second cup met with less hesitation than the first, while Catra accepted only water.

And then, finally, they began negotiating in earnest.

Huntara’s mind was sharp, incisive, and unforgiving. Catra had watched powerful rulers before, but never one quite like her—someone who could have cornered Prime himself and left him scrambling, humiliated by the sheer clarity and precision of her mind. She would have taken him apart piece by piece, exploited every flaw in his command, and emerged unscathed. The thought thrilled Catra.

The military requests Catra had brought were modest, carefully measured to ensure compliance without revealing vulnerability.

But Huntara's interest was strategic: the terms of trade after victory, the equitable benefits for both peoples, the long-term ramifications of renewed relations. She spoke with authority, her mind threading through decades of planning and the subtle manipulations of power.

Catra found herself drawn in despite herself, surprised by the depth of Huntara's understanding, the way she framed challenges as opportunities for mutual gain. They discussed the past, dissected the strained relationships between their peoples, and debated responsibility and blame. Every word, every gesture of Huntara's, was a lesson in diplomacy—and Catra hung on it, trying not to let her growing admiration, and the subtle ache for Adora at her side, become too distracting.

Even as she negotiated, Catra's gaze kept flicking toward Adora. She was watching, listening, the smallest movements of her body betraying alertness and curiosity beneath the forced composure. Every shift, every exhale, reminded Catra of what she wanted and what she might never allow herself to fully have.

Huntara's laugh cut off. She leaned back in her seat, pipe stem between her teeth, chewing at it while smoke drifted upward in slow, twisting coils. Her expression hardened as she thought—it was the kind of face that only grew fiercer the more serious she became.

Catra realized she liked her. She liked the way Huntara listened, measured her words instead of dismissing them out of hand. Not like the Horde, who had spat labels at her—slacker, screw-up, coward, useless. Huntara didn't sneer. She considered. She weighed.

And Catra found she liked being weighed and not discarded.

A few months ago, she would have come at this whole thing differently. Like Prime—slick, scheming, holding back the valuable truths, twisting the terms until she got everything she wanted and left her "ally" with scraps. This wasn't that. This was… straighter.

Not the blunt, golden straightforwardness Adora wielded, no. Something slower. Respectful.

For a flicker of a moment, Catra could almost see herself playing diplomat under Shadow Weaver's rule—Queen Shadow Weaver, and her sharp-eyed right hand. Sitting down with other rulers, trading carefully chosen words for genuine benefit. Pretending it was all in good faith. The vision almost felt real.

Almost.

The night stretched, and the conversation stayed so steady Catra barely thought to glance at Adora—only enough to confirm she was still there, still under control. Until Siah rose and whispered in Huntara's ear.

Catra followed Huntara's gaze—and blinked.

Adora had loosened up, all right. Her grin was wide, her curls mussed, her posture relaxed in a way that made her look—soft. She glowed in the firelight, too at ease for the sharp-edged woman who had arrived at Catra's side with her hackles up. The sight yanked at Catra, pulling her backward into the memory of a tent, thin cloth sliding over her skin, Adora's hands steady at her waist. The way Adora had leaned close, voice dropping until it was just for her: quiet, steady, unshakable.

Unless you want me to—

Catra's shoulders tensed with the ghost of it.

"…generous terms," Huntara was saying. Catra snapped back to attention. Huntara's mouth twitched with amusement as she clarified, "My Siah wishes to be ridden by your Etherian."

Catra blinked again. She turned to Adora, the thought tangling in her chest. Practical, sure. A gesture that could earn favor. But personal—oh, she wanted to see Adora like that again. She wanted—

She stopped herself. Want wasn't the same as need.

"Only if she agrees," Catra said, sharper than intended.

Huntara's brows rose, but she gave a short nod.

Catra's pulse thudded too fast. She thought of Adora's fury in the gardens, Double Trouble between her legs in Catra's form. She thought of her warmth in the tent. The way her eyes softened sometimes, even when they should've been enemies.

Catra raised her voice. "Huntara asks, respectfully, if you'll do her man, Siah, an honor."

Adora's gaze swung to her. There was heat there—not the heat of drink, though the liquor she'd downed was surely spiked with something. Catra recognized the edge of it. Not a numbing, not a fog, but a sharpening. A lowering of the walls without touching the mind. She hadn't let herself drink it; she already knew what she did sober when Adora smiled at her like that. Her heart was hammering hard enough.

Adora tilted her head, eyes never leaving Catra. Her grin curved smaller, warmer. "What kind of honor?"

Catra's voice cut out sharper than intended. "He wants you."

The corner of Adora's mouth twitched—just a flicker, a spark of something behind her usual poise.

"I'm a slave," Adora muttered, the words tasting foreign, forced out more easily by the drink than by will.

Catra's chest tightened. "Choice's still yours," she said, but she knew Adora wasn't hearing her fully. Siah was coming back down the dais, drawing her attention—and Catra felt the sting of jealousy before she could stop it.

It wasn't like the usual heat of being desired by Adora. This was different. There was respect here, hunger even, but also a kind of

trust that Catra had never fully earned. She remembered the balcony at Ghost's Ridge—Adora's body pressed to hers, warm and strong, but restrained. A controlled fire that could have destroyed her if unleashed. And now, seeing her look at someone else with that same fire—Catra's stomach twisted.

"Wait—" Adora's words faltered. She paused, licking her lips. She'd been unwilling in other encounters, like with Double Trouble, keeping herself guarded even as she appreciated the service. Now she hesitated again. "Are you… ordering me to do this?"

Catra leaned back on her elbows, crossing her legs at the ankle as if unconcerned. "Do you need an order? I can direct you, if you lack the expertise."

Adora's glare left Catra as her eyes returned to Siah, who stood uncertain and still, and Catra's pulse skipped. That mix of authority and fire, the stubborn refusal to bend even under Catra's gaze—it was maddening. She wanted to direct Adora, not because she needed to, but because she could. Because she had the power to, and she loved watching Adora resist it.

"Kiss him," Catra said.

Adora moved instantly, sliding forward, capturing Siah's face in her hands, fingers threading through his hair. Catra's eyes widened, heart hammering, breath catching as she watched. She'd done plenty in her life—had plenty done to her—but she had never been kissed. She was fascinated, almost painfully so, trying to understand the intimacy, the closeness. Would it feel weird?

What could someone possibly enjoy about it?

But—

Adora's lips were soft, plush, perfect, and Siah's groan pulled a shiver through Catra. She couldn't deny it: she was envious, curious, and painfully aware of her own desire. Siah's hands roamed boldly, claiming Adora in ways Catra had never dared.

When Adora pulled back, her voice low, pleased, entirely confident, she addressed Huntara, not Catra. “Tell her it would be my honor to lie with one of her men.” She didn’t glance Catra’s way, not once.

Huntara tapped Catra’s arm. “How many do you think she’d enjoy?” she asked, her expression unreadable.

Catra’s mind was a mess of jealousy and longing. She didn’t want to leave the warmth of the fire, didn’t want to avert her eyes from the way Adora moved atop him, the way Siah responded. She wanted to shout orders, to tell him exactly how to touch her, how to make her quiver. She wanted to pretend she could reach through the fire and claim a taste of the intimacy, to see Adora enjoy it fully, to feel it on her own skin, even if only in imagination.

“Come,” Huntara said, voice firm. “We’ll continue the negotiation elsewhere. She’ll be brought to you when she’s done.”

Chapter End Notes

~I have updated the playlist a bit~

Edit** I have been up since 6am and now have a 4000 word draft of Chapter 11

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

I got a full night's sleep and managed to eat.

More pining and flirting and self doubt spirals from Catra.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The talks weren't a disaster—but they weren't the clean victory Catra wanted either. She knew she'd slipped, let herself get distracted. Huntara knew it too. That was the worst part. Whether Huntara had planned it or not, she pressed when Catra's focus wavered, testing, probing, needling just enough to take advantage without pushing so hard as to break the fragile trust between them.

Her people couldn't afford to alienate the Horde completely, and Huntara knew it. Still, Catra left the discussion gnashing her teeth at every concession she shouldn't have made.

And then, of course, there was Adora.

By the time the negotiations gave way to feasting and spectacle, Adora was already at the center of it: five men deep and laughing, sweat-slick and radiant under the glow of firelight.

"She's insatiable!" one of Huntara's men crowed, passing around a bowl of dried fruit as if it were just another night's entertainment.

Catra didn't answer. She couldn't. She was staring.

Adora wasn't just keeping up—she was thriving. Her laugh cut bright through the beat of drums, low and unselfconscious. She moaned when she wanted, cursed when she wanted, screamed when the heat pushed her there. And the men with her weren't grim or forced, they weren't glassy-eyed soldiers ticking off an

order—they were smiling. They were having fun. They were all having *fun*.

Catra's throat went dry.

She'd seen plenty of sex. Orgies, couplings, "entertainments." But they had always been transactions. Performance. One-sided, or two-sided at best. This… this wasn't that. There was no calculation in the men's touch, no mask on Adora's face as they were kissing the scars on her back or sliding into her arms.

When one of Huntara's men reached out and brushed Catra's cheek, she swatted him away without thinking.

"This is why her fur is so soft," the man said with a grin, turning toward Huntara. "She keeps her master soaked in her passion. Tell me—how does a little cat keep such a beast fed?"

Catra's head snapped toward him, eyes narrowing. "Do not forget who you're talking about, I am a Princess of the Horde."

The man blinked, startled, then smiled apologetically. "My mistake. Forgive me, Highness. Then perhaps you'll tell me—how do *you* keep something that hungry satisfied?"

Catra leaned forward, her smirk lazy, dangerous, the kind that dared someone to keep pressing. She crooked her finger, beckoning him closer. When he obeyed, she murmured, "I feed her Crimson Waste tribesmen."

The laughter that followed was raucous and approving. Huntara tipped her head back, barking her amusement, while three of her men stripped on the spot and went to join the fire, eager to prove her joke true.

Eager. That word snagged in Catra's mind and refused to let go.

Because this wasn't eager obedience. This wasn't desperation. It was want. Shared want.

Adora's smile as one of the men lifted his mouth from between her legs wasn't smug or manipulative—it was *happy*. When she slid her hand along his thigh, when another kissed the ridged scars carved across her back, when she pulled a third against her with a low groan—it was all mutual. Equal. For once, it was *fair*.

Catra had never seen sex that wasn't about taking. About one side consuming until the other was empty. She'd dismissed the books that spoke of joy or tenderness as pure fantasy. But here it was, in front of her. Adora laughing, writhing, meeting these men as if they weren't prey or conquerors, but partners.

Catra's heart slammed in her chest. It wasn't performance. It wasn't pain.

It was joy.

And Catra couldn't look away.

✧

Catra's energy gave out before Adora's did. She let Huntara's wife show her to a tent, smaller than she was used to but warm, layered in furs big enough for two. She stripped to her undershirt and briefs, piling the bedding into two neat halves as her mind spun so fast it left her dizzy.

The drums carried on outside, thumping like her pulse. She tried to close her eyes, but all she saw was firelight gleaming on sweat, Adora's golden hair falling wild around her shoulders, her scarred back arching under gentle hands.

Catra buried her face in the furs, but it didn't stop the questions clawing at her.

What would Adora have said if Catra had let her finish that night? *Unless you want me to…* If she'd waited—if she'd held on instead of filling the silence with commands that made everything safe and sharp and controlled—what would Adora have said?

Because those men hadn’t been ordered. They hadn’t been owned. And still they had smiled, and still they had wanted.

Catra’s hands clenched the furs. She’d never let herself imagine sex could be like that. And now she couldn’t imagine anything else.

What would Adora have done?

That first time, back in the baths, before Catra had clawed her open—Adora had wanted her. She’d touched her. But she’d stopped, waiting. She had been waiting for Catra’s permission, for her *yes*, before going further.

What would she have done, if Catra had said yes?

✧

Catra jolted awake at the sound of someone tripping over the flap of the tent.

Her mind was still hazy, heavy with sleep and with all those maddening images she’d been trying not to chase too far. For a moment she thought she was still dreaming, until her eyes adjusted to the dim lamp-glow and she realized she was staring at Adora.

Adora was halfway in and halfway out of her jacket, turning in slow, clumsy circles like she thought the sleeve might chase her if she didn’t get it right. Her pants were buttoned wrong, so each twist tugged them further down her hips. The glimpse of pale skin, the curve of her ass flashing and disappearing, felt far more indecent than any of the deliberate costumes Catra had shoved her into back on the Flagship.

Catra sat up on one elbow, caught somewhere between exasperated and… something else.

Adora growled under her breath, yanking the jacket off completely, then yanking the pants back up like they’d personally

betrayed her. It was only then she noticed Catra staring.

They blinked at each other across the dim tent. Just blinking. And somehow it felt like the most awkward interaction Catra had ever had.

Adora groaned and covered her face with her hands. “Don’t. Just —don’t start. If you laugh, I’ll fall over.”

Catra’s laugh came anyway, sharp and helpless. She pressed her fist against her mouth, but it only made Adora’s sheepish scowl more ridiculous. Watching her tumble around like a lost cadet with two left feet—it was too much.

Adora finally collapsed onto the furs beside Catra’s pallet, hair a mess, smile wide and ridiculous and unfairly beautiful. “Huntara’s got a lot of men,” she muttered, then a beat later added, “Stop laughing at me.”

She swatted in Catra’s direction. The space between them was so small that she should have landed the hit. She missed anyway. She frowned at the distance, then glanced at Catra again, confused at how close they actually were. Her eyes lingered longer this time. Her smile changed, softened.

Catra rolled to face her fully, propping her head on her hand. She’d split the furs into two neat stacks on the low frame, but it still felt like sharing a bed. Close enough that if Adora reached for her, Catra wouldn’t have to move at all.

“You’re a mess,” Catra said softly. Her voice wanted to come out sharp, but it didn’t. “And I’ve seen you drop squads of soldiers without blinking.”

Adora’s eyes flickered, tired and warm. “Not tonight,” she admitted. "They'd kick my ass if I tried now."

Catra’s throat worked. She wanted to say it—you can touch me. That she wasn’t scared of this Adora. Not the She-Ra monster, not the blade-wielding nightmare from her dreams, but the girl who

tripped over her own boots and smiled too wide. The one who looked at her like she mattered. She couldn't get the words out.

Instead, she said, almost flippantly, "Consider yourself relieved of duty in the morning."

Adora's smile widened, soft and crooked. "That's… actually really nice of you." She shifted deeper into the bedding, sighing. "I'm not moving. You'll just have to deal with me here. Unless you need something?"

Catra's heart thudded. Her mouth went dry. She smirked to cover it, and her voice came out low and steady: "Yeah. Take me next."

Adora's groan was half-laugh, muffled as she buried her face under the furs. Catra lay back down slowly, pulse still racing. She stared at the shape of her beneath the blankets for a long, long time before sleep finally dragged her under.

✧

Adora didn't want her.

Catra told herself that, over and over. She was irritated with herself for circling the same conclusion again and again, like picking at a half-healed scab. Usually when people didn't want her, it was about pride. She was used to being the sharpest thing in the room. She was used to getting a reaction.

This was different. It stung because *she* wanted Adora.

And she hadn't misread it. There had been times when Adora would have gone to bed with her, no hesitation. Out of convenience, maybe. Out of compromise. Adora would have found it pleasant enough.

But Catra wanted more than that. Wanted in a way she hadn't even known she was capable of. And Adora—sweet, stupid, infuriating Adora—was too stubborn, too sincere, too *Adora* to push when Catra didn't give her the green light.

It was good, Catra told herself. Safer. If she could want *her* of all people, maybe she could want someone else, someday, someone who wasn't an enemy. Someone who hadn't broken her in half in the first place.

Adora wasn't hers. She never would be. That made her the safest place in the world to start.

Catra groaned into her pillow. What a joke. They had oceans of bad blood between them. Why add another grudge to the pile?

No, the only one she was mad at tonight was herself.

✧

Neither of them had slept much, but the air between them felt lighter than it should have when they left at dawn. Light wasn't the same as easy—just… different. Catra kept her mouth shut, as always, but Adora was smiling. That smile tilted the world, turned silence into something that almost felt like peace. For a moment, Catra could trick herself into thinking they were equals, companions. Not captor and captive. Not enemies.

Adora didn't seem to notice the mess of her tangled hair or the way she smelled of sweat and sex. Catra had barely registered it last night, distracted as she was. Now, riding side by side in the open air, it was all she could notice. Her body ached in ways that reminded her of what they'd done, and it was maddening to think of it when Adora just sat there, humming under her breath, casual as ever.

The sound stopped the second Catra glanced her way.

"Your talks went well?" Adora's voice cut through her thoughts. She hadn't said a word all morning until now.

Catra blinked, trying to realign herself. "They went," she said dryly. The deal would have been a mess if Adora hadn't come with her. Catra wouldn't admit it aloud, but without her, things would've collapsed. None of Catra's soldiers could've impressed

the Wastes the way Adora had—genuine, awkward, and somehow winning them over. Catra hated how much she'd relied on it. The simple act of pleasing a whole tribe… Catra certainly wouldn't have been able to do it.

Adora flashed her a grin brighter than the rising sun. "You should negotiate with the Crimson Wastes more often," she said, wagging her brows like an idiot.

Catra rolled her eyes, but the jab landed. She hated the way her chest tightened at the memory of last night. The careless way Adora had given herself over, like consequences didn't exist. The Horde would make use of any child she bore—princes of Bright Moon turned into soldiers for Catra's command. Adora was currently Catra's property. That was a discussion she had held with Huntara—who the offspring of Adora's escapade would belong to. Did Adora even think about things like that? Of course she didn't.

The thought chilled Catra now. She almost asked the sharp, bitter question—*Do you think it feels better, screwing men? Is that why you don't care what happens after?*

But she bit it back.

Instead she said, "Is it…different? With men?"

Adora looked at her without hesitation, smile still warm. "Yeah."

Catra's stomach sank. Different. Did that mean it would never be like what she'd seen—Adora's careless joy with the men, all ease and laughter and fun? Was that the difference? Catra didn't dare push. If she tried to explain what she'd seen, Adora would see through her. Would see how broken she really was, and why. Catra couldn't bear that.

Adora tilted her head. "Why? You curious?" Her tone was teasing, her grin broad. She had no idea what she was asking, no idea what it cost Catra to keep breathing through the ache of wanting her.

Catra glared at her, heat rushing through her chest. “What?” she snapped. Adora only grinned wider, infuriatingly sure of herself. As if she already knew exactly what Catra wanted and was just waiting for her to admit it.

Would Adora have even noticed, Catra wondered, one more body? One that didn’t melt for her touch the way the rest did? Would it have given her pause—or would it have just been another tally mark on a list she’d never bothered to count?

Catra didn’t have the stomach for her usual sharp-edged questions this morning. She glanced away, jaw tight, and defaulted to the only defense she had left when the silence pressed too close: she filled it with words, as she always did, when she was uncomfortable.

✧

“Your Highness. Two weeks late, but I suppose Ghost’s Ridge has its distractions.”

Keldor’s smile was as rancid as his voice. That scar slicing through his face tugged his mouth into something that showed too many teeth and none of them even. It might’ve been easier to tolerate if there’d been humor behind it—or any warmth at all. There wasn’t.

Catra had braced for this moment, rehearsed it in her head a dozen times. But rehearsals never measured up to reality. She had expected Prime’s trap to spring eventually. She hadn’t expected it so fast, or so close. Hours ago she’d been in her cot at Weave’s Slope. Adora slipping toward the baths. Entrapta blinking owlishly at the sight of Adora, hair damp, still marked by the night as she left Catra's chambers.

Then the report landed in her hand: the border town burned.

Catra had calculated for Prime’s schemes. He’d want a strike to drive Etheria closer to war. Pay raiders, burn a village, watch the

cycle spin. But she thought she had bought herself time. A few days, at least. Not this. Not already.

Keldor's voice dragged her back. "Perhaps we can arrange other… amusements while you're here." He coated it in sugar, but the poison wasn't subtle.

The banners above the courtyard were white, Prime's white, and Keldor made no effort to hide where he'd bent the knee. Catra's own armor blazed red in deliberate contrast, her soldiers behind her marked the same. Here, she was still "princess." Here, people still bowed—most of them. But the air tasted hostile.

Her claws flexed against her palm. She forced her voice into a steel edge. "I'm not here to be entertained. I want reports from every captain on the attack this morning. Assemble them. Now."

Keldor's eyes narrowed. He'd hated her since she was a child—she knew it. She remembered him sneering to Shadow Weaver about her, and Shadow Weaver laughing instead of stopping him. *Soft little girl,* he'd called her.

Catra didn't sound soft now. And whatever he thought of her, he was still obligated to obey until Prime found a way to dramatically kill her. He gave a mocking half-bow, just shy of insult, and waved his men toward the hall.

She felt Adora shift at her back. Felt her moving to step away.

"No," Catra said, "With me."

The timing was too perfect. An Etherian raid the very morning she returned? It reeked of Prime. And she couldn't afford to let Adora out of her sight.

A servant barred their path at the hall. He bowed shallowly, muttering, "Your Highness," like the words burned his tongue. His gaze darted at Adora. "Lord Keldor would prefer the slave remain outside." He said it like she carried filth into the room, though

Catra knew perfectly well Adora was cleaner than half the men in this keep.

Catra didn't break stride. "I prefer she doesn't."

The servant flinched back. If he hadn't moved, Catra would've made a point of grinding her heel into his toes on the way past.

It didn't take long before Catra ran up against another wall.

"Etherians don't belong among us. Surely your highness understands."

This time it was some puffed-up officer, a minor noble—his uniform more polished than his brain. Catra didn't even bother trying to place his name; the ridiculous mustache was memorable enough.

"Does my servant rattle you?" Catra asked, her voice dry, casual. "She can be a handful. Takes someone with actual spine to keep her in line."

The man curled his lip, emboldened by the company he kept, and gave Adora a look that made Catra's claws itch. "I know how to manage Etherians," he said. "I don't let them inside civilized walls." He spoke like Adora was some half-trained beast that might soil the carpet, and the way his eyes raked her up and down told Catra he wouldn't have minded the excuse to "break her in."

Catra almost smiled. *Try it, genius. I'd pay to watch her knock your teeth down your throat.*

Aloud, she said, flatly, "She belongs to me. Step aside, Captain."

She wasn't sure if she'd guessed his rank correctly, but he shifted out of her path without a word. When she finally sat, Adora fell in at her back, silent and steady.

Catra lived for little victories. Having Adora standing there was one of them. Especially when Double Trouble strolled in, clocked

her “slave,” and immediately made a face like they’d swallowed rotten fruit.

✧

The meeting dragged on for hours—four excruciating ones. By the end, even Catra had to admit keeping Adora in the room was a losing battle. Too many eyes, too much bait for insult. She dismissed her, which left her alone in a room full of people who despised her and weren’t shy about showing it.

So when Catra returned to the chambers Keldor had provided and found Adora waiting there, it was almost—though she would never say it aloud—a relief.

Strange world, when her mother’s executioner was better company than her so-called allies.

“Report,” Catra said, sharp and clipped. The mask back in place.

Adora didn’t flinch. She gave her assessment straight. Talon Mountain’s stores were strong, defenses intact—but unprepared for war.

“I think the raids blindsided them,” Adora said.

Catra was already nodding. The knot in her chest loosened—just slightly. Adora’s read matched hers. “Same in the great hall,” she muttered. “Keldor wanted to sound like he was spoiling for a fight, but he didn’t look it. He’s caught off guard.”

Which meant Prime had jumped sooner than he’d planned. Something had shoved him into motion. *Was it me?* Catra wondered, sharp satisfaction sparking under the thought. She hadn’t expected to push this far with so few soldiers. She hadn’t expected—her eyes lingered on Adora—*any of this*.

“So the border lords aren’t working with Prime,” Adora said, her voice quick with hope.

"Not Keldor," Catra allowed. The unspoken word—*yet*—hung between them. Keldor would side with Prime the moment it paid. For now, Catra had leverage. "We ride for Sandsmark. I bought us a few days. He won't move without orders from Prime, and Prime can't answer fast enough while off-world."

That piece still gnawed at her. Why start without the border lords? Why rush? She almost asked Adora what she thought—almost.

Then she caught the look on Adora's face.

Freedom. She wore it plain as day, the thought of it just a few days off. No mask, no disguise. Just raw longing.

Catra's stomach dropped.

"Then Sandsmark it is," Adora said, too brightly. Not the reckless cheer of the girl who'd thrown herself into a Horde training match, or even the quiet joy of the woman who had just ridden an entire tribe of men. This was different. She dropped her gaze quick, too late, and busied herself with pointless tasks.

Catra lowered herself into the nearest chair, slow, like her body weighed twice what it should.

Idiot. *Absolute idiot*. Did she really think she could keep her?

Half her plans depended on trading Adora's freedom back to Mermista of Salineas, to Bright Moon. To use the rightful Queen as a bargaining chip. That had always been the endgame. There was no future where it lasted, this thing between them—a slave who wouldn't fully bow, an enemy who felt too much like an ally.

She sat there, watching Adora move through the room, and hated herself for almost believing otherwise.

Adora had looked *happy* at the idea of freedom. Too happy. Like it had never even crossed her mind to hide it from Catra.

Was Catra supposed to be offended? Hurt? That her enemy—her prisoner—her slave—a woman she had dragged through dirt and blood, tried to break, tried to kill—might actually look forward to the day she was rid of her?

They weren't friends.

They weren't lovers.

Catra's chest still ached like she'd been stabbed.

She could hear her at the washbasin, humming something tuneless under her breath. The soap they shared clung to her skin in a way that made Catra furious—it smelled different on Adora, softer somehow. She was chattering as she scrubbed, spilling pointless little bits of gossip from the troops, half-laughing at her own story. Useless noise.

Catra knew if she glanced over, she'd see her bare from the waist up, pale skin stretched across those ridiculous muscles—marred only by the scars Catra had put there herself. She'd done that. She'd made those marks.

And Adora had caught her watching on multiple occasions. It had become a game between them. Catra's gaze would linger; Adora's grin would sharpen; her movements would slow. A show, just for Catra. And Catra would stay lounged back, acting unaffected, like she wasn't playing at all. Sometimes she'd even make it harder for herself, toss a question into the air and see if she could keep her voice steady while her mind tripped over the slope of Adora's spine.

Not tonight.

"Did you bring my writing chest in with the rest of the supplies?" Catra cut across the middle of Adora's story—something about Clone 16 walking in on Entrapta in the stables waiting for Lonnie. Catra barely listened. The details sounded stupid. The sort of gutter gossip soldiers spun when they were bored and horny.

Adora blinked, thrown. “Uh—it’s on the desk,” she said, quieter now. The cheer drained out of her. Catra could feel the weight of her eyes as she rose, boots loud against the stone. Adora’s attention was a tether, always, even when Catra didn’t want it. Especially when she didn’t want it.

“Catra—” Adora began.

“You don’t have permission to use my name,” Catra snapped, yanking the chair out from the desk and dropping into it like it was a small throne.

Adora’s voice went flat, annoyed. “Your highness.”

Catra ignored her, busying herself with ink and paper.

“Do you need anything tonight?” Adora asked, after a pause.

“I’ve managed my whole life without you. I think I can take off my own jacket,” Catra shot back.

Silence followed. Catra didn’t know if Adora was still standing there, half-naked and dripping, or if she’d already pulled on a shirt. Would she try to slip away before they reached the border? Would she trust Catra’s promise and wait? If she bolted, Catra would drag her back in chains, have flogged at a post for the sheer gall. She’d marked her once. She could do it again.

Finally Adora said, soft, “I just wanted to be sure. It’s been a long few days. I’m going to sleep—if you’re sure you don’t need me.”

Catra’s jaw locked. She forced the words out. “I don’t. Need you.”

The silence stretched, heavy. Catra didn’t look up, but she felt Adora’s gaze burn into her before she finally heard her settle onto her pallet. The rustle of blanket, the small exhale. A routine Catra knew too well now.

Earlier, she had stood in front of a hall full of men and claimed Adora as part of her household. *She belongs to me.* She’d stared

down Keldor's own commander and said it without flinching. She'd meant for it to sting, to humiliate them. And maybe it had. They'd all remember it later, when She-Ra came back into the light. They'd remember Catra—Shadow Weaver's heir—standing tall and declaring her enemy her own.

But what did that matter to Adora? She wanted to go home.

She doesn't need me, Catra wrote in her letter to Kyle. Another for the unsent pile. Then she frowned, staring down at the ink blotting the page. That wasn't what she'd meant to write. She'd meant to say: *I don't need her*.

✧

Catra was up first, as always. By the time Adora stirred, servants had already drawn the curtains wide and sunlight cut sharp across her face. Catra was bathed, dressed, on her second cup of coffee, and knee-deep in reports.

Adora blinked at her through the glare, hair a mess. "Sandsmark?" Catra asked, dryly. "Or are you thinking of staying here? Maybe Keldor will show you the gardens, make a nice day of it."

Adora rubbed her eyes, groaning. "Did you get enough for me, or should I go beg scraps off the soldiers?"

Catra's mouth twitched into a smirk. "Careful. Keep that tone, I'll make you eat off the floor." She stretched a booted foot and nudged the chair opposite her out from the table. The invitation was clear.

Adora pulled on a shirt as she crossed the room, yawning, half-grinning despite herself.

Chapter End Notes

> I reread King's Rising yesterday and I forgot how low the mood can get in that book, damn. Devotion will be an emotional roller-coaster.

Chapter 12: Adora

Chapter Notes

> Just a little Adora chapter, sorry but Catra's still a little cold. This is not really a flirty chapter.
>
> Also a little 20 minute sketch I did at then end that I might make better later, I don't know.

They weren't the first to reach Sandsmark.

Keldor's men had already descended on the ruins, grim-faced and efficient, their armor dusted with ash and dirt. They were digging graves now, the pits stretching like scars across blood-soaked earth. Others worked to drag debris from the paths, to haul what bodies they could to the pyres or cover them in rough shrouds.

The smell hit first: burnt wood, scorched metal, flesh. Adora's throat closed up against it. The village must have been small—half a dozen huts, a few storehouses, one barn—but the destruction was complete. A fence trampled flat. A child's doll, blackened by fire. The cracked remnants of a feast: overturned goblets, fruit still rotting in the dirt.

They'd fought back. That much was clear. Some of the dead still clutched makeshift weapons—a hoe, a broken branch, a kitchen knife—like they'd tried to protect their homes with their bare hands.

Catra's soldiers worked through the wreckage quietly. No orders barked, no unnecessary talk. Adora had expected them to treat her differently, to shove her aside, but they didn't. They handed her shovels, cleared wreckage beside her, worked shoulder to shoulder without a word. It only made her feel worse—like she was trespassing on something sacred.

She saw one of the clones—28, maybe—pause to pull a cloak over a woman's burned form. He bowed his head, whispering a short

Fright Zone benediction. It was brief, but it meant something.

Adora swallowed hard. This hadn't been a battle. This had been a slaughter.

She knew the logic—knew it too well. Horde strikes first, the Etheria strikes back. A cycle of vengeance dressed up as strategy. If Prime had launched a raid across the border, this was Bright Moon's answer. Only… she doubted Bright Moon—Glimmer—had ordered anything like that.

A shadow fell across her. Catra had come up beside her, arms crossed, her face unreadable against the haze.

"There are survivors," Catra said. Her tone was clipped, businesslike. "I want you to question them."

Adora turned to her, startled. "Me? I shouldn't—"

"Etherian survivors," Catra interrupted.

Adora's stomach dropped. She didn't like where this was going. "If Horde soldiers were captured after something like this," she said, carefully, "they'd be executed."

Catra's eyes didn't waver. "They will be," she said. "Find out what they know about the raid that started this."

There was no anger in her voice—just the cold detachment of command. Adora wanted to argue, but what could she say? That she couldn't stomach it? Catra was watching her, waiting for her to flinch.

So Adora nodded. "Yes, Princess."

✧

The hut was dark, the air thick with sweat and rot. A single candle flickered near the cot, throwing more shadow than light.

Adora had expected restraints. There were none. The prisoner didn't need them. He was dying—his breathing ragged, shallow, blood seeping slowly through the bandages at his stomach. Someone had tried to patch him up. It wouldn't be enough.

She crouched beside him, keeping her voice low. "Can you hear me?"

The man's eyes shifted toward her. Grey, wide, glassy with pain. His hair—curled, dark with sweat—stuck to his forehead. Younger than she'd thought. Nineteen, maybe twenty.

He blinked, and when he spoke, it was in First Ones. His accent was rough but clear. "You're… Etherian."

Adora hesitated, then nodded. "I am."

A ghost of a smile tugged at his mouth. "We—retook the village?"

Her chest tightened. She owed him the truth, however cruel it was. "No," she said quietly. "I serve the Horde princess."

The words felt like poison in her mouth.

The boy's breath hitched, a wet rattle. For a moment she thought he'd curse her, spit at her—but he just stared, unfocused now, eyes slipping past her shoulder like he could see through her.

Adora stayed there, even after his breathing stilled.

"You shame your people," the man rasped, voice raw with smoke and rage. He threw the words at her like a final, wasted sword-thrust.

Adora waited for the choke to pass—watched his chest rise and fall, counted the painful breaths until the rhythm steadied enough for him to answer again. "A raid on Etheria set this off?" she asked, blunt, because there wasn't time for gentler approaches.

He laughed—half a chuckle, half a cough, bitter. “Did your Horde mistress send you to ask that?” he snapped.

“Yes,” Adora said.

“I bet she did this,” he spat, proud even as his strength leaked away. “She’d sooner burn a village than admit the truth. Our deaths are light compared to what we did in Sandsmark.”

Anger flared hot in Adora, useless and scorching. She swallowed it down because it wouldn’t get them answers. She kept her face still.

“Where did they strike?” she asked, quieter.

“Sweethoney,” he breathed—the name like a stone in the dark. “Foothills.”

“So it wasn’t official Bright Moon troops,” Adora concluded aloud. “Raiders."

“They ride through the passes,” he managed. “They’re paid to—” His chest heaved; the next words were ragged. “Your mistress… she’ll use you. She uses you now—against your own.” He shut his eyes.

Adora softened without thinking. “What’s your name?” she asked.

He blinked. The skin around his eyes was ashen, but there was defiant light in them. “Sunday,” he said.

“Sunday, you fought under Frosta?” Adora recognized the sigil on the frayed cuff. “She was stubborn, but loyal. There's a treaty—if she broke it—she must have been desperate to go against the Queen.”

“Glimmer…” Sunday rasped. “False queen. Adora—should have led. She would have known how the Horde works. Liars. Deceivers. She would never have—sided with them as Glimmer has.”

Adora listened, the words twisting a cold knot in her stomach. “You may be right,” she said after a long, careful silence. “The Horde is stirring its forces. There’s little to stop a war now.”

“Let them come,” Sunday said, voice lowering to a rasp that could have been courage or madness. “The Horde hides behind ships and engines. Bring them into the open and we’ll cut them down.”

Adora said nothing else. She stayed until the rattling in his chest slowed and finally stilled, then rose and stepped back into the gray light of the ruined village, that image of stillness following her like a shadow.

✧

She told Catra what Sunday had said as plainly as she could. No flourish. No saving the bitter parts. When she finished, Catra’s face didn’t change much—features practiced into the mask of a commander.

“The testimony of a dead man is not much in a court of war,” Catra said, voice flat as a blade.

“You knew what he'd say,” Adora pressed. “You sent me in. His answers point to the foothills. These attacks were timed with your arrival—someone is baiting you away from Talon Mountain.”

Catra took her time looking at Adora, as if weighing the girl’s words against something only Catra could see. Finally she said, “Yes. The trap is closing in on me. There’s nothing else to be done here."

Outside the tent the cleanup went on in a grim choreography. As Adora headed to the tack for her saddle she crossed paths with Entrapta, hauling a length of tent canvas that caught on the dirt and dragged like stubborn webbing. Dust and ash streaked Entrapta’s hair; her hands were smudged with soot. She looked small and fierce in the hard light.

“You leaving camp?” Entrapta called, brow knitting as she shifted the canvas on her shoulders. "Where?"

Adora hesitated. She had the packs slung over one arm, the map case at her hip. “You wouldn’t believe me if I told you,” she said honestly.

Entrapta blinked. “Try me.”

Adora gave a half smile that was all exhaustion and resolve. “It’s about speed and silence, not numbers. If we’re going to spy for a strike force hiding in the hills, we can’t go roaring in with all the horses and tanks.”

Entrapta’s eyes lit. “Oh—oh! That’s smart. Smaller profile, less thermal signature—” She faltered when she saw the look on Adora’s face and added, “—metaphorically. I mean—be careful.” Her hand brushed the strap of Adora’s pack in a small, personal way.

Adora tipped her chin in thanks and moved on.

✧

They left the main road and took the tracks the locals used—single-file wheel ruts that threaded between pines and over old outcrops. Catra rode with her reins loose, the way she liked: relaxed but ready, every muscle coiled for whatever came next. The sun dropped through the leaves in quick, bright patches; the dust smelled like broken rock and warm sap. Adora rode slower, steady and careful, glad for the rhythm of the horse under her.

An hour of quiet stretched between them. Catra broke it first, circling close enough that the tips of their saddles almost touched. Catra looked… nervous.

“Think I’m going to sell you to the nearest Etherian troop?” Adora asked.

Catra’s reply was a shrug and a half-smile. “I don't think you could keep up with me.” She gave her horse a nudge and rode ahead. For a breathless moment they opened up, the world narrowing to the thunder of hooves and the blur of branches. The gallop didn’t last: the trail folded into a thin deer path and they slowed, threading through ferns and leaf litter while sunlight painted the world green and gold.

When they came out to the little stream, Catra had already unslung her reins. She let her mount drink and watched Adora ride the last few yards. The water ran cold and clear.

Then the horn split the air.

It was not the call of hunters or a warning—it was low, Echoing: an Etherian horn. Birds exploded from the branches. Adora noticed as Catra’s hand went to her pommel. The sound came from over the next rise, and without a word she swung her horse toward it and Adora followed.

At the crest they could see a line of cloaks and polished steel spread along the valley: Etherian soldiers, ranks held neat and sure, banners displayed proudly. The woman with the horn stood at their edge, small against the field and bright with command. The standards were Frosta’s. Adora’s lungs tightened. Home—everything she had ever trained for, everything that felt like the right answer—sat glittering in that hollow.

She looked at Catra and for a beat Catra’s face was very still. No nerves in it now, only assessment. “Closer than I thought,” Catra said.

Adora’s hands found the bit and the leather creaked under her grip. She stared down the slope at where Frosta’s troops had paused, at the familiar sweep of their formations.

“I could throw you over the back of my horse,” Adora said, voice flat.

Catra’s laugh was soft, almost a purr. “You could.”

The horn sounded again—a single, long note that felt as much like a rope pulling at the heart as a trumpet. Adora's jaw worked. The urge to ride down, to hand Catra over, to make things simple by handing her enemy back to her people, thrummed in her wrists. It would be clean. It would be decisive. It would be what she would have done three months ago.

And still, where the light hit her face, Catra watched her with something that was not scorn: small, brittle, and very fragile. Adora closed her eyes for a breath, feeling the pull of two loyalties—one to her home and the other to the woman beside her—and the world narrowed to the thud of the hooves and the weight of the choice.

"You need to take cover," Adora said, eyes scanning the horizon. "We're already inside their scouting lines. I'll keep watch until they move on."

Catra arched an eyebrow. "And leave you to run off? You really think I'm that stupid."

"Your Highness," Adora said flatly. "Go."

A beat passed—Catra's gaze lingered on her, unreadable—then she gave a small, careless shrug. "Fine. Don't get yourself caught."

They set a rendezvous, and Catra rode off. Catra had the interesting job of trying to hide herself and an entire horse in nothing more than trees and shrubs.

Adora's job was harder. Catra hadn't been gone ten minutes when the faint vibration of hooves rolled through the ground beneath her. She swung off her horse, pressing herself and the animal into the undergrowth just as two riders tore past.

She held still. One mistake could give them away. She wasn't only protecting Catra—she had to be careful for her own sake too. Her uniform still bore the red and black of the Horde, and to the Etherian outriders, that made her an enemy. Under normal

circumstances, it would have meant a tense exchange, maybe a fight. But these were Frosta's troops—the same soldiers who had razed Sandsmark—and someone like Catra would be priceless.

Adora tightened her grip on the reins, waited until the last echo of hooves faded, then slipped through the trees. She hid her horse in a narrow crevice between outcroppings and went on foot.

It took her nearly an hour of careful watching—tracing the riders' paths, counting their intervals, mapping the shape of the force—before she understood what she was seeing. A thousand soldiers, at least, moving west with supplies. Reinforcements. The kind of organized campaign she hadn't seen at Talon Mountain. War didn't begin with battles; it began like this—with lines drawn, orders issued, stores filled.

The attacks on the border villages wouldn't have reached Glimmer yet, but the Western Princesses already knew what was coming. Frosta, who had started this by striking Sandsmark, was likely marching to meet Mermista—her bannerwoman, her ally—somewhere near the border. Others would follow soon enough.

When Adora returned to the streambank, her horse was waiting, ears flicking nervously. She mounted and followed the sound of running water until she found a convenient cave. From most angles it looked like solid stone, but inside, it was shadowed and deep—a good hiding place.

The faint clatter of hooves on rock announced Catra before she appeared. She rode out of the darkness where she'd been waiting all along, posture loose, expression unreadably calm.

"I thought might be halfway back to Sandsmark by now," Adora said.

Catra's tail flicked, and she gave a lazy smile that didn't reach her eyes. "What, and miss all the fun? I figure the odds of them killing me outright are pretty low. I'm worth more as a bargaining chip. Even Prime wouldn't throw me away without a performance first—

though I'd *love* to see his face when he heard about it." She tilted her head, mock-thoughtful. "You think Mermista and I would get along?"

Adora frowned. "I wouldn't need to tell them who you are to sell you to that troop."

"Oh, really?" Catra asked, pretending offense. "I figured twenty was too old. Must be the ears."

"It's your lovely personality," Adora said.

Catra grinned. "You don't seem to mind."

Adora said nothing. The thought slipped through her mind anyway: *If I took her back to Etheria, they wouldn't hand her over to Mermista. They'd hand her to me.*

"Before you kidnap me," Catra said, breaking the silence, "tell me about Frosta. Those were her banners out there. Is she acting with Mermista's blessing, or going rogue?"

Adora hesitated. "I think she broke orders," she said at last. "She was angry. Sandsmark was retaliation, not strategy. Mermista would've waited for command from her Queen. But now that Frosta's done it, Mermista won't stop her. She'll fold it into the cause. That's her way."

Catra's eyes gleamed. "Until it backfires. Glimmer's losing control of the west. If she wants to hold Bright Moon together, she might decide Silaneas is expendable."

"Glimmer wouldn't—" Adora stopped herself. The thought had already formed. Glimmer wouldn't think of it—but Bow might.

Catra leaned forward slightly, watching her. "To get what you want, you have to know what you're willing to give up."

Adora drew a steady breath. "You can stop stalling. The outriders are gone. We're clear."

Catra's smirk softened, just barely. "Lead the way."

It should have been that simple. She'd done everything right.

Adora had tracked the outriders' pattern for hours, waited for the signal that the last of them had cleared the ridge, and followed the movement of the army at a safe distance. Every step had been careful.

She hadn't counted on the outlier—one soldier who'd fallen behind, his horse lamed, trudging back on foot through the brush.

Catra was already across the river, reins loose in one hand, glancing back at her with that impatient *come on, slowpoke* look. Adora was halfway through the stream when she saw it—the brief flash of navy in the thicket behind Catra's horse.

That was all the warning she got.

Catra got none at all.

The man raised his crossbow.

Adora's breath caught.

The bolt sang through the air—

The horse shrieked, jerking violently sideways. Water exploded upward, glinting silver as it caught the light. No sound of impact—just the horrifying crash as the animal lost its footing, slipping hard on the slick stones and going down in a wet, crushing thud that echoed through the gorge.

"Catra!"

Adora's heart slammed into her ribs. She kicked her horse forward through the current, sword already in her hand—not the Sword of Protection, just cold, ordinary Horde steel.

The man was running now, closing the distance with his sword drawn. Catra was on the ground, winded from the fall, half rising, dazed.

Too far. She was too far away to reach him in time.

She didn’t think. Her body just moved.

She switched her grip, twisted her arm back, and threw.

For a heartbeat, she felt the old light surge through her—warmth, power, something bigger than she was—and then it was gone, leaving only the weight of motion and a sharp, cutting silence.

The sword hit home.

The man crumpled, driven backward into the stones, his blade falling from his hand.

By the time the echo faded, Adora was already off her horse, splashing through the shallows to reach Catra. She dropped to one knee beside her, soaked and shaking.

“I saw you go down,” she said, her voice rough. “Are you hurt?”

Catra coughed, pushing herself upright. “No. You—you got him.” Her tone was unsteady. “He didn't—”

Adora’s hand hovered, then pressed gently along Catra’s shoulder, tracing down over her ribs. “Stay still. You could’ve—”

“Relax,” Catra muttered, though her voice was softer than usual. “I'm fine. Promise.”

Her clothes were soaked, hair plastered to her face. The only movement was the slow rise and fall of her chest, the trembling of her fingers where they gripped the wet stones. Her eyes were fixed on Adora and for a moment all Adora could do was look back into them.

“Can you stand?” Adora asked. “We have to move. It’s not safe here.”

Catra blinked up at her, eyes sharp again, if a little unfocused. “Yeah, yeah. I get it. Everyone’s trying to kill me.” She managed a faint smirk at Adora. "I guess not everyone."

Adora offered her a hand. Catra hesitated a beat before taking it, hauling herself to her feet with a hiss of breath.

The gelding had gotten up too, limping, saddle half-hanging. Its sides were flecked with foam and mud.

“I’m sorry,” Catra said quietly. Then, after a pause, “We can’t just leave him here.”

She didn’t mean the horse.

Adora’s throat tightened. “I’ll take care of it.”

When it was done, Adora walked out from the undergrowth, wiping her blade clean against the wet grass. Her hands were steady again, though her face wasn’t.

“They’ll notice when he doesn’t come back,” she said simply. “We need to go.”



Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

> Me? Use my own trauma and feelings for storytelling? Never. Ah, anyway, enjoy some feelings and flirting and some hurt/comfort.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“I saw you go down,” Adora’s voice came rough, almost breaking. Her breath hitched as she crouched beside Catra, hands already moving, searching. “Are you hurt?”

Catra blinked, dazed. “No. You—you got him. He didn't—” Her words tangled. She couldn’t think past the heat of Adora’s hands on her, the way she looked at her—like she was the only thing that existed. *You were going to leave*, Catra wanted to say. *You can’t look at me like that when you keep trying to leave me*.

“Stay still. You could’ve—”Adora muttered as her hands moved over Catra. She was probably checking for a head wound, but the gesture was too gentle, too familiar. Catra forgot to flinch.

“Relax,” Catra managed to say. For a moment, the rest of the world didn’t exist—not Prime, not the Horde, not the blood. Only the cold rush of the stream and Adora’s hand, warm and steady against her. “I'm fine. Promise.”

“Can you stand?” Adora asked, all focus, all concern. Her fingers brushed Catra’s temple, sweeping wet hair from her face.

“We have to move,” Adora said quietly. “It’s not safe here.” Her palm rested against the back of Catra’s head, protective, careful. It felt like shelter—and Catra didn’t know what to do with that. She couldn’t stop staring at her. Couldn’t stop seeing the sword flying through the air, the impossible strength behind it.

Then Adora seemed to realize how close she was. Her hand fell away and she offered her arm instead.

Catra took it, still a little unsteady. “Yeah, yeah. I get it. Everyone’s trying to kill me.” she muttered, her voice thin and dazed. "I guess not everyone." She wasn’t sure what she meant, but Adora pulled her up easily, her grip sure. Once she was standing, Catra found she didn’t want to let go.

She did, though. Eventually. She stepped back, assessing herself. Her ribs ached, her chest throbbed, but there was no blood. Her horse had made it up too, limping, but alive. The stream burbled beside them, indifferent. The world, as always, moved on.

“I’m sorry,” Catra said at last, voice catching despite her best effort to steady it. She wasn’t even sure what she was apologizing for—the near-death, everything. The soldier still lay in the water, Adora’s sword jutting from his chest. He was trying to breathe, a terrible, broken sound. Catra didn’t look at his face. Didn’t want to see how young he was. “We can’t just leave him here.”

“I’ll take care of it,” Adora said.

Something in her tone made Catra look away. She didn’t want to see the expression that went with it—didn’t want to see the weight in her eyes, or the part of her that still hated doing what she had to do. Catra stayed silent, granting her that small mercy.

When Adora returned, her sword clean, she didn’t say anything at first. Just looked toward the trees, jaw tight. “They’ll notice when he doesn’t come back,” she said simply. “We need to go.”

✧

They didn’t speak again until much later, after Catra confirmed her gelding’s injury was only a sprain. That left them with one horse.

“My proportions are better suited for riding double,” Catra said dryly, though her voice came out a little too casual. Truthfully, she

didn’t trust herself to sit that close—not with her pulse still skipping every time Adora so much as looked at her.

She climbed up behind her anyway. And immediately regretted it. The warmth of Adora’s back pressed against her chest, the curve of her hips, the solid rhythm of her breathing. Catra’s arms slid naturally around her waist, and she froze, fingers hovering before they found their place.

Oh.

She swallowed hard, trying to cover the sound. “You’ve managed to get me over the back of your horse,” she muttered.

Adora stilled slightly, not getting it—as usual. “I'm shocked you're even giving me control.”

“Well, I can’t exactly see through all your hair,” Catra shot back. “It’s like riding behind a haystack.”

Adora huffed out a quiet laugh—then, with a surprising flicker of humor, said, “We could always switch.”

The tone was teasing. Flirtatious, even. It startled Catra enough that she let her forehead rest against Adora’s back, breathing her in. “Sure,” she said softly, wryly. “Next time, I’ll take the front, and you can carry the horse.”

✧

“I thought killing came naturally to you,” Catra said later, breaking the long, uneasy quiet between them.

Adora’s hands tightened slightly on the reins. The silence that followed wasn’t cold—just heavy, complicated. It clung to the air around them, part guilt, part understanding.

Catra leaned her cheek against Adora’s back. The warmth seeped through her damp uniform. It was uncomfortable, sticky, but the contact grounded her in a way she hadn’t expected. She didn’t

shiver or cry—she just held on, quietly. Adora didn't mention it. Maybe she hadn't noticed. Or maybe she understood too well.

By the time they stopped to make camp, the sun had gone red behind the hills. The silence lingered.

Catra left Adora to the fire and went to tend the horses, pretending that the ache in her chest was only from the fall—pretending that she didn't miss the feeling of Adora's steady heartbeat beneath her hands.

Were you watching, Weaver?

Hiding by the horses, Catra prayed Shadow Weaver's ghost wasn't trapped in her tomb—that she was still somewhere out there, watching. Surely, if she was, she'd understand what she was seeing now. She'd like Adora, Catra thought. She'd *respect* her, and somehow that mattered more.

Did you see the way she looked at me?

Catra pressed her forehead to her horse's flank. The creature shifted, nosed her hair once, then returned to its feed, unconcerned. A poor substitute for Adora's back. Catra's mind kept replaying it—the frantic way Adora's hands had checked her for wounds, the way she'd brushed the hair from her eyes, cupped the back of her head like something precious. How could someone who looked at her like that one moment glare at her with disgust the next?

Probably the same way *she* could loathe Adora so much it made her chest ache—and still dread the day she'd have to hand her over to Mermista. The same way she could want her, fiercely and shamefully, and still flinch at the thought of actually touching her.

She knew she'd been wrong about Adora. She knew she'd been cruel. And yet she couldn't forgive her—for killing Shadow Weaver, for taking something that had belonged to *her* alone.

“I thought killing came naturally to you,” Catra said again. The words came soft but sharp, her voice carrying over the crackle of the fire. It wasn’t the question she wanted to ask, but it was close enough. She didn’t have the strength to tell her the truth—not tonight, not while sitting there half undressed in the firelight, skin prickling from the cold and from Adora’s nearness.

She couldn’t bring herself to say, *I know. I know it was you who killed her. The same hands that threw that sword for me—those were the hands that gutted her.*

So instead, she had said, *I thought killing came naturally to you.*

Adora looked at her quietly for a long moment. “I’m a soldier,” she said finally, voice low and steady. “I have been for most of my life.” Her tone wasn’t defensive—it was tired. “I’ve killed in service to my queen. I’ve killed in battle. But easy?” She shook her head. “No. It’s never easy. It shouldn’t be. Is that the answer you were looking for?”

Catra’s throat went tight. She tried to picture Adora on the battlefield again—the invader, the Mage-slayer, blood-slick blade gleaming in the sun. She tried to remember the grin she swore she’d seen on her face that day. But when she thought of Adora now, all she could see was that same grin in a hundred other moments—laughing, alive, soft.

Had she been a monster that day, or just a girl with too much power and too little understanding of what it cost? Was she just happy she had survived the fight? She was a child, like Catra was, in the middle of a battled. Was Adora just smiling because she was just giddy with relief?

“You know it isn’t,” Catra said at last. She didn’t look at her. She didn’t dare ask the real question: *Did she matter to you at all, when you killed her?*

“I know what you think of Etherians,” Adora said softly. Her gaze didn’t waver. She wasn’t challenging; she was listening,

seeing her. “What happened at Sandsmark was wrong. I don’t expect you to believe me, but I am sorry for it.”

Catra almost scoffed, but the look in Adora’s eyes stopped her. There was no performance there, no pity—just that same relentless sincerity that always made her feel off-balance.

“I don’t understand you,” Adora continued, “but I know what you’re trying to do—what you’re trying to stop. And I know how much it costs you.” She hesitated, then said, with quiet conviction, “I couldn’t let him hurt you.”

Catra inhaled sharply. That was the answer, then. Simple. Honest. Adora needed Catra alive to stop the war.

She turned her face toward the fire, the light flickering gold against her cheek. She wasn’t sure what she felt—something that might have been loss, but she refused to name it that. She didn’t *want* Adora. Not really. And they weren’t friends. Allies, maybe. Temporary ones.

Still, her words had been a strange kind of reassurance. *You matter enough to save.*

It was something.

She forced herself to breathe, to focus on the crackle of the flames instead of the silence between them. If she didn’t speak, she thought, maybe the day she had to let Adora go would never come. It was a foolish thought.

“In the Fright Zone,” Catra said finally, her tone deliberately dry, “we reward good service. Is there something you want?”

Adora’s mouth twitched. “I'm sure you could guess.”

There was a weight behind the words—a longing that made Catra’s stomach tighten. She hated that she could hear it. Hated that she envied it. Catra was not a part of Adora’s freedom. Catra was going to be left behind.

“I’m not releasing you,” Catra said flatly. It was a lie, but she couldn’t bear to see her face when the truth came. Not tonight. “Ask for something else.”

“Take off one of the wrist-cuffs?”

The request came after a pause. Adora’s voice was calm, but there was something careful in it. When Catra glanced over her shoulder, Adora wasn’t glaring, or tense—she was leaning back against her hands, expression easy, almost teasing. A faint smile played at her mouth.

Catra snorted softly. “I'm *far* to lenient with you.”

Adora’s smile widened just a little. “You don’t give anyone anything you don’t mean to,” she said. “Not really.”

Her tone was warm—*fond*, even. It made Catra’s stomach twist. Coming from anyone else, it would’ve been a compliment. Coming from Adora, it was unbearable. Adora surely didn't mean it the way that Catra felt those words.

You would’ve been a devastating suitor when I was sixteen, Catra thought. *If Prime hadn’t ruined me first. If you hadn’t—*

Adora looked away.

“There is something,” she said quietly.

Catra swallowed. “Go on.”

Adora’s jaw flexed before she spoke. “Don’t use me against my own people. Not again. I can’t—” she exhaled sharply, shaking her head. “I can’t do that again.”

Relief, of all things, rose up in Catra’s chest—bright and foolish and painful. Even now, Adora’s decency somehow survived. “I wouldn’t ask that of you,” she said.

Adora looked unconvinced.

“That’s not kindness,” Catra added dryly, catching the flicker of doubt in her eyes. “It’s strategy. Loyalty doesn’t hold when you pit it against itself. I’m ruthless, not stupid.”

Adora didn’t respond. The silence between them thickened. Catra could feel old words pressing up, ready to spill—all the self hatred she kept tucked away like knives: *whore, coward, weak, unfit.* She shoved them down again, to the pit where they lived.

Finally, she said, “That throw, back at the river—never seen anything like it.” She forced her voice steady, lighter. “I keep wondering how Glimmer managed to catch you off guard long enough to shove you on a ship to me."

She knew, the moment the words left her mouth, that she’d said the wrong thing. It wasn’t meant as a jab—just an idle thought, a stray line between admiration and curiosity. Shadow Weaver would’ve adored that throw, would’ve said Adora fought like a storm given form.

But Adora’s face shuttered.

“It was…” she started, then stopped. Her voice faltered, and guilt stung sharp behind Catra’s ribs. She’d done it again—pushed too hard, poked at something raw. She was supposed to be good at reading people, but Adora… Adora made a mess of her instincts.

“I didn’t see it coming,” Adora said finally, her tone small, almost bewildered.

Catra almost asked *what* she hadn’t seen coming. But she already knew.

She should’ve stopped there. She should’ve let it go, kept the fragile peace between them intact. But she couldn’t. She couldn’t stop watching her—this woman she’d hated for so long, this woman who somehow still didn’t seem to hate her back.

She could understand her too well. She knew what it was to worship someone. She’d done it all her life. Shadow Weaver had

been her everything—perfect, untouchable. A goddess dressed in black and red.

Glimmer wasn’t much different to Prime, Catra thought. The kind of selfish, shining tyrant who smiled while she burned the ones around her.

And Adora—Adora had built her whole heart around her. She saw Glimmer as a sister and she had betrayed her for a throne. She had come to this world and was raised as a soldier-to-be-Queen, fed a lie that Angella and Glimmer loved her.

Catra, alone after Shadow Weaver’s death, looked for a father figure in Prime. He promised that familiarity. He called her "little sister" and he proudly declared her to be his heir.

It was almost funny, the symmetry of it. Prime, Glimmer—both of them playing gods. Both of them seeking to rule. Catra’s opinion of the sparkly little princess certainly hadn't improved since she had received word of the shipment of slaves containing Adora.

Adora’s voice pulled her back. “I didn’t see it coming,” she repeated, softer this time.

And Catra understood, suddenly, exactly what she meant. The shock of betrayal. The hollow ache of realizing that love didn’t protect you from anything.

She met Adora’s gaze, and the weight of it almost undid her. Catra had seen that hollow look in her own reflection too many times.

“I’m sure you would’ve dodged it,” Adora said finally, managing a smirk that didn’t quite reach her eyes. “You’re good at that. I remember the night Prime’s men turned on you—the first time he tried to kill you. You didn’t even look surprised.”

Her tone was teasing, but the edge was gone. She could hear what Adora was really offering—a way out. A chance to turn their conversation back toward something safer, something sharp and impersonal.

Catra didn’t rise to the bait. Instead, in a voice quieter than she meant it to be, she corrected Adora.

“I was surprised the first time, actually.”

Surprised. Hurt. Stupidly, *achingly* hurt.

Adora blinked, caught off guard. “The first time?”

It took Catra a moment to answer. Her throat felt tight—an unfamiliar, humiliating pressure. She waited, forcing herself to steady her breathing before she spoke again.

“I don’t even know what’s left of me anymore.” The words came haltingly, rough. “I remember how it felt. *Dying*, I mean. The first time. Prime’s arena—he loved that place.”

The memory hit like a blow. The sound of the crowd, the heat, the smell of blood and oil. The beast’s jaws closing around her leg. The white-hot agony as bone gave way. The beast’s jaw snapping away leaving her muscle and bones laid exposed on the floor. The way her breathing picked up as she realised she couldn't walk and that the beast was coming for her head. The moment of nothing that followed. Her leg still ached sometimes, like her body hadn’t gotten the memo that it was still there.

“One second, I’m being torn apart,” she said. “Next thing I know, I’m… fine again. New body, no scars. Same nightmare.”

Adora was staring at her—eyes wide, horror dawning slow and awful.

“When he threw you into the arena,” she said softly, “after the baths? I saw you get hurt but then you were fine.”

Catra’s stomach twisted. She forced herself not to flinch. She shrugged instead, as if it didn't bother her.

“I don’t even think these are the same claws that tore your back open,” she said, almost conversationally. “Those probably died

with that version of me."

She'd never blamed Adora for that fight. How could she? Dying had become so routine it barely felt real. She hadn't even tried to stop it anymore. Prime made sure of that.

"He never talks about it," Catra said. "Never admits it happens. Just acts like it didn't."

Once, he used to tell her she'd rule beside him. That he'd step back, just advise, let her lead. Back when she still believed him. Back when she thought the fear was respect.

But then he got bored. Cast her aside. And suddenly everyone in the Horde who'd bowed to her started watching her instead—reporting every word, every breath. She didn't know if they were chipped or just scared. Probably both.

"After that," she went on, "I started testing him. Pushing, just to see what he'd do. I don't know what I was expecting. Maybe I just wanted to see if he'd bother to finish the job for good." She let out a dry little laugh that didn't sound like one. "Guess I didn't think anyone would ever step in."

She could still see it: Prime's smile when she screamed. The way he looked *pleased*. Like her fear was proof of his perfection.

Catra's voice went softer. "After everything, I really thought I was on my own. Turns out, I can still be surprised."

Adora's eyes softened—unbearably so—and for one wild moment Catra thought she might actually try to *hug* her.

"It's not naïve," Adora said quietly, "to trust the people you thought were family."

Catra almost laughed. Almost.

"It is, though." But she took a slow breath, steadied herself, and pushed on. "Still… maybe it's not as stupid as trusting someone

who should be my enemy. Someone I've hurt. Someone who has every reason not to be here. It's not as if I could catch up to you on my horse if you took off now."

Adora didn't look away. Didn't flinch. And in that gaze, Catra saw it—that recognition. That understanding. They weren't strangers. They never had been.

Catra exhaled, then said the one thing she shouldn't.

"I know you're planning to leave. When the border's done."

Adora didn't deny it. Didn't even blink.

"I wonder," Catra said, voice low, "if you're still planning to use the knife I offered."

Adora didn't hesitate.

"No," she said.

Simple. Certain.

She was too honest to lie.

Chapter End Notes

Do you feel that ache in your chest or is it just me? Just me?

Chapter 14

Chapter Notes

CW: mentions of rape, non-consensual touching, mentions of Prime being a fucking creep, and violence.

Enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra had been on watch.

And that meant it was her fault.

There wasn't a single excuse she could stomach offering herself. She *knew* better. She'd spent years under Prime—she should've known what distraction could cost. He'd loved distractions, trained her with them—the flick of a light, the wrong sound at the right time—until she learned that if you focused on the wrong thing, you bled for it.

Except tonight, it wasn't Prime's trap. It was her own stupidity.

The air was warm, the fire low, and the stars looked close enough to touch. She'd let herself get tired. Let her thoughts drift—to Adora, to the weight of everything she still hadn't said—until her mind was a mess of too many things she couldn't untangle. The camp had seemed perfect: sheltered on three sides, the fire tucked out of sight. Safe.

She should have known better than to think that word meant anything anymore.

By the time she caught the flicker of movement beyond the ridge, it was already over. Six compact projectile weapons of various builds aimed at her chest.

They'd pegged her for the lesser threat—made sure she saw them, made sure she *understood*—before turning their weapons toward Adora.

The biggest of the raiders stomped up to her bedroll and shoved the tip of his crossbow against her cheek.

"Up, whore."

The dialect was Etherian—rougher than Huntara's, words dragged like gravel through mud. When Adora didn't immediately react, Catra translated, flatly.

"He said get up."

She didn't bother with the insult. The word sat heavy and familiar in her gut, but she wouldn't gift it to Adora. These men didn't know anything about her, not really. The one behind her yanked her arms behind her back, too tight, and grabbed a fistful of her hair to bow her head.

Catra's teeth bared automatically. She almost said it—*you're gentler than Prime*—but bit it back.

They tied her wrists. She didn't fight. Pointless. When the blindfold came, she didn't flinch. The gag that followed, though—her jaw forced open, rough hands pressing against her face—made her jerk instinctively. But it was only cloth, not the other thing she'd learned to expect. Relief came like a breath she didn't know she'd been holding.

It wouldn't last.

There'd be pain. There always was. Maybe worse. Probably rape. She'd been through it before. She could break herself into parts, leave only the one that could still think. Pain and use and fear she could live with. Death was the only thing you didn't get to come back from. And she wasn't dying. Not tonight.

She told herself that as they hauled her onto a horse, stomach pressed against the saddle, wrists aching. The hours dragged—hot breath, the stench of leather and sweat, the crude laughter of men who thought she couldn't understand them.

But she could.

They weren't shy about their plans. Not creative, either. Two prisoners. Two women. Plenty of time.

Catra kept her breathing even, her mind cold. *Endure first. Think later*.

Adora… Adora was the variable.

Catra didn't know how she'd react once she realized what kind of men they were dealing with. She'd seen that particular brand of rage in her before—with Double Trouble in the garden. If Adora fought, they'd kill her. If she didn't, she'd be broken in a different way.

Neither option was one Catra could stomach.

It wasn't that she was scared for herself. She just didn't want to see *that* look on Adora's face.

So she thought. Planned. Measured the rhythm of their horses, the rise and fall of voices. They were overconfident—most men like them were. If she timed it right, waited for the right kind of carelessness, she might find an opening. During, if not after.

It wouldn't be pretty. But survival rarely was.

Adora wasn't built for this kind of survival.

Catra flexed her bound hands, grimaced at the pain, and thought grimly, *Guess I'll just have to be enough for both of us.*

She would have to make sure that if the raiders' attention landed mostly on her, it *stayed* there. If they decided Adora was the more

entertaining target, everything would go to hell fast. Catra couldn't let that happen—not if she wanted Adora alive, intact, and useful later.

She was going to hate every second of this.

When the blindfolds and gags were yanked away, the sudden light of the campfire made Catra squint. Her ears flattened as she scanned the area, then turned to check on Adora. The blonde was breathing hard through her nose, jaw tight, eyes blazing with barely-contained fury.

Yeah. Catra remembered that look—the same one Adora had given her in the flagship. Fire and defiance. The look of someone who didn't know when to stop fighting.

Catra exhaled slowly through her nose. Right. She'd need to adjust the plan.

"This time," she murmured, just loud enough for Adora to hear, "stay down."

She rose to her feet, brushing the dirt off her knees like it was an inconvenience, not a threat, and switched to the Crimson Waste-Etherian dialect—thick, guttural, full of swagger.

"Most honored and highly esteemed Chief," she said, voice all sugar and venom, "may the milk of—"

The leader barked a laugh that was more of a snarl. "You'll be seeing plenty of milk soon enough. Back on your knees, pussycat. Might as well get comfortable there."

Catra tilted her head, ears flicking in mock confusion. "I see. My mistake."

Then, with exaggerated politeness, "I thought I was speaking with the Chief—"

His fist slammed into her jaw before she could finish. Catra staggered a step, copper flooding her mouth, but her grin only widened. Her ears twitched back as she rolled her jaw to make sure it still worked.

"Wow," she rasped, "didn't realize I was talking to one of the kids. My bad. Guess the real chief's still letting his balls drop somewhere, huh? Or did you misplace them along with your manners?"

A low chuckle rippled through the crowd. Someone snorted. Another raider called out, "Careful, boss, she's got a point!"

Catra's smirk sharpened. She could *feel* the shift—mockery spreading like wildfire. A man in the back shouted something about the leader's receding hairline. *Good one*, Catra thought, tail twitching. It really did share an uncanny resemblance with the Fright Zone's borders.

The chief's face went red, and he turned on his men, shouting insults of his own—pathetic, petty, desperate ones.

"He's got the smallest cock in the camp!"

"Oh yeah?" another yelled back, "At least mine doesn't bend in the middle, you donkey-fucker!"

More shouts, more laughter, arguments breaking out between them. Bows drooped, blades lowered. One man yelled something about his wife being that particular donkey, and suddenly half the camp was too busy bickering to notice their prisoners.

Catra's eyes flicked toward Adora. She could *feel* her ready to explode, muscles bunching like she was about to leap into the fray. *No*, Catra thought sharply, and gave the smallest shake of her head.

Too much, apparently.

The chief noticed. His laughter cut off mid-breath. The air went still.

"Hold her," he snapped.

Two men grabbed Catra's arms, yanking them behind her. She didn't struggle. Not yet. She'd bide her time. Let them think they'd won. Men got sloppy once they thought they were in control.

The chief stalked up to her, reeking of sweat and sour milk. Catra didn't flinch when his hand gripped her throat, slid slowly down her body, lingered where she least wanted it. Catra had to bite back bile as he grinned at her—as he enjoyed the way she tried to squirm away from his groping hands.

"Soft," he murmured, pressing harder until it hurt. "All that mouth, but you'll—"

He didn't finish.

Something hit him—a blur of movement, a sickening crack—and he went sprawling into the dirt.

For a heartbeat, no one moved.

It was Adora on him.

Catra barely saw her move—just the flash of gold hair, the wild snarl. Adora drove her head into the raider's face once, twice, blood spraying from his nose. The men holding Catra let go in surprise, and she hit the ground as they drew their swords.

The metallic ring of blades caught Adora's attention. She turned on them, feral and furious, eyes bright with something almost inhuman. The seemed to glow with her rage—an eerie spectral blue.

And then she *charged* again.

Catra barely had time to roll out of the way before Adora slammed into one man, driving him back into another. There was a strangled cry, a crunch of metal and flesh—and one raider fell, impaled on his companion’s sword.

Catra pushed herself up on shaking arms, watching her.

Even bloodied, even bound, Adora was terrifying.

And, Gods help her—Catra loved it.

The second raider stood frozen, staring down at his friend’s lifeless body like his brain couldn’t quite keep up with what had just happened. Adora didn’t give him the chance to catch up—she slammed her shoulder into his chest, sending him sprawling. Before he could recover, her boot came down hard on his throat and stayed there. The crunch that followed was wet and final.

By the time she looked up, the rest of the camp had finally realized what was happening.

Then they were on her—half a dozen men, maybe more—crashing into her in a wave of fists and steel. Catra could barely see through the chaos, only flashes of blonde hair, the glint of a blade, a grunt of pain. Adora vanished beneath the crush, then burst free for an instant, blood streaking her cheek, teeth bared ininn animalistic snarl. She fought like something feral—kicking, driving her head into anyone who got close, using her whole body as a weapon. But even Adora couldn’t fight that many.

Eventually, they brought her down.

“Kill her!” the clan leader bellowed, his voice wet with blood. He was missing several teeth now, and the gap in his grin only made him uglier.

Several raiders shouted over each other to volunteer. The argument was short-lived, a mess of snarling egos eager to be the one to finish the "bitch".

Catra's stomach dropped when she saw them force Adora onto her knees. One of the men raised his sword.

Without thinking, she shouted in the Wastes dialect—her voice sharp and cutting through the noise:

"A fast death won't hurt enough!"

The camp went still.

The leader turned toward her, slow and cruel, then chuckled. He raised a hand, stopping the blow mid-swing.

Catra's heart hammered in her chest. She didn't even know why she'd said it—some twisted reflex. All she knew is she didn't want Adora to die.

And now she'd condemned her to worse.

The raiders beat Adora instead. They wanted to draw it out. To make a show of it. Catra was forced to watch, hands bound, jaw tight enough to ache.

Adora didn't make a sound at first. She *refused* to give them that satisfaction. But when one of them struck her ribs—again, and again—her breath hitched. Catra saw her stumble, saw the way her head snapped to the side when another blow landed. The left side of her body took the brunt of it. One hit, too hard, too fast, sent her collapsing.

Catra's gut twisted. She told herself to stay detached, to calculate, to wait for the right moment. But it was hard to keep pretending she was cold enough not to care.

When the leader finally called it off—bored, apparently—Catra felt no relief.

"Enough," he grunted. "You're distracting everyone. Finish the camp. Take her away."

Adora was dragged off by two of them, limp between their arms. For the first time that night, real fear gripped Catra. Not the kind that made her fight harder. The kind that made her *freeze*.

She couldn't see Adora anymore.

Without that distraction, the rest of the raiders got back to work, moving faster now that they'd had their fun. The leader turned his attention back to her, his grin returning.

He pointed toward one of the tents being raised nearby. "I'm going to give you what you deserve, cat. And when I'm done, the rest of my men can have whatever's left."

Catra bared her teeth in something that wasn't quite a smile. "Wow. So generous."

He laughed—low, ugly—and tangled his fingers in her hair. Then he yanked, forcing her head back until her neck strained.

"You're one of *them*, aren't you?" he said. "The little pets. The ones that purr if you pull the leash right." His breath was rancid against her ear. "If you please me, maybe I'll keep you to myself for a few days."

"Oh, absolutely," Catra deadpanned. "My heart's fluttering. I don't think I've ever been wetter."

The leader blinked, trying to decide if she was mocking him or flirting. His brow furrowed; clearly, both ideas required more brainpower than he had to spare.

Before he could come to a conclusion, another raider ran up, panting.

"Chief," the man gasped, urgency cutting through the sleaze of the moment.

The leader snarled but turned his head, still gripping Catra's hair like a leash. They spoke quickly, in low voices—too quiet for her to

catch much beyond a few clipped words.

Whatever it was, it made the leader's expression twist. He swore—loudly, violently—and shoved Catra back to the ground.

"Get used to being on your knees," he snapped.

Catra spat dirt, eyes flashing. "Wow. You're really original. Should I start purring, or do you want to work your way up to humiliation first?"

His only answer was another curse—and that was when Catra knew something had gone wrong.

Which was right about the time Catra noticed the fires starting to bloom along the camp's edge.

The first shouts came seconds later—panicked, confused. The bandit chief spun, maybe to bark an order at the man guarding her—right before an arrow whistled out of the dark and buried itself in the underling's throat.

The man dropped without ceremony.

Then came another volley—flaming shafts cutting through the night sky, bright arcs of orange reflected in wide, startled eyes. Screams rose. Chaos bloomed.

Catra's heart gave a little kick as the chief froze, torn between keeping hold of his prize and saving his camp. Beyond the spreading fires, riders tore through the shadows, darting in and out of the light on stocky mountain horses, their arrows finding marks faster than the bandits could regroup.

"Oh no," Catra drawled, deadpan. "Tough choice. Me or your whole camp. Tick-tock."

The chief ripped his sword free and leveled it at her. "Stay."

Catra smiled sweetly. "Woof."

The sound he made was almost a snarl. She watched the hatred flicker in his eyes before he turned and bolted toward the chaos.

Catra gave it a few seconds, just long enough to make sure no one was paying her any attention, then pushed herself upright.

She moved north—toward the narrow mountain pass that cut away from camp. No more than two men wide, half-blocked by rock and scrub. Running would be suicide. The attackers would be scanning for movement, and anything fast would draw an arrow.

So she slipped between tents and shadows instead, staying low, ears tuned for the scrape of boots, the hiss of arrows. She searched for something—anything—to cut through the ropes around her wrists.

More than that, she tried to steady her breathing. To *think*. To not let herself think about—

Someone grabbed her from behind.

Her body reacted before her mind did—muscles locking, lungs seizing, heart punching against her ribs. Fingers gripped her shoulders, spun her hard. A glint of metal flashed near her face. The rest of the world fell away—the battle, the fire, the screams.

For one suffocating instant, she thought she'd made it this far just to die here, alone and unseen.

Then the wind shifted. A faint trace of soap—clean, simple, familiar—hit her senses.

And everything inside her went still.

Catra drew a shaky breath that scraped like glass in her throat. "What took you so long?" she muttered, the words soft, almost steady. Almost.

If Adora noticed the quiver under it, she didn't show it. Her voice came low, irritated, even as she worked the knife against Catra's

bindings. “Did you *plan* this? Seriously? You set yourself up as bait and didn’t think to tell me?”

Even annoyed, her voice was grounding—real, solid, *Adora*.

Alive.

Catra wanted to melt into it. Wanted to reach out, dig her claws into her and hold on until the world stopped spinning. Wanted to cry like she hadn’t since she was a kid.

Instead, she said, “I thought we’d lost Huntara’s riders. You know—because *someone* insisted on taking the scenic route through every cursed ravine in Etheria.”

Adora gave her a look, pure exasperation.

“They hit me, too,” Catra added, quiet now. “In case you’re planning another lecture about reckless choices.”

Adora’s jaw tightened. Her eyes flicked over Catra’s bruises, then back to the advancing shadows beyond the firelight.

“Once,” she muttered, grudgingly.

She shoved the knife into Catra’s hand, then raised the sword she’d claimed, squaring her shoulders toward the oncoming raiders.

Catra flipped the knife in her grip, smirking despite the pounding in her chest. “There she is.”

Adora didn’t look back. “Try to keep up.”

✧

Catra hadn’t quite made it to the mountain path before Adora found her, but once they did, she maneuvered them there—inch by inch—forcing the fight backward until the narrow pass worked in their favor. No more than two raiders could rush them at once,

and the walls of rock cut off any chance of an ambush from the sides.

Adora was bleeding—badly—but Catra didn't let herself think too hard about that. Not yet. This way, at least, she could keep control of the field.

She'd stolen a sword somewhere in the chaos, and now she stayed to Adora's left, where her movements were slower, where the blood soaked deepest through her torn sleeve.

Catra was not a natural fighter. Never had been. She'd learned combat the same way she'd learned everything else—by surviving it. But tonight… something in her snapped. The part of her that always bit back fear with cruelty found the violence *easy*.

She cut her opponents down fast, efficient, no flair for cruelty—but she didn't hate the sound of a body hitting the dirt. And when the tide began to turn, when more of the raiders tried to flee than fight, she felt a dark, vindictive thrill she couldn't quite smother.

She didn't stop until Adora physically hauled her back, arms locking around her waist, dragging her out of the way of a rider she'd been ready to tackle off his horse.

"Catra!" Adora snapped. "Enough!"

Catra hissed, breath heaving, claws still half-extended.

"One of us needs to check the dead," Adora said finally, voice low, winded but firm. "Make sure none of them—"

"I'll do it," Catra cut her off, eyes flicking toward the firelight below. Huntara's riders were already sweeping through the wreckage. "Later."

Before Adora could argue, Catra gripped her arm and pulled her sharply down to her knees. "Sit. You're gonna fall over anyway," she muttered.

Adora resisted for half a second, then obeyed with a small, exhausted grunt. Catra pressed a steadying hand to her shoulder —told herself it was just to keep her still, not because she *needed* to touch her. Not because the moment she let go, she'd feel unmoored again.

Because there'd been a moment—a heartbeat—when she thought Adora was gone. Taken and beaten to death in some dark corner of the camp while Catra waited to be passed from hand to hand like a common whore. That she'd failed again. That Etheria would fall. That everything would turn to dust.

She wasn't ready to stop touching her.

Huntara approached through the haze of smoke, her fur cloak dragging ash and blood alike, her posture effortlessly regal. Her dark eyes gleamed with satisfaction; a splash of scarlet across her cheekbone made her look carved from war itself.

"We'll relight the fires," Huntara said in her rough, clipped Horde. "We camp here tonight. The men will be bound. A good fight. Strong kills. Many captives."

"The chief?" Catra asked before she could stop herself. Her fingers tightened unconsciously in the fabric of Adora's shirt.

"Dead," Huntara replied, as though he'd been barely worth killing. Then, with a sharp nod: "You fight well." Her tone turned almost approving. "It's a pity you're too small to breed strong warriors. But not deformed. Your face is… well-balanced."

Catra blinked. "Uh. Thanks?" she managed dryly, before Huntara slammed her on the back with enough force to knock the breath out of her.

"You have fine lashes!" Huntara declared brightly. "A pretty cat. You will sit with me tonight—we drink, we eat meat!"

Catra wheezed, rubbing her ribs. "Fantastic. Guess I made a new friend," she muttered. Adora, utterly useless, was too busy

fighting back a grin.

Then Huntara's gaze shifted to her. "Your slave is strong," she observed. "Later, she will serve at the coupling fires."

Catra froze.

"The slave lies in no bed but mine," she said before she could think better of it. The tone came out *too* sharp.

Huntara only blinked, taken aback for half a second. Then she looked between them, comprehension dawning—and barked out a laugh.

"Oh! You couple with women, not men!" she crowed, snapping her fingers for two of her wives. "Then she will be made ready for you!" she said, magnanimous. "Good meat, good liquor—your blonde will have endurance for the night. See?" She gestured grandly, beaming. "This is Crimson Waste hospitality!"

Catra stared, at a rare and total loss for words.

Adora pinched the bridge of her bleeding nose. "Oh, for the love of—"

Catra realized, belatedly, that Huntara *liked* her. Not in the mild, strategic way allies did, but in that warm, lioness way Huntara had with those she respected. She wasn't just an asset or a political curiosity. Huntara thought they were friends—thought they would forge something lasting between the Horde and the Crimson Waste. Thought Catra would one day send emissaries, and Huntara would send daughters, and they'd share stories over hunts and blood and trade.

Catra felt something in her chest deflate. It wasn't relief. It was the weight of it all—the realization that Huntara's favour meant she'd have to play along.

She let them take Adora. For now.

✧

Huntara wagged a thick finger at her as they strode side by side through the ruined camp, smoke curling low around their boots. “You are far from where I was told to find you,” she chided, her tone the same one she’d use on a wayward cub.

“My estimates were... slightly optimistic,” Catra admitted dryly. “My apologies, Chief.”

Huntara barked a laugh. “*Slightly*! You were nearly on the other side of the canyon! You must learn the terrain better. My men will teach you. You will come next summer, yes? It is decided.”

Catra hummed as if weighing her calendar. “Assuming Prime hasn’t turned my skeleton into powder then? Sure. I’ll pencil it in.”

“Prime,” Huntara scoffed. She made a hand gesture that looked vaguely obscene—half milking, half strangling—and then feigned disappointment as she mimed a very underwhelming finish. She estimated the size accurately enough to make Catra snort.

Huntara grinned at her reaction. “Tell me, little cat—where would the Horde’s girl be without us to pull her tail out of the fire?”

“Oh, swimming in a sea of disappointing cocks, probably,” Catra replied without missing a beat.

Huntara roared with laughter and smacked her on the back so hard Catra stumbled a step forward again.

“Come,” Huntara said, voice warm with amusement. “Let us revisit those trade terms before you charm me into giving you *everything*.”

✧

They walked the camp together—through the ash and ruin, past bound prisoners and the fallen. Huntara was thorough; she wanted Catra to see the tally herself. The spoils, too.

Catra didn't claim any of it. She'd pretend to defer, all polite gratitude, and Huntara would pretend to accept it magnanimously. They both knew it was theater. If Huntara wanted, she could take every last crate and leave Catra's body cooling beside them. But power was a currency best spent sparingly.

They negotiated as they walked, and again over dinner, with the fires rekindled and the camp almost orderly again. Huntara's soldiers laughed and drank. The smell of roasted meat clung to the air. Catra secured better terms than Huntara had expected—though she had to concede another sliver of tariff control to the Crimson Wastes to do it.

"You see?" Huntara said at last, leaning back in her seat, purple smoke curling from her pipe. The haze caught the torchlight, softening the sharp edges of her eyes. "This is why I like you, my little cat. You dance faster than I can sometimes." She tapped her temple, approvingly. "Our friend at Ghost's Ridge told me true."

"When you visit Weave's Slope," Catra said, idly spinning her cup between her hands, "I'll have to make sure the alcohol's stronger."

Huntara had already downed six cups of something that smelled like it could strip paint, and she didn't so much as sway.

She grinned, teeth white and sharp. "When I come to Weave's Slope," she said, "I will wait to negotiate until after your blonde has exhausted you. Your lust makes you sloppy—but not sloppy enough. *Next time*!"

She tipped back the last of her drink, slammed the cup down, and barked an order at two of her warriors. "Take my clever little cat. She has waited long enough for her blonde!"

Catra blinked, caught somewhere between horror and laughter.

Huntara’s grin widened. “Go! Before I change my mind and keep her for myself!”

Catra groaned under her breath. “Yeah, that’d go over real well,” she muttered, pushing to her feet.

“I hope she beds you well!” Huntara called after her, raising her cup.

Chapter End Notes

> Next chapter is big. At least it's taking me forever to proofread is so it feels big, I haven't actually checked the word count 🙃 Let me know if I made any mistakes.

Chapter 15

Chapter Notes

> I am very sick, but I managed to get this chapter done. Please pretty please enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra had absolutely no intention of ending the night tangled up with anyone.

Not with the now-very-dead leader of the Crimson Wastes' bandits.

Not with the very-alive, very-heroic Adora of Bright Moon.

That didn't mean her mind was on its best behavior either. The thought crept in anyway—sliding uninvited through the cracks of exhaustion and adrenaline—because of course it did. Adora had that effect on her. Sometimes, from time to time, Catra allowed herself the thought: what would Adora be like if taken to bed? Catra had two points of reference: the last night they'd shared the Wastes' strange brand of hospitality. Firelight. Laughter. A type of intimacy Catra wasn't sure was real. And the drugged haze of pleasure Catra had received from Adora while about Prime's flagship.

She'd seen Adora again, briefly, during the tour with Huntara. Catra had been ushered to a private tent, a bath, and all the trappings of respect. Adora had been… scrubbed. Out in the open. A crowd watching like it was sport. Catra had seen Adora naked before but even she had to look away this time. The urge to tear someone's throat out was stronger than the urge to watch.

They'd left her with a basin of hot water and an array of oils that smelled faintly like spice. Beside them lay a curious collection of instruments. One of them, long and polished smooth, caught her eye. She had definitely heard of these before, but she had

pictured the item to be more obviously phallic. Catra supposed the lack of carving to give it a head reminiscent of the real thing would make it harder to seal with a protective coating.

The attendant noticed her hesitation. "To… assist, if you have the need," the woman offered lightly.

Catra held the item up, arching a brow. "You're kidding me."

"I assure you, it's of excellent quality."

Catra snorted. "I assure you, I won't be needing this."

She was the Horde's Crown Princess, not some desert brothel's latest entertainment. And she wasn't about to let anyone—least of all Adora—put *that* anywhere near her.

The attendant wilted under Catra's glare, mumbled something about hospitality customs, and quickly excused herself.

Catra was alone. Finally.

She sank into the water. It was hot and clean, the scent of the soap foreign and sweet. For a few fleeting minutes, she let the heat seep into her bones. She was safe, for now. Safe enough to let her shoulders drop, to pretend the tremor in her hands was just fatigue. She tried to stop thinking, stop remembering—but peace was still a language her body didn't speak.

She rose from the bath sooner than planned, toweling off briskly. The clothes laid out for her were soft, clearly chosen with ceremony in mind. She wrapped herself in the fur cloak Huntara had gifted her earlier—a rare kindness from someone who liked her just enough not to stab her in the back. Yet.

And she took the vaguely phallic item—along with the awaiting belt that was set with it. She tucked it under her cloak to conceal.

Outside, a woman waited to guide her to her tent. She handed Catra a small block of ice before she left. The same ice Catra had

requested earlier.

✧

She thought Adora might be asleep when she reached the tent.

Maybe she hoped she was.

Catra paused outside the flap, her pulse strangely uneven. She told herself she wasn't nervous—just tired. Tired of Adora's eyes on her. Tired of what those eyes always seemed to see. She didn't expect anything tonight. She didn't *want* anything tonight.

But when she stepped inside, Adora was awake.

And, of course, she was impossible not to look at.

The tent was smaller than the last one they'd shared. No separate cots this time—barely enough room for Adora herself. She was sprawled on the furs, dressed in something that looked like a cross between a strip of leather and a challenge meant only for her. It hung loose over one hip, doing nothing to hide her chest, all creamy golden skin and lamplit muscle.

Catra looked. She let herself. And, for once, she didn't feel the urge to mock or run or hide behind a smirk or cutting word. Just… quiet.

The realization came slowly, solid and heavy as a stone dropping into deep water. It had been there for a long time, unacknowledged, half-buried. But now she could see it clearly—the shape of it, immovable, inevitable. It didn't frighten her. It just *was*. Something she'd built her whole life around avoiding, only to find it sitting at the center of her chest all along.

She exhaled. Met Adora's gaze.

"Here's to Crimson Waste hospitality," Catra murmured. Her voice was soft, almost amused.

Adora was lying on her side, one elbow propped beneath her, the other hand absently tangled in her curls. The lamplight caught in them, gold threaded through gold.

"It's a traditional outfit," she said dryly. "All the guys wear them. Guess they decided something about… us."

That you would the one to fuck me, and not the other way around?

Catra found it strange—how calm she felt. Maybe even peaceful. She shrugged off her warm fur cloak—carefully tucking away the concealed item—and watched Adora's eyes flick up, the way her mouth twitched like she was fighting a smile. Catra liked that look on her. Liked that *she* could still pull that look from her.

"Mine's got more fabric," Catra murmured, her voice low and even. "Disappointed?"

Adora's grin deepened. "Would be—if the light wasn't behind you."

Catra rolled her eyes but said nothing. She'd told Huntara that Adora would share her tent—her bed. It had seemed practical at the time. Necessary. She hadn't expected the words to turn real in quite this way.

When she crawled onto the pallet beside her, Catra froze, pulse jumping. For an instant, she thought—no, feared—it might turn into something she wasn't ready for. But when she looked, Adora was just there. Relaxed. Grinning that easy grin that once made Catra want to punch her and now made her want to… breathe. The blue in her eyes was steady. Safe.

Catra exhaled. Sat instead of lying down. Close, but not too close. Close enough to feel the heat of Adora's body and hate how much she liked it.

"Thanks for, uh…" Adora gestured vaguely around the tent. "All this. Hospitality and whatever."

Catra arched a brow. “What, for exercising my royal right of first claim?” she said, tone sharp enough to cover the heat rising to her face. “Relax, you’re not my conquest for the evening.”

“I didn’t say I was!” Adora protested, pink already creeping up her neck.

Catra smirked. “How aroused *are* you, then?” she asked, flicking her gaze—very deliberately—to the small scrap of cloth Adora was calling a garment.

Adora sputtered, tugging down at her only scrap of modesty. “Catra! I’m *not*—ugh. I didn’t drink that stuff again, okay? I had plenty last time.”

“That wasn’t what I asked,” Catra said, voice smooth, unbothered. There was no real bite in it tonight. The threat that used to live between them was gone.

She wasn’t aroused—not really—but she thought of the ride here: her arms around Adora’s waist, her cheek against her shoulder, the steadiness of her heartbeat. If she’d told herself she didn’t miss that closeness. She’d be lying.

“This is close quarters,” she said finally, under her breath.

“Close enough to count your eyelashes,” Adora teased, fingers twitching like she wanted to reach out but didn’t quite dare. Her hand brushed Catra’s knee before retreating. Her voice dropped, rougher now: “You know, you’re lucky you’re small. Less competition to breed you for heroic warrior offspring.”

The playful tone sent a hum through Catra’s chest. She wanted to lean in, wanted to press her face to Adora’s neck and just *stay*.

“My size is normal for my species,” Catra said. “I’m a cat, not a lion. Besides, you’re not exactly a seven foot tall giantess.”

Adora laughed—really laughed—and looked at her in that maddening, open-hearted way that made Catra’s chest ache. So

full of affection.

Who do you see when you look at me like that? Catra wondered. It couldn't be *her*—not the *her* who'd done everything she'd done. Not the *her* who'd hurt Adora more times than she could count.

If you could just hold me for a little while—

No. She couldn't ask for that. Couldn't even think it.

Instead she said, lightly, "I get that being in my service doesn't leave you a lot of time for… release. So, if you want to take advantage of the freedom tonight, find some guy to—"

"No," Adora interrupted quickly, firmly. "I don't want a man."

Catra's breath caught. She looked at her for a long, loaded second.

She wanted to ask *who*, but she already knew the answer, and Adora would be too honest to lie. The better question was *how*. How could Adora look at her that way—after everything?

Oh, Adora thought she knew the worst of Catra. She had no idea.

Catra was the first to look away.

"Sit up," Catra ordered, reaching for the bundle she'd been saving—the small cache of ice brought down from higher up the slope. It was already half melted, wrapped in a clean handkerchief that had soaked through with cold water. She could see Adora tense before she even turned back around.

Catra focused on her task, because if she didn't, she might notice how hard her own pulse was hammering. The bruises along Adora's ribs looked worse now that they weren't half hidden under her uniform.

Adora frowned, confusion pulling at her brow. "What are you—?"

“Hold still.”

Adora sucked in a breath as the cloth touched her skin, her muscles jerking under the chill. Her hand shot up instinctively, covering Catra’s over the ice. Catra ignored it. Or tried to.

“What,” Adora hissed through her teeth, “no magic healing salve?”

Catra smirked faintly, voice low. “Sorry to disappoint. I don’t think they are as easy to come by in the Fright Zone.” Her eyes flicked up to meet Adora’s. “They brought it from up the ridge.” She didn’t mention that she’d asked for it herself. Adora would only go digging for some hidden motive that wasn’t there.

They’d been getting along too well lately. That usually meant an argument was due.

Catra swallowed the thought and, after a pause, said quietly, “I told the clansmen to make it hurt.”

Adora looked at her, surprise softening into something else. “It saved my life.”

“Since I can’t throw a sword,” Catra said lightly, offering the smallest smile. She nodded toward the compress. “Here. You hold it.”

Adora took it, but her eyes stayed on her. Catra forced herself to shift back, to put a few inches of air between them. *She already missed the contact.*

“You know,” Catra began, reaching for something neutral, “these were the same men who hit Sandsmark. Huntara’s sending ten of them with us to Sandsmark, then on to Talon Mountain. We’ll use them to pry open the border negotiations. The rest stay with her —along with all the weapons.”

Adora listened, quiet, steady. “And she agreed to turn her raids west—away from Bright Moon?”

Catra's mouth twitched. "More or less."

"And at Talon Mountain," Adora went on, "you're planning to prove Prime was behind the attack."

"Yes." Catra drew in a long breath, let it out slow. She let herself look at Adora fully then, memorizing her in the flickering light—the scrape of her jaw, the faint blue in her bruises, the strength she carried even while sitting half beaten. "I think… things are about to get dangerous." She wanted to say *more than you know.*

"About to get dangerous?" Adora repeated, half a laugh in her voice. She really didn't know. Not about Prime. Not about how deep his reach went, how far Catra was willing to push to end him.

Catra said, "Keldor's the one who needs convincing. If you hated Bright Moon more than anything—if someone handed you one clean chance to burn them to ash—what would stop you? What would make you lay down your sword?"

She was too careful with words. But the look that crossed Adora's face made her wish she'd chosen different ones.

"I wouldn't," Adora said softly. "Unless I was angrier at someone else."

Catra's stomach turned. The thought that followed—*or in love with her enemy*—was one she didn't let herself say aloud. She looked away before Adora could read it on her face.

If only she'd hated Prime enough, early enough, to love Adora before she had fucked up so badly.

"This isn't how I pictured spending the eve of war," Catra murmured, and her voice broke a little around the edges. She felt caged by her own walls—close enough to reach out, but not enough to cross the distance. She wouldn't let herself take Adora's hand. Wouldn't let herself give in to the need clawing at her chest.

She couldn’t say what was burning in her throat: *I know who you are. I know what you’ve done. And even though you took everything from me—even though you took her—you gave me something new that I don’t know how to repay.*

Adora smiled that impossible smile, equal parts trouble and light. “What, you mean with me in your bed?” she teased.

It was like being punched and kissed at once.

“And in my confidences,” Catra said quietly. Her gaze lifted to Adora, and for a moment she almost—*almost*—let something real slip out. But the words caught somewhere behind her teeth, and stayed there.

She couldn’t say *I’m sorry*. Couldn’t explain *you’ve become too important to me.* Couldn’t confess that freedom was waiting just over the horizon, or that Shadow Weaver’s ghost might finally rest knowing the woman who’d ended her had done so with honor.

She couldn’t say *if we both make it out of this war alive, I want to try being your friend.*

She couldn’t say *I don’t know how to imagine a world without you anymore.*

So she said nothing.

Catra lay down, shoving Huntara’s cloak away before she could pull it close. Tonight wasn’t for comfort—or honesty. Her truths would stay locked up, pressed tight behind her ribs. She pressed her wrist hard against her forehead, forcing her thoughts back to strategy, to movement, to anything but *her*.

“Tomorrow’s going to be long,” she said finally, voice low, even. “Thirty miles through the mountains—with prisoners. We should sleep.”

She didn’t say *before I start saying things I can’t take back.*

The air between them felt like ice.

✧

Catra couldn’t sleep. Wouldn’t, really. She was too aware of everything—the warmth of Adora’s body only a breath away, the quiet sound of her breathing, the soft half-snores that would have made Catra smirk if she weren’t so damn restless.

“Adora,” she whispered.

Nothing.

She tried again, louder. “Mara.”

Adora stirred. “Glimmer’s…” she mumbled into the furs, smiling faintly. “That’s my nightgown.”

Catra stared, lips parting around a soundless laugh. Stars, she was ridiculous.

It would be so easy—too easy—to shift just a little closer. There wasn’t much space between them anyway. If they touched in their sleep, it could be explained away. *An accident. Nothing more.*

Her fingers hovered near Adora’s hair, over the loose, gold strands tangled across her pillow. She could feel the warmth of Adora’s breath against her skin.

“Don’t leave…” Adora murmured.

Catra’s chest ached. She imagined it—just once—waking up tangled together. Pretending it was a coincidence. Pretending she didn’t want it.

She almost reached out. Almost.

But then—like a door kicked open inside her head—came the memory. Prime’s shadow. His weight. His voice. His hands. The

suffocating certainty that *no* didn’t matter. That her body had never been her own.

Catra’s hand jerked back like she’d touched fire.

She turned away fast, curling in on herself, her claws digging into her palms until they hurt.

Adora was her slave. She couldn’t really deny Catra anymore than she could truly choose to want her. Not like this. *No* wasn't an option for her.

She didn’t sleep.

✧

Twelve hours on horseback later, Catra decided she’d undersold how miserable the day would be.

Huntara’s clan didn’t have coffee.

By the time twilight bled across the peaks, Sandsmark’s ruins were nothing but shadows and ash. Keldor’s men had already cleared out, but Catra’s troops lingered, securing the perimeter and salvaging what they could.

When her tent came into view—Shadow Weaver’s old tent, gaudy and blood-red against the gray—something in her chest loosened. Familiarity, maybe. Or control. Or the illusion of both.

“Report to the medic,” she told Adora briskly, slipping back into command before her thoughts could wander. She’d left the tent before dawn, before Adora could wake, and she’d made sure to keep busy since. Better that way.

“There’s a lot to do, and you’re still half-broken,” Catra went on. “Let him check your ribs. If he doesn’t want to keep you under observation, you get the evening off.”

Adora frowned, and Catra could see the question forming before she said it.

"Are you sure you don't—?"

Catra's laugh came sharp, cold, perfectly deflective. "Need you? Is that where you were going with that?"

Adora met her eyes, steady as ever. "Yeah."

Catra hated her for saying it that simply—for meaning it. She hated how tired she suddenly felt. How close she was to admitting that yes, she did.

But she only turned away, jaw tight. "Go see the medic, Mara."

"I think you've earned a little rest," Catra said, voice rasped thin from exhaustion. "And maybe a few hours without me breathing down your neck."

Her tone was still dry, still clipped, but the bite wasn't there. She didn't have the strength for it. Every muscle in her shoulders burned like coiled wire; her jaw ached from clenching it through half the night. The tent lights made her head throb.

She wanted sleep. Stars, she wanted it. But she knew she wouldn't take it.

"Medic first," she added sharply, cutting herself off before she softened too much. "Or I'll make sure the next beating you take hurts worse than the last one."

It came out harsher than she meant it to. It always did.

✧

By the time she finished another sweep of the town—and another terse round of negotiations with Huntara—night had settled heavy over Sandsmark. The campfires burned low, flickering red in the

wind. When Catra finally ducked into her tent again, the silence hit her like a wave.

No guards. No generals. No gorgeous Etherian.

Just quiet.

She stripped off her gloves, splashed cold water from the basin onto her face, and dragged her wet hands down over her eyes. The shock of cold helped—barely. She still smelled of horse and smoke, but she couldn't stomach the effort of undressing. Not yet.

Before she could even call for coffee, it arrived. A pot—still steaming—and a tray with the kind of simple meal she could actually stand after a day like this.

She blinked at it, then at the servant.

"Your—ah—your pet sent it ahead, your highness," the soldier stammered. "Was that… incorrect?"

Catra hesitated. "No," she said finally. "It's fine." A beat. "It'll do."

The servant vanished, leaving her alone with food she hadn't ordered and the dull ache of gratitude she refused to acknowledge.

She ate mechanically while Lonnie gave her the day's report, eyes scanning requisition lists between bites. When the tray was cleared, she downed the entire pot of coffee like it might burn away the fatigue crawling under her skin.

By the time Adora returned, she'd almost convinced herself she felt normal again.

"One more night," Adora said in greeting, stepping into the tent. Her voice was low, tired, but sure.

Catra didn't look up right away. Her thoughts were running too fast—through plans, through contingencies, through one terrible,

brilliant idea she'd been turning over in her mind since morning.

It was reckless. It was everything she shouldn't do.

It was the only thing she *wanted* to do.

She couldn't tell her. If she did, Adora would ruin it—by being *herself*.

So she kept her eyes on the maps spread across the table. "Keep the prisoners breathing," Catra recited flatly. "Keep Huntara cooperative. Keep our troops from killing each other."

She didn't say the last part.

Free Adora. Get her picked up by Mermista's outriders. Don't look back.

The logic was madness. She was about to give away her best leverage—her bargaining chip, the one thing Mermista couldn't refuse. But Catra couldn't stop turning the thought over in her head.

Because if Adora was really who Catra believed she was—honest, infuriatingly moral, incapable of letting people down—then she didn't need to be bought.

She'd come back.

Not as a prisoner. Not as leverage. But because she *wanted* to.

Catra could see it as clearly as if she'd already lived it: Adora returning to her camp at Talon Mountain. Maybe the battle would still be raging. Maybe Catra would have taken the fort by then. Either way, Adora would ride through the chaos like a beam of light, her banner flying beside Mermista's.

The Queen of Bright Moon—free, radiant, impossible to ignore. Dressed in that ridiculous golden armor, hair too clean, eyes too

earnest. Probably with some overdramatic steed conjured from pure magic.

She'd think no one would recognize her. She'd want privacy, as always—would try to speak to Catra quietly, confessing, apologizing, explaining, because she still didn't understand that Catra had always known.

And Catra—Catra would do what she always did best.

She'd smile.

She'd greet her in front of everyone, voice warm and easy. She'd say her name—*Adora*—as though it were a victory, as though she hadn't spent a lifetime choking on it.

She could already see the look on her face when she realized.

Catra's pulse kicked hard. Her claws bit into the edge of the table.

The words already lived on Catra's tongue.

The Princess of the Horde welcomes the arrival of Adora, rightful Queen of Bright Moon.

She could picture it—the hush falling over the camp, the ripple of confusion, the faces of her soldiers trying to make sense of what they were hearing. A declaration like that would end it. No fight, no awkward explanations. Just a single clean break from everything that came before.

She'd once held her mother's killer in her grasp and chosen to let her go. *Now*, she thought, *I'll welcome her back. Not as a prisoner. Not even as an enemy. As an equal.*

An ally.

Maybe even—one day—something more.

But not tonight.

“Get over here,” Catra said abruptly, cutting off her own thoughts before they could start spiraling. “We’re talking geography.”

Adora crossed the tent without hesitation, dropping into her usual spot across from Catra. The map stretched between them, worn at the folds, covered in pencil marks and corrections. They’d done this a hundred times before—studied troop movements, plotted routes, argued over tactics—but tonight it felt different.

“Talon Mountain,” Catra said. She leaned forward, tracing the path from Sandsmark with a claw, slow and deliberate. “How well do you actually know this stretch?”

Adora frowned, one brow cocked in suspicion. “We’ve gone over this, like, three times already.”

“Then humor me,” Catra said. Her tone was flat, her face unreadable.

She didn’t explain that she needed to be sure. That every detail mattered—every ridge, every valley, every pass that Mermista’s outriders might use to find her once Catra set her free. Adora’s freedom depended on it. So did everything else.

(And yes, there was also the small matter of Prime’s forces possibly waiting somewhere in those mountains, ready to pounce. But that part, at least, Catra could plan for.)

✧

They talked deep into the night.

Catra knew she should have stopped an hour ago. She could feel her focus slipping, her eyelids dragging with exhaustion. But she couldn’t. Not tonight. Every time Adora laughed softly at a joke she didn’t mean to make, or leaned across the map to point out something obvious, Catra found another excuse to keep her there.

“All right,” she said finally, voice rough from overuse. “If we keep going, we’ll still be here when the sun comes up.”

She pushed away from the table, her joints creaking in protest, and began tugging absently at the fastenings on her cuffs. The fine buttons refused to yield, her claws scraping against the delicate thread.

"Here," Adora said softly. "Let me."

Catra froze.

She'd thought about this earlier—how the uniform was a pain to get off alone—but she'd been too tired, too distracted, to ask for help. She hadn't expected Adora to just *offer*.

Before Catra could protest, Adora stood and stepped closer. Her presence filled the space between them like heat. Taller, broader, so steady it was almost infuriating. Catra could smell her.

Adora worked quickly, deft fingers undoing the buttons at Catra's wrist, then the ones trailing up her sleeves. Her touch was careful, gentle in a way that made Catra's chest ache. When the jacket came loose, Adora eased it off her shoulders, lingering again.

Catra exhaled without meaning to. The sudden lightness made her dizzy. She rolled her shoulder to relieve the ache, and then—

Adora's hand settled there.

Catra went very still.

It wasn't rough or commanding. It wasn't even hesitant. Just *steady*. Warm.

"Sore?" Adora asked quietly, her thumb brushing once against the muscle near her collarbone.

Catra closed her eyes. Her voice came out softer than she meant it to. "Maybe."

Adora's other hand rose to mirror the first, and the air seemed to thicken between them. Catra could feel every inch of it—every line

of Adora's fingers, every trace of heat. It was as if the touch carved itself into her skin, branding her from the inside out.

She wasn't supposed to feel this way.

And yet—she couldn't stop.

Once, being this close to Adora would have made her defensive, volatile, desperate to push her away before she could see how much power she really had. Now, the fear felt different. It wasn't that she was afraid of Adora.

It was that she was afraid of what Adora made her *want*.

Catra stood there, breath caught between one heartbeat and the next, and let herself feel it—the impossible tenderness of being touched without expectation, without command, without control.

Adora was still behind her, steady as the stars, and Catra realized with a kind of dread that she didn't want to move.

Not because she was weak.

But because—for the first time—she felt truly safe to be touched.

And that terrified her more than anything.

Catra swallowed hard and opened her eyes, her voice coming out thin and brittle.

"So," she said carefully, "are they teaching massage techniques in Bright Moon's army now?"

Adora's voice came from behind her—quiet, gentle, measured. That was new. Adora didn't do *measured*. She was the type to blurt things out, to rush in before thinking, to fumble over honesty because she didn't know how to be anything else. But now, she was choosing every word with the kind of care you'd use around a wild animal that might bolt.

“Not exactly,” Adora said. “But… it’s not hard to figure out. I can try, if you want.”

Catra’s first instinct was to laugh in her face. *If you want?* As if Adora hadn’t already crossed the line ten times over by even offering. Adora had nerve—steel-plated, galaxy-sized nerve—to so easily touch her again after the baths on the flagship.

And yet she did.

Catra felt the first press of Adora’s thumbs—steady, cautious—at the base of her shoulders, and her body betrayed her with a sharp, involuntary breath.

Adora’s tone softened even more. “You brought me ice last night,” she said. “Figured I could return the favour.”

Catra shut her eyes again, a muscle in her jaw jumping. She didn’t want that warmth—didn’t want the reminder of how easily Adora could be kind, how that kindness could tear her apart. When she spoke, her voice came out with edges sharpened.

“This,” she said, through a tight throat, “is a little more... Than ice.”

Adora paused. “Too much?”

There was no teasing in her voice—only an open door. That was the worst part. Adora didn’t play games; she never had. Catra could stop this with one word. One breath. And Adora would step back immediately, no questions, no arguments.

The certainty of that undid her more than the touch itself.

She drew a breath, then another, willing her voice steady. She didn’t tell Adora to stop.

The hands moved again. Pressing deeper this time, finding the knots of tension just beneath her shoulder blades. The pressure walked a fine line between pain and relief. Adora’s breath brushed

her hair, and Catra realized how close she'd moved. Too close. She could feel the faint heat of her skin, the quiet rhythm of her breathing.

Catra wanted to tell her it wasn't working—that this kind of comfort didn't fix anything, that it couldn't. She even opened her mouth to say it.

"I—"

But the words jammed in her throat. *I can't. I'm too broken. You can't fix me.* None of it would come out.

Adora's thumbs pressed down on a spot between her shoulder and spine, and something deep inside Catra's chest gave way.

"There," Catra breathed.

Adora's voice dropped, just above a whisper. "Here?"

"Yes."

They didn't need to say more. The rhythm between them shifted. Adora's hands traced the lines of muscle along her back, finding each place that made Catra tense and working it loose.

Her palms spread lower, firm and warm, finding another knot near Catra's ribs. Catra flinched when Adora pressed, the reaction involuntary.

"Like that?" Adora murmured.

"Yes."

It sounded too soft. Too vulnerable. Too much like *something else*.

Adora's touch was maddening. Catra could pretend it was just practicality, that Adora was just being helpful—but her body didn't believe it. The quiet heat in Adora's hands, the gentle strength in

her grip—it was impossible not to imagine how easily it could turn into something else.

She could almost see it: Adora leaning closer, lips brushing the curve of her neck; hands sliding lower, gathering the fabric of her shirt; her breath against Catra's skin, slow and shaking with the same restraint Catra was losing by the second.

It would have been so easy to let herself fall into it—

But Adora, damn her, spoke.

"Is it really that hard for you to relax?" she asked softly. "You could walk outside right now and see what you've built, Catra. Look at them—they follow *you*. You did that."

The warmth in her voice was real. Proud. Almost tender.

And it shattered the moment completely.

Catra stiffened, every muscle seizing at once. She could no longer feel her hands, her breath, her pulse. Just Adora's voice—gentle, forgiving—

Unbearable.

Because Adora meant it.

And Catra couldn't stand being seen like that—through Adora's eyes, through her ridiculous, unshakable faith.

"That's enough," Catra said sharply, jerking away before she could stop herself.

Adora's hands fell back to her sides.

Catra didn't look at her. Couldn't. The skin beneath her shirt burned where Adora had touched it, as if her body hadn't gotten the message that it was over.

It couldn't keep going like this. *She* couldn't keep going like this.

But maybe she wouldn't have to—not for much longer. Maybe, someday, years from now, when the fighting was done, when the borders were steady, when the bruises of it all had faded—maybe then it would be easier. Maybe by then she'd be able to breathe without flinching. Maybe by then, it wouldn't hurt so much just to *look* at her.

For now, the distance helped. A few steps between them, a few inches of air, and Catra could think again.

She turned, made herself face her. Made herself *speak*.

"Thanks," she said, quietly. And because the word alone carried too much weight, she forced another out, dry and sharp. "Didn't realize getting tied up left such a lasting impression. Guess captivity's not as comfortable as I thought."

Adora's mouth quirked faintly. "Yeah, well. It's not."

Catra tried to make it a joke, tried to turn the sharpness into something easy. "I promise not to tie you to the back of a horse."

She failed spectacularly. The silence that followed stretched long enough to make her regret ever opening her mouth.

Finally, Adora said, softly, "That's right. I'm still your prisoner."

The words hit harder than Catra expected. Her body didn't move, didn't flinch, but the ache settled deep, somewhere behind her ribs.

"Your eyes say 'for now,'" Catra said. She shoved the words out, fast, like ripping something open before she could stop herself. "They've always said it. Even on the flagship."

Once, that defiance had been something she'd wanted to break. Now it just scared her—how true it still was.

She drew a breath. "If you were just a pet," she went on, deliberately flat, "I'd have freed you by now. You are just too..."

Important.

No, that wasn't right. It didn't describe how she felt.

If you were just a pet, she thought, *maybe I could tell you the truth.*

Catra could see it in her—Adora's longing for the open sky, for freedom that wasn't borrowed or conditional. She was wild at heart, still tethered but untamed, a wolf on a leash pretending to play nice. And Catra—stars help her—was the fool who kept pretending she could keep her.

"I'd still be here," Adora said. Her voice came without hesitation—strong, immediate, as if she'd been waiting to say it. "You know that. I told you I'd see this through to the end. You think I'd break my word?"

Catra blinked, momentarily thrown. It wasn't just the words—it was how fiercely Adora meant them.

"No," she said slowly. "I don't." Her chest felt tight. "But you've thought about it. Leaving."

Adora didn't deny it. Her jaw flexed, eyes flicking away before meeting Catra's again.

"I know you enough by now," Catra said, quietly now. "I saw how it got to you—on the flagship, yesterday in the square. You hate being trapped. You hate not fighting back."

Something flickered across Adora's face—*guilt*, maybe, or recognition. And then she stepped forward, so suddenly that Catra barely caught herself before retreating.

Adora's hand lifted—hesitant at first, then firm. Her fingers brushed along Catra's jaw, feather-light, tracing the bruises there with an expression that made Catra's stomach twist.

"The man who did this to you," Adora said, low and dangerous.

Catra's body reacted before her mind caught up. She jerked back, sharp and instinctive. She hadn't meant to. She hadn't planned to.

But Adora's face—Adora's *eyes*—she had never seen them look like that before.

Except… maybe she had. Maybe she'd just never let herself *see* it.

And now she couldn't unsee it.

Adora blinked hard, pulling herself back together. Her hand dropped to her side. The heat in her gaze dimmed into guilt. "Sorry," she said quickly, voice raw with sincerity. "That was—stupid. I shouldn't've…" Her fists clenched, helpless. "I know better."

She took a step back. Then another.

"I should check on the watch," she said, forcing her voice steady. "I'll take a shift tonight."

She turned toward the tent flap, already halfway gone.

Catra watched her hand lift the canvas. Watched her walk away. Watched everything she didn't understand slip through her fingers.

The tent felt too small, the air too thin, her pulse a hammer inside her chest. She couldn't move. Couldn't think.

And then—

"No."

Adora froze, half-turned, firelight from outside cutting across her face.

Catra's throat burned. Her voice came again, uneven, caught between command and plea.

"Wait. I—" She swallowed, hard. "Wait."

It sounded like an order. It wasn’t.

But Adora stopped anyway.

Adora stopped. She turned, cautious, shoulders tensing before her eyes found Catra’s.

Catra’s throat locked. The words fought her. She knew Adora couldn’t read her—couldn’t possibly decipher what she meant when she stood there, armor-plated in her own silence. She knew what she looked like: cold, cruel, carved out by guilt. The kind of person who once tortured someone for reaching toward her—and Adora, stupid, infuriating Adora, had almost gotten herself killed because she couldn’t stomach the thought of raiders touching something she thought was still worth saving.

Catra needed her to understand. She needed her to *know*.

“What the soldiers said,” Catra began, too slow, too quiet. “About my mother and me—it wasn’t true.”

Adora’s brow furrowed. “I didn’t think it was.”

“I mean…” Catra swallowed. “Whatever rot the Horde has ingrained in it, she wasn't like that.”

“Rot?” Adora asked, the word sharp with disbelief.

Catra’s jaw clenched. Of course she’d push it—she was *Adora*, Bright Moon’s golden idiot, and she couldn’t just *let things go*. Catra forced herself to keep going, though her chest ached from the pressure of it.

“You remind me of her,” she said. “That’s why I wanted to tell you. She was—she *was* the best woman I ever knew.”

Until you. Now there are two. Two, and I’ll lose you both. You took her from me, and you’ll walk away too. You’ll look at me like that, but you’ll still go, because it’ll never be enough. *I’ll never be enough.*

"You should know that," Catra said, forcing her voice steady. "You deserve that, at least."

Her throat burned. "On the flagship—I was cruel to you. Deliberately. I won't insult you with apologies. I can't make that right. But I wouldn't—if I had the chance again, I wouldn't do it." She exhaled, bitter and shaking. "*Angry* doesn't even begin to cover what I was."

There wasn't a word strong enough for the storm that had lived inside her aboard Prime's ship—the fury that had made her want to tear the universe apart. She'd looked at Adora, enslaved and blazing like a sun behind glass, and seen nothing but the ruin of her own making. Adora, smiling through battle with Shadow Weaver's blood still wet on her sword.

Prime hadn't known the mistake he'd made, allowing Catra to have her. And Catra—Catra had nearly squandered it all. She could've reached out instead of clawing back. She could've chosen compassion over control. But she hadn't.

"I have your word," Catra said finally, voice low, "that you'll see this border war through to the end?"

Adora nodded once.

"Then you have mine. When it's over—when we've won—I'll take off the cuffs and the collar. I'll set you free." The words hit her hard. She felt sick saying them. There was nothing willing about the admission. She wanted to keep her. She wanted to *keep* her so badly it hollowed her out.

"After that," Catra said, forcing coldness into her tone, "we can face each other as equals. Whatever comes next—comes then."

Adora didn't respond. Catra braced herself for that damn smile—for the spark in her eyes when she realized freedom was within reach. But the reaction never came. Adora just… looked at her. Steady. Silent. Like she was waiting for the trap to spring.

Catra felt something inside her twist.

“It’s not a trick,” she said, voice quieter now.

“You’d really let me go,” Adora said—not asking, just *stating*. Her voice was flat, untrusting.

She didn’t believe her.

Of course she didn’t. Adora could look at her like that, could even *want* her, but she didn’t trust her. She couldn’t. Catra had destroyed that, same as everything else.

Catra couldn’t bring herself to answer.

Adora’s tone cooled further. “And until then?”

“Until then,” Catra echoed, her voice almost breaking on the softness of it, “you’re my slave. I’m your princess. That’s how it is.”

That was how it had to be.

And when it ended—when they stood across from each other as enemies or allies again—would Adora remember the way she’d looked at her tonight? Or just the sting of Catra’s claws?

Chapter End Notes

> Yes, Catra calling her Adora in the middle of the night was intentional. Catra is playing with fire a little bit there.
>
> If you want to see any art I draw of this series I am cjowoart on tumblr. There I have links to everything else. My patreon where I post drafts, nsfw (no nsfw catradora, yet) and I was going to start posting previews of chapters as I am working on them as well. Some art I have not posted to chapters are on patreon because they are technically spoilers or just irrelevant to that chapter. I also have bluesky but that's mostly nsfw of bg3, again, not as much catradora there.

Chapter 16

Chapter Notes

> This chapter got so long I had to split it into two. Sorry if I made any mistakes, it's 2am.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra slept later than she meant to, and when she finally woke, the tent was empty.

That part didn't surprise her. What did surprise her was that she'd managed to sleep at all. She hadn't expected to—not after everything that had happened the night before. Not after the things she'd said. Not after *that look* Adora had given her.

She'd gone to bed too aware of her—too aware of the way Adora's hand had brushed her face, the way her eyes had lingered, the way she'd made Catra feel. And as usual, Catra had ruined it.

She'd expected her thoughts to keep her awake. To lie there and pick apart every word Adora hadn't said, every flicker of hesitation. Or, failing that, she thought she'd spend the night running through strategy—the map in her head, Prime's next move, every possible betrayal and countermeasure.

But instead, she'd passed out. Deeply, dreamlessly. And when she opened her eyes again, it was to an empty tent and the faint light of early morning pressing through the canvas.

Adora was already gone. She'd been up, done her duties, and vanished. The tent was tidy, everything in its place: Catra's armor laid out, the basin refilled with clean water, a plate of breakfast waiting beside a pot of coffee that was still warm. Typical Adora—never half-measure, never careless. Always *leaving things better than she found them.*

Catra sighed, sitting down. She poured herself coffee first—priorities—and let the steam rise against her face.

While she ate, she started another letter to Kyle. Another one she'd never send. She told him about the mess she'd gotten herself into, about how she was juggling too many fronts, about Adora—though she didn't name her. Kyle would hate all of it. She could practically hear him whining through the ink.

She pushed her food around the plate. Her nerves were a tangled knot, and Adora wasn't the only thread in it. Prime's messengers had probably reached Talon Mountain by now. He'd know she'd outmaneuvered Sandsmark, and he'd already be planning his next move.

But distance made even Prime's hand slower. Catra had eyes and ears everywhere. Information came to her fast, shifting like sand under her claws. Prime's intel was slower, duller, wrapped in his arrogance. That was her advantage.

Her allies were holding strong, for once. Adora wouldn't turn on her—not anymore. Prime couldn't touch that bond, not even with his lies. Huntara had her own rough brand of loyalty, and Catra trusted that—mostly. The Fright Zone was waiting for her call, and she wouldn't even have to fuck Scorpia to secure it. The Etherians might come next, though that alliance was draining for Catra to think about.

They were hers—her victories, her people, her *work*. Hers *and* Adora's. For once, the ground under her feet felt solid.

Of course, only a fool would believe every spy had been flushed out after the uprising. She knew better. She wasn't stupid enough to think charm alone had won hearts that used to beat for Prime. But Prime would have to do better than whispers this time. He'd have to bring the full weight of the border lords down on her. And she'd be ready.

By the time Catra stepped out into the cool dawn, her camp was only just beginning to stir—soldiers half-dressed, fires struggling to catch. Huntara's camp, on the other hand, was already alive and roaring.

Adora stood among the rough mercenaries and the fire-scorched armor of the Crimson Wastes like a shaft of sunlight in a graveyard—radiant, incongruous, and infuriatingly beautiful. The sudden ache that flared in Catra's chest made her angry enough to pretend she didn't feel it.

She dismissed the guards by Adora with a flick of her fingers. Every step toward Adora felt inevitable. Gravity, as usual, refused to let her go.

When she reached her, Catra said coolly, "I don't remember approving any downtime. You don't have time to find a guy to warm your bed this morning. You should've taken me up on the offer the other night."

Adora blinked, unruffled. "Thanks," she said evenly. "But I didn't come for that. I heard the horses getting restless."

Her tone was flat—too flat. Her face was calm in that infuriatingly *Adora* way that always made Catra doubt herself. For a second, Catra wondered if she'd imagined everything about last night—the touch, the look, the *possibility* that had hung between them.

Catra's tail twitched. "So you *do* prefer men, then?"

Adora's mouth curved just enough to sting. "Mostly, I guess."

That grin hit her like a slap. Catra's claws flexed involuntarily. She wanted to shove her, or hit her, or kiss her, just to wipe that maddeningly calm expression off her face. But she didn't. She schooled her features, pretending the flicker in her chest wasn't there at all.

"I never really saw the appeal," she muttered.

“Yeah, I noticed,” Adora replied, and for a moment her tone softened—fond, teasing, the way it used to be. Then she shifted, straightening her shoulders. “You ready to face Lord Keldor?”

Catra opened her mouth, then shut it again. She had no idea how to tell Adora that the thing tying her in knots wasn’t politics—it was *her*. She’d take a border skirmish over feelings any day. So she just turned, tail swaying behind her, and started walking. Adora fell into step beside her without being asked.

When they neared the edge of their camp, Adora spoke again, voice low.

“I don’t get how Prime’s managed to push you this far back,” she said. “You can outthink him. You’ve done it before.”

The quiet confidence in her voice made something hot bloom in Catra’s chest. For all her pride, Adora’s faith in her meant more than she’d ever admit.

“Maybe it looks that way now,” Catra said, keeping her tone dry, steady. “But when this game started…” She hesitated. “I was a child.”

✧

They left before dawn had finished clawing its way across the sky. The light came slow and gold, spilling over the dunes as they rode toward Talon Mountain. For a while, Catra felt calm—almost steady. Prime was far away, working with incomplete information. She was closer to the ground, sharper, faster. He didn’t know her anymore.

And she had Adora.

These soldiers were *hers*. She repeated it in her mind like a mantra. They were hers. The Crimson Wastes stood with her. She’d built this. She and Adora both. Every alliance, every step forward—earned, not given.

She’d clawed her way to this moment, and she would hold it.

The air grew colder as they crossed the field of talons. When Huntara called for a halt, Catra reined in her horse and lifted her gaze—and the breath froze in her lungs.

The hill ahead was smothered in white and grey.

Columns. Ranks upon ranks of soldiers, the kind of sight that made the ground itself seem to tilt. Her stomach dropped, heavy and hard.

Catra’s mind moved automatically, forcing order over panic. Count them. Break them down. She turned the sea of colorless uniforms into numbers, estimates, logistics. Eight hundred, minimum. Maybe more.

Her pulse pounded, but she stood straighter. Fear could be worn like armor if you knew how to hide the seams.

She’d known Prime would call on the border lords. This wasn’t surprise. Proof that he’d seen her coming.

The detachment from Sandsmark merged into the mass—white upon white, until individuality vanished and all that remained was Prime’s faceless perfection mixed with the local bred Lords.

Her jaw set. “Bring it on, you sanctimonious bastard,” she muttered under her breath.

“They’re flanking us,” Lonnie said, scanning the horizon. Her hand hovered near her weapon, ready. “You think they’ve mistaken us for a target?”

“No,” Catra said flatly.

“There’s still an opening to the west,” Adora added, eyes narrowing against the light. “We could fall back before they close in.”

Catra didn’t even look at her. “No.”

She thought, briefly, of Weave’s Slope—her once-secret contingency. The place she’d planned to vanish to, dig in, and die gloriously defiant if it came to that. A romantic little tragedy. *Prime would have approved*. Then he would probably find another way to defile her body.

When the delegation detached from the mass of soldiers and started toward them, Catra spurred her horse forward. “You two, with me.”

Lonnie fell in at her left; Adora, at her right.

They met the oncoming party halfway. Keldor led the procession. Flanking him wer Double Trouble, and Marzo. A dozen mounted soldiers followed, half of them with that eerie sameness that marked Prime’s clones.

Catra had only her Etherian-born captain and her Etherian slave. And herself.

Keldor didn’t bother with courtesy. “You’ve seen our forces,” he said, tone grand and oily, like a man showing off a weapon—or something far more anatomical. “You’ll come with us.”

“I take it you’ve heard from Prime,” Catra said.

He didn’t answer. Men like Keldor didn’t waste words on women they didn’t consider worth them. Prime had seen to that—his propaganda had stripped Catra of even her title, reduced her to some spoiled upstart clawing at power she didn’t deserve.

“What am actually accused of?” she pressed.

Keldor’s lip curled, tugging at the pale scar that cut through it. “We know you’ve been paying bribes to the Crimson Waste raiders,” he said. True. “We know you're infatuated with the Etherian.” Also true, though Catra doubted she’d been obvious enough for *anyone* to know. “And,” he continued, voice deepening

to the rhythm of accusation, "we know you've conspired with the Wastes to weaken the Horde with raids and border attacks. Sandsmark was one such casualty. You'll be taken to Talon Mountain for trial and execution."

Catra's smile didn't reach her eyes. "Execution," she repeated softly. Her horse shifted beneath her, sensing the tension.

"Can you deny," Keldor said, "that you've sheltered the raiders responsible? That you've coached them to lay the blame on Prime?"

Catra almost laughed. "I can deny anything I want," she said, voice silk over steel. "Especially when you don't have proof."

"Oh," Keldor said smoothly. "She does."

A figure nudged her horse through the line of soldiers, impatiently pushing for space. The effect would've been dramatic if not for the awkward fumbling of reins and boots.

"I have the proof," she said. "I saw everything."

Entrapta.

She threw back her hood with what she clearly thought was flair—her hair bursting free in a cascade of violet coils. It might've been impressive if the moment weren't already so ridiculous. Her armor gleamed too bright, all chrome and polish, the kind nobles wore for parades—not war.

Catra stared at her, incredulous. Entrapta was perched stiffly in her saddle, the picture of a scientist pretending to be a knight.

Perfect.

Of course Prime's "proof" would be her. The girl could dismantle a battleship but couldn't lie to save her life.

Catra's claws flexed against the reins. She wanted to laugh, or throttle her, or maybe both. "Really, Entrapta?" she said under her breath. "You could've at least practiced your entrance."

Entrapta, oblivious, fidgeted with her gauntlet and said brightly, "I, um, wanted to make sure my testimony was accurate!"

Adora stiffened beside Catra, jaw tight. Lonnie muttered something like, "This is bad," and reached for her weapon again.

Keldor, of course, was smiling—slow and smug. "You see," he said. "Even your own turn against you."

Catra met his gaze, unflinching. "Oh, Keldor," she said softly. "You really don't know what it means when I stop playing nice."

If Catra hit Entrapta—just once, clean across that smug face—she was sure the blood would come out Prime's favorite shade of crimson. It would glisten like expensive lip paint, and the irony would be almost poetic. Catra could picture herself smiling as she told Entrapta how *stunning* she looked, dripping in that perfect shade of treachery.

But for now, Catra moved. She yanked her reins sharply, her horse sidestepping into Lonnie's path. "Go back to the troops," she snapped. "Now."

Lonnie hesitated—never a good sign.

"Don't make me say it again."

Any soldier could turn on her. She'd always known that. What she hadn't expected was the knife twisting to come from *within* her own camp.

How long had Entrapta been gone?

How long had Lonnie known—and said nothing?

The thought burned hotter than betrayal should've been able to. Lonnie, who had been welcome unto her tent for planning, who had followed orders without question, who never pushed back when Catra *needed* her to. Adora had always challenged her. Lonnie just... obeyed.

Too good to be useful.

"Now," Catra ordered again. This time, Lonnie went.

Catra waited until she'd disappeared into the ranks before turning her gaze back to Entrapta.

Hatred came easily to her. It was her oldest, most reliable skill. She'd been honing it since she was a young teen, when love had failed to protect her. She looked at Entrapta now and let that hatred bloom in her chest like poison.

"You just made me your enemy," she said softly. The tone wasn't a threat. It was a statement of fact. "And you're not going to enjoy what that means."

Entrapta's mouth twisted. "You sleep with Etherians," she said, her voice sharp and bitter, chin jerking toward Adora. "You let them crawl into your bed."

Catra's fury pulsed like a second heartbeat. "Oh, that's rich," she said. Her voice was low and dangerous. "You mean like you let Lonnie crawl into yours? Or was that Prime's little idea—something extra to make sure you felt owned?"

Entrapta's fingers trembled against her reins. "I don't betray Prime," she said, too quickly. "I'm nothing like you. You hate him. You—you had *feelings* for your mother. Twisted ones."

Ah. There it was.

The missing piece. The rot beneath the armor.

Time slowed. For a heartbeat, everything fell quiet inside Catra—cold and clear and *still*.

Of course. She'd seen it before. The symptoms were familiar: the devotion, the self-loathing, the desperate need to please. Prime's handiwork, carved bone-deep. She should have recognized it sooner.

"At thirteen?" Catra asked. Her voice was a blade's edge of mockery and grief. "Guess I was an early bloomer, like you."

Entrapta flinched—not at the words, but at the truth she saw reflected in Catra's eyes.

Catra didn't hide it. She let the understanding show: *I know what he did to you. I know what you called love. I know how you crawled for him*.

He'd broken Entrapta and taught her to worship him. Just like he'd tried with Catra. And now, Entrapta had passed that poison on to Lonnie.

Well. If she thought she understood pain, she was about to learn new definitions.

Entrapta's color rose hot across her face. "You think you've been clever, but I've been watching you," she said, the words tumbling out in a bitter rush. "All this time, pretending you were in control. You disgust me. I wanted to laugh in your face." She tossed her head sharply, violet hair whipping behind her. "I would have—if it hadn't made me sick to take orders from you."

Catra almost smiled. "Who fucks better, Entrapta?" she murmured, too quiet for anyone else to hear. "Lonnie, or Prime?"

"Enough of this," Keldor said, "You will come with us willingly, Catra... or we'll take you after your soldiers are broken and kneeling."

He smiled, slow and sure, the kind of smile men wear when they think they've already won.

"You have a choice," he said.

Catra almost laughed. She almost said something about Prime and his obsession with "choice"—that empty, gilded word he liked to throw around like it meant mercy. She almost told Keldor to take his sanctimonious face and shove it somewhere dark—

Or better yet, to go let Entrapta crawl all over him, since she seemed to have made that her latest party trick.

But instead, Catra made herself *think*.

"If I give myself up," she said at last, her tone light, almost conversational. "If I walk into Prime's chains willingly... what happens to my soldiers?"

Keldor's expression twisted as if the very act of speaking to her offended his sensibilities. "Your soldiers are innocent of your crimes," he said, in a voice that oozed false generosity. "Their loyalty, though misguided, will be rewarded. They will be disarmed and dismissed. The raiders will be escorted back to the Crimson Wastes."

His smirk deepened. "The Etherian slave, of course—will be executed."

"Of course," Catra echoed.

Her voice didn't waver, but the words clawed their way up her throat like shards of ice. She'd wanted—*for one flicker of a second*—to imagine a way out of this. To just *end it*, to stop the endless, gnawing struggle. But not like that.

Not if it meant losing Adora.

Double Trouble, ever the opportunist, chose that moment to sidle their horse closer to Entrapta's. The actor's voice rang out clear,

dripping with performative outrage. “Prime would never *debase* himself with words like these, so allow me to speak on his behalf.” They threw a dramatic hand to their chest. “Out of respect for your mother’s memory, Prime has shown you mercy beyond reason. And how have you repaid him?”

They leaned forward, eyes glittering. “With mockery. With arrogance. With utter contempt. You’ve spat on his generosity and dragged his name through the mud.” They turned to the gathered soldiers, voice rising to a stage-perfect crescendo. “And now you dare to play the victim, when your greed and vanity have led you here?”

Catra’s lip curled. “Prime’s ‘generosity,’ huh? Yeah—trust me, it was *memorable*.”

Double Trouble’s smile faltered for half a heartbeat. “You're not even sorry,” they snapped, breaking character just long enough to reveal the irritation beneath.

Catra tilted her head, squinting at the sun. She’d stalled long enough. Time to make her move.

“Speaking of arrogance,” she said.

She lifted one gloved hand. From behind her, two of Huntara’s guards rode forward.

Catra could feel Adora’s eyes on her back, wary, questioning. But the game had already started. There was no stopping it now.

“I believe I’ve got something of yours,” Catra said sweetly. “I’d scold you for your carelessness, but I’ve just had a crash course in how easily trash wanders from one camp to another.”

She turned slightly in her saddle and spoke in the Wastes’s dialect. “Drop the garbage here,” she ordered. “Before these pigs decide to rut on it and scare the horses.”

The guards obeyed.

A prisoner hit the dirt—bound, gagged, and half-conscious. Catra didn't even look down. She was watching them.

Double Trouble puffed up again, trying to reassert the spotlight. "If you think some pitiful hostage ploy will spare you from Prime's judgment, you're deluding yourself," they said, their voice just a little too high, too brittle. "You'll get what's coming to you, Catra."

Catra smirked. "I usually do."

Marzo was the only one sharp enough to actually look at the man on the ground. "It's one of ours," he said after a pause.

Catra clicked her tongue. "Try four," she corrected lightly. "You're losing track of your toys."

Keldor turned to his captain, brow furrowing. "Why wasn't I informed?"

"The reports are delayed," Marzo said. "The terrain's been—"

"—broad. Yes, I've heard the excuses." Catra chimed in.

One of Keldor's soldiers dismounted, moving to cut the scout free. The man's voice broke the tension before his hands were even steady.

"Commander—there's a force moving north!" he gasped. "Riders—hundreds—heading this way, to intercept you at the Talons—!"

"This *is* the Talons," Double Trouble snapped, rolling their eyes.

Catra ignored them. Her gaze slid to Entrapta instead. The scientist's face was pale. Catra smiled and blew her a kiss.

Entrapta flinched as though she'd been struck.

Oh, how Catra wished she had been.

"What force?" Entrapta demanded, her voice cracking under the pressure.

Keldor gave a disdainful snort. “A rabble of scavengers and misfit clans, perhaps. Or some of Etheria’s more *mercenary* strays. Hardly worth the ink of a report.”

Catra’s grin widened. “You’d *like* that, wouldn’t you?” she said softly. “To think it’s just another mob.”

“—carrying the princess’s red banners,” the scout rasped, clutching desperately at Marzo’s armor, voice breaking under exhaustion. “Marching beside the black of Scorpion Hill.”

On the field of the Talons, beneath a pitiless stretch of sun-bleached sky, *Keldor, Double Trouble*, and the rest of Prime’s faithful sycophants faced their “Crown Princess” with eight hundred mounted soldiers arrayed like a wall of polished blades—and dared to accuse *her* of treason against the very empire she had been promised.

The audacity was breathtaking. Even for them.

The sheer number of troops told her everything she needed to know. Prime hadn’t sent this army to *defeat* her—he’d sent it to *humiliate* her. To drag her through the dirt, parade her downfall, and call it justice. That was always his favorite part.

And Entrapta’s betrayal? Not even surprising. Prime’s tastes were predictable once you learned them. He liked minds he could bend and break until they believed obedience was affection. Entrapta fit the mold too easily.

Catra knew there was at least one more traitor slinking about. There always was.

She’d been right about Prime’s game. Right about which pawns he’d play. Right about the place—this wide, open valley of grey earth and pale dust. The perfect stage. She’d even predicted how Keldor would set his forces.

A low, rolling bellow carried from the north—the sound of *Crimson Wastes* steel. A moment later, the call of *Scorpion Hill* rang back,

darker and deeper.

For a heartbeat, no one moved. Then the ranks around Catra began to stir—soldiers craning their necks, straining to see past the heat shimmer on the horizon. Engineers ducked out of half-tanks. Even Entrapta, ever the twitchy genius, couldn't keep up her calm façade. Her fingers flexed compulsively at her reins, her hair twitching in nervous arcs behind her. The confidence had drained from her face, replaced by something small and sharp and *scared*.

Catra didn't bother turning toward the sound. She didn't need to look. She knew what was coming.

Her eyes stayed fixed on Keldor.

"I have a choice?" she asked. The words dripped with mockery—echoing his earlier sermon back at him.

Keldor's mouth tightened, but she didn't give him a chance to answer.

"Tell me," she went on, purring now, "did you really think if you threw down your pompous little gauntlet, I wouldn't challenge you?"

There had been a time—back on the flagship—when she might have surrendered. When she had thought there was no way to win. When all she wanted was to take as many of Prime's monsters down with her as she could before she fell.

But that Catra was gone.

This one had *learned*.

And this one still wanted to watch something burn.

"My scorn," she said, smiling faintly, "doesn't require your leniency."

Her voice dropped, hardening. "Lord Keldor—" she made the title sound like filth, "—you stand on *my* soil. You breathe *my* air. Every soldier here lives at *my* pleasure. So if you want to play the loyal dog, go ahead. But understand—this is my kingdom. And you only leave it if I let you."

Entrapta had gone blotchy red beneath her pale skin. "Attack!" she shrieked suddenly. Her voice shook with panic as she looked wildly between Keldor and Double Trouble. "Attack her, *now*! Before they reach us! You don't understand—she always—she always finds a way to twist things!"

Catra's claws flexed against the leather of her gloves. *I'll twist your neck*, she thought viciously. Her pulse thrummed with it. The ache to strike.

Double Trouble leaned back in their saddle, one perfectly arched brow lifting as if amused by Entrapta's meltdown. "Oh, sweetie," they murmured, voice rich with sarcasm. "You really should've rehearsed this panic attack in front of a mirror first."

Keldor took his time. His gaze was fixed on Catra now. For the first time in his life, he wasn't seeing a half-feral orphan dragged up from the gutters. He was seeing an equal. Maybe even a threat.

Catra hoped the realization hurt.

At last, Keldor spoke, his voice cool and almost kind. "Your Highness, I have my orders," he said, each word deliberate, smooth as oil. "From Prime himself. I am not at liberty to disobey."

He said it as though they were strangers meeting at court. As though he hadn't known her since she'd been small enough to fit under a table.

Catra's smile cracked into something sharper. "This isn't even his planet," she snapped. "I was *born* here."

And in that moment, with the sun painting the dust a muddy green-gold and the horns still echoing across the field, Catra looked every inch the predator Prime had tried to tame—and failed.

Keldor's frown deepened as he counted his options like a man counting coins. "I need time to consider," he said at last, slow and theatrical. "And to consult my advisor. One hour."

"Go." Catra's answer was a single, cold syllable.

The moment the envoy trotted away, the air between them unclenched. Catra exhaled once and turned straight to Adora.

"You'll take the troop," she said, no preamble. The oddness from earlier evaporated under necessity. She needed the solid thing in the middle of the storm—Adora, steady and honest. "Captain—take command from Lonnie. It should've been yours from the beginning." She stopped herself before she could say more: I need you. I need She-Ra. She swallowed the plea down and breathed another, steadier breath. "He's going to proceed."

"He seemed unsure," Adora said.

"Double Trouble will egg him on," Catra said, nodding. "They pick winners the instant it's convenient. They'll bait Keldor into fighting whether he wants to or not." She met Adora's eyes hard. I need the Mage-slayer, she thought without speaking. I need She-Ra. Can you give her to me today?

That confession would derail them both.

"So advise me, Captain," Catra finished instead, forcing the businesslike tone. "We've mapped this a hundred ways. In the field you've been better than me. Tell me what to do."

✧

She swapped her mount for a skiff—lighter, more maneuverable, less to worry about in a scrap—and rode to stand beside Adora

where the men were gathering.

They gave the troop its orders together. Shouts of “For the Princess!” rose, rough and proud, and something like heat uncoiled in Catra’s chest. Huntara’s clan would only send two riders into the battle proper; Catra accepted their terms, letting them claim the horses of anyone they felled.

Adora agreed Lonnie should stay in the chain of command; Catra didn’t argue. Not a single soldier grumbled when the Etherian took the captain’s role. It was quiet confirmation that whatever this was between Catra and Adora, it didn’t weaken their authority in the ranks.

Catra didn’t have time to dwell on it, but she kept noticing how Adora’s face steeled as she looked over the field.

When she couldn’t dodge the moment any longer, Catra edged her skiff up beside Adora’s. Choosing words took longer than she expected.

“Keldor’s men have cracks,” she said finally, soft but direct. “The fact I was born in the Fright Zone matters here. It matters to a lot of these clans.” She watched Adora’s face; the Etherian didn’t look at her, but Catra forced herself on. “A captain’s work is the prep you do before the first horn. You’ve been my captain in the long hours. You taught us to hold and to break.”

“Frills don’t win fights,” Adora answered gruffly, still not meeting Catra’s eyes. “A solid line does.”

“It wouldn’t have been my plan.” Catra let that hang, then moved on. “I have an order for you: make it a clean win, and avoid a rout. Quick, decisive—minimal losses.” She repeated a phrase Adora had used earlier to remind them both of the target. “When we punch into their lines, find the leaders. I’ll go for Double Trouble. If you get there first—kill Keldor.”

Adora’s head snapped up. “What?”

Catra kept her face steady, the words flat and stripped of pleading. “Why fight an entire army when you can take its head? Etherian way, right? Cut off command, and the body collapses. Do it cleanly.”

Adora stared as if Catra had asked the stars to fall. The look felt like a test Catra hadn’t meant to give.

“You won’t have to hunt them down,” Adora said finally. “They’ll come for you.”

“Then it will be swift,” Catra said. She forced herself to push on, the promise tasting both hollow and holy. “If we sleep in Talon Mountain tonight, I’ll take the collar off your neck in the morning.” She almost added *and then maybe we talk*, but she swallowed it. “This is the fight you came for.”

Chapter End Notes

I want to be clear: I love Entrapta, I relate to Entrapta, I feel physical discomfort writing scenes where Entrapta is being threatened or mistreated. But the plot needs this okay 🥲

It won't be for long

Chapter 17: (Chapter 16, part 2)

Chapter Notes

> Due to the fact I split chapter 16 into 2 parts, Adora's next chapter will be one chapter later than the existing pattern.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She could tell it didn't surprise Adora when Keldor broke parlay. She saw it—the flicker in her eyes, the tightening of her mouth. That look—disgust, disappointment, judgment—Catra knew it like an old wound. The same expression Adora had worn back on the Flagship, staring at the her as though she'd never seen anything so rotten. The Horde: Prime's perfect little empire of hypocrites and monsters.

Adora didn't flinch. The troop was already in motion, perfectly drilled. Catra watched her issue commands—short, clipped, decisive. "Hold the line!" Her voice carried through their comms, steadying the chaos before it could even begin. She'd been ready for this the whole time.

And then the world came apart.

Catra had thought she remembered the sound of two armies colliding. She'd been wrong. The noise was an earthquake made flesh—metal shattering against metal, horses screaming, engines roaring, voices breaking under the weight of war. The air itself trembled.

And Adora—Adora changed.

The woman beside her wasn't the soldier who'd spent weeks looking over maps by lantern light. This was something else entirely. When she moved, it was with an impossible clarity, every swing and strike a clean, lethal truth. She was unstoppable, devastating, radiant in her violence. The battlefield bent around her like it recognized its master.

Catra had seen She-Ra before, but this wasn't her. This was just Adora. No sword glowing with divine light, no transformation. Just Adora—the girl who she was slowly falling for—now wading through blood and smoke like she'd been born to it.

It should have been terrifying. Instead, Catra felt something dangerously close to awe.

If she had any faith in magic, she might have called it that—the way Adora gracefully navigated the battlefield.

But there wasn't time for wonder. Not here. Not now. Catra's world narrowed to the rhythm of her own breath, the crash of steel, the way her blade found the weak points between armor plates. She didn't let herself think about what it meant to kill. She didn't let herself think about anything at all. Disassociation was a familiar comfort—it kept her alive.

Keldor's lines began to crumble. Orders shouted across the chaos, horns blared, the signal to regroup. Adora countered instantly, rallying their troops tighter around them. Catra followed her lead without hesitation. It felt… natural.

A second wave hit—the distinctive red-and-black of Scorpia's forces slamming into Keldor's flank. Catra's troops surged forward.

Some idiot missed his mark and struck her skiff's side instead of her. Catra turned and, with practiced precision, cut him down—first the sword arm, then the rest. She didn't think about the horse that went down beside her, or the sound it made. Not now. Those nightmares could wait their turn.

Then Marzo came for her.

"To the Princess!" Adora's voice cut through the din, fierce and commanding. Catra could hear the soldiers moving around her, shifting formation to keep Catra protected as she dueled her own opponents.

Marzo was tall, broad-shouldered, his armor marked with Keldor's sigil. Catra remembered him—how he'd blocked her at the hall, how his gaze had lingered on Adora. "I don't invite them indoors," he'd said.

Now he had a blade in his hand and orders to bring her down.

"You'll do," Catra said coolly.

He inclined his head, mockingly polite, before striking.

Their swords met with a crash.

Marzo had reach and muscle, but Catra had speed and cunning. She slipped under his guard, forcing him to fight her on her terms—close, fast, ruthless.

Catra could see the calculation in Marzo's eyes. He didn't want her dead—just broken. Captured. A gift for Prime.

She smiled.

"Try it," she hissed.

If Prime wanted her delivered in chains, he'd have to dig her out of the bodies himself.

It was also fortunate, then, that Catra rode a skiff and not a horse. Marzo reared in his stirrups, long sword arcing down with the weight and angle of a man who expected to finish the fight in one clean stroke. If that blade had landed on Catra's shoulder or temple she'd have been on the ground in an instant.

She didn't meet it. The motion was a feint – a breath, a tiny shift – and at the last possible second Catra twisted the skiff away just enough for the blow to miss. Marzo, committed to the strike, was left off–balance: heavy in his saddle, his warhorse slow to right itself, the reins the only thing keeping him from pitching forward.

Catra took the space she'd carved out and drove. Her skiff surged, a low, brutal charge that hit the flank of Marzo's mount like a battering ram. The horse staggered; for a single hot second rider and steed lost rhythm. Catra used every ounce of leverage she had and slammed her blade into the man's back with all her fury. Marzo folded, clattering from the saddle in a chaotic, graceless heap.

Warhorses screamed and tangled around them—hot, terrified, trained animals turning vicious in the crush. Catra looped her skiff around to face Marzo. When Marzo hit the dirt she slapped his horse with one quick hand as if dismissing a dog; the gesture sent his mount galloping back into the fray.

Marzo scrambled up, face white with shock, then anger. Catra met Marzo on the ground at his level but didn't move in. She'd been taught to wait. Shadow Weaver would have waited. She had been schooled to let courtesy govern the pause. She let him gather himself, watching the theatre of battle spin and howl around them. Somewhere to her left Adora's voice rang out; she was deep in combat with Keldor.

When Marzo finally steadied, he came on again—this time not clumsy or cruel, but as a trained commander should. He wasn't the brutish fool Govart had been; he was a professional, tempered by campaigns and obedience. His strikes were precise, the pattern of his swordsmanship deliberately unfamiliar enough to be hard to read at first. Catra's eyes narrowed; lessons in border fighting had given her an unexpected advantage. The stance read, the rhythm clicked into place.

"This is a battle, not a tea party, girl," Marzo said, "If you shy from a real man's blade, you should have yielded when you had the chance. It is cowardice to ask soldiers to die for a child who shirks the fight."

Catra let his blade slide along hers, deflecting with a sharp, casual touch. She toyed with him—no need to overcommit, no need to let him feel formidable. He was not Govart; he had strength and

pride and the patience of a seasoned fighter. She matched him, but on her terms.

"Girl. Child," Catra said, tasting the words like bile. "Those are not my titles." Her blade whispered across his. There was no aim to maim—only control.

Marzo's jaw tightened. "I see no Princess. Certainly not a Queen."

"You will," Catra answered, voice flat, eyes cold as a blade. "When my Etherian kills your Lord you'll beg me for mercy, and then you'll understand you've already lost."

The words landed before she let him close in for the mortal strike. He lunged; her parry and riposte were clean, the steel singing as it bit flesh. Marzo's sword clattered to the ground. He crumpled, stunned, knees buckling beneath him as the shock of defeat registered in his face.

Someone hauled Catra's skiff over to her and she jumped back on with ease. On the outside she was composed—controlled, almost bored. Inside, something like glee hummed: her blade finding purchase in Marzo's side, the deadening look in his eyes as he fell. It was victory and she let herself savour it for the smallest fraction of time before the battle swallowed them both again.

The tremble in his voice when he surrendered made Catra's grin sharper.

"Hail to the princess!" Marzo's soldiers cried, their voices cracking and uncertain, yet somehow fierce enough to carry across the field. Catra's eyes swept over the battlefield, searching for Adora. She found her: astride a horse she barely recognized, muscles coiled, yellow hair plastered to her forehead with sweat, every inch of her radiating controlled intensity. Their gazes met briefly, and for a heartbeat, Catra saw something unreadable in her eyes —

Later, there would be time for that.

“Half an hour,” she ordered over the comms. “We depart for Talon Mountain in half an hour. Move the troops, tend the wounded.”

The field was a mess. The clone medics and the Patran physicians would have their hands full. Wounded littered the ground from both sides, and Keldor’s arrogance had ensured no medics accompanied him. Double Trouble had vanished, as expected—they always ran first—but no one had fled toward Talon Mountain. Huntara’s clan, though mostly spectators, had dispatched outriders to ensure the fort received no warning of the outcome. Catra allowed herself the tiniest smirk. Order had its rewards.

Then a familiar voice cut through the din.

“Your Highness, I have a gift for you.”

Clone 28 jogged up, unnervingly casual for someone who had just openly betrayed his maker, giving her a bold, cocky grin.

“I know you’re busy,” he continued, “but this is a very nice gift. I promise.”

Catra raised an eyebrow. “I won’t go with you alone.”

“Fair enough,” Clone 28 said easily. “I’m surprised I wasn’t the traitor too. Bring whoever you like—except Lonnie.”

The pieces clicked. Catra’s expression sharpened. She would go alone.

✧

The tent was empty but for one occupant. Entrapta sat bound, arms and legs trussed like a roast pig, gagged, filthy, and furious. Clone 28 lingered for a moment, clearly debating whether to comment, then shrugged.

“Never liked the little bitch,” he muttered, catching himself. “Er… your highness. Anyway, I haven’t told anyone else yet. If you

wanted to interrogate her alone… well, I might not remember how badly I injured her when I brought her in."

Catra's eyes narrowed. She surveyed Entrapta, the way one might examine a particularly large bug before deciding whether to crush it.

"I'll be outside," Clone 28 said, sensing the shift.

Catra breathed out a slow sigh. "What a day," she murmured, stepping across the worn, colorful carpets toward Entrapta. She lowered herself to the ground, close enough that her fingers brushed a few of the violet curls sticking up from where they'd matted with blood.

"Shall we chat?" she asked softly, deliberately. "Do you have something to say for yourself now?"

A string of nonsensical noises was all that met her. Catra arched a brow and gestured, imperious. Speak.

Entrapta thrashed, twisted, red-faced, but she was trapped. Catra let her fumble until frustration bubbled. Then, with mock enlightenment, she plucked the gag free.

"What was that?" Catra asked, voice honeyed and sharp.

"I don't have anything to say to you now!" Entrapta snapped, jerking her head. "You want to be my friend?"

"Oh, darling," Catra said, tracing a finger through a curl, "you know I want nothing of the sort."

"Fuck you," Entrapta hissed.

"You're not *my* type. Thank you anyway."

"You're… a deviant! Disgusting! I hate you! You fucked your mother, you tried to seduce Prime, and now you bend over for Bright Moon! Whore! Vile, filthy whore!"

Catra's grin deepened. The sharp tang of anger and fear in Entrapta's voice was… amusing. She twined a stray curl around her finger. "It's funny," she murmured, "how often that second rumor is left out of the story. You're not supposed to tell anyone that one, are you? Prime hates it when anyone leaves him open to questions. Funny how that works. Fortunately, some things remain difficult to convince others of."

Entrapta flushed scarlet, her wrists bruising against the tied knots. Catra leaned in, close enough to smell the tang of sweat and blood, and let a slow, deliberate silence hang. In the quiet, the only sound was Entrapta's shallow, angry breaths.

"You lured him," Entrapta spat, trembling with fury. "You *dangled yourself* like a prize, and he…he fell for it. A moment of weakness —that's all it was!"

Catra let a slow smile creep across her face, tilting her head. "Isn't it funny how he brags to all his little toys about it, yet somehow no one else hears? No one else even considers the possibility. I guess he knows how to make you pity him first—so you *almost* forget when he gets what he wants."

Entrapta's cheeks flushed, her hands straining against the bindings. "He kills anyone who talks! And you—you—" She shuddered violently. "I can't believe you let him—"

Catra's hand slid through her purple hair with calculated calm, ignoring the bleeding scrapes along her temple. "I've seen uglier things than his sorry little self." Her voice dropped low, almost a purr. "I thought nothing could be more pathetic… until I saw you squirming like this."

"You weren't even any *good*! He told me himself. Said it wasn't worth the trouble, that your face, your body—it was all wasted. You'd never learn. That's why you seek out anyone who shows you the slightest kindness or love. Because no one else will ever touch you." Entrapta's words came fast, sharp, desperate.

Catra hummed, tugging the gag back into place. The cloth cut across Entrapta's split lip, reopening it slightly. "Enough," she said softly. "I have work to do. But congratulations—you got your wish. You're my guest of honor now. You'll be seeing plenty of me."

Entrapta thrashed uselessly, muffled curses spilling out. Catra ignored it, brushing a hand over her hair with casual tenderness.

Outside, Clone 28 stood at rigid attention, the perfect image of a Horde clone: eerily loyal, expressionless.

"Your Highness," he said, voice clipped. "Shall I report?"

"She's secure. That's enough for now," Catra replied. Her eyes flicked toward the tent flap. "Nothing else matters."

Clone 28 inclined his head and fell back into the shadows.

✧

Adora was waiting near the command tent, arms crossed and eyes sharp. She didn't bother greeting Catra. "This…this is wrong," she said, every syllable clipped. "What you're planning—it's dishonorable."

Catra gave a mock sigh. "Oh, *really*? That's your take?"

"Yes! Cowardly—completely beneath you."

Catra let her pace, circling like a predator amused by its prey's moral outrage. "I've been called worse and survived. And I'll survive this, too. But please—don't let your righteous fury slow us down. We have a battle to win."

"My mother would haunt me if he knew I went along with this," Adora muttered.

Catra tilted her head, smirk twitching at the corner of her lips. "Maybe it's time she learns you're not a child anymore."

Adora growled, but didn’t argue further. She had no choice but to fetch Marzo.

✧

When Catra entered the tent, Marzo was on his feet, still bleeding, stubbornly upright. She assessed him without a word. The wound wasn’t fatal, unless he kept reopening it—or refused care. Catra didn’t mind.

“Kneel,” she said.

He hesitated for the briefest second, then obeyed. Armor clanked, the sound sharp in the quiet tent.

“Your Highness,” he began.

Catra cut him off. “What happened to girl or child? I was hoping we could have that tea party.”

Marzo blinked, caught off guard, and lowered his gaze. “I served Lord Keldor for ten years. Double Trouble acted under his authority—and Prime’s.”

Catra’s tone sharpened, cool as steel. “Double Trouble has no say over my succession. Only Prime, and that won't be an issue much longer. We ride for Talon Mountain. You’re alive because I *chose* it. And when you finally see my Prime for what he is… I’ll expect your loyalty.”

Marzo swallowed hard, silent, head bowed.

Catra tucked her helm under her arm, brushing dust from her gloves. “Try not to bleed out before we reach Talon Mountain,” she said lightly. “It would be inconvenient.”

Marzo looked up—though not at Catra. His eyes sought Adora instead.

Adora straightened, crossing her arms, her expression hard. She met his stare head-on. Even now, Marzo dismissed Catra entirely, as if she were a petulant girl playing at command while the Etherian at her side carried the real weight of authority.

That's right, Catra thought darkly. Just a mindless little kitten, batting at the world because I don't know better. Pretty to look at, easy to dismiss. Never mind that I almost left the battlefield dragging your head behind me like a prize.

She flicked her wrist, snapping her fingers near his ear once, twice, then again, closer each time until he startled and turned his attention back to her.

"Better," Catra purred, lips curling into a sweet, smile. "I remember—you don't like her. She killed your Lord for me." Her voice dipped. "And now? You deal with *me,* not her. Try to keep up."

Marzo's lip curled, the barest twitch of contempt. "You'll never breach Talon Mountain." His tone was measured, disinterested, as if addressing a spoiled noble child whose tantrums bored him. Catra's title meant nothing to him; her victory less. A fluke, not worth respect. "Double Trouble broke through your lines with their escort. They ride for Talon Mountain even now, to warn them you're coming."

His flat stare said the rest: *You're a fool. A child, just as Prime says. Stop wasting soldier's lives to play with your pet. Give up.*

Catra's smile didn't falter. "No," she said softly. "They're not going to Talon Mountain. They're running to Hell's Rest. Nursing thier wounds, praying I'm too busy to force them to choose between loyalty and survival."

The thought clearly hadn't occurred to him. Marzo blinked, thrown off balance for the first time. The idea that one of his own could choose cowardice seemed incomprehensible.

"You're lying," he said at last.

Catra leaned forward. “Am I?”

Marzo squared his shoulders, chin high even in restraint. “Why would they run, when they have a chance to crush you here?”

“Because,” Catra said, smiling faintly, “I have their pet princess.”

That made him look at her—*really* look. Their gazes locked, the world narrowing to a single point between them. Catra met him evenly, her eyes cold.

“Yes,” she continued, voice low. “Entrapta. Trussed up, tied down, and still finding new ways to insult me.”

Marzo froze. Then, slowly, he inclined his head—not in respect, but in reassessment. For the first time, he spoke to her as if she were something more than a brat in armor. “So,” he said in a measured tone, “you need me to get inside Talon Mountain. That’s why I’m alive. You expect me to betray those I’ve served for ten years.”

The disgust in his voice was palpable. But Catra had weathered worse. Adora could glare daggers more effectively than anyone alive, and she was doing it now—jaw tight, fists balled at her sides—but Catra ignored her.

“To get inside Talon Mountain?” Catra laughed softly, the sound half amusement, half threat. She flicked her eyes toward Adora, who was too busy glaring at Marzo to notice the faint, teasing grin Catra aimed her way. Then she looked back at the prisoner. “Oh, no, Marzo. You misunderstand.” Her tone turned almost gentle. “I don’t need you.” She paused, savoring the tension. “I just need your clothes.”

Marzo stiffened, the blood draining from his face. He didn’t resist as two soldiers stepped forward and hauled him to his feet, but his jaw clenched tight.

“My original plan,” Catra mused, tone conversational, “was to do this in front of the whole camp.” A third soldier moved in,

beginning to undo the clasps of Marzo's armor. His motions were impersonal. "I thought a little humiliation might motivate you. Maybe let the Crimson Wastes' soldier strip you bare and chase you with blunted spears. It'd make a fine show."

Her gaze flicked up. "But I decided to be merciful. For once. We're also short on time."

Marzo's lip curled again. "Should I consider it mercy," he hissed, "that I'm not stripped by the filthy hands of your slave?"

Catra's expression went blank. She closed the distance between them in a heartbeat and slapped him across the face.

"That *woman*," Catra said evenly, "is the personal slave of the Princess of the Horde—and the captain of the army that just beat you into the dirt." Her voice dripped with false sweetness as she leaned in close enough for him to smell blood and dust on her breath. "But please—go on. Tell me again how shameful it would be to be touched by *her*."

Marzo turned his head, spitting a thin line of blood across the dust-streaked ground. This time, he stayed silent—wisdom, perhaps, finally nudging aside stubborn pride. Adora, accepting the scraps of armor as they were stripped from him, gave Catra a look that was impossible to read. Catra had enough of her looks of disgust for today. A forceful attack would not win them an impenetrable fort. This was the only fucking way.

"Are you going to be precious and demand privacy?" Catra asked.

"Not at all," Adora replied smoothly in First Ones, tilting her head.

Catra's eyes swept over her, slow and appraising. "I've an army to move. See to yourself."

✧

When they dragged Marzo out into the midday glare, dressed in one of Adora's plainest suits, Catra's dry voice cut across the

murmurs of the men.

“You see?” she said, almost conversationally. “My kindness knows no bounds.” She bobbed her hands mockingly, but Marzo refused to join the farce. His scowl did little to dampen the soldiers’ laughter as they hoisted him into a saddle and secured him in place.

“You’d think a man would be grateful for not being paraded naked,” Clone 17 muttered, fidgeting with the feather in his borrowed helm, which drooped heavily over his eyes in the heat.

“Some men struggle with gratitude as a general concept,” Catra observed, passing by him. Clone 17 jumped half out of his skin, caught off guard by her proximity.

When Catra swung into her saddle, a sea of grey stretched out before her. Her men wore the garish, overbearing colors of her uncle’s army, a reminder of the chains she was dismantling. She drew a slow breath. Adora slid up silently beside her.

“You will not change my mind,” Catra warned Adora softly. She didn’t need to fight over it again; the Etherian would not waver.

“I’m resigned to that now,” Adora said evenly.

“Talon Mountain matters more to me than a slave’s notions of honor,” Catra replied, her lips curling faintly.

“The traditional forms of warfare exist to give the other side a chance,” Adora reminded her, though the familiar edge of disappointment didn’t fully vanish.

Catra’s grin was sharp, mischievous, and utterly confident. “I'm not interested in giving them a chance, Mara” she said.

Adora didn’t flinch, but she didn’t falter either. Marzo’s gaze lingered, stiff and displeased, as Catra watched him maneuver his horse to begin the march. Her eyes traced the tight coil of Adora's shoulders under the borrowed armor.

Catra forced herself to focus. She couldn't afford to dwell on Adora of Bright Moon, no matter how tempting the thought.

The fortress waited. The prize waited. And she had an impenetrable path to carve through it.

✧

From a distance, they looked every bit the part they claimed to be.

The first set of gates swung open for them without question. No hesitation, no challenge.

At the second gate, the guards exchanged a quick series of signals. A banner waved; Adora gave the slightest nod. Someone—perhaps Clone 28; it was hard to track with all the unfamiliar helms—waved back. The second gate creaked and began to lift.

They passed through into the courtyard, quiet and controlled. Catra positioned herself toward the middle of the front, where her orders could reach the small troop. The soldiers instinctively parted for her. She could feel Adora's gaze sweeping over her.

Catra had not traded a bit of her red for a shred of white and grey . The only thing discarded was the helm. She wanted Talon Mountain to know it was her, to feel her presence, to understand exactly whose power they were witnessing. Her horse moved smoothly beneath her, her soldiers following. Keldor's banners were torn and trampled under their hooves.

Adora's voice rang across the courtyard, bright and cutting, impossible to ignore.

"Lady Keldor has been defeated at the Talons. Talon Mountain is now under the protection of the Crown Princess."

The fighting inside the mountain had been sharp and merciless—and then it was over. Swift. Bloody. And somehow, impossibly, Talon Mountain was theirs.

Catra had anticipated escalation. She had mapped Keldor's moves in her head, guessed at his strategies for years. But she had never, in any scenario, imagined success like this.

Not at this scale.

Not with this certainty.

She had wanted to win, yes—but in her private imaginings of victory, she had always envisioned retreating to Weave's Slope with a handful of loyal soldiers. Perhaps Lonnie and Rogelio, maybe one or two others. At her most cowardly, she imagined selling herself to Scorpion Hill, giving up everything for a few more miserable years of survival.

She had never dreamed she would actually *take Talon Mountain*.

The moment of victory hit like a tidal wave. The celebration was intoxicating. Catra wasn't certain she could have held her soldiers back if she had tried; she didn't even want to. They were dancing, they had someone strumming music, they poured wine into the fountain. They had been a chaotic, disorganized disaster, incapable of even digging a proper latrine, yet now they ruled a fortress. Their arrogance felt earned.

Adora, however, did not celebrate.

Adora stood apart, surveying the aftermath with the same sharp focus she brought to every plan, every maneuver. Her eyes were cold, commanding. Noone dared to argue when her Captain moved among them, ordering the drunk and the frightened alike into their proper places—man the gates, check the inventories, calm the terrified residents in private quarters.

She ensured Keldor's nephew was properly secured as a hostage. She oversaw wall defenses, coordinated patrols. Catra watched from a distance, restraining the urge to micromanage, to cling, to shadow every motion. It was over. Adora had the fortress in her hands. Catra would not be needed here, and in truth, he had never felt more useless—and more alive—at the same time.

Still, she replayed her plan in her mind. In the morning, Adora would be freed. Formally. In front of the troops, if she was strong enough to make it official. Adora deserved that moment. Their outriders would be arriving shortly, bringing the Etherian forces safely.

There would be delays. A day, maybe more. Timing would need to be exact. One didn't just stroll into a fortress expecting a formerly imprisoned Queen to greet them like an old friend. Catra knew Mermista would arrive, but she would have other priorities. Other Princesses would need consultation. Plans would need to be formed for Glimmer and her strange allegiance with Prime.

But Mermista and her soldiers would help Catra. Adora would insist. And Catra knew she would not be denied.

Catra's attention shifted back to the courtyard. She snatched a passing servant by the arm.

"You," she said, sharp. "I require an attendant."

"But I've been sent for more—!" the boy began, only to realize belatedly who he was addressing. His face flushed crimson.

"Yes, your highness. Of course," he stammered, his voice trembling.

Catra released him, letting the boy scurry off, and allowed herself a moment to soak in the sight of Talon Mountain finally under control—hers, Adora's, theirs. Victory. At last.

Chapter End Notes

I recently learned that Prime's Flagship is called the "Velvet Glove" and that sounds like something fucked you'd find on

Urban Dictionary, so I will not be using that. "Prime’s Falgship" will do.

Also. I have some nsfw art of Catra and Adora and I want guage the reception of putting that in the appropriate upcoming chapter. Otherwise it'll go on Patreon.

Chapter 18

Chapter Notes

> Someone commented that they pictured Etherian/First Ones sounding like French. So enjoy what I made of that for this chapter. I absolutely used one of the songs from the playlist for this chapter. Also updated the playlist.
>
> 😘 Enjoy 😉
>
> As always, let me know if I've fucked up and had anyone refer to Adora as Adora in conversation.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra lasted longer than she thought she would before she broke down and sent for Adora.

The servant trying to help her out of her armor was hopeless—all fumbling fingers and nervous glances, as if touching a clasp wrong might get him gutted. His hands shook so much he nearly dropped a pauldron, and the sound of metal scraping over stone was enough to set Catra's teeth on edge.

She could feel her patience thinning, her temper winding tight. By the time another servant arrived with her coffee and a stack of battle reports, the first was still struggling with a strap.

"I need Mara," Catra snapped.

The second servant froze mid-step, blinking at her.

"But, your highness—"

"I *need* her," Catra bit out, voice sharp as the edge of her gauntlet. "Now. Go."

The first servant jumped when the door opened again. Catra didn't turn right away, didn't want to give herself away—but her ears twitched before her head did. She knew that footstep.

When she finally looked, Adora was there. Standing in the doorway.

Catra hadn't expected the heat that shot up behind her eyes, like she might actually cry—gods forbid—over *this*.

I wanted to talk about tomorrow, she'd meant to say. Calm. Detached. She'd practiced it.

Instead, what came out was, "How do you like my fort?"

Adora's lips quirked, soft and fond in that maddeningly sincere way of hers. "I like it," she said, and she was looking at Catra—really *looking* at her. "Wouldn't mind seeing you with a few more like it. Maybe to the west."

She was still wearing Prime's dull grays. It made Catra's fur bristle. She hated it—hated seeing Adora wrapped in someone else's colors. Hated the reminder that soon she'd be gone, back to her own people.

Catra crossed her arms, mostly to keep her hands from shaking. "Good thing you fit so well into Marzo's armor," she said, voice casual. She didn't trust herself to say anything else.

Adora smirked, tilting her head. "Oh, please. You just like that I fill it out better. Whatever happened to Double Trouble out there?"

Catra scoffed. "You wiped the field before I even got there. You tell me."

Adora's grin was warm, disarming. "Guess I'm just efficient."

Catra's claws itched to reach for her. "I thought I'd have half a chance," she said, quieter now, unsure if she meant the battle or the space between them. "Are all your victories that effortless?"

Adora’s voice softened. “Do yours ever go the way you plan?”

Catra huffed a laugh that wasn’t quite a laugh. “This one did,” she said, and the words tasted bitter. “Everything did.” She paused. “We just took an impregnable fortress.”

“I know.”

Adora didn’t move closer, but she didn’t have to—Catra could *feel* the pull between them, thrumming like a live wire.

“It’s twice the soldiers I expected,” Catra said, fighting to keep her tone steady. “Ten times the supplies.” She gestured vaguely toward the window. “Honestly? I thought I’d end up defending Weave’s Slope instead.”

Adora’s lips twitched. “You had that ridge stocked for a siege,” she said. “Talon Mountain’s better. Just make sure your troops check under the helms before they open the gates.”

Catra couldn’t stop the small, reluctant smile that tugged at her mouth. “You see? I learn so much from you.”

Adora looked away, and the moment shifted. They were both filthy, streaked with dirt and sweat, their hair matted, their armor dented. The whole room smelled like blood and sweat.

Catra still wanted her closer.

Still wanted to touch her.

“What will you do next?” Adora asked.

Catra’s tail flicked once. “Bathe,” she said, briskly. “Then put on something that doesn’t chafe.” She tilted her head, studying her. “You should too. I had the servants set out something for you. Very Horde-chic. You’ll hate it.”

Adora laughed, low and quiet.

“And,” Catra added, almost absently, “I have something else for you.”

It wasn’t planned, but now that she’d said it, it felt right. Necessary.

When Lonnie had turned in her captain’s badge, Catra had nearly had it melted down out of spite. Now, she found herself wanting to give it to Adora—to see her wear it. To have everyone see her wear it. Even if it was only for tonight.

“I didn’t get a chance to give you this before the battle,” Catra said. Her voice came out lower than she meant, rougher, as she stepped closer to Adora and held out the insignia. The metal caught the candlelight as she offered it, the space between them suddenly feeling too small.

Adora’s expression softened. “Lonnie was your captain for most of the march to the border,” she said carefully, like she was reminding Catra of a fact instead of herself.

Catra’s mouth twitched. “And you’re my captain now.” Her tail flicked once behind her. “You earned it.”

Adora huffed a breath that wasn’t quite laughter. “Barely.”

“I don't what I would have done without you,” Catra said. She didn’t mean to sound so raw, but she couldn’t help it. Her gaze lingered on the narrow cut across Adora’s slave collar—a blade had come too close. The thick platinum still bore the mark, the edge nicked and scarred. Her claws twitched at her sides. She wanted to touch it, to smooth her fingers over the metal, to make sure the skin beneath was whole.

They *should* have been sitting. Discussing logistics, her departure, rations, all the careful planning that would send Adora back to her own people at dawn. But Catra couldn’t bring herself to talk about it—not yet.

She wanted to stay in this fragile, quiet moment, where she could still pretend Adora wasn't leaving. She wanted to lean forward, bury her face against Adora's neck, and breathe her in—blood, sweat, and soap. Anything but the cold, empty scent of absence.

She wanted too many things she couldn't possibly ask for.

✧

Adora was the center of everything that night—as she should be.

The great hall had transformed from a fortress into a riot of sound and color. The air was thick with laughter and victory. Music swelled, boots stomped against stone, and soldiers toasted until the floor was slick with spilled wine.

Catra sat apart, watching. Watching *her*.

Everywhere Adora went, people stopped her. They reached out to clap her shoulders, to thank her, to share some ridiculous story from the fight. Catra's claws flexed against her cup. She hated it—how freely they touched her. How easily they smiled around her, as if she were theirs.

Even Scorpia and Perfuma were laughing with Adora—and Catra hated them too, for a moment. For being the ones who could stand next to her without trembling.

Then Adora's gaze found her across the crowd, and the noise around Catra dimmed.

She stood before she even realized it, moving toward her.

"You're not going to eat?" she asked when she reached her.

Adora shook her head, curls damp, her skin scrubbed clean and still flushed from the heat of the bath. She looked radiant, even in Horde red—which made Catra hate that uniform even more. It fit her too well. It made her want to take it off her.

“I should check on the work outside,” Adora said. “Make sure the outer walls are fortified. I want… to leave it right. For you.”

Catra’s chest tightened at the simple sincerity of it.

“It can wait,” she said, trying not to sound like she was begging. “You just handed me a fortress, Adora. Let me spoil you for once.”

Catra leaned a shoulder against the wall beside her. Close—but not close enough. She told herself it was fine. She was only losing a soldier. A servant. A slave. Nothing more.

Except it wasn’t fine. It would never be fine.

Soon Adora wouldn’t be in her tent, or by her side in battle, or within reach when she turned and said something that demanded a response. Soon she’d be gone—across the border, out of Catra’s orbit again.

But maybe she’d choose to be an ally. Maybe she’d still fight for her.

Adora would destroy Prime. Catra believed that with everything she had left.

And maybe, someday, there’d be something like friendship.

“I remember,” Adora said, matching her pose against the wall. Her smile was faint, a private little curve of her lips. “You take the small wins when you can.”

Catra’s smirk was sharper. “It’s not small. First time I’ve ever beaten Prime at his own game.”

Adora tilted her head, studying her. “You beat him once before. On the flagship. When you gifted Scorpia those slaves.”

Catra barked a laugh. “That wasn’t Prime. That was Kyle.”

She leaned closer, the grin on her lips softening with a hint of something warmer. "Teens are easy," she murmured, low enough that only Adora could hear. Then, reckless as ever, she added, "Back when I was thirteen, you would've had me wrapped around your little finger."

Adora's breath caught—the faintest, smallest hitch. And for a heartbeat, Catra wondered if she'd finally said something that Adora wouldn't walk away from.

"I can't believe you were ever *easy*," Adora said, a grin tugging at the corner of her mouth—that same half-smirk that drove Catra mad. There was warmth behind it now, though. Fondness. Maybe she'd been drinking, and Catra just hadn't noticed.

"Think of the most naive, bright-eyed—," Catra began, smirking. But then her own words caught up with her—the implication too personal. Her tail twitched. "Oh, right. You don't sleep with girls."

Adora tilted her head, that same familiar, infuriating glint in her eyes. "*Women*," she corrected softly. "Sometimes."

That shouldn't have done anything to Catra. But it did. Her pulse stuttered, her mouth went dry. "Only when there aren't any men around that take your fancy?" she asked, voice a little too even.

Adora's gaze dropped to Catra's lips.

"When I *want* a woman," she said simply.

That low warmth, that dangerous flutter, bloomed in Catra's chest. Her breath caught. She'd always been good at hiding what she felt, but Adora… Adora had been able to read her too well.

And Adora was looking at her like she wanted her.

Not as a rival. Not as an obligation. But as something she wanted to *touch*.

Catra tried to sound composed, to keep her claws sheathed. "If I'd known that, I might've worried about sharing a bed with you."

Adora's grin grew, "I think you *did* know that."

Catra swallowed hard. The look in Adora's eyes said *It's our last night*. Said *Let me touch you before it's over.* Said *Don't you want to know what it would be like?*

And she did. She wanted to know.

She wanted to know if it would undo her.

Her throat felt tight when she finally breathed, "Come on. Eat something."

Adora opened her mouth—maybe to protest, maybe to say *don't change the subject*—but she didn't. She just followed, silent and obedient, back to the table.

They sat close enough for Catra to feel the heat of her arm beside her own. A servant handed Adora a plate, but before she could reach for the food, Catra stopped her hand with a gentle tap.

What could I possibly offer to make her stay? she thought. What could I give that would matter against freedom?

"I read once," Catra said, forcing lightness into her tone, "that in Eternia, it's the slave who feeds the master."

Adora blinked at her. "That's… true," she said slowly, as if not sure where Catra was going with it.

"Then you can't really object," Catra said. Her voice was soft. She lifted a piece of meat from her own plate, fingers steady only because she forced them to be.

Adora hesitated—but not out of discomfort. Out of *awareness*. Then she said, "I don't."

She sat back, straight-backed, proud, every inch the Queen she'd been born to be. She didn't reach forward; she waited. Watching Catra.

Catra leaned in, holding the food up between them. Her pulse pounded so hard she could feel it in her throat.

Adora's lips brushed her fingers as she took the bite.

The sound in the hall dimmed. Catra could hear her own breathing, feel the rush of blood behind her ears. Adora's gaze didn't waver. When Catra offered another bite, Adora leaned in closer this time—her mouth soft, eyes locked on Catra's.

For a heartbeat, the noise of the feast, the laughter, the flickering torches—all of it vanished. It was just the two of them. Just *them*.

Adora sat back finally, and lifted her hand. "Can you play Des Riens Doux," she said to the bard.

Music drifted through the hall—too sweet for a place like this. It took Catra a moment to recognize the language. As the bard sang she was sure he didn't truly know the words he sang, only memorizing their sounds. He mispronounced things here and there.

"*Je ne cacherai pas ce feu dans ma poitrine,*

Qui trouble un peu mes vœux.

J'adoucis ma voix, craignant qu'elle devine,

Ce que je veux de toi, silencieux."

Catra knew enough First Ones' tongue now to follow the words—

Adora's eyes never left her. Not once.

And when the next line came, Adora's lips curved just barely before she whispered along with the bard, her voice barely

audible above the strings:

"*Imagine ce que c'est d'être aimé par moi*."

Imagine what it is to be loved by me.

Catra felt locked inside herself. Her pulse was so quick she thought it might shake her apart. She couldn't breathe, couldn't move, couldn't do anything but *feel* the weight of Adora's eyes on her—steady, searching, tender in a way that made Catra's chest hurt.

It was happening. She could feel it—that precipice right before everything changes. Adora was going to reach for her. Touch her. And this time, Catra knew she couldn't pull away. Not if she meant it. Not if she really wanted her.

But stars, she was terrified.

Her claws bit into her palms as Adora shifted and Catra braced herself for the touch that didn't come.

Because Adora didn't touch her.

She stood with no warning. No words. Just rose from her seat and walked away.

And Catra stayed frozen, pulse still rabbit-fast, the ghost of Adora's gaze still burning on her skin.

✧

Clone 17 was in the middle of complaining about something—Catra didn't care what—when he caught sight of her. Both soldiers immediately straightened like they'd been caught doing something wrong.

"She ordered the wall cleared, your highness," one of them said quickly.

Catra didn’t trust her voice, so she just nodded once and started up the steps.

She didn’t know why she was following. She shouldn’t have been. It was stupid—pathetic, even. Like a half-tamed pet still chasing the one person who had already turned away.

She’d watched Adora leave the hall—and for the first time in a long time, Catra didn’t know what the hell had just happened.

Was that rejection?

Adora had looked at her like she *wanted* her—hadn’t she? That look couldn’t have meant nothing. But then she’d left.

Catra’s chest ached. It was their last night. If there had ever been a chance she’d just lost it.

Or maybe she’d imagined the whole thing. Again.

No. Not this time. That look had to have been real.

Still, she told herself she was going after Adora to *talk*. To settle things. To make sure they were ready for tomorrow. That was it. That was the reason.

When Scorpia tried to stop her for another chat, Catra mumbled something about “later” and slipped past her.

And when she finally stepped onto the battlements, all her reasons fell away.

Adora stood there, leaning forward against the stone, forearms braced, head bowed. The wind tugged at her hair. Her shoulders were slumped in a way Catra had never seen—like she had finally run out of strength. Even in the worst moments, even on the flagship, Adora had never looked this defeated.

It should’ve felt good, seeing her like this. Catra had dreamed of this—of the mighty She-Ra brought low. But now that it was real,

it just made something twist painfully inside her.

Adora heard her coming and looked up.

In that glance, Catra saw everything. The longing. The grief. The ache that mirrored her own. It wasn't for Bright Moon or for duty. It was for *her*.

And in that instant, Catra knew they weren't going to manage a calm, clean goodbye. They weren't built for tidy endings.

She crossed the distance quietly and leaned against the wall beside her—close enough that their arms brushed when the wind shifted. She matched Adora's pose, forearms on the stone, eyes on the dark horizon.

The silence between them wasn't heavy this time. It was… peaceful.

For a moment, Catra let herself just *be* there beside her. The wind played through her hair, cool and soft, and she didn't bother wondering how she could love this woman—the one who'd broken her and saved her all at once. She just knew she did. And that she always would. Perhaps she would in every lifetime.

"You know," Adora said finally, voice rough but trying for casual, "Scorpia sure repaid you for those slaves you gifted her."

Catra's mouth twitched. "I'd say so."

Adora tilted her head, side-eyeing her. "Here I thought you were helping them out of compassion."

Catra exhaled through her nose, almost laughing. "Cute."

That earned her a small huff. It warmed something in Catra's chest.

She looked up at the stars, committing this to memory—the quiet between them, the sound of Adora's breathing beside her, the

ache of it all.

“My mom hated the Horde,” Adora said quietly. “Called them cowards. Liars. Said they’d stab anyone in the back to get what they wanted.”

Catra nearly laughed again—bitterly this time—but stopped herself. She wanted to let Adora keep talking. Wanted to hear everything. Every piece of the woman she’d never really known how to hold onto.

“She would’ve been just like them,” Adora continued after a pause. “Like Keldor. Frosta. Hungry for a war she didn’t truly understand. I can only imagine what she’d think of *you*.”

Catra snorted softly, her eyes still on the horizon. She could *feel* Adora looking at her, gaze heavy and sure.

“Oh, I think we both know,” she murmured. “Would’ve been a disaster.”

Adora’s voice was quiet, almost careful when she spoke.

“Your mother would’ve been proud of you today.”

Catra let out a low, humorless laugh. “Yeah,” she said, too sharp, too bitter. “I’m sure she would.”

The silence that followed was heavy enough to sting. Adora didn’t fill it right away—she rarely did when things got tense. When she finally spoke, it was softer, cautious.

“You don’t even want the throne, do you?”

Catra turned her head.

“I *want* it,” she said. “You think after everything, after how far I’ve clawed my way up, I’d flinch from power now?”

Adora met her gaze evenly. “No,” she said, almost to herself. “No, I don’t.”

Then came the quiet again. Catra could see Adora’s mind working—she always wore her thoughts too openly, like she hadn’t learned yet that being unreadable was power.

“I never questioned the way my mom saw the world,” Adora said at last, voice low. “I just wanted to be the kind of daughter she’d be proud of. To never… dishonor her memory.” She paused, chewing over her words, then frowned, looking almost lost. “I’m sorry.”

Catra blinked. “Sorry? What are you—why would you apologize *to me?*”

Adora’s eyes met hers, steady and sincere. “Because I didn’t understand,” she said. “What all of this—what being Queen—meant for you.”

Catra’s ears flicked, wary. “And what’s that supposed to mean?”

Adora hesitated only a second. “It means you’re fighting for a way to stop fighting. You don't want to fight anymore.”

It was like being punched without the pain—only the ache that came after. Catra looked away, jaw tight. Adora always had that terrible way of *seeing* her, right when she most wanted to stay hidden.

I don’t want you to see that, she almost said—but didn’t.

The thought of Prime slithered back through her mind like oil, twisting all the warmth she’d been feeling into something raw and ugly. She hated it—hated how easily Adora could stir that guilt in her, even now.

And then, as if she could feel Catra slipping, Adora moved closer.

“I wish it could’ve been different between us,” Adora said, her voice barely above a whisper. “I wish I’d treated you with more… I don’t know. Honor.”

Catra started to shake her head, ready to cut her off, to make a joke, anything to stop the sincerity from burning through her—but Adora didn’t let her.

“I want you to know,” she said, firm now, steady, blue eyes locked on Catra’s, “that you have a friend in Etheria. No matter what happens tomorrow. No matter what happens to either of us.”

Catra barked out a laugh that cracked halfway through. “Friends? That’s what this is?” she said, her voice unsteady, mocking to hide the way her throat felt tight. “That’s cute.”

Adora looked at her and something broke in her expression. “Catra,” she said, quiet and helpless. “I’m still your slave.”

The words hit her like a tremor through her chest. Catra’s breath hitched; she couldn’t hold it steady. Then Adora’s hand was there—fingers brushing along her jaw, thumb catching the edge of her cheekbone.

Catra didn’t move. She couldn’t. Every part of her was shaking, but she wasn’t afraid. Not of *this*.

Adora’s touch trailed down, light as air, to the curve of her neck, then into the fur at the nape of her neck. Her fingers tangled there in her hair. Her eyes searched Catra’s face—waiting for a *stop*, a *no*, anything.

Catra closed her eyes instead. Her lashes were damp. Her chest ached. She wanted her. She wanted her so much it scared the life out of her.

Then Adora kissed her.

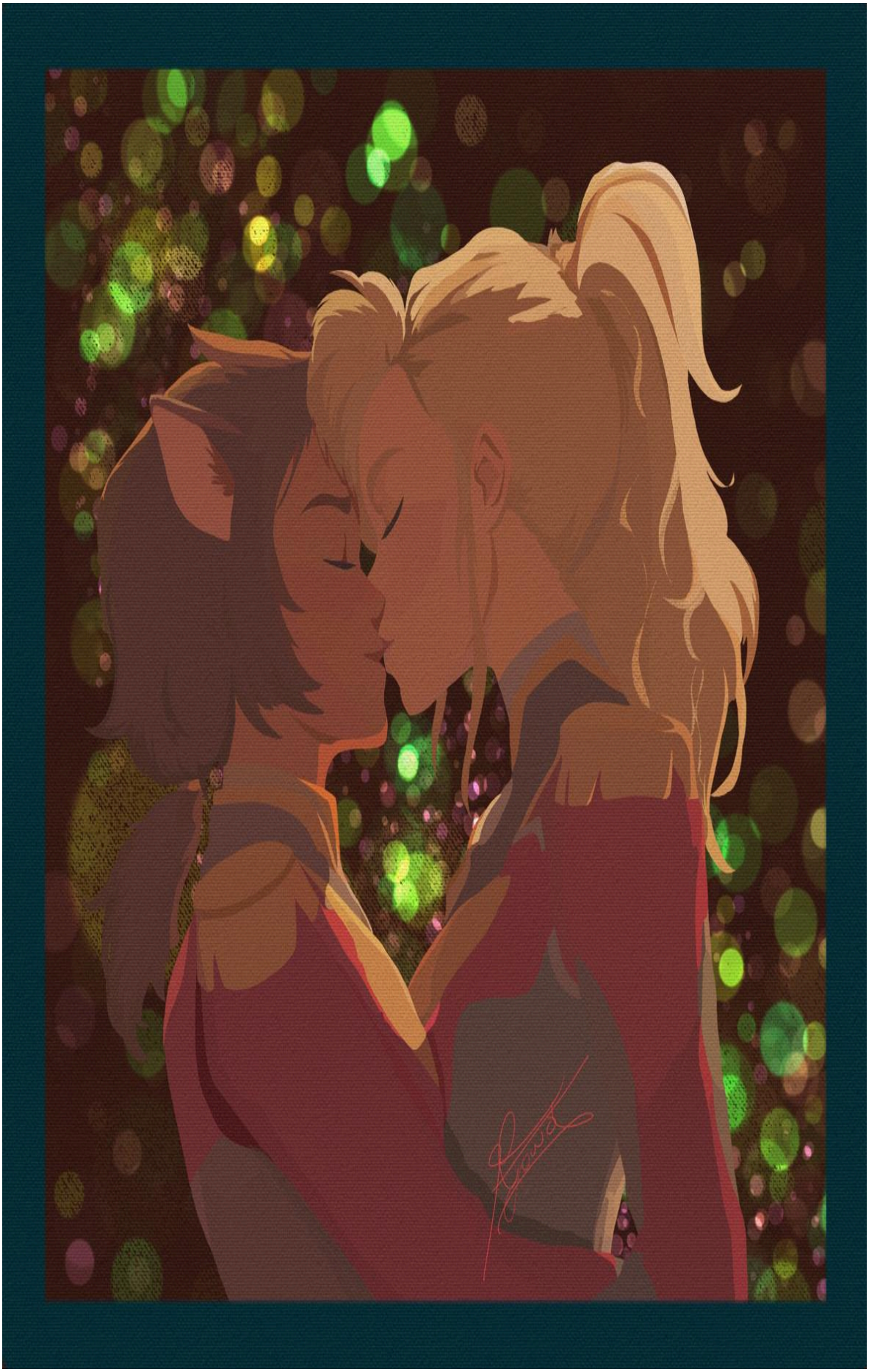
It was barely a kiss at first—just a soft, uncertain brush of lips, gone almost before Catra could catch her breath. So light it

could’ve been imagined, if not for the empty ache when Adora pulled away.

Catra’s breath hitched, a small sound escaping her throat, and then Adora leaned back in, firmer this time, surer. The kiss deepened. Adora pressed her gently back against the wall, hand still curled in Catra’s hair, and Catra didn’t feel cornered. She felt *seen*. She felt—

Oh…

So this is what it's like to be kissed.



“Your Highness—”

The voice cut through the moment.

Adora jerked back at once, the warmth vanishing as quickly as it came. Catra’s hand flew to her lips, her heart slamming in her chest.

Lonnie stood frozen on the steps, eyes wide.

Chapter End Notes

> [When I draw a kiss that is truer to this scene, the image will be getting updated.]
>
> As someone in the comments said: perhaps there is an upside to not sleeping...
>
> Also re: nsfw art. Someone asked how it could be worse than the orgy. I merely mean it's easier to covertly read smut in public when there's no pictures of titties on you screen. But it seems to be a unanimous "yes".
>
> Also, two smut chapters coming up soon 😊 As a treat.
>
> Next chapter is Adora's pov again.

Chapter 19: Adora

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Catra,” she said softly, eyes unguarded. “I’m still your slave.”

The words cut through the quiet, painfully naked. They hung in the narrow space between them, heavy with everything they felt. Catra froze. Her breath came fast—shallow, ragged, as if her lungs couldn’t decide whether to hold or to release.

Adora felt it too—that invisible pull, the way their breathing found the same rhythm. She moved before she could think better of it, her hand rising in slowly. She searched Catra’s face for any trace of resistance, the flick of an ear, the narrowing of an eye.

There was none.

Her fingers brushed Catra’s jaw, tentative at first. Catra’s skin was warm under her palm, tense as coiled wire. The pads of Adora’s fingers traced upward, her thumb brushing softly on the edge of a fading bruise, sliding across the sharp line of Catra’s cheekbone. She could feel the faint tremor in the muscles beneath her touch.

Catra didn’t move away. Unlike last time.

She closed her eyes instead, as if the act of not looking was the only control she had left.

Adora’s hand drifted to the nape of her neck, finding the heat there, the fluttering pulse just beneath the skin. Catra’s breath hitched. Slowly, Adora leaned in. She bent her head, lowering herself just enough.

The kiss was light as a sigh. Barely real.

A brush of lips, uncertain.

When she pulled back, Catra exhaled sharply, eyes still closed, her mouth parting as though to call the moment back. Adora hesitated only a heartbeat before finding her again. The second kiss was deeper but still soft, still careful.

For that sliver of time, it felt like the only truth left between them.

The only thing they had left.

Adora knew she'd leave tomorrow. The thought flickered and died before it could matter. All that mattered now was giving Catra this—what she would take, what she would let herself feel. Adora asked for nothing in return. That was enough.

Then—

"Your Highness—"

They broke apart instantly.

Adora staggered a step back, heart racing, lungs burning as if she'd surfaced too fast from deep water. The air felt colder without Catra's warmth pressed against her. Her stomach turned as she glanced toward the sound of boots on stone.

A figure was climbing the steps into the torchlight.

Lonnie.

Now they stood apart, the distance between them a gulf too wide to cross. The battlements stretched long and uneven, lit in fragments by sputtering torches.

Adora snapped. "I ordered this section cleared."

In Bright Moon, words would have been enough. One order, and privacy would return. She could have turned back, picked up exactly where she had left off—that impossible, breathtaking moment pressed against Catra's mouth.

“I’m not here for you, *Mara*” Lonnie said flatly, her arms folded.

“Then say what you came to say,” Adora said, her voice clipped, “and go.”

Lonnie’s expression didn’t change. “My business is with the Princess.”

Catra let out a quiet, humorless laugh. She pushed off the wall and straightened, her hair shifting in the torchlight, wild and uneven. “Here to warn me about the dangers of mixing diplomacy with foreplay?”

The silence that followed was almost poisonous. Lonnie’s jaw tightened. She didn’t rise to the bait.

“Nothing to say?” Catra prodded, her smirk thin. “Didn’t think so.”

Lonnie’s tone was even, but her eyes gave her away—a flicker of disgust. “Not while she’s here.”

“*She’s* your captain,” Catra said.

Lonnie’s reply came steady. “She *knows* she should go.”

Earlier

Keldor wasn’t an easy opponent. He moved like a man who had survived too many wars. His sword rang against Adora’s.

He dropped his shield and lunged. For a heartbeat, it was nearly even—his practiced form against Adora’s raw instinct. But when she pressed forward, blade steady and sure, his balance faltered. His expression shifted—not fear, but the sharpness of recognition.

“I know you,” he rasped, voice torn and sudden. His grip tightened. “I *know* you.”

He struck wildly then, a desperate, reckless arc. Adora’s training took over. She parried, pivoted, and drove her blade upward,

straight through his open guard.

The sound it made was small, wet. Keldor's eyes went wide.

"I know you," he gasped again, voice breaking. "***She-Ra***… Mage-Slayer."

The words hit harder than the fight itself.

Adora froze, sword still lodged deep, her mind empty but for the echo of that name. Then she wrenched the blade free, and he fell.

A breath later, she felt it—someone watching.

Her chest tightened. For an instant, she thought it was Catra. She turned, hope and dread twisting together.

It wasn't Catra.

It was Lonnie.

Her sword hung slack at her side, eyes wide with horror.

"No," Adora whispered, too quiet, too late. "It's not— I'm not—"

The sounds of battle dimmed, fading to a dull roar.

Lonnie stared at her like she was seeing a ghost. "Does she know?" she asked.

Adora never answered. She couldn't.

Because then the troops erupted in noise—Catra's troops pouring through the defensive lines, toppling Keldor's banners. The cry rose, swelling through the air:

Hail to the Princess!

And closer:

Mara. Mara.

✧

~Now~

"While we compare notes on sleeping with the enemy?"

The silence that followed was worse than shouting. It pressed down like weight. Adora could feel it in her chest, in her bones—the distance between them, only four steps of stone but wide as a chasm.

"Well?" Catra's tone was sharp, almost taunting.

Lonnie's eyes flicked between them. The flicker of emotion there wasn't just anger—it was disgust, and disbelief. She didn't speak the accusation in her throat, but it was plain enough in her face: *Adora of Bright Moon.*

And now—this.

The silence grew thick, suffocating.

Adora stepped forward. "Maybe—"

The clatter of boots cut her off—metal on stone, hurried, purposeful. Lonnie turned toward the noise. Two soldiers appeared at the top of the stairwell, one of Marzo's Horde clones in his polished armor and another guard at his side, both looking tense and uncertain.

Adora exhaled sharply and rubbed a hand over her face. Everyone in the fort seemed determined to find their way to the one place she'd ordered cleared.

"Captain," said the clone, voice crisp but uneasy. "Apologies for the interruption. There's a situation downstairs."

Adora's tone snapped back to command. "A situation?"

The soldier straightened, hesitating. “A group of men… they’ve decided to make sport with one of the prisoners.”

The world, cruelly persistent, came rushing back—its orders, its duties, its filth. The part of her that had dared to forget it for one impossible moment froze over again.

“The prisoners are to be treated with respect,” Adora said tightly. “If they’ve been drinking, you know how to rein them in. My orders were clear.”

“Yes, Captain,” said the clone, though his hesitation lingered. He was a seasoned man—efficient, obedient, one of the few Adora had trusted to follow orders without cruelty. Yet even he looked uneasy.

“Your orders *were* clear,” he said carefully. “But… some of the men believe Her Highness will support them.”

The words fell heavy between them. Adora didn’t need to ask what kind of ‘sport’ he meant. The implication was enough—the kind of ugliness she thought she’d purged from their ranks.

Her stomach turned. Her faith in the troop’s discipline felt suddenly naïve.

Catra’s eyes flicked toward Lonnie.

“Entrapta.”

Adora turned sharply. Catra wasn’t looking at her—she was watching Lonnie. And the look on Lonnie’s face, that flash of dread and guilt, confirmed it before a word was said.

Of course.

It was Entrapta.

Lonnie’s jaw worked once before she dropped to her knees. Her armor clanked faintly against the stone.

"Your Highness," she said, voice steady only by effort. She didn't look up. "I know I've fucked up. I'll take whatever punishment you see fit. But Entrapta—she was loyal. She stayed loyal to Double Trouble. They were the only reason she wasn't executed or sold off to the slave colonies off-world." Lonnie's hands clenched into fists against her knees. "She doesn't deserve to be handed around for it. If my service means anything… please."

Catra tilted her head, a slow, dangerous motion. Her tone was sharp with venomous amusement.

"*This* is why she slept with you, Lonnie."

"I know," Lonnie said quietly.

Catra's eyes narrowed. "Rogelio didn't get that mercy. He didn't deserve to die by a self-serving bitch he thought was a friend."

"I know," Lonnie repeated, her voice raw. "I'm not asking for forgiveness. Or freedom for her. Just—" she swallowed, hard—"don't let them destroy her. She was scared. That night—she didn't know what she was doing."

Catra's smile was slow and cruel.

"I should make you watch," she said softly. "While she's stripped down for every man in the fort."

Adora moved before she realized she was moving.

"You don't mean that," she said, stepping between them. Her voice trembled, part outrage, part plea. "You *can't* mean that. You need her alive—you need her as a hostage."

Catra didn't blink. Her expression was smooth, perfectly composed, the face of a ruler carved from stone. "I don't need her entirely *intact*," she said.

The words were cold enough to make Adora flinch. For an instant, she didn't recognize her—this version of Catra, untouchable,

expressionless, unreachable.

Something in her had shifted. Adora could feel it—the space between them, widening like a fracture she couldn't mend. Somewhere along the way, she'd lost step with her.

She wanted everyone gone—Lonnie, the clone, the wind, the world.

She wanted to find her way back to the woman she'd kissed barely minutes ago.

But the moment was gone.

And Catra was already looking past her.

And yet, this couldn't just be left to rot in silence.

Adora said quietly, but firmly, "If Entrapta's to be judged, then it'll be done properly. No chaos. No mob. Fairly. Publicly. Not just a handful of drunk soldiers deciding who deserves what."

Catra tilted her head, voice low and amused. "Oh, how noble. Justice, huh? Well, if that's what our hero of the hour wants—let's give her some justice. Go on," she said, flicking her wrist toward the door without looking away from Adora. "Drag Entrapta away from her fan club and bring her to me. East tower. Let's get this little show started."

"Y—Yes, Your Highness," the soldier stammered before hurrying off. Others followed him down the stairs, armor clattering faintly in the stillness that followed.

Adora stepped forward, every muscle in her body coiled. "Catra, what are you doing? When I said she deserves justice, I didn't mean—now. Not like this. You're—" She stopped herself, meeting Catra's eyes, searching for the woman she'd kissed, not the queen standing before her. "When we were—"

Catra's gaze was unreadable, her expression so composed it almost hurt to look at. "Oh, I'm thinking perfectly clearly," she said. "If Lonnie wants to grovel for Entrapta, then she should see who she's really kissing ass for."

✧

The east tower crowned the fort like a spear tip—bare stone, cold air, a room built for defense, not comfort. The narrow circular chamber beneath the parapet was meant for archers during siege, but now it felt more like an arena. A heavy wooden table dominated the space, surrounded by three chairs. The guards who should've been stationed there were gone on Adora's orders, leaving the silence to stretch between them.

Catra, enthroned in the high-backed chair, was every inch the ruler she'd fought to become. Her confidence was effortless, dangerous. She ordered that not only Entrapta be brought, but also wine, food—luxuries that didn't belong in this grim setting. Servants arrived, stumbling slightly under the weight of trays stacked with roasted meats, crusty bread, and pitchers of deep red wine and one of water.

Catra crossed one leg over the other and lounged back, as though this were a casual dinner. Her eyes followed the rim of her goblet of water as she idly turned it in her hand. Adora stood near the table, the back of her neck prickling.

She knew this look. That distant calm, the way Catra's tail flicked lazily. Her instincts screamed at her that Entrapta was safer with the half-drunk soldiers downstairs than in this room under Catra's gaze.

In that suffocating quiet, Adora remembered the kiss.

The warmth of Catra's lips—quick, surprised, fragile. It had broken off before it could deepen, before she could feel the full heat of it. But the memory was enough to make her chest tighten.

If she closed her eyes, she could almost imagine the rest of it: Catra leaning in, the soft catch of her breath, fingers trembling before settling against Adora's collarbone. She would have been cautious. She would have continued only on Catra's terms.

✧

Earlier

Lonnie's voice was raw. "You here to kill me?"

Adora shook her head. "No."

Silence. Two paces apart, both too aware of the knife in Lonnie's hand, the tension coiled tight between them. The light flickered against the steel.

Adora's voice was low. "You haven't told her."

Lonnie let out a bitter laugh. "You're not even going to deny it?" Her eyes burned. "You hated us that much? Hated *her* that much? You had to twist the knife like this? Was this all just—what—revenge?"

Adora didn't answer.

"So, what?" Lonnie pressed. "I tell her the truth? That the woman she trusts, lied to her face? Manipulated her into—into that?" Her voice cracked with disgust.

"I wouldn't hurt her," Adora said. The words sounded hollow, heavy as lead between them.

Lonnie's face twisted. "You killed her mother, Adora. Then you went and climbed into her bed."

Put like that, it was beyond fucked up.

Adora's throat closed. She wanted to say *it's not like that between us*, but she couldn't—because what could she say? That it was

complicated? That she hadn't meant for it to happen? That every time she touched Catra it was like trying to hold something already breaking? None of that would sound right.

She thought of Catra's teasing, her endless games that flipped from warmth to ice in a breath. Of how, when Adora matched her rhythm, it became something real—something almost tender, hidden beneath the constant edge of danger.

And now, the truth between them was another weapon.

"I'm leaving," Adora said quietly. Her voice was steady, but it felt like she was forcing every word through a wound. "I was always going to. The only reason I stayed was because—"

Lonnie cut in, sharp and furious. "Yeah, that's right. You're leaving. You don't get to tear her apart just because you're feeling guilty." Her jaw was tight, her tone clipped with anger that had nowhere else to go. "You'll give the order to move on Talon Mountain. You'll keep your mouth shut around her. And when it's done—when we've taken the fort—you'll get on a horse and disappear. She'll grieve, she'll move on, and she'll never have to know what you did."

That had always been Adora's plan. From the moment she'd stepped back onto Etheria, she'd known this was temporary—a mission, an ending she'd already written for herself.

And yet the words hit her like a sword blow. Her pulse thudded in her chest, fast and unsteady, like steel clashing again and again.

"In the morning," Adora said. Her throat felt tight. "I'll give her the fort and ride out. It's what I promised."

Lonnie's eyes narrowed. "You'd better. Because if you're still here when the sun's overhead, I'll tell her myself. And what she did to you on the Flagship will feel like a sweet kiss compared to what I will fucking do to you."

Adora’s stomach twisted. She wanted to hate Lonnie for the threat—but she couldn’t. Lonnie was loyal. Always had been. Loyal to Catra, to whatever broken sense of order still held them all together. Adora had admired that about her, that grounded, unwavering loyalty.

Now, surrounded by the wreckage of battle—grass torn and muddied, the air still heavy with the echo of steel—it felt like that loyalty had turned into a blade pointed straight at her.

“She’ll know,” Adora said softly. The words slipped out before she could stop them. “When she hears I’ve gone back, she’ll know. Tell her then that I—”

Lonnie’s expression twisted. “You make me fucking sick,” she said flatly. Both her hands gripped the knife now, white-knuckled, as if she needed it to keep from shaking.

“Captain!” a voice called from down the slope. “Captain!”

Adora didn’t turn. Her eyes stayed fixed on Lonnie, on the tremor running through her shoulders, on the fury and hurt knotted behind her glare.

Lonnie’s mouth tightened. “That’s you.”

Chapter End Notes

I updated the playlist 😊

I aalso trued my best to put it in order of emotions as the story progresses.

7 more chapters! Woo!

Chapter 20

Chapter Notes

> If you've been waiting for chapter 20, keep in mind that chapter is now technically chapter 21 because I split chapter 16 in two.
>
> Huge cw: csa in memories, referenced csa, ptsd
>
> This not by any means a happy chapter but I really enjoy writing bitchy Catra.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"We're having a private showing," Catra said dryly, flicking her tail as she waved for more wine to be brought to the east tower. That was the phrase Prime used, she remembered—whenever he decided to make an example of someone. *A private showing*. The memory of those "performances" still made her stomach turn—the gleaming tables, the neatly folded napkins, the polished smiles while someone screamed in the middle of the room, begging for him to stop. Prime had called it order. She called it what it was—evil.

Well, she didn't have time for *that* kind of ceremony. But if Entrapta was going to waste her pity and Lonnie's loyalty, then fine—Catra would at least make the point memorable. The table was already set with small plates and bright sweets, delicate little things that looked absurd under lamp light. She slouched back against the large table, one leg crossed lazily over the other, ignoring the others gathered in the room—*especially* Adora, who lingered near the edge of the light, and Lonnie.

Catra smirked faintly. Neither of them could appreciate the effort she'd gone to. Entrapta might.

Entrapta was dragged in between two guards, her boots scraping stone. She struggled instinctively—wild hair tangled, eyes wide

and unblinking. Catra wondered, fleetingly, if Prime had ever tried to "teach" her the same way he'd taught everyone else. The thought soured instantly.

When Entrapta saw Lonnie, she froze. "No," she whispered, pale. "Not you. Go away!"

Ah. Catra's grin widened. So that was it. Lonnie *had* come running to her defense—but Entrapta hadn't asked for it. She hadn't schemed her way into this, hadn't seduced her guard or manipulated her way free. No—this was worse. It was real. Lonnie had done it out of love. Out of some sad, stupid loyalty that Catra couldn't decide if she wanted to laugh at or tear apart.

It made her stomach twist. It made her *furious*.

"Well," Catra said, voice smooth as silk. "How sweet. A heart-warming reunion."

Entrapta lifted her chin, trembling but defiant. "If you brought me here to gloat," she said, her voice shaky but proud, "you're wasting your time. I don't regret what I did. I did it for the glory of the Horde. I'd do it again."

Catra tilted her head, smile sharp and amused. "That's a nice story," she said. "But how about you try the truth this time?"

"That *is* the truth." Entrapta's tone hardened, eyes flashing. "I'm not scared of you. Double Trouble's going to destroy you."

Catra laughed softly, low in her throat. "Double Trouble?" she repeated, pretending to savor the name. "Please. They bolted for Hell's Rest the moment things got hard. Tail between their legs, as usual."

"They're regrouping!" Entrapta shot back, voice rising. "They'd never abandon me—not like you would." Her gaze swept over Catra, brimming with contempt. "Guess you thought fucking Shadow Weaver was the only way you could show loyalty."

That hit its mark—and Catra's smile turned into something cold.

"Funny you should mention that," she said softly. Her hand closed around the nearest goblet.

The sound—the sharp crack of metal striking skin and bone beneath—rang across the stone walls. Entrapta gasped, staggered, her head snapping to the side. A red line bloomed along her cheekbone where the rim had split skin. The guards' grip tightened to keep her upright.

"Keep my mother's name out of your mouth," Catra said, voice flat.

She stood there, breathing hard, every muscle tight with something that wasn't satisfaction. It wasn't even anger, not exactly. It was the raw, sick feeling she'd had for years—the same one she'd learned to hide behind smirks and sharp words and perfect posture. The one that came from being silent while Prime and his perfect army spat their poison, while she smiled like a good little pet and took it.

She remembered every word they'd used to drag her down, every cruel joke, every quiet threat about what would happen if she slipped—if anyone learned what she really was, what she had really done to earn the title of Princess of the Horde. How thoroughlyshe debased herself for years.

Better to let them think she was ruthless. Better to make them *afraid*.

But even now, with Entrapta bleeding in front of her, the echo of those lessons burned at the back of her mind like acid.

It felt *good* to hit Entrapta. The sharp sting in Catra's palm, the startled sound that ripped from Entrapta's throat, the thin line of blood beading at the corner of her mouth—it all sang in a terrible, satisfying way. Something deep and molten had cracked open inside her, all the cold, brittle composure melting into a heat that burned too bright to contain. Somewhere on the edge of her

awareness, Adora moved forward, voice low, warning—but Catra didn't care. Lonnie was worse, thrashing against Adora's grip, spitting fury in defense of the traitor. The ice inside Catra hissed as it melted, boiling over.

She was going to kill Entrapta. She could feel it—the violent, feral certainty of it. She wanted to tear her apart with her own claws and teeth and not stop until there was nothing left but the sound of her own breathing.

"You can hurt me all you like," Entrapta managed to say, her voice trembling but not breaking. It was defiant—brave in the way Entrapta always was, the kind of bravery that didn't understand fear until it was too late.

Catra smiled, sharp and humorless. *Oh, I plan to*, she thought, her pulse hammering. *You think I need permission? I'm going to keep going until there's nothing left of him in either of us. Until all that's left is our rotted husks.*

"Can I?" she murmured aloud, her tone low and taunting. "What else can I do to you, Princess? Clearly you're up for anything. I'm surprised you weren't bending over giddily for every cock that sought you out down there. I assumed that was goal; suck off every soldier until you turned my army against me."

Lonnie tore at Adora's grip, desperate. "Stop this!" she shouted, voice cracking. "She's—she's just a *Princess*! She's not built for this, Catra—she's scared! She thinks you're going to destroy the Horde!"

Catra and Entrapta both froze at that, twin flashes of disbelief twisting their faces in perfect synchrony. For a heartbeat, the room felt still, absurd. *Just a Princess*. As if that ever meant weakness. As if any of them had the luxury of fear.

Catra tilted her head, eyes narrowing. "I *am* going to destroy the Horde," she said softly. "But that's not exactly what she's fighting for."

“What else?” Lonnie snapped, disgust and heartbreak mingling in her voice. The look she gave Catra was worse than a blade—pure disappointment. *Every year I served you was a mistake.* Catra could see the words in her eyes. And the worst part? She wasn’t wrong. But Catra didn’t have room for guilt now. Not when rage felt this clean.

“Why else would she betray—?” Lonnie paused, as if hating the honesty in her outburst, changing it last minute. "—You."

Catra smiled without warmth. “You really can’t think of any other reason?”

Lonnie glared, jaw tight, her silence saying everything—her disbelief, her disillusionment. And when Catra turned back to Entrapta, she didn’t see the bleeding, trembling woman before her. She saw herself.

Thirteen years old. Standing before Prime’s mirror. Hair shorter then—Prime liked it that way. His hand had been tangled in it, his grip cruel. The paint smeared across her lips looked like blood. His other hand had wrapped around her throat, forcing her to *look*. She remembered that reflection—the swollen eyes, the tears, the way she’d begged herself not to cry. She remembered the hit, the sharp crack against her cheek, almost exactly where she’d struck Entrapta now. The way her body had jerked, helpless against each thrust. The moment the light in her eyes went out for good.

And now, Entrapta was her mirror. Prime’s ghost grinning between them. Lonnie couldn’t see it. Adora wouldn’t know how. But Prime would’ve. That’s why he’d chosen Entrapta—not just as a spy, but as a reminder. To keep Catra small. To remind her that freedom was something she’d never get to keep.

The thought made her sick as she stepped closer. Entrapta flinched from her, jerking against the guards’ hands. They tightened their grip, wary. Catra reached up, brushing a strand of purple hair from Entrapta’s face. It felt wrong that it wasn’t brown. She dragged her thumb over Entrapta’s split lip, smearing

the blood like paint. It gleamed against her skin in the light, thinner than Prime's heavy pigment.

She stroked the bruising line of Entrapta's jaw—gentle, deliberate. Entrapta whimpered anyway, a small, wounded sound that slipped out before she could stop it. When Catra tilted her chin toward the light, Entrapta's breath hitched.

Catra's eyes softened, just for a moment. She wondered if Prime had looked at her the same way.

"Such a pretty face," Catra said, her tone lazy and venom-sweet. "Bet you were adorable as a kid. A perfect little doll, huh?"

Entrapta froze. The flicker of terror in her eyes was subtle but unmistakable—a twitch, a tremor, the brief widening of her pupils. Catra caught it instantly. That tiny reaction was all she needed. The unspoken rule, the one thing no one ever, *ever* said aloud. Catra tilted her head and smiled, a slow, deliberate mirror of Entrapta's desperate, infinitesimal shake of the head. *Don't*, her eyes pleaded. *Please, don't say it.*

Catra's grin widened. She leaned in, voice light, conversational, cruel. Sadistically upbeat. "So," she asked, loud enough for every ear in the room, "how old were you when you started sleeping with Prime? Still a kid, or had you at least hit your blood by then? Was it even fun for you?"

"Shut up," Entrapta hissed, voice sharp and breaking at the edges.

Catra clicked her tongue, mocking sympathy as she trailed her claws lazily through Entrapta's tangled hair. "He told you you were special, didn't he?" she murmured. "Promised you'd be together again, if you just did one more little thing for him. That's how he works." Her voice had turned cold, almost hollow. "Makes you think the pain means you matter."

Every word was a blade she'd already turned on herself a thousand times. Catra remembered what it was like to crave his approval, to flinch and still *want* to be seen. To dread his attention

but fear losing it more. Prime always made sure his toys believed they couldn't exist without him. And she—fool that she was—had believed it, too.

"Did he tell you he missed you?" Catra asked, eyes narrowing. Lip pouting to mock her.

"Shut up," Entrapta said again, weaker this time.

"He was lying," Catra said softly. "You're too old now. He wouldn't touch you again."

Entrapta's voice dropped to a shaky whisper. "You don't know what you're talking about—"

"Oh, I do." Catra's tone was sweet and poisonous. "He wouldn't want you anymore. You're used up. Not the shiny new toy he liked. You think Prime keeps what he's finished breaking?"

Entrapta's voice trembled, rising in pitch. "You don't know anything—"

"With your aging body, your worn-out neediness, you've filled out, you've got a woman's body," Catra pressed, her voice cutting and unrelenting, "you'd make him *sick*."

"You're wrong about us!" Entrapta snapped, her control finally breaking. She thrashed against the guards restraining her, sagging, tears and fury spilling over her face. "He *loves me!*"

And there it was. She hoped Lonnie was listening.

The words doused Catra's fury like cold water. The fire didn't vanish—it hissed, turned to steam. Her anger rose and coiled, slow and deliberate, a poisonous mist that filled her chest. She let a cruel smile curl her lip.

"Loves you?" she repeated softly, almost tenderly. *Prime doesn't* ***love*** *anyone. He drains them dry and tosses what's left. That's not love. That's hunger.*

Catra's voice stayed calm, almost eerily so, but her claws itched for something to tear. Prime had devoured them both—her and Entrapta—just in different ways.

She could have told Entrapta what love really looked like. That it was Lonnie defying orders just to save her. That it was the way Adora's breath caught before she kissed her—like she was afraid Catra might shatter if she pressed too hard. But that was private. That was *hers*. Prime and Entrapta had already taken too much. She wasn't giving them that, too.

"You pathetic little tinkerer," Catra sneered. "I doubt you were even his favorite. What did you get, huh? A handful of quick fucks between meetings?"

Entrapta's voice cracked, furious and wounded. "You don't know *anything* about us!"

"Oh, I know plenty." Catra's smile was ice. "He never brought you to the arena. Never dined with you." Never punished you in front of me, like he did the ones he *really* cared about. She leaned in, voice low, lethal. "He left you rotting in Dryl. Or stashed away in Hell's Rest until Double Trouble dragged you back to him. Didn't that ever make you wonder why?"

Entrapta's breath hitched. Her voice was small now, cracking apart. "He didn't want to leave," she whispered. "He told me he wanted to stay with me."

Catra smiled without joy, her eyes empty. "I bet you fucked all his clones just to get a taste of him."

Entrapta's voice trembled, thin and wavering—but her conviction, her desperate, blind faith, held fast. It made Catra sick. She needed to shatter it, to break *her*. To rip that unshakable belief apart until there was nothing left behind those wide, terrified eyes but understanding—painful, terrible understanding.

This was what Prime had wanted Catra to be. What he'd tried to make her into—mindless and obedient, a hollow puppet dancing

on invisible strings. A thing that smiled when commanded, cried when told, suffered prettily for the sake of his pleasure. A perfect imitation of a person, built to serve and break and beg. That was what he'd seen when he looked at her. A doll, not a girl.

Catra could still feel that expectation crawling under her skin. It burned.

"I bet you were so easy," she said, low and venomous. "A few sweet words, a little attention, and you gave him everything. All that wide-eyed curiosity—he must've loved that." She tilted her head, voice twisting into a sneer. "Did you even fight back? Or did you just tell yourself it was fine?"

Catra remembered how still she'd gone for Prime, how he'd hated that—how his voice had turned sharp and disappointed when she'd stopped reacting. He liked tears. He liked the struggle. He liked pretending their resistance meant he hadn't already taken everything from them.

"Bet he thought you were fun, for a while," Catra said. "Something new to play with. A change of pace." Her smile curved, cruel and knowing. "But there's only so much to do in Dryl, huh? The novelty must've worn off."

Entrapta had been young—too young. Probably pushed into it, coached, used like all the rest. The thought turned Catra's stomach, but she couldn't stop herself. Couldn't stop aiming every poisonous word like a blade. She *knew* she was striking the wrong person, but the ones who *deserved* it weren't here. And she needed Entrapta to *see*. Needed her to *break*.

"No," Entrapta said, barely above a whisper.

Catra's tone softened into mockery. "Pretty enough. Eager enough. But you don't age well, do you?" She leaned in close, eyes glinting. "Used things stop being useful. Cheap wine doesn't belong on a fine table."

"No," Entrapta said again, shaking.

"Prime's got standards," Catra continued, her smile sharp and empty. *I know him better than you ever did. He kept me longer. Hurt me worse*. "Not like Lonnie—she'll take someone's leftovers and pretend it's worth love." Her words turned bitter, almost feral. Pretend *we're* worth something. We're not.

"Stop it," Entrapta sobbed.

"Why do you think Prime told you to spread your legs for a soldier before he'd even look at you?" Catra asked sweetly, almost gently, as she brushed a claw against the bruise blooming on Entrapta's cheek. "He wanted you dirty. He wanted you ruined. He wanted you to feel too ashamed to even ask."

Entrapta jerked back, wrenching free of the guards' grip for a moment. She was crying now, ugly, desperate sobs that filled the room. She shook her head over and over, as if she could deny reality by sheer force.

"That's enough," Adora said.

Catra froze. For a heartbeat, she'd forgotten anyone else existed. Adora's tone had that rare, absolute authority—the one that reminded everyone who she *was*.

"Get her out of here," Adora ordered, and the soldiers obeyed instantly.

Catra watched as they dragged Entrapta away, still sobbing, still shaking, and felt something hollow twist inside her.

"You," Lonnie said hoarsely. "You heartless *bitch*."

Catra turned, slowly. Her smile was sharp as before. "And now we come to you," she said, almost purring.

Adora moved before Lonnie could take a step, putting herself between them.

“No,” she said—to Catra, to Lonnie, to the whole room. Then, to Lonnie, “Get out.”

Everyone cleared out of the room, leaving Catra alone with Adora again.

Her words landed like commands from a throne. The air around her seemed to shift, heavy with power and restraint. She stood tall—too tall—her stance broad, unyielding, eyes locked on Catra’s.

“Calm down,” Adora said. Her voice was steady, but it was an order.

Catra bared her teeth in something halfway between a smile and a snarl.

Catra’s tone was sharp. “I wasn’t finished talking.”

Adora’s frown deepened. “Finished what? Cutting down everyone in the room just to make yourself feel stronger? Lonnie’s not your equal in a fight, and you know it. Stand down.”

Catra tilted her head, a faint, dangerous smile tugging at her mouth. She thought about the single word that could shatter Adora’s composure completely. *Adora*. That was all it would take. Let’s talk about fairness, about balance, when you can kiss me like you mean it, swear you’ll stay, then walk away as if I won’t notice. As if I’m too broken to understand.

Something flickered across her face—too raw, too revealing—and Adora caught it. “Are you going to try that with me?” she asked, voice level and cold. “Or do you only go after people who can’t fight back?”

“I remember this,” Adora said, still steady, still unflinching. “You got like this before. Lost control. Gave Prime exactly the excuse he needed to throw you into the arena.”

Catra remembered, too. The sharp rip of her claws through skin. Adora’s skin. The hot, vivid red that followed. The way she’d felt

justified, triumphant even, right up until she'd seen Adora's face. She could see it again now—the same image burning behind both their eyes, shared and inescapable.

And Adora had still kissed her.

Catra turned away so fast the world tilted. She couldn't look at her. Couldn't look at *anything*. The urge to tear, to destroy, to *feel* something surged through her chest. She wanted to hurt Adora—to hurt her, and to love her, both so badly it made her sick. She wanted to lock her away so she could never leave her. She wanted to burn every place Prime had ever touched her—if any of him had ever even touched this body. She wanted Adora to take the knife and finish what was left of her.

Her claws dug into the table. Then, with a sudden, jerking motion, she swept her arm across it, sending everything crashing to the floor. It still wasn't enough.

When she spoke again, her voice was measured. "What you're saying," she began, "is that when I lose control, I screw things up. Prime knew that better than anyone. Maybe it amused him to throw Entrapta in my way—something to make me unravel. You always think you're right, don't you, Mara?" Her voice trembled despite her effort to steady it. "You, with your shining ideals and your perfect sense of justice."

She drew a shuddering breath, closing her eyes. "I remember the trip to Dryl," she said quietly. "He left me on the Flagship for two weeks. Then three. Said he needed more time… for business." The words scraped out like something raw. *And I was stupid enough to miss him*.

She heard Adora shift, the soft sound of a step forward. Too close. Too dangerous. If Adora touched her now, she'd fall apart completely.

"Don't," Catra warned, voice low and shaking. "If you want me calm, then go. Just… get out, Mara."

[Quick Sketches I did that are not great but definitely make me want to draw some more of the characters. I really want to draw more Lonnie and Entrapta. I might write out their fling since it wasn’t featured much in this fic.]


Please accept these quick sketches while I work on much prettier things
<3
Calm down
I wasn't finished talking.
I need to draw some happy Entrapta art at some point
I should draw Lonnie more

Chapter End Notes

I am part way through the next chapter. You will like it. It's good. It's happy. The next 3 or 4 chapters are happy I believe, according to the plan.

Edit: I am struggling with the next couple of Catra chapters, they are complex. Lots of mixed emotions due to what's happening in them, lot of ups and a few downs

Obviously, updating the playlist as I go.

Chapter 21

Chapter Notes

TW: some thoughts about Prime.

This is what you've been waiting for (part 1 at least)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra wasn't sure how long she'd been in the east tower—long enough for her anger to burn itself out, leaving only the hollow ache behind. Her so-called "self-control" had come at a cost, as usual. The room bore the evidence of it: shredded cushions scattered like snowdrifts, a chair hurled clean through the window. That one almost made her proud. Those things were fucking heavy

When she finally came back to herself, she was slumped on the floor beside the overturned table, surrounded by the wreckage of what had once been a perfectly respectable spread of snacks—slices of cheese, bits of dried meat, tiny cakes, all mashed into the rug beneath her boots. Wine stained everything a dark, ugly red. The smell was thick and sour. She almost laughed at herself. *A child's tantrum*, she thought. *Real dignified.*

She inhaled, and it hurt. So she tried again. And again.

Her muscles protested as she stood. She brushed the dust from her clothes, ran her fingers through her tangled hair, and drew one last deep breath. Then she stood there for a moment, weighing whether she'd actually managed to calm down or if she was just pretending she had.

What she felt wasn't calm—it was empty. The kind of stillness that came after everything had already been destroyed. There was nothing left to do but face the fallout. There would be plenty of that. There always was.

Tonight was done. Useless. Wasted.

Lonnie was lost to her—maybe not in body, but in trust. And Entrapta hadn't cracked. That one still belonged to Prime, no matter what Catra had thrown at her. Two failures. Two fractures in a plan that couldn't afford any more.

And then—Adora.

Her Etherian would leave her. That had always been inevitable, hadn't it? No matter what happened tonight, no matter what was said or done, Adora would go. And when she did, things would change again. Catra would have to adapt. Learn to breathe on her own again. Learn to live without the constant presence of her.

Adora had kissed her.

Catra shut her eyes hard, pushing the thought away. It didn't belong to her. Not anymore. It was as meaningless as Lonnie's betrayal, or Entrapta's tears. Another useless distraction she couldn't afford. If not for the victory at Talon Mountain, the day would have been nothing but a ruin. What did it matter, really, that Adora's kiss had been gentle? That her first kiss—her *first* kiss—had been soft, and hesitant, and given by the woman who'd killed her mother?

None of it mattered.

✧

Adora of Bright Moon was standing in her rooms.

The door closed behind Catra with a muted thud.

By the bed, Adora turned toward her, the movement sharp, startled. A dozen emotions flickered across her face—surprise, confusion, alarm—and then something softer, something like amused realization.

“I’m sorry,” Adora said finally, the silence breaking. “I must’ve been brought to the wrong room.”

“No,” Catra said, quiet but sure. “You weren’t.”

Because she hadn’t told them. Hadn’t told anyone more than she had to. Because she hadn’t thought about separate rooms at all. Not once. Somewhere deep down, she’d assumed Adora would stay by her side until her last night.

Now they just stood there, staring at each other.

Catra’s heart was pounding so hard it hurt.

It was, Catra thought, their last night.

Their *last night*—and Adora had kissed her.

“Entrapta’s back in her quarters,” Adora said, cautious. “Under guard.”

That was irritating—infuriating, really—since Catra had ordered the woman thrown in a dungeon, not tucked into a room with linens and a view. But she wasn’t really listening.

“I don’t want to talk about Entrapta,” Catra said. “Or Prime.” Her voice trembled, not with weakness, but with the effort of control. There was only one thing clawing at her thoughts, pounding in her head like a war drum: this was the last night they’d have together. “You’re leaving tomorrow. Crossing the border. You won’t come back.” Her throat was tight. “Say it.”

“Catra—”

“Say it.” Her voice cracked sharp.

Adora didn’t flinch. Her chin lifted instead. “I’m leaving tomorrow,” she said quietly. “And no—I’m not coming back to the Horde.” She hesitated. “Catra, I—”

“No.” Catra cut her off. “I don’t care.” She stepped closer, her tone lower, rougher. “Tomorrow, you go. But tonight? You’re still mine. You are still my slave.”

Catra moved before she could stop herself. One heartbeat, Adora was standing by the bed; the next, Catra had her pinned there, pressed down, her knee sinking into the mattress, her hand spread flat over Adora’s chest.

“Wait—” Adora started, the word catching somewhere between protest and plea.

“I know this it what you want,” Catra said, voice low.

If she hesitated now—if she let herself think—she wouldn’t do it. She couldn’t. Sweetness would break her, and she couldn’t afford to break. She couldn’t give Adora kindness or apologies or any of the things she *should*. What she could give was this—raw, real, something she could *control*.

Her hands moved like they remembered. Prime had once praised her for how well she’d learned undress another without hesitation. She shoved that thought away like poison. This wasn’t for him. This was hers.

Her fingers were graceful, tracing the line of Adora’s shirt buttons, undoing them one by one. Adora’s breath caught. Her hands hovered awkwardly in the air, trembling slightly, as though unsure where to go—whether to push Catra away or pull her closer.

Catra could feel the heat of her, could feel her thigh beneath her. If she shifted even slightly, she could press her hips down, feel the muscle tense against her. The thought burned through her.

“What is happening?” Adora’s voice wasn’t angry—it was uneven, trembling around the edges. Not fear. Not exactly. She could throw Catra off if she wanted to. But she wasn’t.

“What's happening?” Catra echoed, her words soft but biting. Her breath was shaky now, too. She wanted to drag her claws lightly

over Adora’s skin, to taste the heat rising there. She wanted to kiss her again—hard, desperate—but she didn’t even know how to start. She had Adora’s shirt half undone, and that was its own victory. “You’re clearly not paying attention, are you?” she murmured.

Adora swallowed. “You’re upset,” she said. Her hands trembled, still suspended between them. “And even if you weren't—” her voice was quiet, breaking just slightly, “you never do anything without a reason.”

That hit her uncomfortably.

Catra froze mid-motion, her hand still tangled in fabric. Her chest rose and fell too fast. The insult wasn’t even unfair, but it still hurt. She couldn’t look at Adora—not when she knew what she’d see in those eyes. Not tonight. She needed to pretend that disgust wouldn't be there.

“Don’t I?” she muttered. *You kissed me. You kissed me first*. “I must want something from you, right?”

With a vicious tug, she tore through the last of the buttons, ripping Adora’s shirt open in one rough motion. The fabric fell away, baring warm, lamp-lit skin. Adora’s breath hitched; her body flinched beneath Catra’s touch like a startled animal.

Catra’s gaze dragged down. She wanted to press her palm against that trembling stomach—to feel the shiver, to claim it, to prove it was hers. To *own* the way Adora shook beneath her.

Her fingers twitched. She wanted to reach higher. To cup her breasts, to grasp, to feel their weight as she kneeded them.

And she hated that she wanted it so much.

“Catra.”

Catra’s ears flicked back before she could stop them. “I'm your Princess,” she snapped. “I never said you could call me that.”

Her tone was sharp, but her pulse betrayed her. She wanted to kiss her. She wanted to touch her. She wanted to *stop wanting*. It was infuriating—how easily Adora could make her forget the cage, the programming, the pain. All she knew were the lines she'd been forced to live by, and Adora broke them without even trying.

Adora's mouth pulled tight. "Your Highness," she said instead, and the words sounded like they cost her. There was strain in her voice—something brittle and aching. Catra looked up despite herself.

Adora's head was tipped back slightly, eyes closed as if she couldn't bear to see her. There was no disgust there—only restraint.

"I don't think *you* really want me," Adora said quietly.

The words sank in like her own claws. Catra's hand trembled as she reached out, unable to stop herself this time. When her fingers brushed Adora's skin, she felt a shiver move through the other woman.

Catra's fingers mover to the laces drawing Adora's pants closed. She pull them loose before slipping her hand in underneath. Her hand pressed against the thin layer fabric, already damp.

Catra watched her, captivated. Her gaze traced the shape of Adora's body with the same fascination she once reserved for weapons—impossible not to reach for. She wanted to taste the heat under her fingertips, to know her reactions by heart.

"You're so wet…" Catra breathed, then stopped herself. The part of her that still braced for punishment expected a blow, a command, a voice telling her what to do. But nothing came—only Adora's uneven breath.

Adora's tone was strained but steady. "You've seen me aroused before," she said.

Catra's mouth twitched. "Yeah," she said softly. "And I remember what you liked."

Catra's fingers slipped beneath Adora's underwear, parting her, feeling exactly how wet Adora was beneath her touch. When she finally slipped a finger inside Adora's breath hitched. The sound pulled a small, involuntary smile from Catra. For the first time in so long, she felt something that wasn't scripted. Something *hers*.

"You liked this," she murmured, teasing, her voice dropping into that low, dangerous purr Adora always seemed to draw out of her. "With Double Trouble—"

"That wasn't them," Adora cut in, smirking faintly. "That was you. You know that."

Catra slipped another finger inside, curling them both so that her claws scraped gently against the soft spongey sensitive spot inside her.

Adora made a noise somewhere between a gasp and a curse, reaching instinctively for her. Catra's reaction was quick, almost reflexive—pulling her fingers out to bat her hand away. "No." The word wasn't shouted; but it was a command.

Adora froze. Her hand fell back to the sheets, clutching tight. Only then did Catra continue.

With her now slicked fingers, Catra's fingers circled the bundle over nerves. When Adora let out a soft moan, Catra moved faster, pressed harder.

"You know," Adora managed between breaths, "Double Trouble used their mouth."

Catra remembered the feeling on her knees. The burn when she choked. The hand in her hair, tugging her back and forth—

She pushed the thought away again. He wasn't here.

“I don’t think I need to,” she said coldly. "I think I can make you cum just fine."

Adora groaned, trying to follow the rhythm Catra allowed. Catra pushed her back down again. This wasn’t generosity; it was possession. The one way she could still feel like she *chose* something.

Prime had broken her in too many ways to count. But here—now—she could still take back a fragment of power.

And Adora would let her.

When Catra slipped inside her again—three fingers, then four—pressing upwards just right. Adora's head fell back as she cursed. Catra could feel the way her inner walls gripped at her.

She couldn’t kiss her. Couldn’t let herself. But she memorized everything—the heat, the tremor, the way Adora’s voice cracked on her name. The way her hands fisted in the sheets like she was holding herself together.

For that moment—just one—Adora of Bright Moon belonged to her completely.

Adora’s eyes had been shut tight—like she was bracing for impact—but near the end, they opened. And when they met Catra’s, everything stopped.

It was too much. Too close. Too *honest*.

Adora was the one half-dressed and trembling on the bed, but somehow Catra felt more exposed. Like Adora had reached straight through her armour and found every raw, ugly part she kept buried. All the things she thought she’d hidden—even from herself—suddenly lay bare between them, fragile as glass.

Adora’s thighs tensed as she came apart, her breath catching, body arching before her eyes fluttered open again. And Catra—

Catra just sat there, frozen. She didn't feel triumph or satisfaction. She felt hollow. Foolish. Heart-sick.

What had this changed? Nothing.

She was still broken. Adora was still leaving. And now, instead of clean edges between them, there was this—this messy, aching thing that only made it harder to breathe.

The Queen of Bright Moon would be able to say she'd once been finger fucked by the Horde's Princess. Or—worse—by some uptight, half-reformed soldier still pretending she was fit to wear a crown.

"Good enough, I guess," Catra muttered, and it came out wrong—too raw, too thick in her throat. She turned away before the words could sink in. Before she had to see Adora's face.

But Adora caught her wrist. Her grip was firm yet trembling. "Catra—wait."

Catra looked back, startled. Adora's chest still rose and fell with unsteady breaths, her cheeks flushed. Her voice, when she spoke again, was low and bare of pride.

"Kiss me," Adora said.

The request made something twist painfully in Catra's chest. Her gaze betrayed her—sliding down Adora's body, the rise of muscle and skin, the soft curve of her stomach, the open shirt framing her shoulders. It was almost unbearable to look at her and *still not understand*.

Adora had already come undone. What else could she possibly want from her? What else could Catra give that wasn't already broken?

Won't you ever stop tormenting me? she wanted to say. *Can't you just let me be miserable in peace?*

But then Adora said it again, softer this time. “Kiss me.”

Not a command. Not a demand. A plea. And her hand tugged gently at Catra’s wrist—an invitation, not a capture.

Catra’s eyes flicked down to her mouth. She didn’t even know why she moved forward, only that the pull between them had never really gone away. Maybe it was because they’d been interrupted before—on the battlements—and some part of her had been waiting for this. Or maybe because kissing was the one thing Prime had never taken from her.

Adora tilted her head up, eyes closing, lips parting slightly in anticipation—waiting, trusting her to decide.

Catra placed a hand on her shoulder first, steadying herself. She wanted to cup Adora’s face, to hold her properly, but she didn’t dare. She didn’t know if she was allowed to want that.

She leaned in, brushing her lips against Adora’s—soft, uncertain, and careful. The contact sent a small shock through her, a pulse that made her heart stumble in her chest.

She drew back just slightly, breath catching. Her fingers twitched, wanting to touch her hair, but she stopped herself. The kiss was simple, nothing like what they’d already done—and yet it made her feel more vulnerable than anything that had come before.

When Adora pulled back, she did it gently, as if afraid to break her. Her blue eyes searched Catra’s face, and it was unbearable—because in that gaze, Catra could feel every wall inside her trembling. Adora could see it all: the fear, the longing, the exhaustion, the ache in her chest.

Surely she saw it. Surely she knew.

That Catra loved her—desperately, hopelessly, entirely. That she was terrified of the sunrise, of what it would take away.

Adora’s fingers brushed her jaw, skimming over the faint bruise there. She tilted Catra’s face upward.

Then Adora leaned in again, and her lips met the side of Catra’s throat.

At first, Catra didn’t understand. The brush of warmth there, the way Adora’s breath trembled against her skin—it didn’t make sense. And then it did.

Adora’s mouth moved upwards, tracing a line of perfect kisses up her neck. Catra could barely believe the gasp—the moan as Adora found the pinna of her ear and bit at it softly.

The world outside the room vanished. Time slowed.

Adora’s mouth moved lower, her hand steady at Catra’s jaw, guiding her just where she wanted her. Catra’s own breath came unevenly, another small sound escaping without permission.

Everything else—the war, Prime, duty, loss—was gone.

There was only this.

Only Adora.

Catra felt dazed—like the world had gone soft around the edges—when Adora finally drew back. Her brain felt fogged, her pulse still echoing somewhere in her throat. Those blue eyes held her fast, warm and dizzying, and she couldn’t seem to look away.

Adora’s hand was on her cheek, calloused but impossibly gentle, her thumb sweeping slow circles against Catra’s skin. Then her fingers slid back into her hair.

It shouldn’t have felt good. Catra hated people touching her hair. Always had. She didn’t let herself remember why. But Adora’s touch—gods—it made her lean into it without thinking.

Adora looked at her like she couldn’t believe Catra was real, like just being near her was some kind of miracle. That expression—pure, open, unguarded—made Catra’s chest tighten painfully again.

There was no trace of Prime in her touch. No shadow. No command. Just Adora.

When Adora’s hands cupped the sides of her head, Catra went still. Her breath caught.

Then Adora kissed her again—and this time, she used her tongue.

Catra trembled, startled by how quickly she melted into it. She opened her mouth, trying to follow her lead, clumsy and unsure, but wanting. Adora’s hands stayed steady at her jaw, firm but tender, guiding without forcing.

Adora kissed like she fought—with focus, with patience, with a kind of aching intensity that made Catra feel oddly limp, like she was jelly.

Catra made a sound—small, helpless—and Adora swallowed it between them, kissing her deeper.

Adora tasted like one of those sweet cakes Catra had mashed into the carpets earlier—though she hadn't seen Adora take one. Every drag of her teeth, every flicker of tongue made her want more, and she hated and loved how much she wanted it.

When they broke for air, Adora’s breathing was rough. Her forehead pressed lightly against Catra’s, and Catra’s fingers flexed, unsure where to go. The world had narrowed to heat and the sound of her own heartbeat.

Then Adora’s hands started to move—slowly, carefully—sliding down the front of Catra’s uniform. Her fingers traced the seams, following the shape of her body through the fabric.

She didn’t ask permission before undoing the first button.

Catra swallowed, pulse kicking harder in her chest. Of course this was where it would go. Adora was breathing harder now—intent, determined. She'd want to see her. To touch her. To finish what they'd started.

Adora paused briefly, glancing up at Catra through her lashes—not seeking permission exactly, just *checking*. And then she went on, fingers deft on the buttons.

Catra's breathing hitched. She told herself to relax. To want this. To let herself have it, for once.

She did want it. She didn't want it. Both things at once, crashing together until she couldn't tell which feeling hurt more.

This was the price, she told herself. The cost of one more night. The last one. If she could keep Adora here—if she could have this—then maybe that was enough. Maybe it didn't matter how much it broke her.

She undressed Catra as she had many nights before tonight—sliding her hands underneath the jacket, pulling it off her shoulders. Then her undershirt—one that tied to the side—she unlaced and pulled open. Catra shivered. Adora's hands were greedy now, exploring the planes of her torso, the curve of her ribs.

This time, she wasn't just touching. This time, she was *taking her in.*

Catra's heart stuttered. The thought—*she's really going to…*—hit her like a shock.

Her hands found Adora's skin in return—tracing the line of her collarbone, the smooth slope downward. She brushed her knuckles gently against her chest, her touch light and hesitant.

Adora's breath caught. Catra's fingers lingered, tracing circles, before she pressed a thumb to a peaked pink nipple.

The sound that escaped her was soft, involuntary, and Adora's mouth curved into a grin. That old, infuriating grin—cocky, bright, impossible not to want.

"You want to keep going?" Catra managed, her voice raw, cracking slightly at the edges.

Adora's grin widened, slow and real this time. "I might," she said. Her tone was teasing, but her eyes—her eyes were pure tenderness.

She rolled her thumb over Catra's skin again, then leaned in close enough for her breath to brush her ear.

"Nothing you don't want," she whispered.

The words were a promise. A vow.

Catra froze. Her chest rose and fell, fast, uneven. She remembered what she'd said before—*I don't think you really want me.*

Now, hearing Adora's voice she wasn't sure she'd been right.

Not about Adora.

Not about any of it.

"You don't think I want to keep going?" Catra's voice was a barely a whisper.

Adora froze for only a heartbeat before she moved. The bed dipped beneath her sudden weight, the world tilting as Adora pushed Catra down, her hands braced against the mattress on either side of her.

The motion stole Catra's breath. It wasn't rough—but it was decisive. Adora above her, eyes bright and jaw set, was a force of nature wrapped in soft skin and barely contained restraint.

It should have been ridiculous—Adora half-undressed, her shirt hanging open, her hair mussed, her chest still flushed from before—but there was nothing funny about it.

Because it was *Adora*.

And Adora had a way of making even vulnerability look commanding.

She hovered there for a moment, as if realizing exactly what she was doing, then exhaled and pulled the rest of her shirt off, tossing it aside. The muscles in her arms and shoulders caught the light, smooth and defined. She hesitated only long enough to glance at Catra again—as though still needing to make sure this was real, that this was allowed.

Catra's heart was thundering. Every nerve in her body screamed for touch, but her mind spun in protest. There was so little between them now—just layers of cloth and pride—and she didn't know which would tear first.

"Like being on top, huh?" Catra managed, her voice lower, rougher than she intended.

Adora smirked, the expression caught somewhere between playful and deadly serious. "Guess I do," she said.

Her gaze traveled down Catra's body and her hand followed, fingertips tracing over the fabric that still covered her. Her touch was feather-light, but every brush left a trail of fire.

When Adora's hand stopped, resting meaningfully at her hip, Catra's breath hitched. Every part of her wanted to move, to press closer, but she forced herself to stay still. She'd spent a lifetime learning control; she wouldn't lose it now.

Adora began to unlace Catra's pants, tugging on the drawstring that held her back from her intended prize.

Catra could feel her pulse everywhere.

And then, without thinking, she pushed her heel up against Adora’s chest, halting her.

It wasn’t anger. It wasn’t rejection. It was instinct—defense, defiance, a flicker of fear she couldn’t control.

Adora froze immediately, eyes snapping up to meet hers. No offense taken. No surprise. Just steady understanding—and maybe, just maybe, a spark of arousal.

The tension broke when Catra realized Adora *liked* it. The look in her eyes said as much. Catra’s pulse steadied, and something inside her shifted—her resistance turning into something else.

“I'm waiting.” she said, tilting her head, her tone light but her eyes daring.

Adora’s answering smile was pure fire. She reached up, wrapped her hands around Catra’s ankle, lifting her boot away.

Her gaze stayed locked on Catra’s face as she discarded it, then the other. Every movement was a promise of what was coming next.

Adora climbed back over her, moving with the easy grace of someone who’d spent months holding herself back—and was finally done doing so.

Then she kissed Catra again.

It was unhurried this time—softer again. Adora kissed like she wanted to memorize her. Every movement of her hands was patient, exploratory, tracing the lines of Catra’s body as if she were committing them to memory.

Her fingers made their way back to the drawstring left partially undone, and finished the job. Catra was only slightly aware of Adora’s fingers slipping under the waisband.

She made an alarmed little sound, too high to be a moan, as her Etherian finally touched her, skin, finally, to skin—as she parted her, gently. She arched, thrust, blindly, up against her.

Catra's arms shook as she reached up, wrapping them around Adora. It felt foreign, terrifying, wonderful. She wasn't used to holding anyone this close, wasn't used to being allowed to touch back.

But Adora didn't stop her.

She didn't command or control; she let her. She *wanted* her.

Catra's thoughts blurred. Her body melted into the mattress as Adora's hands mapped her, every touch building, spreading warmth like a slow tide. Her breath came in uneven gasps, her mind gone so completely soft around the edges.

Adora's mouth moved again—her neck, her shoulder, lower still.

Catra's breath broke on a soft, startled sound. The last of her defenses faltered.

For once, she didn't think about what she should be feeling. She just *felt it.*

Catra blinked up, confused when Adora pulled back. For a heartbeat she didn't understand why—why Adora had shifted, why her gaze was fixed so intently downward. The air felt heavier. Her face was hot, her pulse hammering in her throat.

Adora wasn't looking at her face anymore.

She was… studying her. Quietly, with focus, like she was something fragile that deserved her full attention. The weight of that look made Catra feel exposed in a way she wasn't used to—like Adora wasn't just seeing her body, but the parts of her she kept buried.

Catra’s thoughts tangled. Her chest ached with the effort to breathe. For a second she wanted to laugh, to make some flippant remark about being “everyone's is different,” to dispel the tension building between them. Anything to keep from trembling.

Instead, she just stared. She wanted to say something—wanted to apologize, absurdly, for herself. For existing. For wanting. But no words came. So when Adora reached to help her remove the last of her clothing, Catra simply obeyed, lifting her hips, her mind blank and spinning.

Then they were both bare, except for the jacket and shirt still tangled around Catra’s arms, binding her just enough to make her feel contained. The illusion of restraint should have unnerved her. Instead, it steadied her.

Adora didn’t rush. She traced the edge of Catra’s thigh with her fingertips, following the line of muscle until her thumb found the quick beat of her pulse. She leaned in and pressed her lips there.

The touch was so tender it made Catra’s throat close.

Adora lingered for a moment, lips brushing skin, her breath warm. She wasn’t taking, wasn’t commanding. She was… offering. Something Catra didn’t know how to accept.

“Wait,” Catra blurted, the words harsh in the quiet. “I’m not—”

Adora lifted her head, her expression open, confused. “You’re not what?”

Catra swallowed hard. Her voice came out too sharp, trying to armour itself. “I’m not—doing that back. Just so you know.”

Adora’s brows knit. “What?”

Catra forced herself to meet her eyes, even as her heart pounded painfully against her ribs. “I’m not going to—” she hesitated, cheeks burning, “reciprocate. So if that’s what you’re expecting, then you’d better know now.”

It sounded defensive even to her own ears. She couldn’t tell if she wanted to offend Adora or spare her.

Adora stared for a long moment—long enough that Catra almost regretted saying anything at all. Then she said, calm and utterly unbothered, “So?”

That single word—the simplicity of it—made Catra’s stomach twist. “Do you want me to lick your cunt?” she started, exasperated, flustered—resorting to crude language to deflect her own discomfort. “Because I don’t plan to.”

Adora’s lips curved into a faint, knowing smile. “Catra,” she said quietly, still holding her gaze, “you really don’t have to warn me, I've done this before.”

And before Catra could find a retort, Adora moved again, her mouth closing over where Catra had most wanted her. Where she had felt hot and warm every time she thought about the last time Adora had been there.

Catra’s words died in her throat, replaced by a soft, startled sound. Her whole body tensed, then melted, the protest she’d been building lost in the sudden rush of warmth and sensation.

Whatever she had meant to say no longer mattered.

Chapter End Notes

> Check back in I don't know, 10 hours, and maybe I'll have added the art I planned to put in this chapter. Or it'll be at the very start of the next chapter.

Chapter 22

Chapter Notes

I updated the tags.

More smut, enjoy ✌️

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Nothing had ever broken her quite like this.

Adora of Bright Moon was between her thighs.

Adora of Bright Moon was really *doing this*.

Again.

Catra half-sat up without thinking, curling forward, her knees drawing in as though she could contain the feeling. Her hands hovered uncertainly above Adora's head—half wanting to touch her, half terrified that doing so would make her stop. A sound slipped from her, unguarded and raw.

She'd known submission before—the ugly, forced, degrading kind. She knew pain and endurance, obedience learned in fear. She knew the taste of cruelty and the weight of hands that hurt rather than cared.

But this—this was nothing like that.

Adora's movements were slow at first. She seemed utterly focused, her breath steady, her touch patient. It wasn't hunger alone—it was care. And the strangest thing of all was that she *seemed to like it.*

A low, quiet sound left Adora's throat, one that vibrated through Catra's body. It didn't sound like she was performing a chore. It sounded like pleasure. Catra stared, transfixed, her lips parting.

Adora's tongue moved and searched, jutting inside her every now and then in a way that made Catra arch and moan.

Adora's hands slid up along her legs, strong but gentle, thumbs tracing circles over every sensitive inch of her. Every motion was purposeful, confident. Catra couldn't stop trembling.

Adora's eyes lifted, catching hers for a heartbeat. There was something almost amused there—warm and teasing. A tiny,

infuriating spark of satisfaction, like she was proud of the effect she was having.

And Stars help her, Catra *liked* it. She loved that look in her eye.

The sound she made next wasn't something she recognized—it was too soft, too desperate. Her claws tore faint lines into the sheets to keep from reaching for Adora, from tangling her fingers in her hair, from grinding up into her.

It was too much. Adora was relentless. She knew exactly how to hold Catra still when her body tried to escape her own pleasure. Every instinct screamed to surrender to it, but something deep inside refused to let go.

Catra's mind spun. She'd been touched before, used before—but never like this. Never where every flicker of sensation was matched by something else, something dangerous and tender all at once.

Her thoughts tangled with memory, with fear, with the unbearable truth of what Adora meant to her. Every soft sound that escaped her was suddenly a betrayal.

Adora's attentions moved to Catra's clit alone—tongue flicking at it, circling as she sucked deliciously at it.

It built too quickly, that wave rising, unstoppable. The room blurred; her breath came in short, broken gasps. She could almost—almost—let herself go.

Then the thought hit her. Hard.

She couldn't. She couldn't let herself fall apart, not here, not with *her*.

It felt like a punch to the gut—the realization, the terror of release. Catra's body wanted to yield, to drown in it, but her mind clawed for control.

And she couldn’t.

She wouldn’t.

She bit down on a sob and turned her face away, trembling so violently she thought she might shatter.

Catra came back to herself piece by piece, her body trembling, breath breaking unevenly. She didn’t even realize at first that Adora had stopped—that the rhythm had gone still. She was lying flat on the sheets, eyes squeezed shut, her whole body still coiled tight from what she’d almost allowed. The denial hurt. The ache of it left her shaking.

When she finally opened her eyes, Adora was there, still close—her head lowered, her mouth pressing gentle, scattered kisses along Catra’s inner thigh. Her hands were warm and steady, smoothing over Catra’s hips in slow, soothing motions. She wasn’t speaking. Just waiting. Patient as always.

It took everything Catra had to force herself to look at her. The courage to do even that came in fragments, pieced together between shallow breaths. Adora didn’t push. She simply waited.

“I…” Catra started, voice hoarse. “I find it hard to—” she stopped, swallowed, tried again, quieter—“I can't.”

Her chest rose sharply with each inhale. “Release,” she added. The word came out like a confession.

Adora rested her chin lightly on Catra’s knee, utterly at ease despite their closeness, despite their nakedness. She looked up with that maddening calm, tracing lazy shapes—little figure-eights—with her fingertips along the inside of Catra’s thigh. It wasn’t calculated. It was instinctive, soothing. Comfort for comfort’s sake.

“I can tell,” Adora murmured, her tone half teasing, half tender.

Catra let out a strangled noise that might’ve been a laugh. Or maybe a sob. She pressed both palms to her eyes until colors

bloomed behind them. She wanted to laugh properly—to make a joke, to turn the moment into something easier—but she couldn't quite get there. She was too aware of how exposed she was. How utterly defenseless.

Unlike Adora, who seemed incapable of embarrassment, Catra felt it burn through her skin. She was sprawled open, completely revealed, and Adora was still right there—touching her, watching her, being impossibly gentle. It was almost unbearable.

It was their last night. The thought clawed at her like a wound. Their last night before morning took Adora away. Before everything ended.

Catra lowered her hands from her face. She told herself the tremor in her voice didn't matter—that Adora would understand.

Adora, soft-voiced, started to say something—"I wish I could—"

"You want to take me," Catra interrupted, quiet but certain.

Her words weren't a question. And Adora didn't deny it. The idea made Catra's pulse jump; it terrified her. It thrilled her. She could see it in Adora's eyes—the want, the hesitation, the reverence. Catra's mouth twitched. "Like a man takes a girl?" she added, mocking herself before Adora could.

Adora's answer came gently, without shame. "Like one person takes another," she said. "Like someone who wants you. Who wants you to feel good."

Her hand traced a path up Catra's thigh, over the trembling plane of her stomach, and came to rest above her heart. "I want to take pleasure in you," Adora said, "and give it back to you. That's all."

The words hit Catra somewhere deep. They shouldn't have sounded as devastating as they did. Something in Adora's tone—possessive and submissive all at once—made her shiver. She wanted to believe it, wanted to believe that it could be that

simple. That she could belong, even for a moment, to someone who didn’t see her as broken.

Adora shifted, stretching out over her, the strength in her body evident even in the smallest movement. She hovered just above Catra, close enough that every exhale brushed her skin.

“I wish,” Adora whispered, voice rough, “I could be inside you.” Her breath caught as she spoke the words. “I want you to fall apart in my arms.”

Catra huffed a laugh that was half disbelief, half fondness, her mouth curling in a small, shaky smile. “You make it sound so easy,” she said.

Adora smiled back, her expression soft and sure. “It is,” she whispered.

Adora took Catra into a deep kiss again. Catra’s tension eased, melting against her. She could taste herself on Adora’s lips, and the realization made her dizzy. She reached up, cautiously threading her fingers through Adora’s hair, marveling at the soft gold of it between her claws. She didn’t pull—just twisted a curl around her finger, watching it spring free again.

Adora laughed quietly, that warm, earnest sound that always found its way under Catra’s skin.

“It’s simple,” Adora repeated, her voice a low murmur against her mouth.

Adora hovered there, holding herself up with effortless strength, every muscle drawn taut to keep her weight from settling. She could have pinned Catra easily. Could have taken control completely. But she didn’t. She waited. She wanted Catra to ask for it.

And that made Catra want it all the more.

Adora's voice carried that bright, confident lilt that always made Catra want to claw the nearest wall. Certain, teasing—like she already knew she was going to win. She said it so easily, as if the whole universe would bend for her.

Adora kissed her again—softly, annoyingly tender. Catra frowned into it.

"So that's it, huh?" Catra muttered. "You want me to roll over so you can play the man."

It wasn't really about the words; it was about the power. Adora could make anything sound simple, make Catra's head spin with her ridiculous faith in people, in *them*. Even now—especially now—when Catra's mind was a snarl of contradictions, Adora looked at her like this was the easiest thing in the world.

Adora only smiled, unbothered, shifting onto one elbow to brush a stray lock of hair from Catra's forehead. She pressed light kisses—one to her brow, one to the bridge of her nose, one to her mouth. Each one more disarming than the last.

"Then tell me what *you* want," Adora murmured. "Unless you think I've got a secret cock lying around somewhere."

Catra's gaze flicked, before she could stop herself, toward the wooden chest in the corner—the one she still hadn't unpacked since they'd arrived.

Adora's brow arched. "Wait. Do you?"

Catra sighed—loudly, dramatically, to cover her nerves—and slid out from under her. The air felt too cold all of a sudden. She stalked across the room, kneeling to open the chest. Her hands found the object easily enough, wrapped and hidden. She pulled it free, along with its belt, and turned—avoiding Adora's gaze as she passed it to her.

"Try not to look so smug," Catra muttered, climbing back onto the bed. She lay back, trying to ignore the sound of buckles and

leather. Trying not to think about what came next.

The room felt unbearably still. Catra shut her eyes. Her chest rose and fell too fast, every breath a battle between dread and anticipation. This was really happening. Adora—of all people—was going to take her.

She thought of the ways she'd been used before, the weight of commands she couldn't disobey, the sharp voice of Prime echoing through memory: *Look at you. Filthy. Broken.*

She clenched her fists. Not tonight.

"I want—" Her voice caught, the words like shards in her throat. She couldn't say it. Couldn't say *I want to have sex with you.* It would make her too exposed, too real. She settled for, "I just… want it to be simple."

She hoped Adora would understand what that meant.

The look Adora gave her said she did. Every trace of teasing was gone.

"Turn over," she said.

Catra held her eyes for a second longer than she should have. Then she exhaled, slow and trembling, and turned away.

Her body remembered this shape too well. Knees positioned, back arched, hands fisting in the sheets. It was reflex, drilled into her long ago, but she hated how easily it came back. The posture of surrender and control all at once.

She buried her face against the pillow, hoping Adora couldn't see the heat rising in her cheeks. The air in the room felt thick, heavy. Every sound seemed louder—the quiet stretch of leather, Adora's steady breathing, her own heart hammering against the mattress.

Waiting was always the worst part.

And then—movement. A slow shift in the bed's weight. A deep breath behind her.

Adora's hand touched her first—light, uncertain—then firmer, sliding along her back, down over her hip. Her touch was slow.

Adora slipped a finger between her legs, gently brushing against the place her mouth had so freely explored moments ago. A single slipped inside, meeting strict tension.

"You're shaking," Adora said quietly. Her tone was soft, but Catra could hear the frown in it. "You're so tense."

That only made her tighten further, her whole body stiffening under Adora's palm. She could feel her presence close now—the heat of her, the faint press of the faux phallus against her thigh, the warmth of her breath against the base of her spine.

Adora's fingers splayed over her skin, tracing the curve of her hip, the dip of her waist. Her voice came low, almost hesitant now.

"Are you sure you've done this before?"

Against her will, Catra felt her throat tighten and her vision blur. She blinked hard, furious at herself for it, but the tears still came.

"Yes," she managed, voice rough and trembling, the word barely shaped around the knot in her chest.

Adora's touch was maddeningly gentle—her fingers tracing a slow line down the small of Catra's back.

Adora slipped another finger inside, testing.

"This?" Adora asked softly, her tone almost playful but edged with concern.

"Yes," Catra forced out, her voice breaking. She hated how small it sounded.

Adora's hand slid out and upward instead, resting between her shoulder blades. Catra swallowed a sound that threatened to escape her as Adora leaned forward, her weight shifting until the warmth of her body pressed close. She brushed her lips against the back of Catra's neck—gentle, patient, heartbreakingly tender.

"Relax," Adora murmured, her voice low, steady. "You don't have to—"

"Don't," Catra cut her off, her tone sharp and fraying. "I don't want to talk about it."

Adora froze behind her. The silence that followed felt suffocating. Catra's heart pounded, and she knew—she *knew* she'd ruined it. Her voice had cracked; the tears must have been obvious now.

She wanted to scream, to claw something, to erase the look she imagined must be on Adora's face—pity, confusion, maybe disgust. The ache in her chest twisted tighter.

That's it, she thought bitterly. *She's done. She's finally seen what a broken mess I am*.

Catra's thoughts spiraled. She could already see it: Adora walking away, out to her waiting soldiers. Dozens of strong, eager bodies ready to welcome her—ready to worship her the way Catra couldn't. Adora didn't need this, didn't need *her*. There were simpler, cleaner options. People who wouldn't break in her hands.

She should've sent Adora to them. Should've let her have the night she deserved. But Catra had wanted—no, *needed*—this. Needed to prove she could be wanted, too. Needed to know what it was like to choose, just once, instead of being chosen *for* something.

And now she'd wrecked it.

No. She refused to let that be the end.

Adora was tugging at her shoulder, gently, coaxing her to turn back over. Catra resisted for a heartbeat, then gave in, letting herself be guided.

When she finally faced her, Adora's expression was soft—searching. Her eyes flicked over Catra's face and lingered on the wet streaks she hadn't managed to hide.

Adora reached out, brushing a tear away with her thumb. She looked at it curiously, as if it were something puzzling. Then her gaze returned to Catra's, and the shame hit hard and fast.

She hated how raw she felt—how exposed under that steady blue stare.

"Always gotta fight everything," Adora said quietly. It wasn't mocking. It was fond, almost sad. "Even yourself."

Catra swallowed, jaw tightening. "Then don't give me something to fight."

The words came out hoarse, halfway between a challenge and a plea.

Adora's brow furrowed, the smallest crease of worry forming there.

Catra's hands fisted in the sheets. Her voice dropped to something low, cracked, but unflinching. "Just—fuck me."

She'd meant it to sound sharp, commanding, defiant—to turn the trembling into control. But it came out softer than she wanted.

Adora's eyes softened. She didn't smile this time. "I want to," she said, her voice steady and sincere. She hesitated, studying her. "But do *you* want me to?"

The question broke something open in Catra. She shut her eyes against it, unable to stand the tenderness in Adora's voice—the patience, the care. It was the one thing she couldn't fight.

Catra didn’t know. Not really.

She didn’t know if she could let go any further than this—if she even had that part of herself left to surrender. There wasn’t time for slow acclimation, no time for learning how to exist in this kind of closeness. The night was all they had.

And Catra had already wasted too much of it being afraid.

She didn’t understand how this kind of intimacy worked—not with someone like Adora. Not with someone who asked what she wanted. The idea of sex as something shared, something joyful and open, was as alien to her as the stars beyond Etheria’s sky.

She couldn’t make sense of it: why Adora cared whether she found pleasure, why that seemed to matter more than anything else. Did she think it was about fairness? About keeping a score? What if Catra had let go earlier, when Adora’s mouth had been on her—would she have stopped then, content? Would it still have been enough for her? Or was this some strange, noble act.

If they stopped to talk about it, they’d still be talking when the sun rose.

“I do want it,” Catra said at last. The words scraped out of her like something painful. “So stop… overthinking it. Just—get on with it.”

Her voice was raw. The truth beneath it was worse. She was terrified. Terrified that Adora, with her stupid sense of honor, might hesitate. Might look at her and decide she wasn’t worth the risk.

She wanted this more than she feared it. That was all that mattered.

Adora seemed to understand that now.

She moved slowly, deliberately, stretching herself over Catra again. One of her hands slid up Catra’s arm until she found her

fingers and laced them together. That simple touch—that tether—nearly undid her. Then Adora kissed her again, like before.

It was unhurried—as if Adora was memorizing her. And somehow, this, just this, felt more intimate than anything else that had come before. More than being laid bare. More than Adora's mouth between her thighs. The press of her weight, the warmth of her skin, the way their bodies fit together—all of it felt too real, too much. Catra could feel herself shaking beneath her, and Adora didn't seem to mind.

She could feel Adora smiling faintly against her mouth, as if the trembling didn't scare her at all. As if she knew she could calm it.

Catra gave herself over to the kiss, desperate to lose thought, to lose self. She followed Adora's lead, uncertain but eager, trying to mimic her movements—the gentle drag of tongue and lip, the push and pull of breath between them. She tried not to think about Prime, or her body, or what might come next. She tried to think only of this—of Adora's warmth, the sound of her breathing, the feeling of her hand still twined with her own.

Piece by piece, Catra began to loosen. To uncoil.

It felt like thawing after years of winter. Slowly, the noise in her mind quieted until it was just the two of them—the press of Adora's mouth, the weight of her body, the soft pulse of their joined hands.

If she could freeze one moment from her entire life, Catra thought, this would be it.

Eventually, Adora drew back. She brushed the hair from Catra's face, her eyes steady and full of something soft. Catra felt warm all over—almost safe and completely protected.

Adora's gaze searched hers, a flicker of uncertainty crossing her face. She was checking. Waiting. *I went too fast,* her expression seemed to say. *Is this better?*

The thought made Catra ache—that Adora, of all people, might doubt her own gentleness.

For the first time that night, Catra realized Adora was nervous, too.

Adora shifted to lie beside her, on her side, propped up on one arm. Catra stayed on her back, letting herself breathe. Their mouths found each other again and again in soft, unhurried kisses neither seemed able to stop.

Catra could feel Adora's arm slide around her, drawing her closer. Without thinking, she hooked one leg over Adora's hip. Her body moved before her brain could argue—seeking warmth, seeking contact. Her hand found Adora's hair, tangling in the golden curls.

Adora drew back just enough to look down at her. "Do you want me to…?" she began, her voice rough, uncertain. The question broke off halfway, like it was embarrassing to ask, after all this.

Catra's stomach twisted, fear sparking again. But this time, the fear was small. Manageable. She wanted this. She wanted *her*.

"Yes," Catra whispered. Her throat was tight, her voice barely there.

Adora's answer was a kiss.

And Catra held on as though the entire world might fall away if she didn't.

Adora shifted between Catra's legs

From this angle she looked different—commanding, focused, it made Catra's pulse stumble. The glow from the lamplight caught along Adora's shoulders, her chest, the hard line of her jaw.

Adora's palms smoothed over Catra's thighs. She lifted her legs, pushing them up experimentally as if gauging Catra's range, and the grin that tugged at her lips was half amusement, half awe.

"*Very* flexible," Adora murmured, almost teasing. "Didn't know you had that in you."

Catra's face burned. She obeyed when Adora guided her knees upward, folding them close, holding them there even as her whole body screamed self-consciousness. She had never felt so exposed—so open under that gaze.

It wasn't dignified. Then again, no position really was.

Adora leaned forward, adjusting her hold, guiding Catra's legs to rest on her shoulders. She pressed a small kiss against the inside of Catra's knee, another to the top of her thigh.

Catra gasped when she felt it—Adora moving inside her, slow, steady. Her hands clenched in the sheets; her breath caught in a startled, helpless sound she hadn't meant to make.

It wasn't what she had imagined. Not in the fantasies she never admit she had. This was deeper, heavier, *realer*. The stretch, the pressure, the intimacy—it was too much and not enough at once.

Adora's eyes never left her face. They were dark now, molten, full of want and something else—something that made Catra's chest ache. That look said, *You're mine*, even if Adora never would.

And for a heartbeat, Catra wanted to answer, *Yes*.

But she couldn't. Because tomorrow Adora would be gone. And if she looked into those eyes too long, she might believe—stupidly, hopelessly—that Adora wanted to stay.

Adora's pace stayed slow, steady—torturously controlled. She kissed Catra's neck, her jaw, the hollow beneath her ear.

"Catra," she whispered, voice thick and low, each word vibrating against her skin. She shifted, easing closer, pressing them chest to chest, so every breath, every heartbeat lined up.

Catra clung to her, voice breaking around half-formed words. She didn't realize she'd spoken until she heard herself—

"Harder."

The word came out like a command, but it trembled at the edges, raw and pleading. She didn't even recognize her own voice.

Adora obeyed.

Each thrust drew another sound from Catra's throat, each one sharper than the last, until she was barely coherent—reduced to ragged gasps and the desperate rhythm of her hips rising to meet her.

"Please," she breathed. It wasn't clear what she was begging for—release, mercy, forever—but it poured out of her anyway, unstoppable. "Please—"

It hit her all at once: the years of loneliness, the ache of every lost connection, the awful, fragile joy of having *this*, right now, in her arms.

Why couldn't anything in her life just stay? Why couldn't she have *this*, without losing it?

"Please," she whispered again, clinging tighter. *Please love me. Please don't go.*

Adora's breathing hitched. "Catra," she moaned, voice breaking open into something raw and desperate. The sound of it tore through her.

"Catra," Adora gasped, voice half-shattered, half-worshipful. Then, in First One's: "You sound so fucking beautiful. Every sound you make."

Even through the haze, Catra's body reacted to it—to the language, to the voice, to *her*.

Adora’s head fell forward, breath hot against her skin. “Catra,” she whispered again, the words trembling. “Come for me.”

And Catra, in the same ancient tongue, answered, softly but certain—

“Yes.”

Bonus: Entrapta and Lonnie. I have started writing a little series for their behind the scenes romance.



Chapter End Notes

I'm really tired and I've gotten a bunch of anon hate lately for this story. So if you are not enjoying this, stop reading it.

Chapter 23: Adora

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora felt *happy*. Truly, bone-deep, almost disbelievingly happy. The kind of happiness that left her body warm and heavy, her mind soft and floating. Every inch of her skin hummed with the afterglow, the phantom weight of Catra still pressed against her.

She could hear movement—the faint rustle of sheets, the creak of a floorboard. Through her half-lidded haze, she realised Catra had slipped from the bed. Adora shifted, slow and languid, turning her head toward the sound. She caught only a glimpse of movement disappearing through the archway into the adjoining room.

For a moment, Adora just lay there—naked, unhurried, the cool air brushing across her skin. Her limbs felt deliciously heavy, her pulse still thrumming low. The faint glint of her slave cuffs caught the lamplight, the metal stark against her bare wrists and throat.

She smiled faintly, tracing a thumb over the edge of one cuff. *Bed slave*. The thought made her want to laugh. It was absurd. It was also… true. For tonight, at least.

She closed her eyes and let herself remember—the first time she had pushed inside Catra, the sound she had made, the way her whole body had arched, startled, fierce, *alive*. That image alone was enough to make Adora's stomach twist in quiet awe.

When she opened her eyes again, Catra had returned.

She stood framed in the doorway, backlit by the softer light from the other room. She'd pulled her white shirt back on—nothing else. Adora remembered tugging it halfway off earlier, remembered how it had tangled around Catra's wrists. The hem barely reached the tops of her thighs. The sight sent a slow ache through Adora's chest.

Catra moved across the room with her usual restless grace, though slower now, her body a little stiff from exertion. Adora propped herself up on one elbow, chin resting in her hand, and let herself watch.

"You can—uh, you should probably relieve yourself," Catra said, pausing at the table. She poured water into a cup, her tone clipped, practical, as if the words were armor. She set the cup on the low bench beside the bed. "Here."

"Come back to bed," Adora said, quietly.

"I…" Catra hesitated.

Adora reached out before she could finish the sentence, catching her hand. Their fingers fit together like they were meant to. Catra froze, looking down the length of their joined arms.

The feel of her hand hit Adora like a fresh shock. Every heartbeat felt new, sharp with wonder. She'd known Catra's touch in battle, in anger, she remembered the feeling of her claws—but this was different. This was… gentle. And it undid her.

Catra's usual edge had returned in pieces—her chin slightly lifted, her expression trying for aloof—but she hadn't buttoned herself back into her uniform. She hadn't put her boots back on. She was still here. Still soft around the edges.

Adora tugged lightly on her hand.

Catra resisted, only half-heartedly, then gave in, ending up awkwardly braced with one knee on the mattress and a hand near Adora's shoulder. The position made her look unsteady, unsure of what to do next. Adora looked up at her and felt her heart squeeze again.

"You take liberties," Catra muttered, her voice tight.

Adora grinned, lazy and unrepentant. "Come back to bed, Your Highness."

That earned her a long, slow look. Adora felt a rush of affection so strong it made her dizzy. She gestured toward the cup of water. “Did you really bring that for me?”

Catra hesitated, then nodded, eyes darting away. “I… thought you might be thirsty.”

The simplicity of it caught Adora off guard. She blinked, her chest tightening with something almost painful. Catra meant it. She had *thought of her*.

Adora couldn’t help smiling. “So this is what it's like to get you in bed, huh?” she teased softly.

Catra’s brow furrowed. “What am I like?”

“Kind,” Adora said, her voice gentle now, full of quiet awe. “And impossible to read.” Her thumb brushed over the back of Catra’s hand. “I should be bring you water, I'm suppose to be serving you.”

“I…” Catra hesitated again, cheeks coloring faintly. “I needed to take care of myself anyway, as you should.”

It took Adora a beat too long to understand. Then she did—and the blush rose in *her* cheeks instead.

There was a self-conscious air about Catra now—like the reality of what she’d done with *Mara* had caught up with her. The absurdity of it, maybe. A princess tending to a slave.

Adora’s gaze drifted back to the cup of water that still sat beside her, its surface trembling faintly in the candlelight. It was such a small thing, yet her chest ached at the sight of it. *She brought that for me*.

Catra’s face was still flushed, her posture taut—shoulders drawn, jaw locked, trying too hard to seem composed. Adora shifted, resting her chin in her hand to study her. The sight stirred something quiet and tender in her.

“Gonna make me sleep at the foot of the bed?” Adora asked, her tone easy, teasing. “Please don’t. It’s a long way, and it looks cold and lonely.”

Catra’s eyes flicked toward her, wary, guarded. Then, switching to First Ones, she said, “Is that how it’s done in Bright Moon? I can kick you if I need something before morning.”

Adora laughed softly. “*Something?* That’s what we’re calling it?”

Catra blinked, feigning confusion. “Is that the wrong word?”

“Well, we’re not in Bright Moon.” Adora stretched out lazily on the sheets, voice dropping to something almost daring. “Why don’t you show me how things work in the Fright Zone instead?”

Catra’s mouth twitched. “We didn’t keep slaves in the Fright Zone.”

“I’d have to disagree,” Adora said, reclining on her side, utterly unbothered under Catra’s sharp stare.

"I meant when I lived here, when I was younger." Catra explained.

The humor faded into quiet again. It struck her all over again—their situation, the sheer impossible *fact* of it. The war, her enslavement—all gone for this one night. Catra was still half-dressed, the loose white shirt hanging open at her throat, her bare legs lit up by the lamp. Adora didn’t move; she simply looked at her.

Catra had cleaned herself up. There was no visible trace left of what had happened between them. Even her hair—hopelessly messy at the best of times—looked unchanged. Catra’s ability to erase herself, to armor back up, was uncanny.

Adora waited.

Catra shifted her weight. “I lack…” She hesitated, eyes darting briefly to the wall, then back. “The—uh—laid back attitude some would have with…” She pushed the word out, barely audible. “A lover.”

Adora’s lips curved. “You lack that laid back attitude with *anyone*, Catra.”

That earned her a sharp exhale, almost a laugh. Just almost.

A hand’s breadth separated them—bare skin and heat and silence between. Adora could see the minute tremor in Catra’s chest when she took a breath, saw her close her eyes as if to steady herself.

“You’re not…” Catra started, then faltered. Her voice was softer when she tried again. “You’re not the way I thought you would be.”

Adora tilted her head. “You thought about what I'd be like in bed?”

Catra’s eyes flicked toward her, then away again. “You kissed me. I thought about it.”

“I remember,” Adora said, a quiet smile tugging at her lips. “That was hardly a kiss.”

“It lasted,” Catra countered, deadpan, “for some time.”

Adora’s grin widened. “And you *thought* about it.”

Catra narrowed her eyes. “Are you *angling* for a conversation about this?”

“Yes,” Adora said easily. “I am.”

Catra stared at her, still as stone. Adora could *feel* the tension in her—the fight between self-preservation and honesty, the urge to hold everything in. She waited through it.

“You were…” Catra began, finally. “Just… different.”

The word hung there between them, heavier than it had any right to be.

Adora’s throat tightened. She wanted to reach out, but she didn’t. She let the silence stand.

“Should I turn off the lights, Your Highness?” Adora asked quietly, when the pause stretched too long.

“Leave them,” Catra said, the words coming too quickly, betraying more than she meant.

Adora studied her—the careful stillness of her posture, the way she seemed afraid even to breathe too loudly, as though the smallest motion might break the fragile calm they’d built.

Then, softly, Catra said, “You can call me by my name. If you want.”

Adora smiled, that gentle, unstoppable warmth rising again in her chest. “Catra,” she said.

The name tasted like something sweet.

Adora wanted to say her name while her fingers slipped into Catra’s hair—to feel its tangled weight between them, to tilt her chin and close the last breath of space before their lips met again. Kissing seemed to wind Catra tight, made her tremble with restraint and heat all at once.

Adora sat up beside her. The motion alone made Catra’s breath catch. Adora didn’t reach for her, didn’t push or soothe—she just sat, watching the subtle shift of Catra’s chest as she tried to even her breathing.

“I’m not afraid of sex,” Catra said suddenly, the words clipped and defensive, her tone too sharp for what they meant.

Adora’s response was gentle. “Show me. Do whatever you want.”

Catra looked up, her eyes dark and unreadable, the same look she’d worn since returning to the bed—caught somewhere between anger and longing.

Her voice was low when she said, “Just… don’t touch me.”

Catra reached for her first. The faint brush of her fingertips was startling—an uncertain, almost cautious touch.

Her hand drifted over Adora’s arm, testing, mapping the curve of her bicep with slow curiosity, as if learning its shape by feel instead of sight.

Catra’s gaze followed the motion of her hand, tracing her like she was something she’d never seen before—territory claimed. Adora held still, heart pounding.

When Catra reached her hair, Adora bowed her head, surrendering to it. Catra’s palm cupped the back of her neck, fingers sliding through her long hair with care. The touch was uncertain, like she was trying to understand what softness felt like.

It occurred to Adora that Catra hadn’t done this before—not even earlier, when Adora’s mouth had been on her. She had clutched the sheets then, refused to hold her. Maybe she hadn’t known how. Maybe this was the first time she’d dared to touch someone like this.

Catra’s breath shook. She wasn’t giving herself over to the moment; she was caught in it—fighting her own instincts, her own walls. Adora could feel it in the way she trembled, in how careful her breathing had become.

When Catra’s fingers drifted lower, her touch found the faint lines that crossed Adora’s chest—a pale scar that had never quite faded. Her gaze lingered there. Then she touched it.

Adora inhaled sharply.

Catra’s fingertips traced along the mark, slow and delicate, following its jagged path as though reading something written there. Her eyes had gone dark, deep with thought—too deep.

“I thought you were untouchable.” Catra murmured.

Adora’s voice was quiet. “Clearly I'm not.”

Catra’s tongue darted out to wet her lips. Her touch swept upward again, her fingertips gliding back across the scar as though retracing an old wound.

“No, *clearly* you're not.” she repeated softly.

Her hand lingered there, warm and steady over the place that had nearly killed Adora once.

Catra was close—closer than Shadow Weaver had ever been when she’d cast that spell. But there was no cold, no anger now. Only the weight of Catra’s hand, trembling slightly, was warm.

Adora looked at her and felt her heart tighten. The past hovered between them like smoke—unwelcome, unshakable—but this touch, this slow, uncertain gentleness, burned it away for just a moment.

Catra’s eyes met hers again. And Adora thought—perhaps for the first time—that this, right here, was what forgiveness looked like. But Catra didn’t know. She didn’t know it was her.

Catra’s gaze lifted—not to Adora’s eyes, but to the collar at her throat. Her hand came up, hesitating before her fingers brushed the metal. Her thumb found the small dent in its edge, pressing against it lightly.

“I meant what I said,” Catra murmured. “About taking this off you.”

Adora’s throat tightened. “In the morning.”

“In the morning,” Catra echoed. Her tone was calm, but her eyes were restless, flicking to the scarred nick beneath her thumb. “Make sure they're careful where they cut.”

Their eyes met. Adora’s heart stumbled in her chest, the rhythm uneven, almost painful. It was like Catra’s look said *I don't want to lose you*.

“It’s still on right now,” she said quietly.

“I know.” Catra replied.

The simplicity of it hit harder than it should have. Adora held her gaze—and couldn’t look away. There was something unguarded there now. Catra had let her in. Adora could feel it, could *feel* the space she had entered as she eyed the warm hollow between jaw and neck where her mouth had rested.

Catra shifted. Adora felt her knee slide along hers, felt her move closer. Then, before Adora could draw a breath, Catra leaned in and kissed her.

Adora had half-expected roughness, dominance, something meant to reclaim control. But Catra’s kiss was nothing like that. It was light—tentative, almost shy—a gentle press of lips, like she was trying to memorize the feeling. Adora’s hands curled in the sheets, fighting the instinct to pull her closer. She stayed still and let Catra explore at her own pace.

Catra shifted again, one knee pressing into the bed beside her, the white fabric of her shirt brushing against Adora’s bare stomach. Her breathing was uneven, shallow—like she was walking a tightrope without a safety net.

Her fingers traced down, hesitant but curious, a slow journey that made Adora’s breath falter. She could feel the tremor in Catra’s hand, could feel how every inch of touch was a negotiation with herself.

Catra’s hand paused between her legs. Her voice, when it came, was low and laced with dry amusement. “Excited, aren’t we?”

Adora swallowed hard. “It’s not—” She faltered.

Catra’s eyes lifted to hers, sly but unsteady. “It's okay, really, I like that I have that effect on you.”

Before Adora could respond, Catra’s weight shifted again—pressing her gently back into the bed. Adora’s breath hitched as she found herself half-reclined beneath her, Catra straddling her lap.

“I don't need your self control right now,” Catra murmured.

Adora’s hand rose without thought—resting against Catra’s hip, just to steady her. The realization of what she’d done hit a heartbeat later. She froze.

Catra noticed. Her body went still, too, caught between retreat and surrender. Adora could *feel* her uncertainty, the way her breath hitched and held. But she didn’t move away. Instead, she tilted her head slightly, an invitation rather than a command.

Adora hesitated only a second before leaning forward, slow and careful. When Catra didn’t pull back, she pressed her lips softly to the curve of her neck. Then another.

Her skin was warm under her mouth. She traced her lips to the space beneath Catra’s jaw, her breath mingling with hers. Each kiss drew a shiver out of her, small and involuntary.

Adora could feel the fine fur against her lips, the way it tickled, how the slightest motion seemed to set Catra trembling. She adjusted, slowed down, learning the rhythm of her responses—the places that made her melt, the ones that made her draw in a sharp breath.

When she kissed lower, Catra shuddered.

Adora wanted to keep going. To touch, to map every part of her the same way Catra had done moments ago—to see if gentleness could undo her, piece by piece. But she didn't dare. Her hands remained still at her sides, the only motion the trembling of her breath.

The silence between them pulsed. Catra's chest rose and fell, her pulse fluttering where Adora's lips lingered.

"That…" Catra's voice cracked, a whisper just above breath. "I like that, keep going."

Adora smiled against her skin, a soft sound escaping her.

"As you wish," she whispered.

Their chests brushed—barely, just enough for Adora to feel the shallow tremor of Catra's breathing against her. She could hear it, too, warm and ragged in her ear. Catra moved with unconscious rhythm, small, almost hesitant motions that pressed against her in quiet searching.

Adora's hand came up, light as a whisper, resting on Catra's opposite hip—not guiding, only feeling the movement. Catra had forgotten herself enough to move freely, chasing after sensation rather than control. There was nothing deliberate or polished in it—just pure, instinctive need.

It struck Adora, the realization that Catra was close—that these tiny movements, this slow, aching friction, could undo her. She felt the tremor ripple through Catra's body, the uneven breaths, the faint, broken rhythm. The sparks that jumped between them with each shift felt small, but bright—struck from flint and steel, catching before either could stop it.

Adora didn't think she could ever reach her own edge this way, but the slower she kissed Catra, the more she could feel her unraveling.

Maybe Catra had always been this sensitive to gentleness. Maybe no one had ever given her the space to find out.

Catra's eyes were half-lidded now, unfocused, her expression stripped of calculation. A sound escaped her. Her cheeks were flushed, her lips parted slightly, her head tilted back. The look on her face was pure and disbelieving, as if she couldn't reconcile the feeling with herself.

That's it, Adora thought, her chest tight. She wanted to say it aloud, to encourage her, but she didn't know if it would break the spell—if it would sound patronizing, or worse.

Her own body was responding now, thrumming in tandem with Catra's, each breath syncing, the heat between them spreading. Adora's hand slid upward, tracing the curve of Catra's waist, gliding beneath the loose fall of her shirt. Her hands cupped the soft breasts beneath, and Catra's reaction was immediate—her claws flexing, digging into Adora's shoulders hard enough to sting.

Adora didn't care.

She saw it—the moment it happened. The flicker of surrender across Catra's face. The tremor that shook through her as her defenses gave way.

Yes, Adora thought. *There*.

Catra jerked against her, startled by her own release, eyes flying open as though in disbelief at her body's betrayal. Then she was collapsing into Adora, both of them tangled in the sheets, breathless, trembling. Catra's head rested against her chest, and for a few seconds, neither of them moved.

Adora was smiling helplessly, dizzy with warmth. "That was… good enough, I suppose."

Catra huffed out a breath that could've been a laugh. "You've clearly been waiting to say that." Her words were blurred, drowsy, but teasing.

Adora laughed softly and pressed a light kiss to her shoulder. The gesture startled a faint flicker of uncertainty across Catra's face—but she didn't pull away. The tension ebbed from her body, leaving her pliant against Adora.

They lay like that for a while.

Then, quietly, Catra said, "Do you want me to—"

Adora lifted her head slightly. "You're half-asleep."

"Not quite yet," Catra murmured, eyes closed, voice rough.

Adora smiled faintly. "We've got all night," she said. Her throat felt tight as she added, almost to herself, "Until morning."

The thought ached more than she'd expected.

She could feel the outline of Catra's body against her, lean and restless even now. Adora wanted to say it—to ask her to stay, to order her to stay—but she couldn't.

It wasn't right.

She was twenty years old, a soldier turned Princess, and Adora was… her slave. And that wasn't even the thing that separated them the most.

"Until morning," Catra said quietly.

Adora nodded.

A few heartbeats later, she felt Catra's move, rolling off of Adora onto the bed.

Adora took the chance to leave the bed and freshen up herself, while Catra had dozed off.

when she returned to the bed, drank the water that Catra had brought for her and laid down next to Catra once more.

She felt a subtle shift and then Catra’s hand came to rest on her arm. The faintest curl of her hand there, a ghost of touch, and still more than she had ever dared to hope for.

Adora closed her eyes.

[Sort of unrelated, I'm going to post more on tiktok. Just process videos from drawing mostly.]

Chapter End Notes

My phone is on 3%, no time for notes

Chapter 24

Chapter Notes

> Updated the tags to include the stuff from this chapter and the last 3.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra drifted in and out of light sleep—not because she wanted to, or because Adora had told her to, but because she couldn't help it. Her body gave in even as her mind refused. She didn't dare sink too deeply into rest; every minute of sleep was stolen time, a minute taken from the few remaining hours she had with Adora.

The first few times she tried to force herself awake, her body refused. But when she finally managed, the world came back to her in fragments—the soft sheets, the quiet rise and fall of breath beside her, and the lazy, idle movement of Adora's fingertips tracing nonsense patterns across her stomach.

"Don't watch me sleep, you creep." Catra muttered, eyes still closed.

She felt Adora's smile rather than saw it—radiant and wordless. Then Adora leaned closer, and before Catra could protest further, their mouths met—slow, sleepy, tender. It was all warmth and drowsy joy, the kind of kiss that belonged to people who weren't fighting time. Catra sighed into it, half-lost already, her claws grazing over Adora's shoulder in a fond gesture.

She almost let out a giggle as Adora's hand slipped between Catra's legs again, though she still hadn't opened her eyes for any of it.

Adora whispered against her lips, "We don't have to—you should keep sleeping if you need to." Her tone was teasingly gallant, though her hand contradicted her words.

Catra's smile curved. "It would seem that I'm awake now," she murmured, catching Adora's wrist before she could move away. "Keep going."

Adora's quiet laugh was honey in her mouth. Neither of them seemed inclined to stop kissing long enough to finish a sentence.

"Bossy, aren't you?" Adora teased.

"Do you need me to tell you how and—" Catra started, only to break off with a small, pleased sound as Adora leaned in again.

Adora chuckled. "I won't stop," she promised. "I just need some water first—but I'll come right back to finish what we started."

Catra groaned, flopping back into the pillows dramatically. She turned her face into the fabric, smiling helplessly despite herself.

Her own hand replaced Adora's as she began lazily playing with herself. She didn't care much about arousing any further feeling—just continuing that touch that Adora had started.

Adora moved away, her silhouette shifting through the soft light as she crossed the room. Catra watched through half-lidded eyes, tracing the line of her back, the quiet strength in every motion. She was half expecting Adora to pour herself a proper glass of water, but of course the woman simply grabbed the pitcher and drank straight from it—loud, graceless gulps and all.

Catra rolled her eyes fondly, her lips twitching upward.

Then Adora came back, practically throwing herself back onto the bed. The mattress dipped hard enough that Catra bounced slightly with a startled laugh.

Adora had brought the strap back with her and was in quickly buckling it back into place—notably much quicker than Adora had done any of the buckles and straps to conceal away Catra in any of her clothes.

“Hands off,” Adora said playfully, catching Catra’s wrist before she could misbehave any further. “I want to do it myself.”

Catra gave her a look full of challenge and delight, deliberately disobeying as she rolled onto her back. “You seem to think this is yours,” she drawled. “Now who’s the bossy one?”

Adora’s answering grin was bright and feral, her eyes gleaming in the dim light. Catra barely had time to finish her taunt before Adora moved, quick and sure, pinning her again with a soft growl that made Catra’s laugh turn breathless.

She was so wet and so ready that Adora was able slide into the hilt in one slow thrust. Catra let herself cry out at the feeling of Adora thrusting that little bit deeper, bumping her cervix in way that was not at all unpleasant.

Adora’s hands found her, steady and sure. Catra tilted her head back with a soft sigh, arching instinctively into the warmth of her touch. The room seemed to narrow to the rhythm of their breathing, as Catra wrapped her legs around Adora’s waist.

“Princess,” Adora murmured in First One’s, teasing her softly, “Are you going to sing a little song for me.”

Catra huffed, the sound dissolving into a low, pleased growl as Adora’s lips brushed the side of her neck. When Adora bit down softly, Catra whined.

She tilted her head, giving Adora silent permission, her voice a soft whisper of laughter and disbelief. “Keep that up,” she murmured, “and I just might.”

It was harder for Catra to hold back her reactions this time. Her walls weren’t as strong—maybe she didn’t even want them to be. The sound that escaped her throat was soft, needy, uncontrollable. Every motion, every word that left Adora’s lips—low, breathy praise in that earnest voice of hers—only made it worse, made it better.

“Didn’t know it could feel like this,” Adora murmured in First One’s, almost to herself, a confession that slipped out between breaths.

Catra didn’t know why she felt the urge to answer her—maybe because, for once, she understood. “No,” she panted. “Neither did I.”

Adora’s smile brushed against her shoulder before she spoke again, her voice rough with emotion. “Never felt like this about anyone.”

Catra nodded—helpless, undone. Her teeth caught her lower lip, trying to muffle the sounds building in her throat. Her hips moved without thought, reckless and hungry, each motion slower and sweeter than the last. She didn’t know if she was trying to match Adora or just losing herself in her entirely.

“More,” she breathed, and felt Adora’s grin against her skin.

“All right, Princess,” Adora said softly and she pulled back. “Turn over.”

There was no fear this time—no hesitation, no second-guessing. Catra shifted, rolling from her back to her knees, aching with the loss of Adora’s touch, aching even more with the anticipation of it returning.

The position should have felt humiliating once—it had, in another life—but now it didn’t. Now it felt like surrender on her own terms. Now it felt powerful. The thought of Adora seeing her like this—open, willing, hers—made her tremble. She *wanted* to be seen this way. She wanted Adora to see all of her.

Adora’s hands skimmed her skin, steady and reverent. She was careful, aligning, guiding, easing in until Catra’s breath hitched and shehitct a curse break from her throat in a small, helpless sound.

Adora started slow, steady, deliberate. Catra could hear her breathing, hear her whisper something that might've been her name. A moment later, Adora shifted, drawing her upright, pressing Catra's back to her chest. One arm wrapped tight around her, holding her in place; the other slid upward to cup one of her slight breasts, grasping and kneeding at it as she rocked her hip continuously.

Catra made a sound that was half-moan, half-laugh, breathless and alive. Every motion sent sparks through her—every soft, rhythmic push, every word Adora breathed into her ear.

"Yes," Catra whispered, again and again, not even sure if the word left her mouth or just echoed in her head. "Yes."

Adora's voice came in quiet, ragged murmurs—praise, promises, nonsense words. Catra's hand reached up to Adora's bowed head, tangling its way through the mess of golden curls spilling over her shoulder. "Yes," she gasped again, shaking, her control shattering completely.

When the end came again, it hit like lightning—her whole body trembling, breaking, her breath coming in harsh sobs. And Adora was there, holding her through it, whispering something gentle she couldn't quite hear.

She came back to herself slowly, each breath a small, sweet relief. Adora gathered her up, pulling her close, cradling her as if she were made of something fragile.

Catra was exhausted, utterly boneless, the tension drained out of her completely. Her eyelids felt impossibly heavy.

"You should sing for me more often," Adora teased, voice soft, affectionate, her smile audible. "You've got a lovely voice, you know."

Catra groaned, managing a faint glare without lifting her head. "Are you even capable of being quiet after sex?"

Adora laughed, brushing hair from Catra's face. "No," she admitted, utterly shameless.

Catra made a noise that might have been a scoff or a laugh—it didn't matter. Whatever Adora said next was lost to her. The warmth, the closeness, the steady beat of Adora's heart—all of it pulled her under.

Before long, Catra stopped listening, stopped thinking.

She slept again.

✧

Morning found them in defiance of everything that had come before.

Catra didn't want it to be daylight. She didn't want to open her eyes. But her body had other plans. She woke slowly, piece by piece—first to the golden warmth filtering through the curtains, then to the pleasant heaviness of her limbs, and then to the steady weight draped across her chest.

The bed was absurdly comfortable. The sunlight was soft. She was warm. She was safe.

She wasn't alone.

A sound escaped her before she could stop it, a small hum of contentment as she turned—and met the solid warmth of Adora's body. Her cheek brushed skin, her hand found muscle, and Adora's arm instinctively tightened around her, holding her closer.

When Catra opened her eyes, she was greeted by a sight so intimate it almost hurt—Adora's face, peaceful and drowsy in the morning light, golden hair mussed, her expression unguarded. Adora's fingers idly traced slow, thoughtless patterns along Catra's spine.

“It’s morning,” Catra murmured, reluctant to name it, as though speaking it aloud would end the spell. “We slept?”

Adora’s lips curved into a sleepy smile. “We slept,” she confirmed softly.

Catra wasn’t entirely convinced. Adora didn’t look like someone who needed sleep last night—just as now she looked like someone who needed it desperately. Still, she didn’t press. The way Adora looked at her made her chest ache too much for teasing.

She should have gotten up. There were orders to give, soldiers to address, plans to set in motion. But instead, Catra found herself leaning in—pressing her lips to Adora’s, slow and certain.

The kiss deepened lazily, hands wandering without urgency. Catra lost track of whose sigh came first. Her mouth curved into a grin against Adora’s when she felt the woman’s hands settle possessively on her hips.

“Your… enthusiasm seems unchanged,” Catra teased when they finally broke apart, her voice low, still thick with sleep.

Adora’s answering smile was shameless. She cupped Catra’s chin, brushing her thumb along her bottom lip, eyes bright and unbearably soft. “You talk the same in bed,” she said fondly.

“Got a better way of saying it?” Catra challenged, though her tone was gentler than her words.

Adora’s grin only widened. “Yeah,” she said, almost too simply. “I want you.”

Her hands slid lower, resting at Catra’s waist before squeezing. Catra flushed but couldn’t stop the small, incredulous smile tugging at her mouth.

“You’ve already had me,” she pointed out. “Twice? Three times? I think I lost count.” Her tail flicked lazily, betraying her amusement.

“I swear I can still feel the aftershocks.”

Adora laughed, burying her face in Catra’s neck. “Don’t tempt me,” she warned, her voice muffled but full of mirth. “You won’t be able to walk.”

Catra’s answering purr was all warmth. She melted against her again, cheek resting over Adora’s heart. The steady rhythm beneath her ear was grounding, impossibly soothing. Every slow brush of Adora’s hands against her back, her hips, her thighs—it was almost too much to bear, too sweet to last.

“I’d welcome the chance to walk,” Catra murmured, smiling faintly. “I’ve still got a horse to ride.”

Adora’s hands stilled, her touch softening with a note of worry. “Did I—?” she started gently, fingers skimming protectively along Catra’s side. “I tried to be careful. I’ve never used… those before.”

Catra chuckled, low and breathless. “Relax,” she said, her voice teasing but warm. “I liked it.”

She lifted her head, forcing herself to meet Adora’s eyes. Blue met hers, and the moment stretched—fragile, tender, full of things neither could say.

“You’re…” Catra started, her voice catching. “You’re a thoughtful lover, Mara.”

Adora blinked, caught between surprise and bashful delight. Catra smiled, watching that light bloom in her face.

“I feel—” Catra tried, but the words tangled, turned into a shaky laugh. “So fucking happy.”

The admission slipped out before she could stop it. Her throat burned. She pressed her forehead against Adora’s chest to hide the emotion breaking across her face.

It was true—every word of it. Whatever happened next, whether she survived the coming days or didn't, Catra would keep this. She would keep *her*. The proof that Prime hadn't hollowed her out completely—that she could still love, still laugh, still find light again.

And somehow, impossibly, it was Adora who had given that back to her.

"I guess," Catra said after a long moment, her voice quiet, raw, "is it like this all the time?"

"No," Adora said quietly—too quietly, her tone suddenly serious. She reached up, brushing her knuckles against Catra's cheek. "No, it's not—"

She trailed off, frowning a little, eyes distant as if searching for the right words. Her fingers slipped into Catra's hair, combing gently through the tangled strands. Catra's eyelids fluttered. Adora's hands in her hair—how could something so simple undo her so completely?

Catra tried to hide the warmth in her chest behind a smile. "Does that give me away?" she asked softly. "My inexperience? You've heard the stories—once a decade, if I'm feeling charitable."

Adora let out a faint, breathless laugh that faded almost immediately. "I can't," she said at last, voice cracking just slightly. "I can't just have this for one night."

Catra froze. Her heart lurched painfully in her chest. She knew what Adora meant but the words still caught her somewhere deep. She wanted to take them, twist them, mold them into something closer to what she longed to hear. *Stay with me. Choose me.*

How would it feel, she wondered, to be the one Adora loved, not just the one she wanted? To be the reason for that golden smile, that impossible tenderness?

“One night and one morning,” Catra corrected softly. She knew it was foolish. She knew it would break her later. But she also knew she’d never regret it. Not one second.

She caught Adora’s hands, pressing them down against the sheets. Her voice trembled when she spoke. “Don’t waste it.”

And then she was kissing her—nothing gentle about it this time, no hesitation, no restraint. It was hungry, desperate, claiming. *If I can’t keep you, I’ll at least remember the taste of you.*

“Don’t rush,” Adora pleaded, breathless between kisses.

“We’re out of time,” Catra snapped, sharper than she meant—but she couldn’t stop.

Adora’s grin broke through, bright even through her haze of want. “It’s not like I’m going anywhere,” she murmured, her thumbs stroking small circles against Catra’s skin. “You’ve got me… pretty well occupied right now.”

Catra huffed out something like a laugh, though her throat was tight. “You’re still leaving,” she said flatly.

The grin faltered. Adora didn’t deny it. Her hands slowed, her gaze trailing over Catra’s face, her shoulders, her body—as if memorizing every detail to carry with her as well.

Catra swallowed, forcing the words out before she lost her nerve. “Do you… do you even find me pleasing? Or does daylight ruin the illusion?”

Adora drew a slow breath. Her calloused fingers traced a deliberate path—down her stomach, up her chest, lingering briefly at her neck before curling behind it. Then, with an almost reverent gentleness, she pulled Catra back down to her.

She kissed her—not hard, not claiming, but soft. Barely there.

When she spoke, it was in First One's, quiet and serious. "You are the most beautiful thing I've ever seen," she said.

The language had never sounded that way before—not sharp and ancient, but fluid and tender. Like music.

Adora's lips brushed her jawline. Her next words were a whisper. "You shine brighter than the suns. You're fierce, and clever, and completely terrifying." She smiled against her skin. "And I love that about you."

Catra's throat closed. Every word hit too deep.

"Stop," she whispered.

Adora stilled immediately. She didn't try to touch her again, didn't protest, just waited—watching her with that same wide, wounded look that always made Catra feel like she was the villain in her own story.

Catra's breath hitched. She clenched her fists in the sheets, staring at the wall because she couldn't bear to meet those blue eyes. "You can't say things like that," she managed. "Not when I can't keep you."

"Catra," Adora's voice broke—quiet, unsure, full of everything she wasn't allowing herself to say. *I'm Adora of Bright Moon. I killed your mother and I just spent the night making you feel pleasure you never thought possible.*

Before she could continue, Catra pushed her back down and kissed her hard, swallowing both their words. It was desperate and unsteady. Every brush of lips, every breath between them felt like it was running out.

Because it was.

Adora's hands rose, tangling in Catra's hair, holding her there as if she could stop time by sheer will. Catra kissed her harder, deeper—because there was nothing else left to do.

If this was the last thing they had, it would be everything.

Catra reached between them, and Adora’s breath caught—her head falling back, a low, involuntary sound escaping her. The heat between them built fast, like fire trapped beneath their skin.

“I can’t keep you,” Catra said quietly, the words slipping out between uneven breaths. “But you're mine.”

Adora’s lips parted. Her voice was raw when she answered. “Yes,” she said. “Always.”

Catra caught her hands before she could reach for her again and pinned them down against the sheets. The look in Adora’s eyes—shock, hunger, something dangerously close to awe—made her pulse jump.

Catra’s movements became deliberate, controlled, finding a rhythm that set both their bodies in sync. Every press, every shift of motion made Adora shudder.

“You can go off and fight your battles,” Catra said through clenched teeth, her voice almost a growl. “Charm every reckless soldier, every brave idiot who thinks they can handle you—” she leaned close enough that their noses brushed, “—it won’t change the fact that you were mine.”

“Catra—”

“Don’t forget,” Catra demanded, her grip tightening.

“Catra—Fuck—”

“Say it.”

The command left no room for refusal. She pressed down harder, not cruelly but insistently, keeping Adora pinned beneath her. The intensity of their connection built until every breath they took seemed shared between them.

“I won’t forget,” Adora promised. The words came out as a gasp, almost a cry. "I'm yours—I'm yours—"

Satisfied, Catra gave a sharp, trembling nod before claiming her mouth again. The kiss was fierce, dizzying—one last act of defiance against the morning that would take them apart.

That was when Adora moved. With strength and speed that made Catra’s heart stutter, she gathered her close and rolled them. The shift knocked the air out of Catra’s lungs, and a startled sound escaped her as her back hit the mattress.

Then Adora was above her—steady, powerful, unyielding. She caught Catra’s wrists in her hands and pinned them above her head, their eyes locked, their breaths ragged and uneven.

“I'm yours,” Adora murmured, and despite everything—the ache, the inevitability of goodbye—Catra smiled up at her.

Core met core again as Adora’s grinding pace matched Catra’s earlier rhythm. The air between them was only their breath. Catra clung to her, claws scraping lightly down Adora’s arms, her body straining toward her. Every movement brought them closer to breaking.

“Don’t—stop,” Catra gasped.

“I wasn’t... planning to,” Adora breathed against her skin.

When it came, it was wordless—a sound caught somewhere between a sob and a laugh, too much feeling for a single moment to hold.

Then it was quiet again, save for their breathing—two hearts trying to find the same rhythm.

Catra’s fingers trembled when Adora finally loosened her hold. She could still feel the ghost of her touch against her wrists, her chest, her heart.

For a long time, neither spoke.

Then, softly, Catra whispered, “You promise not to forget?”

Adora smiled, brushing a strand of hair from her face. “You've made it impossible to.”

Chapter End Notes

I have written the last 2 chapters, I just need to proofread them. Should be up by the end of the week at the lastest. There will be trigger warnings. I may update the tags as a bit of a heads up.

Chapter 25

Chapter Notes

> TW: Death, body parts, referenced torture, referenced sexual assault of a minor, referenced sexual abuse, suicide.
>
> I am sorry. I really am. This chapter and the next one were hard.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra stayed where she was for as long as she could justify it—longer, really.

The room smelled of sex and Catra didn't mind it one bit. Adora's weight beside her was a solid, sleeping heat. Catra lay tangled in the sheets, tangled in thought, tangled in the wild, sweet ache of it all.

When she finally moved, Adora stirred too, frowning in her half-sleep, one hand reaching instinctively.

"No," she murmured, voice soft and drowsy—almost a whine. It wasn't desperate, but it hit something in Catra anyway. Even now, Adora clung to her.

Catra's chest constricted. She reached out, threading her fingers through the hopeless tangle of golden curls one last time. "I need to wash up, dummy," she said, her voice as even as she could make it.

Adora made a soft sound of protest but didn't argue. By the time Catra stood, she was already asleep again, her breathing slow and deep.

Catra lingered on the edge of the bed. Her throat burned. It felt like something huge and terrible was stuck there—something that wouldn't move, wouldn't go away. Maybe she'd throw up. She

pressed her palms hard against her eyes until she saw stars. The tears didn't come. What had slipped out the night before had been an accident—a glitch in her well crafted armor.

She didn't cry.

Not anymore.

But she had cried last night in front of Adora.

Eventually, she stood.

There was still water in the basin—cold, from hours ago—but it would have to do. She didn't want to summon attendants or guards. She couldn't bear the looks, the questions. She washed in silence, with the same grim practicality that had carried her through every other time.

However, it wasn't like with Prime. She didn't feel unclean. She didn't feel used. She wasn't scrubbing anything away. She only wanted to pass for normal, to face the day without smelling overwhelmingly of sweat and sex.

And she had sex. She had let Adora have sex with her as if that could possibly make her stay. Adora had taken her apart, piece by piece, and somehow put her back together again in the same breath. Now she was whole, but not the same. Changed.

And alone.

When they met again, Adora would be changed, too.

Who will you be, Adora of Bright Moon? Queen. Hero. Savior. She-Ra. Who will you be when you come back to me—if you come back at all?

What if they did all this and lost anyway?

Catra stared down into the basin, her reflection rippling faintly in the water. She could almost see it then—Adora kneeling beside

her, both of them broken in chains, the sunlight beating down. Their bodies worn and scarred, the hope gone from those blue eyes. Not blame. Not anger. Just emptiness.

The thought sliced through her.

She shut it down. Hard.

That kind of thinking was poison. Feeling was poison. She couldn't afford it.

Catra forced herself to focus on the mirror. Her reflection stared back—eyes rimmed red, pupils wide, hair a disaster. She fixed what she could. Straightened her shoulders. Pulled her hair back until her scalp protested.

Her armour—both literal and emotional—had to go back on.

She dressed quickly, choosing one of her riding uniforms, the one she could strap herself into without help. Every strap cinched tighter than the last, as if she could hold herself together by sheer force of will. By the time she was done, she looked like Catra again.

She looked like she hadn't just been undone by the one person she'd ever truly loved.

But she could still feel the echo of it—the ghost of Adora's hands, the sound of her laugh, the taste of her mouth. It was unbearable.

Catra took one last breath before stepping back into the bedroom. She was ready to beg. She was ready to fall to her knees, to say anything, do anything—if it would make Adora stay.

She would have.

Her boots struck the floor in sharp, measured clicks that didn't sound like her own. The air felt colder now, and every inch of her armour felt too tight.

For a heartbeat, she saw herself as she must look—hollow-eyed, trembling, ready to trade every shred of pride she had left for one more hour of warmth.

But it was too late.

The woman she wanted to be—the one Adora had seen last night, the one who'd been free and unguarded and brave enough to love—was already fading with the dawn.

What was left was Princess Catra of the Horde again. Cold. Controlled.

And *alone*.

Adora wasn't lounging on the bed the way Catra had expected when she returned from washing. The room offered no greeting, no conspiratorial grin; instead Adora lay utterly unmoving, surrendered to sleep. She looked small and unguarded: an arm flung over her eyes, mouth slack, one knee crooked out. There was no modesty, no attempt to cover herself. Vulnerable, disarmed—and for the first time in a long while, Catra felt like the cruelest thing in the world.

A dozen selfish, ugly pleas rose in Catra's throat—Stay. Give up your throne. Keep me. I'm broken; I'll do anything—and she almost begged them out loud.

Instead, a single, ragged line escaped her. "I love you," she heard herself say.

Adora half-turned at the sound and, still half-asleep, curled up against the pillow. Her arm flopped back across her face as if to blot out the morning. For a beat Catra could have woken her, could have knelt and begged and bargained for one impossible bargain; instead she felt something cold harden inside her. She could not ask a woman who had already lost everything to surrender a crown for her.

Catra didn't wait for herself to change her mind. She left.

She moved like she had that armour on despite being suddenly hollow, feet clattering down the corridor until she found a servant and gripped his sleeve.

“Clear my rooms,” she snapped. “Give the Etherian thirty minutes. Wake her then. Have the smith strip the collar and cuffs. Outfit her—horse, she can keep the platinum, whatever she needs to cross the border. See an escort to the gate. Thirty minutes. Now.” Her voice had an edge that brooked no argument.

The man stammered, “Your Highness—”

Before she could repeat herself, Lonnie appeared in the passage, expression sharp with concern and the readiness Catra had come to expect from the former captain. For a fraction of a second Catra felt steadiness at the sight of a known face — and then remembered she was furious: Lonnie had lied for Entrapta. Lonnie had defied her. Lonnie could no longer be trusted.

“Is something wrong?” Lonnie asked. “The troops are in the courtyard, forming up. They’re here to hear you address them.”

Catra hadn’t even thought of the parade, the formal farewell. The idea of standing before her soldiers with the weight of that morning in her chest made her want to laugh and then cry.

“No,” she said curtly. “Dismiss them.”

Lonnie’s brow creased. “Your Highness—”

“Mara leaves today,” Catra cut in. “I’ve arranged escort. You’ll lead them. Make sure she reaches the border.” Her tone left no room for argument.

Lonnie gave a tight nod and turned to carry out the orders. As she watched Lonnie go, Catra felt the last of the warmth from Adora’s sleeping shape like a brand and a chill settle into her bones. She squared her shoulders, wiped whatever remained of tenderness from her face, and prepared herself to act as if nothing at all had happened.

✧

Catra's mount danced beneath her, ears flicking, muscles quivering with restless energy—as if it could sense that its rider was barely holding herself together. The stablehands had scattered the moment she appeared, the quiet command in her tone enough to send them scrambling. No one dared interfere when Catra said she'd handle her own horse.

It was pathetic, she thought—running. But she couldn't stop herself. She'd told herself she was above this sort of weakness, that she could keep her claws buried deep enough to survive a clean goodbye. But Adora… Adora tore through her, left her armour in shreds, and still she loved her for it. Curse that woman—curse her forever and ever.

She had swung into the saddle and pressed her heels hard. The horse shot forward, and the gates of Talon Mountain split open before her like a wound. The wind cut her cheeks, sharp as judgment. Her thighs ached, her body throbbed in places, and she hated how easily her thoughts returned to the night before—to Adora's hands, her voice, her impossible gentleness as they made love.

No. She wouldn't let herself think like that. It wasn't *making love*. It was *fucking*. That's all. A night of exhaustion and release between two people who should have known better. They had wanted each other, nothing more. The rest was her mistake—her own weakness.

She'd tell herself that as many times as it took to believe it.

Catra rode faster. The mountain path blurred beneath her. She had nothing left to lose but the illusion of control. The sting in her eyes came from the cold air. That was all.

Just the air.

Her mind churned, racing even faster than her horse. Lonnie would be escorting Adora—her and a few hand-picked soldiers, loyal enough to follow orders without asking questions. They'd drop her near the border, somewhere within reach of Mermista's patrols. The Crimson Wastes' last reports confirmed Etherian activity there—Catra had made sure of it. Adora would be safe. She'd reunite with her people. With Mermista.

That would be a hell of a story.

The rightful Queen of Bright Moon, miraculously alive. Glimmer's rule overturned in scandal and disbelief. Mermista and her soldiers rallying under the She-Ra banner once more. Catra could picture it too clearly: the gold and white armour gleaming beneath Etheria's suns, the roar of armies carrying Adora's name.

And Adora—She-Ra—would ride at their head, radiant and terrible, that ridiculous white cloak billowing behind her, those blue eyes cutting straight through Catra the moment she saw her again.

She would return. Catra knew it as surely as she knew her own heartbeat. Adora would come back to finish what they started—

The image filled her mind so vividly that for a long moment she didn't register the movement on the horizon. A flicker of white—too real, too near.

Her pulse spiked.

That wasn't imagination.

Catra swore under her breath, yanked the reins hard, and turned her horse. Her body protested with every movement, but she ignored the pain.

Whatever that white shimmer was—flags, armor, an approaching army—it was heading straight for Talon Mountain.

Catra drove her heels in and rode harder, the wind belting her face as she raced back toward the fort.

✧

It was a near thing—too near. The sound of pounding boots behind her blurred into the rhythm of her own heartbeat. They were close enough that Catra could almost feel their breath at her back, the hot pulse of pursuit pushing her harder until she tore through the gates of Talon Mountain. The courtyard was chaos: startled soldiers, clattering armour, the sharp echo of her horse's hooves striking stone. Her lungs burned; her chest felt as though Prime himself had his fingers tangled in her hair again, dragging her down.

This wasn't supposed to happen. It was too soon—far, far too soon for any word of Talon Mountain's fall to have reached him. If Prime had responded this quickly, if his agents were already here, it meant something terrible.

It meant he hadn't been in orbit.

He was on Etheria.

The thought struck like a blow.

Catra's eyes sought her instinctively—Adora. The Etherian. Her Etherian. Her chest clenched when she found her across the courtyard, already dressed and ready to leave. The morning light burned gold against her hair, her damned blue eyes—eyes that, even now, were looking straight at Catra.

It wasn't comfort she felt. It wasn't relief. It was raw panic twisted with something that hurt worse than fear.

Prime was here. Adora was still here. Every plan Catra had made collapsed in her mind like dust.

No time to think. No time to feel. Catra slammed the door shut on her emotions. She forced them down—rage, love, terror—buried

them all until nothing was left but steel and purpose.

“Open the gates!” she barked. The soldiers at the ramparts startled but obeyed, the massive doors groaning open.

Let them come. Let Prime’s creatures see her face to face. She would not hide. She would not cower in her fortress while ghosts from the heavens came calling. What could they possibly do to her that they hadn’t already done?

At the base of the dais, Catra reined in her horse and turned it sharply, posture rigid and proud despite the gallop’s exhaustion. Her tail lashed once, defiant, as the first of Prime’s banners crested the hill.

She watched the line of riders pour into the courtyard, gleaming white and silver like a swarm of carrion birds.

Her jaw set. Her back straightened. She looked every inch the Horde Princess again—unbreakable, untouchable, and empty.

Let them come, she thought. There was nothing left they could take from her.

Catra suddenly felt trapped—cornered, like a feral thing caught with nowhere left to run. The courtyard that only yesterday had echoed with the sounds of her victory was now suffocatingly still. Her triumph had curdled into dread.

Talon Mountain should have been swarming with her soldiers—her banners, her people—but now the air was thick with Prime’s presence. The clones stood in neat ranks of grey and white, gleaming like the bones of a great machine. There were so many of them. Too many. Each one identical, each face carrying that same empty calm. These were dull-eyed copies unlike the ones she commanded in the Fright Zone—those poor, corrupted things Prime could only half-control. It was like a rusted knife left to the elements for too long. Without care or honing they became blunted and harder to effectively weild. He could control them in theory, but it had been so long that it would take considerably

more effort. No, these intruders were perfect. Sharp. Clean. Vessels just waiting for him to slip inside.

Any one of them could become him.

The thought turned Catra's stomach.

Even the crowd in the keep—her own people, her supposed subjects—had gone quiet, the kind of quiet that vibrated with discomfort and fear. They didn't cheer for Prime's arrival, but neither did they object. Their faces were wary, uncertain, some even hopeful. They hadn't wanted Catra ruling them; they'd lived under Prime's rule too long. She could feel the hostility like static in the air.

The herald clone stepped forward, his movements too smooth, too robotic. His voice rang out clear and bright through the courtyard, echoing from the walls.

"Horde Prime sends his message: The false Princess has betrayed the Horde, conspiring with Bright Moon. She has turned Fright Zone villages to slaughter, slain her own border lords, and stained her reputation with treason. She is stripped of her title and her command. The reward for her capture is generous. Mercy will be reserved for none who shelter her. So speaks Horde Prime."

The words fell like stones. Catra stood motionless, though every muscle screamed to move, to *fight*. Her jaw locked; her throat burned.

For an instant, her mind betrayed her—Adora's voice whispered in her ear, low and fond: *You are brighter than the suns. So clever. So dangerous. So smart.*

It felt like a ghost touching her cheek. Then it was gone.

Prime's hands were around her throat again, tightening.

Catra exhaled, long and even, and said with steady precision, "Funny. I don't see Prime here. Just his obedient little puppets."

There was a ripple through the formation of clones—and then one stepped forward. His lips moved, and the voice that came out wasn't the flat, mechanical tone of the herald. It was *him*.

"Catra. My troublesome little creature. I didn't think you'd miss me."

Her heartbeat thundered, but she refused to give him the satisfaction. Her tone stayed dry, almost bored. "If you've come all this way to talk, Prime, I'd rather you get to the point. Or are you just here to watch me squirm?"

The herald's voice shifted again, back to its programmed cadence. "Horde Prime does not play games. He offers you one chance for *honourable* battle. Meet him on the field at Seaspray, three days hence. Bring your Scorpion Hill forces, if you can still command them."

Catra's stomach twisted. The phrasing wasn't accidental. Prime wanted the crowd to hear it, to know her ally's troops were already being recalled. Her power slipping, her allies thinning.

He wanted her cornered. Alone.

Catra's ears flicked, tail lashing once. "I'll fight him," she said coolly. "But not where he tells me to."

The herald's eyes flickered green. "Is that your final word?"

"It is."

She was already thinking ahead. *Three more days*. That was all she needed. Three days until Adora reached the Etherians. Three days until She-Ra returned—with her armies, her light, her impossible brand hope.

Prime thought he was forcing her into a corner. He thought he could keep her kneeling.

He had no idea what kind of beast he'd just backed against the wall.

Catra didn't see it at first. She should have noticed. She should have *known*.

"This one begged for you," the herald said. His voice came from somewhere far away — echoing, warped, like sound underwater. "He stood on the wrong side. And he suffered the fate of any man who stands against Prime."

Catra's mind caught up with the words only when she saw *it*. Another clone was lifting the gruesome object from a stained red bag. Prime had plenty of ways to moving body parts without spilling a drop of blood. It was easier. He would have had to specifically go out of his way to make the delivery gruesome.

It wasn't a man. Not really.

Kyle.

He'd been so young… and now… his eyes. Gone. Not from decay, not from time. She didn't have to get close to know. They'd been *taken*.

Did they wait—no. He would have wanted to pluck them out while Kyle was alive. Make the screams last.

He probably made Kyle eat them if he didn't do so himself

The world tilted. Her vision went sharp around the edges. For one brief, terrible moment, Catra was sure she'd fall off her horse—sure her body would just give up. She saw herself hit the stones, skull cracking open, blood blooming across the courtyard. It would've been a mercy.

But her body didn't give her that. It kept her upright. It made her look.

They'd dressed him up. The curls were still there—Kyle's ridiculous little ringlets, now dull and filthy. His jaw hung slack, the skin an ugly shade of pale. He'd been arranged for display, as if that would make him something elegant, something worth showing off.

She didn't have to imagine how it happened. She could *see* it. Prime had done it himself, probably—toyed with him, whispered promises, and then had him dragged away the moment his usefulness ended. Or maybe Kyle had known. Maybe he'd asked the servants to dress him one last time, to face death looking like something finer than the thing Prime thought he was.

Her throat tightened until she could barely breathe.

She thought stupidly: *I still have a chest full of letters for you.*

And then: *You would've hated what I wrote in them anyway. Rogelio is dead. Lonnie was sleeping with the woman who killed him.*

But you're dead now, too, so what does it matter?

The herald was still talking, holding Kyle's head higher now, turning it for the crowd to see. The people—still her people—shifted uneasily. Even they could feel the wrongness of it. But the clones stood still, unmoved, their faces blank and holy in their devotion.

Catra could barely hear the words anymore. Her mind was too loud.

The cut at the neck wasn't clean. It wouldn't have been. He'd have fought it, even blind. He'd have screamed, struggled all the way down. Prime would've loved that. Prime *lived* for that—for turning suffering into spectacle.

She could hear it in her head. She could hear *him*.

Her hands trembled violently on the reins. The horse tossed its head, nervous, and she yanked it back to stillness.

They'd hurt him. They'd made him scream. They'd taken their time. And when it was done—when his head finally fell—someone had fixed his hair.

Her vision blurred. She told herself it was from the wind.

The herald turned in his saddle, displaying Kyle's ruined face to every corner of the courtyard — the hollow sockets, the twisted jaw, the mockery of what had once been Horde Prime's pampered pet.

Her chest ached like a cracked rib.

She should've taken him with her. Should've kept him close. Should've told him that she cared, that he mattered, that he wasn't just another pawn in this endless, brutal game.

But she hadn't.

And now she could only stare at what was left of him—a message from Prime carved out of the body of a boy who she almost considered a brother.

Catra swallowed hard, the taste of iron rising in her throat.

When he died, she wondered, *did he even know he was loved?*

The herald dipped his head as if he'd been given exactly the response he expected, and Catra felt her confidence wobble like a horse on slick stone. The herald signaled to another clone, who unshouldered a grimy sack with theatrical care. Catra's stomach turned over as he shifted his grip, balancing whatever was inside like a grotesque offering. Some of the clones around him smiled with that same small, hungry cruelty Catra knew too well—the leers of men who'd once tried to corner a terrified sixteen-year-old behind a storeroom door. The memory made her pulse drum in her ears.

Did she look like she had been fucked all night? Could they tell? Was that appealing to them, or was it just the fear in her eyes

that she couldn’t completely hide.

“This is a personal message from Prime to Catra,” the herald intoned.

Catra tasted rot in the air and hate coiled in her gut like a live thing.

“Prime has killed his catamite as a message,” she said flatly, the words leaving her mouth with a bored, dangerous calm. Her voice carried; she made it carry on purpose so every clone could hear and remember. A few of them looked briefly disappointed—not at the act, but because it hadn’t reduced her to the spectacle they wanted. She catalogued their faces like weapons. She would remember them.

She let the mockery on her tongue burn. “What is his message, then? That his favors are unreliable? That even the toys in his bed can see the emperor is naked?” Her voice warmed, thin and bright with a controlled anger. “That his grip on power is only as strong as the next bought mouth?”

Kyle had been a child when Prime grabbed him—a skinny thing fished out of some wretched orphanage and traded for scraps of attention. Prime wrapped him in pretty words and a contract that meant nothing to a ten-year-old who only wanted food. Prime used him like he used everything: disposable, replaceable, a plaything until the novelty wore off. Kyle had been smarter than Prime expected. That must have displeased the man.

Now Kyle was a head on a pole—so to speak. Catra was sure he would have considered that, too—to have her clones arrive with Kyle's head on a pike.

Catra shoved the thought away. She felt the old, hot animal rise in her chest—not sorrow first, not grief; a white, clean fury that tasted of ash.

“Tell him to come to Seaspray,” she snapped. The words were a blade. “Bring his reasons and his witnesses. We’ll meet him in the

open. My troops will show what real soldiers are. But I will not fight on the timetable of a butcher." Her voice trembled only once, then steadied into a vow.

The humour leeched from the clones' faces. The herald, for the first time, was mute. Catra fixed the nearest clone with a look honed on a thousand small cruelties, and it felt like lighting the air. "And if Prime wants a personal message back," she added, quiet as silk and twice as lethal, "tell him he may cut off every child's head between here and Bright Moon and it still won't make him fit to rule. He'll only ensure there's no one left for him to fuck."

She could not stand the sight any longer. Her hands went hard on the reins. The gelding reared and stamped as if he smelled Catra's rage. For a manic second Catra imagined falling again—meeting granite and forgetting—and a small part of her wanted that mercy still. Instead she reined beast forward and turned to leave, to throw distance between herself and the thing on display.

She almost made it.

Adora was waiting at the edge of the dais, exactly where Catra least wanted to see her. The sight of those blue eyes struck Catra like a physical blow. Not warmth. Not comfort. The old, slimey knot of hatred crawled up in her throat, sticky and familiar.

You, Catra thought, furious and suddenly small. *You again.*

Catra's thoughts cracked open like glass, all edges and reflection.

If you hadn't killed Shadow Weaver, none of this would have happened.

If she hadn't *saved* her, Prime would still be in orbit, where he belonged.

If she hadn't dragged the infection back to Etheria—if she hadn't *played hero*—Kyle wouldn't be decapitated and dismembered and —

Where was the rest of him?

Catra's jaw locked, the pain sharp and bright. *You let this happen.*

Kyle was dead—rotting—while you touched me.

He was dying while you made me believe I could be more than what he made me.

He was screaming, and I was laughing, and you—

You made me forget what I am.

Her throat burned when she spoke. "You've outstayed your welcome," she said. The words came out like claws. Every syllable was a strike. She wanted to hurt her, to *see* her hurt. She wanted to trample her into the dust until there was nothing left but red and gold and silence.

Adora didn't flinch. "Catra, don't do this." Calm, steady, like she was handling a frightened animal. Her voice made it worse—too gentle, too sure. "If you ride out against Prime now, unprepared, you'll lose everything. You know you will."

Catra's hands shook on the reins. "But I won't be unprepared," she bit out. Her tone was viciously sweet, her smile a knife's edge. "Entrapta's going to tell me everything she knows. And when she's done, maybe I'll send what's left of her back to Prime as a thank-you."

Adora's eyes darkened. "You don't mean that."

"Don't I?" Catra snapped. The fury was spilling over, too full to contain. Kyle's face. The smell. The sound. The memory of Prime's laugh. *You made me weak*, she thought.

Her mind spiraled down into violence—Entrapta's clever little hands shaking, her wide eyes wet and terrified. Catra saw herself tearing answers out of her piece by piece, feeding Prime the horror he wanted. That was who she was. That was who Prime

had made her. Maybe it would finally drown out the sound of Kyle's screaming voice in her head.

The escort stood ready near the gate. Catra's gaze fell on the lead soldier—a woman standing stiff and cold in her armor—and Catra, half-blind with rage, didn't even realize it was Lonnie.

"I said get her out of my sight," she barked.

She didn't wait to see if they obeyed. Didn't look to see if Adora followed, or fought back, or stayed standing there with that same quiet, unbearable face. Prime's clones were withdrawing, their boots echoing like the toll of a bell. One of her soldiers took the sack from them, holding it out at arm's length, his expression gone a sickly green.

Catra couldn't look. Couldn't breathe.

Her heel struck the horse's flank. The beast lunged forward, up the stairs, hooves clattering. She was off before it stopped moving, the sound of her boots against stone too loud in her ears. She didn't care that she left the animal half-wild and trembling on the dais. She didn't care about Adora, or Seaspray, or war.

All she could see was *Kyle*.

Kyle, smirking across a table, a gleam of purple crystals at his ears.

Kyle, furious and unflinching on the Flagship deck.

Kyle, her loyal idiot, her little brother in everything but blood—

I'm coming back, she'd told him.

Had he known she was lying?

Had he known that empty promise would be the last thing she'd ever give him?

Like every one of Prime's "favourites," Kyle had thought himself indispensable. He'd worried about Catra even when he should have been worrying for himself. He'd believed loyalty meant safety.

I should have brought you with me.

The thought gnawed like rot in her chest as she walked the hall.

Entrapta should have been locked away in the dungeons, not her room. That had been Catra's order. Yet when she reached the door, she found the guards relaxed, the latch already undone. Another act of defiance. Another quiet insult to her authority. Pretender Princess.

The guards—strangers, not her usual men—snapped to attention the moment they saw her. She didn't need to speak; they moved as if her presence alone pushed the air around them. The door creaked open.

Catra stepped inside.

The smell hit her first—a whisper of something sweet and rotting. The window was shattered, the curtains stirring in the breeze that carried the noise of the courtyard below. Her boots scuffed against the floor as she moved forward, each step slower than the one before.

She stopped. Two steps short.

Her breath rasped in her ears. Too fast. Too shallow.

Then the sound of footsteps pounding the stairs—Adora's footsteps—and Catra didn't have to turn to know. She *felt* it when Adora entered, when she saw what lay before them. The sound Adora made wasn't quite a gasp, but it emptied the air all the same.

Inside Catra, everything went white and silent. The world narrowed to nothing but stillness and ringing. Her body stood

there, but her mind had drifted to some other plane—where time didn't move, where feeling didn't exist. For a moment she thought she saw Shadow Weaver in the corner of her vision, pale and disapproving.

Entrapta had dressed herself for it. A final performance. Hair washed and brushed, though the color had almost dulled. She'd chosen one of her old outfits—the ones that still carried the bright hues of her princess days—but the fit was off, the fabric wrinkled. She'd tried to pose herself in a way that hid the bruise on her jaw, but even in death, her awkward earnestness bled through.

It wasn't graceful. It wasn't poetic. Just tragic.

Her eyes had already clouded. A single fly twitched on her lashes. The blood beneath her had gone dark, almost black.

Catra didn't realize she was shaking until Adora's hand touched her shoulder. The contact ripped her back into herself like a slap of cold water. The silence shattered. The smell hit harder. The heat of the room pressed in on her.

She knocked Adora's hand away. Hard.

"Get out," Catra said. Her voice was ragged and sharp enough to cut.

Adora lingered behind her. Catra didn't turn, didn't need to. She could feel the stubbornness radiating off her. *You put her here.* Safe. Alone. "Mara," she said again, lower now, trembling with something that wasn't entirely anger. "Out."

Adora hesitated, then withdrew, the sound of her retreat slow and reluctant.

Catra waited until the footsteps faded before she knelt beside Entrapta.

It was indecent, maybe. But she couldn't leave it to anyone else. Her fingers trembled as she worked her way down Entrapta's arm,

the skin already cold, the flesh stiff. She knew where to look—the little lump above the skin, tucked above the elbow. Her own pulsed faintly in the same spot.

She clenched her teeth, gripped the chip, and tore it free.

The noise it made was wet and small, and it made bile rise in her throat. Entrapta didn't make a sound, of course. She couldn't.

Catra slipped the chip into her pocket, wiped her bloody fingers against her thigh, and forced herself to fix the mess she'd made. She smoothed Entrapta's jacket back into place. Brushed the stray strands of hair away from her face. Closed her cloudy eyes.

Then she stood, breathing through her nose until her vision steadied.

When she opened the door, her voice came out quiet, controlled. "Someone needs to tell Lonnie," she said.

And without waiting for acknowledgment, she walked away—leaving the breeze and the corpse and the ghosts to settle behind her.

Chapter End Notes

> God, out of all the characters I relate to Catra, Entrapta and Kyle the most.
>
> This was so painful to write that I thought it caused me chest pain. I had actually dislocated a rib 😩.

Chapter 26

Chapter Notes

Woooo! Last chapter!

(For now, there will be a 3rd part)

Sorry about how mean Adora is in this chapter, but in her defence she's kinda stupid /jk

Not really, just painfully oblivious.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra didn't *feel*—not properly. The edges of her thoughts were blunted, blurred by exhaustion and fury and the gaping hollow where grief should have been. All she knew was that if she stopped moving—if she paused even for a breath—she would come apart.

So she didn't.

Her voice carried through the halls, curt and clipped. Orders, necessities—actions to fill the void. "Send a runner after Scorpia," she said, though she hardly remembered the words leaving her mouth. "See if there's anything she wants. Anything I can offer to bring her back."

Her tone never wavered, but her throat ached.

"Offer clemency to the remaining Keldor loyalists. If any of them want to swear to me—take them out of the cells. Feed them. Make it known."

The guards scattered to obey, armour clattering in their haste.

"The medic," she continued. "Handle Entrapta. Handle Kyle." Her gaze unfocused, distant. "Lonnie can help… if she wants." Her

next words turned to ice. “If she doesn’t to—just make her anyway. She needs time with Entrapta. As much as you can give her.”

Her next command came quieter: “Have a box made for Kyle. He’s to be cleaned and prepared before we march. I want the best wood you can find.”

The soldiers exchanged uneasy looks. None dared to speak.

Catra couldn’t remember leaving the corridor. One moment she was surrounded by noise, and the next—silence. Her hands were shaking, and she realized she was standing in her own chambers.

She didn’t remember how she’d gotten there.

For the first time in years, Catra desperately wanted to cry. Not a few angry tears, but the kind of sobbing that left nothing behind—the kind that stripped a person raw. She gave herself permission. She waited for it. For the release, for the freedom.

Nothing came.

Not a sound, not a tear, not a breath that didn’t burn.

She got Kyle killed. She promised him she'd protect him like she hadn't protected the others. She left him behind because she thought she wouldn't last a week back in the Fright Zone.

Entrapta was entirely her fault. She had hurled every thought she had ever thought about herself at Entrapta. Every hateful terrible thought. Entrapta, evidently, couldn't take it.

Catra pulled the chip out of her pocket and looked at it.

Maybe…

She shoved it back in her pocket.

The room was too clean. Too still. Her quarters had been cleared of every trace of what had happened the night before. Fresh linens. Folded blankets. A faint floral scent clung to the air. It should have been comforting—it wasn't.

There was no trace of Prime in these rooms. No trace of Bright Moon either. Just the brittle quiet of something emptied out.

Catra's gaze drifted to the desk. Someone had neatly arranged her writing materials there—ink, paper, a sealed pot of wax, the familiar trunk for her correspondence. She reached for it like a reflex, her body moving before her mind did.

The click of the lock was a sound she knew too well. Her fingers found the small compartment inside, the one she never let anyone else touch. The weight of the letters there felt heavier than usual.

Letters for Kyle.

She placed the box on the desk and sat hard in the chair, the motion almost violent. Her claws pressed against the wood as she forced herself to breathe.

The silence pressed in around her again, sharp as glass.

Time slipped past without shape or meaning.

Catra didn't know how long she sat there—minutes, hours, lifetimes. Her hands moved on their own. She watched them unfasten the latch, lift the lid, reveal the contents within. The scent of old paper and wax hit her first. Then, the texture—the soft edges of letters creased and re-folded too many times, the rough thread used to tie them together.

Each piece inside the box was its own ghost.

A bundle of straws darkened with Hordak's blood from a sparring match she'd won by cheating. A silk ribbon stolen from the whorehouse in Nesson, once tied around her wrist as a joke. A pouch of brittle candies made by the old cook at Weave's Slope—

still faintly sweet. A carved wooden horse she'd wagered from Huntara and never returned.

She thought Kyle might like little trinkets from her travels. Something smal to provide legitimacy to her written recounts.

Relics of a life that had almost felt like hers.

She'd told herself she'd burn them all. Watch the box go up in flames, feed the ghosts to the fire. But the plan demanded movement, and her body wouldn't obey. Her legs refused to lift her, her fingers trembled instead.

Then they brushed something smooth, cold—out of place. A bundle of gemstones, alien and purple. She didn't remember putting them there.

The sound of the door cut through her fog. Catra blinked, surfacing from somewhere deep, dark, and endless.

She was standing by the window. She'd changed clothes—her riding leathers replaced by her uniform, crisp and dark. The letters were gone; the box was locked and stowed away. She didn't remember doing any of it.

Below, the courtyard swarmed with motion—soldiers readying for departure, flags snapping in the wind. The sound was distant, muffled, as though the world was underwater.

She didn't turn when she spoke. "Come to say goodbye?"

The warning in her voice was unmistakable. Even she could hear it.

There was no answer. For a heartbeat, she thought she'd imagined the sound of the door. Perhaps her mind had finally fractured. Perhaps the hallucination was mercy.

But no—when she turned, Adora was there.

She stood framed by the doorway, sunlight washing her in gold. Her expression—soft, pitying, *compassionate*—was unbearable.

"I'm sorry," Adora said quietly. "I know what Kyle meant to you."

The words hit like a strike to the gut. Catra felt something coil tight and ugly inside her.

"He was Prime's pet," she said, her voice low, flat. The same hands that had held her so gently last night now twitched at her sides, aching for something to strike. "That's all."

Adora took a step closer. "He was more than that. You saw him. You cared about him."

Catra laughed—a short, broken sound. "Cared?" she repeated. "Sure. I care. I care so much that everyone I care about ends up dead. You want to—"

She couldn't finish it out loud.

She didn't want Adora added to that list.

Adora didn't rise to it. "You don't have to face Prime like this," she said instead. "If you ride to Seaspray now, you'll lose everything."

"I won't lose," Catra snapped. "I've appointed a new Captain. Marzo."

Her lip curled, the memory sharp and jagged. She remembered the cell door swinging open, the clatter of metal as she'd tossed the badge inside. *Congratulations*, she'd said, and the fool had blinked at her, stunned, as it hit him square in the face.

If he'd turned traitor already, she couldn't bring herself to care. She was past trust. Past friendship. Past caring. Past anything that hurt.

Adora's silence filled the room, heavy and suffocating.

Catra met her gaze at last, eyes burning, daring her to cross the distance between them—to touch her, to *say something kind*.

Because if she did—if she reached for her now—Catra knew she would break.

"Is that everything? I've got reinforcements coming tomorrow. I'm taking my troop to Seaspray."

The words surprised her as much as anyone. Saying "my troop" felt like claiming a small, stolen country—an admission that these soldiers were hers and no longer *theirs*. She stepped toward the table to clear her head; Adora didn't move.

Adora held her ground.

"Then you'll butcher them the same way you lost Kyle," she said quietly, each syllable precise and jagged. "You'll drag them into your private game for Prime's approval and call it a battle."

Catra's stride stopped in the middle. For a moment her hands went numb.

"Get out," she managed. Two words. Nothing left in her to make it polite.

Adora took another step forward. "Is the truth hard to hear?" she asked.

"I said get out," Catra snapped again. Her voice shook; the anger behind it barely kept her from splitting open.

"Or are you pretending you're marching to Seaspray for some other reason?" Adora pressed. Her tone sharpened. "This isn't a fight between equals, Catra. This is a performance you put on to make someone watch."

Catra's fingers closed until pain bit into her palm, and she welcomed it—anything that would make the world feel like something other than a knife-edge.

“I’ll fight him,” she said, teeth raw. “On my terms.”

Adora’s head shook. “In a real fight you try to win. You don’t run to play by his rules because you want him to approve of the way you suffer. You let him set the stage. You make moves because he wants you to. Why is that the point of this, Catra? To *prove* something to *him*?”

Catra felt the question cleave something open inside her. Every humiliation, every time she’d bowed and smiled and taken what Prime offered in order to keep a foot in his favour—Adora’s words put them on a bright, accusing ledger. It burned. It was naked and ugly and true.

Adora stepped closer, voice low and fierce, each phrase a bright, cold blow. “You’re not trying to beat him. You’re trying to show him you can play by his rules and still be *seen*. You want him to watch you win because maybe, then, he’ll… what? Praise you? Notice you? Is that why you risk your people?”

Catra had no answer worth giving. The old hunger—attention, approval—coiled and hissed inside her chest, a traitor she’d carried for years. She had kneaded pain into herself for it before; now it lay open under someone else’s gaze.

Adora’s voice went quieter, but it carried the weight of everything she’d said. “If this is about Prime—if it’s about him seeing you—then you already have what you were starving for. You’ve made him care about you, if only as a spectacle. But at what cost?”

Catra’s jaw tightened until she tasted metal. The world narrowed to the set of Adora’s mouth, the steady blue flare of her eyes. She wanted to rake them, to tear them away, to prove she wasn’t some desperate child. Instead she found herself answering in a thin, dangerous tone.

So—now you hate me too.

Of course. Of course it came full circle. From hatred to whatever that last night was—not love, not quite, but something warm

enough for Catra to mistake it for safety—and back to hate. Fitting. She should have expected the ache.

“You must have loved it,” Adora said, ripping the wound open again. “That he was so obsessed with you he killed his own toy to get to you.

I loved Kyle, Catra thought, furious and helpless at once. I loved you.

“You win,” Adora spat.

The room pitched. Catra looked at her like she was a thing to be baited and broken—wanted to fling herself against her, to claw, to beg. Instead the words that came were falsified armour.

“You don’t know anything,” Catra lied. “You don’t understand me. Or Prime.” She tried to make the sound iron. *He hurt me. He hurt Kyle. I was going to fix it. I promised him I would fix it*. The thing she wanted to say—*I loved you*—stayed jammed behind her teeth. Instead came brittle laughter in place of tears she could not shed. “You want me? You are my slave? You can drop the act now. I know you don't want to be here. Get out.”

“That’s not going to work,” Adora answered, the hurt colouring her voice.

That set Catra alight.

“You’re nothing but a pathetic crawling disappointment,” she snapped. The insult tasted like bile and somehow like relief.

“That’s not going to work,” Adora repeated, quieter, wounded.

“Want the truth about Prime?” Catra went on, because fury steadied her and because silence threatened to swallow her whole. “Fine. I’ll tell you, since you can’t see what’s been under your nose.” She gathered the words like weapons. “Glimmer and Bow—didn't you think they wouldn’t betray you? Did you never

wonder why the timing was right? Why things fell apart so cleanly around you?”

Adora’s face shut down, hard as iron.

“You didn’t question the sudden betrayal?” Catra demanded. The mockery in her voice was deliberate and sharp. “You stood there and took it. You never thought the Horde might be involved?”

“No,” Adora said, and the single syllable sounded stripped bare of certainty.

“How about Angella?” Catra pushed, voice low and cruel. “Did you think she died of ‘sickness’? Those constant visits from physicians—did that never make you suspicious? Or did you just keep believing what your eyes told you to?”

Adora went pale. Horror slid across her features. “No,” she whispered.

Catra felt her pulse drive in her temples—rage, grief, the old numbness lined with heat.

“We have a shapeshifter,” she said. “Double Trouble can slip into anyone’s skin. First they look like an incompetent doctor, then it looks like a friend. While Glimmer and Bow sat by Angella’s side, they were wearing her face while they tore down Princess Adora's household. Those useful to us were kept; everyone else—gone.”

She didn’t soften as she spoke. She didn’t offer pity. She needed Adora to feel the inconvenient, ugly truth, even if it made her the villain for saying it. The courtyard and the head, the smell and the blood and Kyle’s face haunted her. She needed someone else to hurt.

Catra forced herself to say the rest, her voice a bitter, trembling rasp.

“—and with that, She-Ra, the Horde’s greatest threat, was eliminated.”

She saw the change come over Adora immediately—the stillness, the narrowing of her eyes, the quiet before the storm. The rage built behind her gaze like a gathering thunderhead, cold and electric. When she spoke, it was low, dangerous.

"You knew," Adora said. "You knew about this?"

Catra laughed—a harsh, splintered sound that barely resembled amusement.

"Knew?" she echoed. "Everyone in the Horde knew. I was *glad*." Her smile was all teeth, but no heart. "I just wish I'd been there to see it happen. To see her face when her own sister's blades came for her."

The lie cut her tongue on the way out. She *had* wished it once. But saying it now made something inside her twist and tear, because the woman she'd wished dead stood before her—alive, fierce, and furious—and Catra loved her. Still did, maybe. That truth was unbearable, so she burned it away.

"Angella got exactly what she deserved," Catra said. "She let a war full of stolen kids bear the brunt of the consequences in her conflict with the Fright Zone. She let her adopted teenage daughter command and sent her to the front lines. She let that monster cut down my mother." Catra's claws curled. "She died like the animal she was—and none of you could stop it."

Adora's expression hardened, fury lighting her from within. The shift was almost beautiful. Before, she'd looked wounded. Now, she looked ready to kill.

"Then again," Catra sneered, "maybe if you hadn't been so busy screwing Bow, you might've notic—"

The strike came before the sentence could finish.

The world snapped sideways. Catra crashed into the table, scattering plates, silver, everything. The sound shattered the room. For a heartbeat, she didn't understand what had happened

—just the bright, dizzying explosion of pain, the metallic tang of blood on her tongue.

Then she knew.

Adora had hit her.

It was almost funny, how familiar it felt.

Catra raised her hand to her mouth, smearing red across her fingers. She looked up at Adora—towering, breathing hard, trembling with fury—and she felt a dark, sick satisfaction unfurl in her chest.

See? she thought. *You're no better than me. You never were.*

She waited for the next blow. Wanted it. Needed it. If Adora kept hitting her, maybe she could stop feeling everything else—Kyle, Entrapta, Prime, the ruin she'd made of her life. Maybe Adora could break her open until there was nothing left but pain.

But the second strike never came.

The doors burst open. Catra barely heard the soldiers before she saw Adora's hands rise, steady, open in surrender.

"Arrest me," Adora said, voice hoarse. "I struck the Princess."

The air went still. The soldiers froze at the threshold, torn between fear and disbelief. This was their Captain.

Catra's lip throbbed. The blood trickled down her chin. The humiliation tasted coppery and warm.

"Do it," Adora ordered again, louder this time.

"No," Catra said.

The word felt like lead leaving her mouth.

The soldiers hesitated, confused. Catra forced herself to look up at them, at the woman she loved being held like a criminal. Some part of her wanted it—wanted Adora shackled, trapped, unable to leave her.

"I provoked her," Catra said finally. Her tone was flat, exhausted. "Release her."

When no one moved, she snapped, voice sharp: "I said *release her*."

They obeyed instantly. The room fell quiet again as they left.

Adora lowered her hands slowly, the fury gone. Catra didn't look at her. She turned away, wiping the blood from her mouth with the back of her hand, refusing to let her see that her fingers were shaking.

It *hurt* to look at her. Her eyes burned, her lip stung, and every inch of her felt flayed raw. Bleeding in front of her—*that* was worse than the hit itself. Worse than the soldiers' eyes. It felt like bleeding before judgment. As if Adora could *see* it now—the truth underneath the mask, the rot Prime had left in her. The shame. The hollow, gutted thing that was all she had left.

"Now get out," Catra said, voice stripped bare.

Adora closed her eyes, shaking her head, the movement small but stubborn. She didn't move.

"No," she said quietly, and her tone—hoarse, steady—made Catra's heart twist. "You can't go to Seaspray. You have to listen to me."

Why do you even care? Catra wanted to ask, but she couldn't. She couldn't open her mouth without feeling the sob in her throat threaten to break loose. She couldn't cry for *her*. Not when she hadn't cried for *Kyle*. She wanted to scream—*You already had me. You got what you came for. Why are you still here? Why won't you just go?*

She tried to laugh instead, cruel and cutting, but it cracked halfway out. “Didn’t you hear a word I said?” she demanded. The question wasn’t really for Adora. It was a plea to the universe, to make it stop—this woman’s voice, this endless light.

“Yes,” Adora said. “You tried to wound me—and you did. But what you’re doing to me is the same thing Prime is doing to you.”

The words hit harder than her fist had.

Catra swayed. Her vision blurred for a moment, like the room had tilted. The familiar haze of panic edged in, dark and suffocating. She could have taken another blow. She could have handled blood, bone, anything—but not this. Not *understanding*.

“Why do you—why do you always—how can you?” The words tangled and fell apart. She couldn’t get enough air. Her heart raced, black spots creeping in around her vision.

Adora was too calm. Too steady.

“I came with you to stop a war,” Adora said, her voice low but firm. “Because you were the only thing in the Horde that stood between Etheria and Prime.”

Not because she cared. Not because of *her*. Because of the cause. Because Adora was a soldier, always saving someone else. The thought scraped like glass against her ribs.

“It’s you who’s lost sight of that,” Adora continued, relentless. “You have to fight him on your own terms. Not his.”

“I *can’t*,” Catra said, and the words tore out of her before she could stop them. “I can’t think.”

It sounded pathetic, childish—and she realized with horror that she sounded like the girl she’d once been, begging Prime not to hurt her.

“I can’t think,” she repeated, quieter.

“I know,” Adora said gently.

She moved slowly, as if she were trying not to startle a wounded animal. She knelt, picked something off the floor. Then she set it, very carefully, on the table.

Catra didn’t have to look to know. But she did.

Her breath shuddered out of her, sharp and uneven. It was Kyle’s earring—

Catra turned away so fast her vision spun. She gripped the edge of the table until her claws bit into the wood, shoulders shaking. Her chest hitched once, twice—and then the tears came.

They came soundless at first, then ragged and unrestrained. She pressed her hand over her mouth, trying to choke the noise back, but the sobs slipped through anyway.

Adora didn’t move. She stayed where she was—near enough to keep watch, far enough not to touch. She didn’t speak, didn’t try to comfort her, didn’t offer the empty kindness of words.

She just stood there.

And for the first time in years, Catra let herself break—just once, just long enough to breathe again—while Adora stood by, the silent witness to her pathetic display.

Eventually, the sobs gave out, leaving Catra hollowed, shaking, and small in the silence that followed. Her breathing steadied by degrees, each inhale sharp in her throat. When she finally turned her head, she found a folded napkin waiting by her elbow—one of the ones that had fallen to the floor earlier, now quietly retrieved and set beside her.

Adora’s doing, of course.

Catra kept her back to her as she wiped her face—blood, tears, whatever dignity she could salvage. The silence stretched thin

between them until she heard Adora's boots scuff the floor. She was moving toward the door.

"Don't go," Catra said, softly—but there was too much in it. Too much ache, too much need.

Adora paused. "I'm not," she said after a moment, her voice gentle. "I just need to clear my head. I told my escort I wouldn't need them until morning."

The words landed like a knife. Catra could almost feel it turning in her chest.

You promised not to use the knife, she thought bitterly.

She couldn't speak right away. Then Adora seemed to realize what Catra had meant.

"No. I don't mean—forever," Catra said quickly, lying to cover the weakness that had already escaped. "Just—three days. I can do this alone. I know I can."

It wasn't convincing. Catra could lie to anyone—she'd made an art of it—but right now, even she could hear the break in her own voice. She needed Adora still. Needed her close. It would cost her the plan she'd built so carefully, but she couldn't send her away. Not yet. Not when the world was already collapsing around her.

She fumbled for composure. "It's only that right now I can't seem to… think straight," she managed. "And I can't trust anyone else to stand up to me when I'm like this." She wiped her eyes again, more out of habit than success. "If you could just give me three days, I—"

"I'll stay," Adora interrupted, immediate and certain. "You know I'll stay, for as long as you—"

"Don't." Catra's voice cracked, the sound startling in the quiet. "Don't lie to me. Not you, too."

Because if she said it like that—if she let herself believe it—then it would mean too much. It would open something that couldn't be closed again. Hope was a cruel thing, and Catra was too raw, too thin-skinned right now to survive another round of it.

Adora's voice softened. "I'll stay," she said again. "Three days. After that, I ride south."

Catra nodded once. She refused to cry again. Now that she knew she could, it felt like something dangerous, something that could get out of control.

Adora came to stand beside her, close enough that Catra could feel the warmth of her body, the quiet strength that radiated from her even when she said nothing. The air between them was charged, fragile.

Catra didn't look up. She couldn't. She knew what she would find there—Adora's gaze, soft and patient, offering comfort. And she knew how easily she could reach for it.

If she turned to her, Adora would hold her. If she asked, Adora would give her that comfort—her arms, her warmth, her lips. It would be everything Catra wanted, everything she'd been starving for.

And it would destroy her.

She wasn't built to endure tenderness. Not now. Not from *her*.

Catra took a slow breath, pulling the frayed pieces of herself back together with sheer will, smoothing over the cracks until she could sound almost whole.

"You're right," she said finally, her voice quiet, almost level. "I killed Kyle when I left him." The words were factual, stripped of feeling, the way soldiers delivered reports. "I should've stayed with him. Or taken him away from Prime. I didn't plan anything properly—I left it to chance."

If she'd died at Weave's Slope as she was supposed to, or sold herself to Scorpia in exchange for safety and silence, Kyle might still have been alive. But she'd kept him close, half-saving him, half-sacrificing him, dreaming of some impossible day when she could make it all right.

"I didn't think Prime would hurt him," she said, almost to herself. "I just… liked him. Did you know he had a silly crush on Rogelio? At least I won't have to tell him now."

Adora's expression softened. "I shouldn't have said what I did," she murmured. "Kyle made his own choice. He spoke up because you mattered to him. That's not something you should regret."

Catra didn't answer. She couldn't.

She just sat there—broken, silent, and still—while Adora stood beside her, the weight of her presence both unbearable and necessary.

"He spoke up for me because he didn't think Prime would hurt him," Catra said quietly. Her voice was hollow, scraped clean of emotion. "None of them do. They all think he loves them."

Her lip curled, not in cruelty this time, but in bitter self-recognition. "That's the trick of it. His love *hurts* right from the start. Pain, humiliation, degradation—it's all part of the game. He makes them think it's devotion. He breaks them, and then he teaches them to call that love."

Her gaze was distant, fixed on nothing. "He gives you gifts. He smiles. He tells them they're special. He makes them *believe* them are. They laugh with him, share his wine, fall asleep under his hand, and they think it's tenderness." Her jaw trembled. "But it's just control. Always control."

She swallowed hard. "It's… fetish. It looks like love until they're old enough to know better. Until they realize they were just one of the toys." She forced a laugh, sharp and humourless. "He collects them, breaks them, and when he's bored, he finds new ones."

“Like Entrapta,” Adora said softly.

Like me, Catra thought, but didn’t say it.

She closed her eyes, forcing her breathing steady. How could Adora *not* see it? How could she stand there, close enough to touch, and still miss what was right in front of her—that Prime had left his mark on Catra so deeply she would never scrape it out again?

She wanted to tell her. Wanted to say it, now that everything between them was ruined anyway. She wanted to confess—about Prime, about the things she’d done, about the rot inside her that never healed. *I slept with him. I let him make me into something I hate. I killed Kyle. I killed Entrapta. I became everything they said I was*.

But she couldn’t. She was too cowardly for truth. Too afraid of the disgust she’d see on Adora’s face—disgust that would look too much like pity.

So she lied by omission.

“Like Entrapta,” she agreed at last, her voice dry, final.

She turned away from the table, from Kyle’s earring glinting faintly on the table, and sank down to the floor. The stone was cold beneath her palms. After a moment, Adora joined her, without a word or invitation.

They sat in the wreckage—food, broken glass, and silence spread between them. Through the arched doorway, the bed loomed in soft shadow. The bed where they’d pretended, for one brief night, that they weren’t broken things.

Their knees brushed lightly.

“You liked him,” Adora said at last. Her voice was quiet, almost kind.

Catra didn’t look up. “Prime brought out the worst in him,” she said. Her tone was steady, but her hands were shaking. “Same as he did in me. Same as he did in Entrapta. But sometimes… he still had good instincts. You could almost see the boy he used to be.” She gave a small, broken laugh. “I thought I could help him.”

Adora’s answer was soft, careful. “You wanted to save him.”

Catra gave a half-smile, bitter and thin. “He didn’t need saving. He was too far gone.” She paused. “He was at my side—but in the end, noone was on his.”

Adora didn’t reply. Catra could feel her gaze. It was unbearable. She knew what Adora saw—bruised skin, swollen eyes, a split lip—and worse, the things she didn’t say aloud.

She wouldn’t look up. Wouldn’t say *Prime hurt me.* Wouldn’t say *I know who you are, Adora*. Wouldn’t say *I love you*.

Her thoughts shattered when she caught the glint of silver at Adora’s wrist.

Without thinking, she reached out and pushed up her sleeve.

The sight of the cuff stopped her breath. For a moment, neither of them moved. Adora’s arm went rigid, her expression freezing.

She had kept one on.

Catra’s voice came out dry, cracked. “Sentimental, are we?”

Adora’s answer came slowly, carefully measured.

“Something like that, I guess” she said, her voice quiet—fragile in a way Catra wasn’t used to hearing.

Looking up at her was a mistake. Catra knew that as soon as their eyes met. It was that same impossible back-and-forth that always left her winded—the endless pull between wanting to *know* and dreading what she’d find. A heartbeat ago she’d been sure Adora

hated her again, that the disgust had finally settled in for good. But now…

Now Adora's eyes softened.

If Catra were any other woman, she might have thought there was affection there. If she were braver—or stupider—she might have hoped for it.

"You should give me the other one," Catra said suddenly.

It wasn't planned. The words slipped out recklessly, but once they were loose she didn't take them back. *If you mean what you think you mean, then prove it.*

Adora flushed under her gaze. The colour spread from her cheeks to her throat, and she fumbled for composure. "I can't imagine you'd… actually wear it," she said, and the awkward lilt in her voice was almost endearing.

Catra's mouth quirked, despite herself. "To keep," she said, tone dry. "Not wear. Though it doesn't sound like your imagination's struggling much with that image."

Adora ducked her head and laughed, low and shy. It was absurd that they could still laugh—after everything—but somehow it slipped through the cracks anyway. Catra wanted to touch her again. To slide closer, lean in, let the laughter turn into something else entirely.

But she couldn't. Not tonight. Not with Kyle's ghost still clawing at her ribs. Not when she knew Adora was still leaving.

So she leaned back instead, bracing herself on her hands, drinking her in—the way her shoulders eased now, the way her hair caught the light. Adora could have gone. She *should* have gone. But she was here, with Catra, by choice. That knowledge ached in a strangely beautiful way.

And then, quieter than she meant to, Catra said, "I shouldn't have told you about Double Trouble like that."

Adora's expression flickered. She turned slightly, running her fingers along the carved edge of the table, tracing a groove with her thumbnail. "Did you mean it?" she asked after a pause. She tried to sound casual, but she was never any good at hiding her emotions. "That you were glad that Angella and Adora were killed like that?"

Catra watched her, feeling the honesty drag at her chest. "Yes."

Adora's hand stilled. Her fingers tightened around the wood until her knuckles went pale.

"They killed my only family," Catra added, softly.

The words seemed to hollow out the air between them. Adora turned her head just enough that Catra could see her profile—tight jaw, flickering eyes, that unmistakable look of someone haunted by old ghosts.

Catra wondered if she was reliving it. The moment Shadow Weaver fell. The sound, the light, the aftermath. *Do you regret it when you look at me?* she wanted to ask. Not to accuse her, but to understand her. To know if it hurt her, too.

She didn't ask. Some truths weren't survivable.

Adora's silence was too long, too heavy. Catra's instinct surprised her—it wasn't to twist the knife, but to ease it out.

"I listened to what you said," she offered. "I'm not going to charge off to Seaspray tomorrow."

Adora's eyes didn't move, but she was listening.

"I still want to fight," Catra went on. "Not because Prime wants it. Because I do. Because this is my planet too."

He doesn’t get to rule the same ground you walk on. Not after what he’s done. Not after Kyle.

Catra went on, “If we work together, we can use Seaspray. We can make it *our* move, not his. We can do what neither of us could do alone.”

For the first time, Catra believed it. It felt naïve, maybe even foolish—but it was real. Adora had always been the light that forced her to look forward. If she could keep her by her side, even for a little while, there was nothing—no wannabe god—that Catra couldn’t face.

And somewhere, deep in the hollow that grief had carved out, that belief hurt worse than hope ever had.

“Prime plans *everything*. He plans his triumphs, and he plans his losses. He scripts both, like he’s staging a war for his own amusement.” Her gaze flicked to Adora. “But you—you were the one thing he never accounted for. You don’t fit into his design. You never did.”

That's why he wanted She-Ra gone. He thought it was enough to separate you from the sword.

If she could only make Adora see that. If Adora could grasp that *she*—not the throne, not Bright Moon, not even She-Ra—was the wild card that could end Prime for good. Once Seaspray was behind them, Catra could already feel the pull, the temptation to turn toward Etheria’s politics, to rebuild, to fight for power. But Prime was the real enemy. And *together* they could end him.

“For all his perfect plans,” Catra said quietly, “Prime didn’t realize what he was doing when he let me have you.”

But Adora didn’t smile at that. She didn’t look proud or triumphant. Instead, her expression darkened, the colour draining from her face. She looked almost… ill.

Catra frowned. “You and I,” she began again, forcing the words past the weight in her chest. “We *work*. You know it. We fight well together. You can’t deny—”

Adora rose suddenly, the movement sharp enough to cut off whatever Catra had been about to say.

“Seaspray’s a trap,” Adora said briskly. “If you approach it wrong, you’ll lose everyone you take with you.” Her voice was tight, her jaw set, her eyes carefully avoiding Catra’s. “We don’t have time to waste.”

Catra tilted her head, studying her. “Then are you going to help me up?”

A pause. Then Adora shook her head. “No. Just—come here. There’s something I need to show you on the maps.”

✧

By sunrise, Catra was heading for Hell’s Rest.

The wind tore at her hair as she sat half out the helm of the tank, stinging her cheeks, but none of it dulled the memory of how Adora had looked at her before she left—like she had the night before, when everything between them had blurred into something fierce and fragile.

“Are you sure you want to leave your enemy in charge of your fortress?” Adora asked, standing beside her.

“Yes,” Catra said simply. Anything else—*you’re not my enemy, I’ll still be thinking of you*—was too dangerous. Too revealing. The soldiers were watching, and she couldn’t afford softness now.

They clasped hands like comrades. But Adora’s grip tightened—lingered—as if she understood everything Catra couldn’t say aloud.

“A lot depends on timing,” Adora reminded her. Her voice was low, almost steady. “We meet again in two days. Don’t be late.”

Catra’s heart twisted.

Inside the fortress, the medic would already be tending to what remained of Prime’s victims—Entrapta and Kyle. Her shadows. Her siblings in suffering. Her failures. Later, the medic would rejoin her at Hell’s Rest with the grim cargo, and news that the Etherians had arrived at Talon Mountain. But that was still to come.

Right now, all that existed was Adora standing before her—a shard of something bright and unreachable. A glimpse into a world where Catra hadn’t been ruined. Where she wasn’t alone. Where there was still a reason to believe that *hope* wasn’t just another form of cruelty.

It hurt. But for the first time in longer than she could remember, Catra found herself grateful for the pain.

She met Adora’s gaze and said, quietly but firmly,

“Trust me.”

Chapter End Notes

Catra is not going to make it there in time 🥲

Give me some time to plan out Devotion. In the meantime I have been planning a Coptive Prince fanfic that is based on The Taming of the Shrew and I need to get it out of my head.

I will keep drawing She-Ra stuff. I'm drawing Lonnie at the moment, I think I want to draw Some cute Kyle x Rogelio stuff. My babies. So sad that Kyle and Rogelio won't be in the next part. I was at odd with myself over Kyle and Entrapta's deaths for weeks.

I have been writing that Lonnie x Entrapta fic and It will be posted to the DFD series as well.

Love you guys 🥰

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!